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THE TIMES OF INDIA

STYLE GUIDE

For writers, editors, and lovers of English

People think I can teach them style. What stuff it all is! Have something to say and say it as clearly as you can. That is the only secret to style.

— **Matthew Arnold**

Ajit Ninan

The virtues of good style are more negative than positive. The man who knows what to avoid is already the owner of style.

— **Henry W Fowler**

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William Safire's rules for writers

The passive voice should never be used.

Do not put statements in the negative form.

Proofread carefully to see if you words out.

Never, ever use repetitive redundancies.

A writer must not shift your point of view.

Use parallel structure when you write and in speaking.

And don't start a sentence with a conjunction.

Never use prepositions to end sentences with.

Write all adverbial forms correct.

Place pronouns as close as possible, especially in long sentences — such as those of 10 or more words — to their antecedents.

Writing carefully, dangling participles should be avoided.

If any word is improper at the end of a sentence, a linking verb is.

Take the bull by the hand and don't mix metaphors.

Avoid trendy locutions that sound flaky.

In their writing, everyone should make sure that their pronouns agree with its antecedent.

Unless you are quoting other people's exclamations, kill all exclamation points!!!

Don't verb nouns.

Always pick on the correct idiom.

The adverb always follows the verb.

Last but not least, avoid clichés like the plague.

***

Note: At times, it is desirable to break some of the rules. William Safire, in his book "How Not to Write: The Essential Misrules of Grammar", not only explains the correct way to write but also demonstrates when the rules can be broken. Safire wrote the "On Language" column for New York Times for 30 years until his death in 2009.

Introduction

THIS BOOK deals with questions that trouble editors and reporters every day. It seeks to make the newspaper's conversation with readers livelier by helping to ensure clarity, consistency and accuracy in articles and headlines. It is not about grammar and usage alone; it is also about unambiguous and precise reporting, which is easy to understand and wins the trust of readers.

Holding readers' interest is the hallmark of good writing. Overworked and redundant expressions put people off as do vague words, unintelligible abbreviations and convoluted sentences. A large number of such words and phrases have been listed, and the attendant pitfalls pointed out, in these pages. The Times of India's credo that the meaning of everything written in the paper should be instantly clear to the reader informs every aspect of this book.

What should be capitalized, what should be one word, what should be hyphenated, what should be put in figures and what should be spelled out are some of the questions regularly raised in newsrooms. To many of these, dictionaries and grammar books do not offer consistent answers. This book tries to do that. Sometimes, even frequently used terms from the worlds of politics, law, business and finance, science, technology, and sports confound us. The meanings and usages of a large number of such terms have been explained here.

Indian journalists seeking guidance on style and usage generally fall back on the stylebooks of US or British publications, because there are hardly any Indian reference sources in the market to meet their needs. But there are certain terms and expressions that only Indians use, and certain mistakes that only Indians make. With its emphasis on international best practices and its balanced treatment of Indianisms, this book tries to offer Indian writers and editors the best of both worlds.

The Times of India follows British spelling and usage, but is alive to the changes taking place in the language. Many of the so-called Americanisms have taken root in India as well as Britain. Some of them, like *vs* rather than *v* for *versus* and *raise* rather than *rise* for *a salary increase*, have been prevalent in India for years. This book recommends these forms.

The *-ize* and *-ization* spellings recommended here are as much British as American. Contrary to popular belief, leading British dictionaries, including Oxford, Collins, Chambers and Cambridge, prefer the *-z-* form. The advantage of this form is that it is universally acceptable. The same goes for the *-ed* form of verbs: *burned*, *dreamed*, etc.

Words like Champs-Élysées and El Niño have been written with accent marks for the benefit of the curious. The Times of India does not use accent marks.

For words and expressions not listed here, you should turn to Concise Oxford Dictionary, our first reference for British spelling and usage, or Collins English Dictionary (*http://www.collinslanguage.com/*), our second reference for British spelling and usage. If you are looking for a more detailed treatment of usage, the following two dictionaries can be helpful: Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary (*http://www.oup.com/elt/catalogue/teachersites/oald7/?cc=global*) and Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English (*http://pewebdic2.cw.idm.fr/*). Note that this book does not approve of some usages that are accepted by dictionaries. This is only natural, for restricting our choices to the best is implicit in the idea of a house style.

The chapter on American spelling and usage (Appendix 3) gives a detailed account of the differences between British English and American English. There are many American dictionaries going by the name Webster's. The one recommended here for American spellings and usage is Webster's New World College Dictionary, available online at *www.yourdictionary.com*. Top American news organizations like New York Times, Wall Street Journal and Associated Press use this dictionary rather than the ubiquitous Merriam-Webster's.

George Orwell's 1946 essay "Politics and the English Language", available at *http://www.george-orwell.org/Politics_and_the_English_Language/0.html* and given in Appendix 4 of this book, is a must-read for all journalists. Orwell's observations about how English has been mauled by politicians, bureaucrats and journalists remain valid even six decades after the essay was written. The following rules come from that essay:

1. Never use a metaphor, simile or other figure of speech which you are used to seeing in print.

2. Never use a long word where a short one will do.

3. If it is possible to cut a word out, always cut it out.

4. Never use the passive where you can use the active.

5. Never use a foreign phrase, a scientific word, or a jargon word if you can think of an everyday English equivalent.

6. Break any of these rules sooner than say anything outright barbarous.

If a seventh rule were to be added, it would be: Use common sense; there is no substitute for it.

Vinay Pandey
New Delhi

A to Z

Only the illiterate will be impressed by dreadful English wrapped in cute graphics.
— **R L Trask** in "Mind the Gaffe"

A

a, an Go by pronunciation, not spelling. If a word begins with a consonant sound, use the article *a* before it: *a European*, *a one-year ban*, *a union*, *a U-turn*, *a year*. Write *a hotel* and *a historical*; *h* is not silent in either word. If a word begins with a vowel sound, use the article *an* before it: *an honest man*, *an hour*, *an MP*, *an MoU*, *an urgent call*. Write *an $18 billion deal,* not *a $18 billion deal,* because it is pronounced *eighteen-billion-dollar deal*.

Use *a* or *an* depending on the sound that immediately follows; do not go by the sound of a subsequent word to which the article is actually attached: *an election month*, though the article is actually attached to *month*.

Put an article before each parallel noun in a series or pair: *The panel included an engineer, a doctor and a lawyer*. | *The hero and the heroine became popular*. Make an exception if the nouns convey a single idea, as in *a series or pair* in the previous sentence. Other examples: *a bow and tie*, *a knife and fork*.

Do not change a direct quote if the speaker says, for example, "an historic".

aam admi (common man) Italicize or put in quotation marks and give the meaning in brackets.

abattoir Note single *b* and double *t*.

ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

Do not use abbreviations which the reader would not quickly recognize. Familiar abbreviations like UN, US and BBC need not be spelled out in first reference. If an abbreviation is not so familiar, it should be spelled out in first reference, followed by the initials in brackets. In subsequent references,

the abbreviated form can be used, but to avoid clutter it is better to use terms like *organization*, *committee*, *commission* or whatever else is appropriate.

If you have added *'s* to the expanded form, do not follow it with the abbreviation in brackets, as in *The Board of Control for Cricket in India's (BCCI) income has risen sharply.* If you insist on *BCCI* in brackets, write *The income of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) has risen sharply.*

An acronym is an abbreviation pronounced as a word. Acronyms of four letters or more are generally written with only the first letter capital: *Nato*, *Unicef*, *Unesco*. Cap all letters where capping the first letter alone will change the meaning of the word: *AIDS*, *CARE*, *DIAL*.

Acronyms that have become everyday words are lowercase: *awol*, *laser*, *sim*.

SEE ALSO **BRACKETS**.

abdominoplasty Surgical removal of excess fatty tissue and skin from the abdomen. The technique is better known as *tummy tuck*. A related technique is *liposuction*, or *lipoplasty*, in which only fat is removed; the skin must be elastic enough to contract on its own.

abduct, kidnap A minor is *abducted* for marriage or seduction. But the use of *kidnap* is not restricted to minors; a person is usually *kidnapped* for the purpose of demanding a ransom from his or her family or employers.

SEE ALSO **KIDNAP, KIDNAPPING**.

aberration Note single *b* and, as in *narration*, double *r*.

able-bodied

ABM(s) Antiballistic missile(s). The abbreviation is acceptable even in first reference, but give the full form somewhere up front in the story.

aborigines, aboriginal Cap while referring to Australian indigenous people. Otherwise lowercase.

abortion Terms like *pro-life* and *pro-choice* are politically loaded. Except in quotes, use *anti-abortion* instead of *pro-life*: *an anti-abortion campaigner* rather than *a pro-life campaigner*. Similarly, *an abortion rights campaigner* rather than *a pro-choice* or *pro-abortion campaigner*. Avoid *abortionist*, which suggests stealth and illegality.

above board (two words as an adverb or as an adjective after a noun), **aboveboard** (one word as an adjective before a noun)

abreast You keep abreast *of* something, not *with* it.

abscess Note the *s* after *b*.

abscond The use of this verb in the continuous tense, as in *The accused is absconding*, is Indian policespeak, which often creeps into our stories. Make it *The accused is on the run*. Will you write *The accused is running* unless you are referring to the action of *running* in progress?

However, *absconding* can be used as an adjective before a noun: *The number of absconding prisoners has gone up.* Other examples of correct use of *abscond*: *The convict absconded from Tihar.* | *The Sharmas' servant absconded with all their cash.*

absence SEE **LACK**.

absent-minded

absent without leave No need to cap the acronym *awol*, which is acceptable in all references.

absolutely necessary A redundancy; remove *absolutely* unless the expression is part of a quotation.

absolve can be followed by *of* or *from*, depending on the context. Generally, prefer *of*.

absorb But *absorption*.

abstruse (difficult to understand), **obtuse** (mentally slow or emotionally insensitive)

Abu means *father of*; it should not be removed from the name that follows. For example, *Abu Mazen* should not become *Mazen* in subsequent references.

abundance

abysmal

abyss

AC (airconditioner), **a/c** (account) Do not use the short form *a/c* in copy; keep it for headlines and graphics.

academic, academician A person who teaches or does research at a college or a university is an *academic*. Do not use *academician* unless referring to a member of an academy who has the designation *academician*. In American English, *academician* also means *academic*.

ACADEMIC DEGREES

No full stops, no spaces: *BA*, *BSc*, *BCom*, *DLitt*, *DSc*, *LLB*, *LLM*, *MA*, *MPhil*, *MSc*, *MBA*, *PhD*.

Use an apostrophe in *a bachelor's degree*, *a master's degree*, *a master's,* etc.

ACADEMIC DEPARTMENTS
Lowercase except for words that are proper nouns or proper nouns working as modifiers: *physics department*, *department of chemistry*, *Hindi department*, *department of English literature*.

ACADEMIC SUBJECTS
Lowercase except for words that are proper nouns or proper nouns working as modifiers: *economics*, *physics*, *chemistry*, *commerce*, *Hindi literature*. Cap when the subject is part of a course name: *MA (History)*, *Sociology (Hons)*.
He read sociology at JNU.
He is an MA (Sociology) student at JNU.

Academy Award(s) Presented annually by the Beverly Hills-based Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences. The awards are generally called *the Oscars*. In subsequent references, *the award(s)*, *the Oscar(s)*.

accede to You *accede to a request*; you do not *accede a request*.

accept (receive), **except** (exclude)

access Use it only as a noun; as a verb it is technical jargon. There are plenty of simpler choices: *find*, *look up*, *retrieve*, *enter* and even *gain access*. However, expressions like *access the internet* and *access your email* are fine.

accessible Not *accessable*.

accessory

accidentally Not *accidently*.

accommodate, accommodation Note double *m*.

accompanist Not *accompaniest*.

accordion

accreditation Not *accredition*.

accused Do not form a plural by adding an *s* or a possessive by adding *'s*. Avoid expressions that imply guilt on the part of someone merely accused, charged or suspected.

SEE ALSO **ALLEGE, ALLEGED, ALLEGEDLY**.

accuse of Not *accuse with*, but *charge with*.

Achilles heel (weak point), **Achilles tendon** (tendon joining the calf muscles to the heel bone) No apostrophe; but in American English, *Achilles' heel*. Logically, *Achilles* in these phrases should be written with a lowercase *a*, because it does not mean *of Achilles*; the sense is metaphorical. But cap it so that it does not look like a new, unfamiliar word to the reader.

acknowledgment Not *acknowledgement*.

ACLU American Civil Liberties Union.

acolyte

acoustics Not *accoustics*. Adjective *acoustic*. As a science, *acoustics* is singular: *Acoustics is his specialization*. When it means a hall's properties that make the quality of sound good or bad, it is plural: *The acoustics of the auditorium are excellent*.

acquiesce Note the *-sce* ending. Although *acquiesce in* is the traditional phrase, *acquiesce to* is now common. There is a slight distinction in meaning: you *acquiesce in* an event, especially an unfortunate one, but you *acquiesce to* a proposal or request, or the person who makes it. Do not use *acquiesce with*.

acquittal, acquitted, acquitting Note *cq* and double *t*.

acre An area equal to 4,840 square yards, or 43,560 square feet. To convert to hectares, multiply by 0.4.

across from Prefer *opposite*.

act Cap when using the full name of an act: *Right to Information Act*. Otherwise lowercase.

acting Lowercase. Write *acting Prime Minister*, not *Acting Prime Minister*.

active consideration Do not use this officialese except in quotes. Just *consideration* is fine. Similarly, write *consider* rather than *actively consider*.

activist The word is not always neutral. It may suggest militancy or, sometimes, nobility. Words like *campaigner* and *advocate* may be more appropriate.

actor, actress Generally, use *actor* for both men and women. Use *actress* when it occurs in the name of an award: *Oscar for best actress*. Certain other contexts may also require *actress*. For example, *Actor alleges molestation* is a vague, even absurd, headline for a story about filmstar Shriya alleging that she was molested by a fan. Rely on common sense.

acute, chronic *Acute* refers to a sudden crisis demanding immediate attention; *chronic* denotes a lingering problem, which cannot be easily overcome.

ad, advert Clipped forms of *advertisement*. Prefer *ad*.

AD (anno Domini, Latin for *in the year of our Lord*), **BC** (before Christ) *AD* goes before the year, but *BC* follows it: *AD 1500*, *500 BC*. Both follow the century: *first century AD, third century BC*. If you do not write *AD* or *BC*, the century or the year is presumed to be *AD*: *11th century* means *11th century AD*.

adage means *an old saying*, so *old adage* is a redundancy.

adaptation Not *adaption*.

adapter (someone who adapts), **adaptor** (plug)

ADB Asian Development Bank.

addendum Plural *addenda*.

additional Avoid this word; *more* is shorter and usually better.

add-on (noun and adjective)

address (verb) often needs to be replaced with a more precise word. Questions can be *answered*, issues *discussed*, problems *solved* and difficulties *dealt with*.

ADDRESSES

Do not put commas after house numbers: *10 Janpath, 7 Race Course Road, 10 Downing Street.*

ad hoc Two words even as a modifier. Never hyphenated.

adieu

adivasi Not *adiwasi*.

ADJECTIVE PILE-UP

This device, used by journalists to pack information in copy and to make headlines fit, often confounds readers. Consider this sentence: *The government has undertaken an ambitious Rs 600 crore traffic-improvement project for the city*. Clear the pile-up and make it *The government has undertaken a Rs 600 crore plan for improving traffic in the city*. Retain *ambitious*, if you insist.

ad-lib Note hyphen; *ad-lib* can be used as a noun, verb, adjective or adverb.

administration Lowercase in all governmental references, but cap when it is part of an organization's name: *National Aeronautics and Space Administration*, but *Obama administration.*

admissible, inadmissible Not *-able*.

admit Use with care. If you say someone admitted something you imply that the matter had previously been concealed or that there is an element of guilt. The plain *said* is usually better.

admit (to), confess (to) SEE **CONFESS (TO), ADMIT (TO)**.

admitted homosexual Do not use this term; it suggests criminality or shame. If a modifier is indeed required, write *acknowledged homosexual*, *openly gay* or *openly lesbian*.

SEE ALSO **GAY** | **LESBIAN** | **LGBT** | **SEXUAL ORIENTATION**.

admn Do not use this short form of *administration* in copy; keep it for headlines.

ad nauseam (to a disgusting degree) Not *ad nauseum*.

adopted, adoptive *The couple has an adopted son.* | *The boy lived with his adoptive parents.*

adrenaline Hormone that increases heart rate and blood pressure: *get the adrenaline flowing*, *a rush of adrenaline*. *Adrenalin* is a trademark.

adult An adult movie or magazine is intended for grown-ups. It is not necessarily pornographic. If you mean pornographic, write *pornographic*.

advance (progress), **advancement** (promotion)

advance planning All planning is done in advance. Write just *planning*.

advantage The phrase is *take advantage of*; not *take advantages of*, no matter how many ways you take advantage of someone or something.

ADVERB PLACEMENT

When a verb has two or more parts (for instance, *will affect*, *has been written, have been rewarded*), the most natural place for an adverb is usually between parts of the verb. *The transport crisis in Delhi will surely affect the chances of the Congress in the assembly elections.* | *They have never been rewarded.* | *The story has been badly written.*

A similar rule applies when *is*, *am* or *are* links a noun to a modifier: *He is often late.* | *I am usually frank.* | *They are normally right.*

Some people, out of confusion derived from misguided warnings about the split infinitive (an unrelated issue), bring the adverb to the front, producing awkward sentences like this: *The transport crisis in Delhi surely will affect the chances of the Congress in the assembly elections.* Do not fall into this trap.

SEE ALSO **SPLIT INFINITIVE**.

ADVERBS

Like adjectives, they should be used sparingly. Avoid adverbs that imply judgment; for example, *generously*, *harshly*, *sternly*.

adverse (opposed or unfavourable), **averse** (unwilling or reluctant)

advice (noun), **advise** (verb)

adviser Not *advisor*, but *advisory*.

aegis means *support*, *protection* or *sponsorship*. For example, *Medical supplies are being sent under the aegis of the Red Cross*.

aeon

aerobicized Toned by aerobic exercise: *aerobicized Hollywood women*.

aerodrome means *a small airport*. Avoid this word; use *airfield* instead.

aeroplane is the British form; *airplane* is American. Now *aircraft* is preferred in both British English and American English.

aesthetic Never *esthetic*, not even in American English.

affect, effect *Affect* is a verb meaning *to influence*: *An increase in interest rates affects borrowers*. It can also mean *to put on something intended to impress other people*: *Sometimes, he affects a ridiculous accent.*

Effect is usually a noun meaning *outcome* or *consequence.* When *effect* is used as a verb, it means *to bring about*, *to accomplish*: *The kidnapper effected his escape with the help of his wife*. It is often an avoidable, pretentious word. *The kidnapper escaped with the help of his wife* would be better.

The verb *affect* can often be vague; seek a more precise alternative. For example, instead of *strike affects services*, say *strike disrupts services* or sometimes in a headline, *strike hits services.*

affidavit is a written declaration on oath, so do not say *written affidavit* or *sworn affidavit*.

affinity *with* or *between*, not *for* or *to*.

afflicted Use less emotional language in citing disabilities. Write *She has cancer*, not *She is afflicted with cancer*.

SEE ALSO **CRIPPLE, CRIPPLED** | **CHALLENGED** | **DEFORMED** | **DISABILITIES** | **HANDICAPPED** | **IMPAIRED**.

afforestation But *reforestation*.

Afghans are people of Afghanistan, **afghan** (lowercase) is a knitted blanket and **afghani** (lowercase) is the currency of Afghanistan. The adjective of *Afghanistan* is *Afghan*. Do not shorten *Afghanistan* to *Afghan* in headlines.

aficionado(s)

aforementioned Use only if it is part of a quoted text.

AfPak Shorthand used by the US foreign policy establishment, and now increasingly by the media, for Afghanistan and Pakistan as a war zone. It is believed to have been coined by the US diplomat Richard Holbrooke. "We often call the problem AfPak, as in Afghanistan Pakistan. This is not just an effort to save eight syllables. It is an attempt to indicate and imprint in our DNA the fact that there is one theater of war, straddling an ill-defined border," Holbrooke said in March 2008, nearly a year before he was appointed special envoy to Afghanistan and Pakistan in the Obama administration.

Afrikaans (the language), **Afrikaner** (the person)

Afro- Use *African-* as a prefix unless *Afro-* is the established usage in a particular context or is part of a name. For example, *African-American*, not *Afro-American*. *Afro-Cuban* is a musical style; *Afro* is a hairstyle.

AFSPA Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act.

after(-) afterbirth, aftereffect, afterlife, aftermarket, aftermath, afternoon, aftershave, aftershock, aftertaste, afterthought, aftertouch, afterword, afterworld

after-dinner (adjective), after-hours

after all Two words.

agenda Strictly speaking, *agenda* is plural and *agendum* is singular. But in standard modern English, *agenda* is used as singular and its plural form is *agendas* (Concise Oxford Dictionary, Collins English Dictionary).

age-old

AGES AND ERAS OF HISTORY

Cap *Stone Age, Bronze Age, Dark Ages, Middle Ages, Christian Era, Renaissance*. But lowercase *atomic age, ice age, missile age, space age.*

AGES OF PEOPLE AND ANIMALS

Use figures even for ages below 10 and set them off with commas rather than brackets: *Shyam, 3, was found dead*. | *Her daughter is 3 months old.*

Use hyphens for ages expressed as adjectives before nouns or as substitutes for nouns: *A 30-year-old man was killed in a car accident*. | *This T-shirt is meant for 10-year-olds*. Do not use hyphens if the age is mentioned after a noun or a pronoun: *He is 40 years old*. | *Hind Hariri, 24 years old, became the world's youngest woman billionaire*.

Avoid an expression like *66-year-old Gupta*, which suggests the person is being distinguished from another, 65-year-old Gupta. *Gupta, who is 66*, or just *Gupta, 66,* is simpler. *The 66-year-old minister* or *an 18-year-old youth* is fine.

Use numerals for decades of age: *The President is in her 70s.*

In giving ages of inanimate objects or other things, spell out from one to nine and use figures for 10 and above.

SEE ALSO **ELDERLY**.

aggravate means *to make worse*; it does not mean *to annoy*.

aggression Note double *g* and double *s*.

aggression, aggressiveness *Aggression* denotes hostility. If a person or a campaign is assertive or vigorous, the quality in question is *aggressiveness*.

aging Not *ageing*. Similarly: *caging*, *paging*, *raging*, *waging*.

agnostic, atheist An *agnostic* believes it is impossible to know whether God exists or not; an *atheist* does not believe in the existence of God.

ago, back Prefer *ago* unless the reference point is a time in the past. If *back* is part of a quotation, do not change it.

agree You *agree on a proposal* or *to a proposal*; you do not *agree a proposal*.

agri-business Not *agro-business*.

ahead of Avoid; use *before* or *in advance of*.

ahead of the curve At the forefront of recent developments or trends. Similarly, *behind the curve* means *lagging behind recent developments or trends*.

aid and abet A redundancy. Often one of the verbs will convey what you want to say, *abet* being the more forceful and appropriate one in contexts involving criminal intent.

aide An overused word for *assistant*. Resist it except in headlines.

aide(s)-de-camp

aide-memoire(s)

AIDS Acquired immune deficiency syndrome. Normally, no need to spell it out. Do not use terms like *AIDS victims* and *suffering from AIDS*. These imply helplessness and are considered insensitive. Use *people with AIDS* or *people living with AIDS* instead. Do not describe AIDS as a disease; it is a medical condition that leads to a number of diseases.

AIIMS All caps. All India (not *All-India*) Institute of Medical Sciences.

ain't Most authorities consider it non-standard. Use only in quoted matter or special contexts.

air(-) airbag, airbase, airborne, airbrush, aircondition, airconditioner, airconditioning, aircrew, airdrop, airfield, airfoil, airframe, airfreight, airlift, airline, airmail, airman, airship, airsick, airspace, airspeed, airstrip, airtight, airwaves, airworthy

air-cooled, air-raid (adjective), air-strike (adjective)

air brake, air crash, air express, air gun, air lane, air pocket, air raid (noun), air rifle, air shaft, air strike (noun)

Airbus Cap. Do not hyphenate.

aircraft Singular and plural; *aircrafts* is wrong. Make sure you use the correct names of aircraft. Jane's All the World's Aircraft is a standard source.

AIR CRASH
When reporting an air crash, identify the airline and the type of aircraft. Give the flight number, the route, the number of passengers and crew, and an estimate of casualties. Check the availability of a passenger list. Check on weather in the crash area. Be extremely careful with any eyewitness report or other statement that appears to impute blame to any party. Be as specific as possible in identifying the type of aircraft (for example, a Boeing 747-400, not just a Boeing 747), its seating or passenger configuration, its power system, its age and its replacement or insured value.

airdash Do not use this ugly word coined in India at a time when air travel was a novelty. Use *fly*.

air fares Two words, as *rail fares* and *bus fares*.

air force Cap in references to the Indian Air Force. SEE ALSO **ARMY**.

Air Force One (the US president's plane), **Air Force Two** (the US vice president's plane)

AIR FORCE RANKS SEE **MILITARY RANKS**.

air hostess, stewardess Sexist terms; do not use them. Ever heard of an air host? Use *flight attendant*, *cabin attendant*, *cabin crew* or *cabin staff*.

airlift Do not use it as a synonym of *fly*, as in *The injured man was airlifted to hospital*. Reserve it for shuttle services: *The US airlifted 50,000 troops to the Gulf*.

airport Use the name of the place followed by lowercase *airport:* Heathrow airport, Sahar airport, Santa Cruz airport. Also, IGI airport, JFK airport. Do not use *the* before the name of an airport: *Heathrow airport* or *IGI airport,* not *the Heathrow airport* or *the IGI airport*.

Airports Authority of India

air show Two words. Cap when specific: *the Farnborough Air Show*.

aka (also known as) No full stops.

AK-47, AK-56 Note the hyphen.

akimbo Use only with reference to arms, never legs. It means *hands on the hips with elbows turned outwards*.

al- Lowercase, always with a hyphen. Used in Arabic names, it means *the*, so avoid writing *the al-…* . Generally, in the middle of a name it is not capped: *Moqtada al-Sadr*.

à la carte

Al Badr

albino(s)

ALCOHOL AND DRIVING

In India, the permissible level of alcohol in a driver's blood is 30mg per 100ml (Section 185 of Motor Vehicles Act, 1988). The limit is 80mg in the US and the UK, and 50mg in France, Germany and Italy.

SEE ALSO **DRUNK DRIVING**.

alfresco (adverb and adjective) As an adverb, it means *in the fresh air* or *outdoors*: *dining alfresco*. As an adjective, it means *outdoor* or *taking place outdoors*: *an alfresco conference*.

alibi means a claim to have been elsewhere when a crime was committed. Do not use it as a synonym of *excuse*.

Alimuddin Street Street on which the CPM headquarters in Kolkota are located. By extension, the state CPM leadership.

A-list Adjective used to describe a group of people who are considered to be the most famous, successful or important: *Only A-list celebrities were invited to the party*. Avoid coinages like *C-list* and *Z-list*.

SEE ALSO **B-LIST**.

Al Jazeera This is how the name is spelled on the television network's website.

all(-) all-star team, all-woman team (not *all-stars team*, *all-women team*)

all-American (noun and adjective)

Allahu akbar Arabic expression meaning *God is the greatest*.

allege, alleged, allegedly Do not report allegations without saying who made them. Do not allow anonymous sources to *allege*.

If a person has merely been accused of a crime but his guilt is not yet proved, the copy and even the headline must use *accused*, *alleged* or *allegedly*. An accusation or claim often becomes definitive in the absence of these words.

Apply the modifier *alleged* or *suspected* to the offence, not to the suspect: *alleged theft*, not *alleged thief*. Try to rephrase *alleged* or *allegedly* to conversational English: *accused of*, *charged with* or *suspected of*. But do not refrain from using *allegedly* if the accusation otherwise becomes definitive.

Do not use *alleged* when you mean *apparent*, *ostensible* or *reputed*.

Avoid redundant uses of *alleged*. Do not write *Police accused him of allegedly taking a bribe*. Make it *Police alleged that he took a bribe* or *Police accused him of taking a bribe*.

Do not use *alleged* to describe an event that has taken place, when the dispute is merely over who participated in it. Instead of *Jewellery worth Rs 10 lakh was taken away in the alleged theft*, write *Jewellery worth Rs 10 lakh was allegedly taken away in the theft*.

Do not use *alleged* or *allegedly* as a cover to publish outlandish allegations. *Alleged* or *allegedly* does not shield the reporter and the paper from defamation charges. All allegations reported in the paper must be thoroughly verified.

SEE ALSO **ACCUSED** | **ARREST**.

All England Club Home of the Wimbledon Championships. No hyphen.

All England Open Badminton Championships For short, *All England*. No Hyphen.

allies, allied Do not cap except in proper names or in references to World War I and World War II alliances.

all mouth and trousers (not *all mouth and no trousers*) is said of a person who talks and boasts a lot but does not deliver.

allocate (set something aside for a specific purpose, as in *a budget of Rs 10 crore was allocated for the campaign*), **allot** (assign something as a person's share with an implied restriction, as in *each speaker was allotted five minutes*)

allot, allotted, allotting

all right The form *alright* is considered non-standard in American English as well.

all-round (adjective) Hyphenate. In American English, *all-around*.

all-rounder Hyphenate.

all-time A record is a record; do not write *all-time record*. Avoid also *all-time high*. Use terms like *highest level ever* or *highest level on record.*

all together (all in one place or a group, all at once, as in *They arrived all together*), **altogether** (entirely, in every way, as in *She stopped seeing him altogether.* | *The idea is not altogether new.*)

allude, refer To *allude to* something is to speak of it without directly mentioning it. To *refer* is to mention it specifically.

SEE ALSO **ELUDE, ALLUDE**.

allusion, delusion, illusion An *allusion* is *an indirect reference* and is in no way connected to the other two words. Both *delusion* and *illusion* denote a false perception, but they are quite different in meaning. A delusion results from a misconception or a mental disorder: *delusions of grandeur*. An illusion results from external factors; we often know that it is false. A mirage is an illusion. *Delusion*, unlike *illusion*, has a corresponding verb: *delude*.

alma mater

almost exactly Something can be either exact or not; it cannot be almost exact.

almost never Avoid. Use *seldom* or *hardly ever*.

alongside

along with Two words; do not treat *along with* as a grammatical equivalent of *and. Along with other convicts, Sanjay Dutt was granted bail* but *Sanjay Dutt and other convicts were granted bail.*

al-Qaida (Osama bin Laden's group) Lowercase, hyphenated; cap it only when it is placed at the beginning of a sentence or in a first-letters-capped headline. But: *Al Badr, Al Jazeera*.

alsatian Use uppercase for all breeds of dogs

also-ran (noun)

altar, alter An *altar* is a raised platform on which sacrifices or offerings are made to a god or an ancestor. To *alter* is to change.

alternate means that A and B take turns; **alternative** means you have a choice between A and B. As an adjective, *alternate* can also mean *every second one*: *We meet on alternate Sundays.* As a noun, *alternative*, long restricted to choices between only two options, now also means *one among several*: *There are four alternatives.*

although, though *Although* is considered slightly more formal but the two are interchangeable except at the end of sentences, where only *though* can be used *("Have you ever been to Madrid?" "No. I'd like to, though."*). Also, *although* cannot replace *though* in the phrases *as though* and *even though*.

In compound sentences formed with *although* or *though*, do not use *but*. In such sentences *yet* is not wrong, but it should be avoided: *Although she smiled, she was angry.*

aluminium is the British spelling, *aluminum* is American. Do not change the spelling in names: *Aluminum Company of America is now called Alcoa*.

alumnus, alumni An *alumnus* (plural *alumni*) is a boy or man who has attended a particular school, college or university. A girl or woman who has attended a particular school, college or university is an *alumna* (plural *alumnae*).

Alzheimer's disease

am (time) Lowercase, no full stops, no space after the figure: *8.30am*, not *8.30 am*. Note the full stop in the figure; do not use a colon instead. Do not use a redundant expression like *8am this morning*; just *8am* is fine. Also: *5am*, not *5.00am*.

ambassador at large No hyphens.

America, American The terms refer not only to the US but to all of North America and South America. They may be used in their limited sense of referring to the US if the context is clear. *North American* includes Canadians. *Latin American* covers everyone on the mainland from the Rio Grande to Cape Horn, and the Spanish-speaking Caribbeans. *South American* excludes Mexicans and citizens of the Central American states.

American airlines Use *US airlines* when referring to US airline companies. Reserve the term *American Airlines* for the airline of that name.

Americas Cup (golf), **America's Cup** (yachting)

amicus curiae Legal term meaning *friend of the court*. The plural *amici curiae* is rarely used. In later references, write *the amicus* or the *"friend of the court"* (in quotation marks, without hyphens, no itals). Here, itals have been used for a different reason (SEE **WORDS AS WORDS**).

amidst Use *amid*.

Amnesty International Spell out in first reference; *Amnesty* thereafter and in headlines.

amok Not *amuck*.

among, between In general, *between* applies to two things and *among* to more than two. But *between* is appropriate in reference to more than two when the relationship is reciprocal: *fighting between the many peoples of Yugoslavia*; *treaties between European countries*; *trade between the US, Canada and Mexico*. When more than two things are related in a purely collective way, use *among*.

amongst Use *among*.

amoral (not concerned with morality), **immoral** (evil, wicked)

ampersand Use when it is part of an organization's official name: *Ernst & Young*, *Procter & Gamble*, *Jammu & Kashmir*, *J&K*. Use also in established terms like *B&B* and *R&D*.

Do not use it as a substitute for *and* in copy or headlines.

amulet is a charm against evil; **epaulette** (American spelling *epaulet*) is a decoration on the shoulder of a uniform.

an SEE **A, AN**.

anaemia, anaemic in British English; *anemia*, *anemic* in American.

anaesthesia is the British spelling; *anesthesia* is American.

analog Use it in the context of computers and technology. Otherwise, *analogue*.

analysis Plural *analyses*.

analyst Qualify the word while using it as a source: *diplomatic analysts*, *military analysts*, *money market analysts*, *telecom industry analysts*.

SEE ALSO **SOURCING**.

aneurysm Not *aneurism*. Excessive localized swelling of the wall of an artery.

Angeleno A native or inhabitant of Los Angeles. Plural *Angelenos*.

angry You can be *angry with* or *angry at* somebody.

ANIMALS

Use the pronoun *it* for an animal unless it has a given name or its sex is clear: *The dog bit its owner.* | *The bull tossed his horns.* | *Katie the cat is playing with her friends.*

annex (verb), **annexe** (noun) In American English, *annex* in both senses.

anniversary Keep the following examples in mind while computing the number: Seema and Sunil were married in 2003; they celebrated their *fifth wedding anniversary* in 2008. The same applies to birthdays: Sonu was born in 2005; his parents celebrated his *first birthday* in 2006.

A person's 50th birthday is also his or her 50th birth anniversary. Do not make the mistake of calling the 50th anniversary the 51st birthday.

The birthday logic, however, does not hold when you are talking of landmarks like Independence Day or Republic Day. India became independent in 1947. August 15, 1947, was its first Independence Day. In 2007, it celebrated the *60th anniversary* of its independence but its *61st Independence Day.* India became a republic in 1950, so in 2010, it celebrated its *60th anniversary as a republic* but its *61st Republic Day*.

ANNOUNCEMENTS
Only competent authorities make announcements. Others simply *say*, or *make statements*. Do not write *it was announced* ...

SEE ALSO **SOURCING**.

announce to Never use a construction like *The Prime Minister announced to introduce a new job scheme*. Make it *The Prime Minister announced a new job scheme*.

SEE ALSO **CONSIDER TO**.

anoint Note single *n* after *a*; do not write *annoint*.

anomaly Not *anamoly*.

ANONYMOUS SOURCES
Allow a source anonymity only as a last resort, when you think that readers will be otherwise deprived of important and reliable information. Use anonymous attribution only for information, not for opinion. Try to provide the most specific possible identification of the source rather than saying *a source said*. Sources should not be allowed to use anonymity and attack people, organizations or policies.

If a pejorative remark is worth reporting, first discuss it with the section editor. Paraphrase such remarks rather than giving them in quotes.

SEE ALSO **ACCUSED** | **ALLEGE, ALLEGED, ALLEGEDLY** | **FAIRNESS AND IMPARTIALITY** | **SOURCING**.

another Do not write *Six men were killed and another 23 injured*. Make it *Six men were killed and 23 injured.*

Another is not a synonym of *additional*; it refers to a number that is equal to a previously stated number. *Five candidates were selected, another five rejected* is right, but *Five candidates were selected, another 10 rejected is* wrong.

antagonist, protagonist An *antagonist* is an adversary; a *protagonist* is the central character in a drama or novel.

ante(-) antechamber, antedate, antediluvian, anteroom

Hyphenate when a proper name follows *ante*: ante-Victorian

antenna In reference to insects, the plural is *antennae*; in reference to radio or TV, the plural is *antennas*.

anti(-) antiaircraft, antibacterial, antiballistic, antibiotic, antibody, anticancer, anticlimax, anticlockwise, antidepressants, antifreeze, antihero, antimagnetic, antimatter, antimissile, antioxidant, antiparticle, antiretroviral, antisocial, antitrust

Hyphenate compounds beginning with *anti* if they would otherwise be difficult to understand, or if the second element begins with *i* or a capital letter:

anti-abortion, anti-aging, anti-apartheid, anti-democratic, anti-dowry, anti-emetic, anti-globalization, anti-inflammatory, anti-inflation, anti-intellectual, anti-national, anti-personnel, anti-rejection, anti-semitic, anti-slavery, anti-smoking, anti-war, anti-American, but Antichrist

anticipate To take action in expectation of; not synonymous with *expect*.

antipodes, antipodean Cap when referring to Australia and New Zealand. Lowercase in the sense of *direct opposite of something*.

(on the) anvil An outdated expression, now seen only in Indian writing. Prefer alternatives like *under preparation*, *in the works*.

anybody, anyhow, any way (in any manner), **anyway** (in any event; do not use *anyways*, which is not-standard in American English too)

any more Two words in British English; generally one word in American English.

anyone, any one Generally, *anyone* is one word, but if the emphasis is on singling out an individual in a group, it should be two words: *Any one of them may win.*

anywhere Often redundant, as in *The price is anywhere between Rs 10,000 and Rs 20,000.* Delete it.

Apec Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation [Forum].

apex(es)

APOSTROPHE

Use the apostrophe to denote a contraction: *it's*, *he'll, you're, there's*.

Use the apostrophe in expressions like *10 years' imprisonment* and *30 days' notice*, where the time period modifies a noun like *imprisonment* or *notice*. But drop it if the time period modifies an adjective: *25 years old*, *seven months pregnant*. In these examples the time period modifies the adjectives *old* and *pregnant* respectively.

Write *a year's worth*, *five days' worth*, *a million dollars' worth*, but *$1 million worth*, *Rs 1 crore worth*.

Do not use the apostrophe while forming plurals of numerals or abbreviations: *1990s*, *PCs*, *TVs*. But use the apostrophe while forming plurals of small letters: *p's, q's*.

SEE ALSO **POSSESSIVES**.

app Software application, typically for mobile devices.

appal, appals, appalling, appalled

apparatchik An unquestioningly loyal subordinate. Original meaning: *a communist official*.

apparent, apparently A person cannot die of *an apparent heart attack*. You probably mean *the person died apparently of a heart attack*.

appeal To carry a case to a higher court: *The company is appealing against the ruling*. In American English, *against* is dropped: *The company has 30 days to appeal the verdict to the Supreme Court*. In British English, *against* is not dropped. Stick to the latter

appendix Plural *appendices*.

(upset the) apple cart Not *applecart*.

APPOSITION is a device in which a word or phrase is put after another to define or explain it. In *Radha's husband, Suresh, works for an IT company*, the second term (Suresh) explains the first (her husband). The word or phrase in apposition appears between commas, or sometimes between long dashes or brackets. Omitting the commas around *Suresh* would imply that Radha has more than one husband. In careless writing or editing, the second comma or dash is often omitted. Guard against this. It can be omitted only if, logically, it would come at the end of the sentence.

appraise (to evaluate), **apprise of** (to inform)

April Fool's Day, April fool But: *All Fools' Day*.

apropos Not *a propos*. Both *apropos* and *apropos of* are fine.

aqua(-), aque(-) Of or relating to water. Note the absence of *c* before *q*.

aquamarine, aquarium(s), aquatic, aqueduct (not aquaduct), aqueous (relating to or resembling water)

Arab, Arabic, Arabian An *Arab* is a member of an ethnic group predominant in much of the Middle East and North Africa. The word *Arab* is not used to describe a geographical area, but it can be used as an adjective in geographical contexts: *Arab world*, *Arab countries*. As a noun, *Arabic* refers to the language spoken by most Arabs. As an adjective, it is used in phrases like *Arabic language*, *Arabic literature* and *Arabic numerals*. The *Arabic press* means newspapers written in Arabic, while the *Arab press* includes newspapers produced by Arabs in other languages.

The adjective *Arabian* is largely confined to geographical contexts: *Arabian peninsula*, *Arabian desert*. It is also applied to folklore and mythology: *Arabian Nights*.

Aravali Not *Aravalli*.

arbitrate, arbitration Do not confuse with *mediate*, *mediation*. An arbitrator hears different parties and then hands down a decision; a mediator listens to the different arguments and then tries to bring the parties to agreement.

arch(-) archangel, archbishop, archdeacon, archduke, archway

arch-enemy, arch-liberal, arch-radical, arch-rival

Also, hyphenate when a proper name follows *arch*: arch-Republican.

Archaeological Survey of India

archaeology Never *archeology*, not even in American English.

archipelago(s)

arctic Lowercase for adjective meaning *frigid*; cap for region around the north pole.

Argentine, Argentinian The two words have the same meaning. Describe the people of Argentina *as Argentinians*. In other contexts, prefer *Argentine* as an adjective.

arguably One of the most overused words in the language. Avoid.

army Cap in references to the Indian Army. Cap also when referring to a specific formation: *the US 1st Army*, *the British 8th Army*. Lowercase *army* in a general sense or in references to the armies of other countries: *the Pakistani army, the army of the unemployed*, *an army of locusts*. Use figures

for military units: *1st Army*, not *First Army*; *15 Corps*, not *Fifteenth Corps*, *15th Corps* or *XV Corps*.

army officer Not *army official*.

ARMY RANKS SEE **MILITARY RANKS**.

aromatherapy One word. The use of aromatic plant extracts and essential oils for therapy.

around Prefer *about* or *approximately*: *about $1 million, approximately 50,000 people.*

around, round As adverbs or prepositions, the two words are interchangeable. British English makes a subtle distinction between them: *round* is used for definite, specific movements (*she turned round*) and *around* in contexts that are less specific (*he drove around the countryside*). Americans make no such distinction and generally prefer *around*.

In certain expressions, only *round* can be used: *all the year round* | *they went round and round in circles*.

arrest Avoid any suggestion that somebody is being judged before a trial. Instead of *arrested for killing*, write *arrested on a charge of killing*.

SEE ALSO **ACCUSED** | **ALLEGE, ALLEGED, ALLEGEDLY**.

arriviste A person who has recently gained power, wealth or success, and is regarded as an upstart.

artefact is the British spelling; *artifact* is American.

article, section Cap when they are placed before a number, as in *Article 19 of the Constitution*, *Section 302 of the IPC*. In subsequent references, *the article*, *the section*.

artist, artiste An *artist* is a person who creates works of art, especially paintings or drawings. An *artiste* is a professional entertainer, such as a singer, a dancer or an actor. *Artist* also means *artiste*. Use the shorter *artist* in both senses.

artwork One word.

as, even as Terms overused, especially in intros, to link or contrast two developments that may sometimes have only a distant connection. Use only when the developments are contemporaneous and closely linked.

ascendancy, ascendant

Asean Not all caps. Association of Southeast Asian Nations. The members of Asean are Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand and Vietnam.

Asia-Europe Meeting For short, *ASEM*. Headquarters are in Singapore.

asinine Stupid, silly; note single *s*.

as many You do not say *as many as third*; you say *as many as three*. But *as many* is often wrongly used: *This was the third death in Tihar in as many days*. Make it *This was the third death in Tihar in three days.* Similarly, *fives times in five days*, not *five times in as many days.*

as of Avoid expressions like *as of October 1* or *as of January*. Use *on*, *after* or *since*.

as per The expression is stilted; use *according to*.

aspirin But *Disprin*. Prefer *aspirin* to *Disprin*, which is a trademark.

assassin, killer, murderer An assassin is a politically motivated killer. A killer is anyone who kills with a motive of any kind. A murderer is one who is convicted of murder. *Murder* is a legal term.

SEE ALSO **ASSASSINATE, ASSASSINATION** | **EXECUTE, EXECUTION** | **MURDER, KILLING, HOMICIDE**.

assassinate, assassination Reserve these words for a fatal surprise attack on a prominent political or religious leader.

SEE ALSO **ASSASSIN, KILLER, MURDERER** | **EXECUTE, EXECUTION** | **MURDER, KILLING, HOMICIDE**.

assembly Lowercase. For example, *Karnataka assembly, Jharkhand assembly, UN general assembly*. House should also be in lowercase.

Assocham Associated Chambers of Commerce and Industry.

assure, reassure Transitive verbs, always followed by a direct object. *The Prime Minister assured* is wrong; *The Prime Minister assured the people* is right.

as to Generally, it should be omitted before words like *how*, *what*, *whether*, *which* and *who*.

AstroTurf Trademark. Note caps.

as well as Unlike *and*, this phrase joins two items without creating a plural. The verb must agree with the first item: *Ramu as well as five of his friends was asked to appear before the high court.*

as yet Normally, *yet* is sufficient but *as yet* may be needed in expressions like *as yet unidentified.*

at, in SEE **IN, AT**.

ATF Aviation turbine fuel. Prefer *jet fuel* or *aviation fuel*.

athlete's foot A common fungal infection between the toes in which the skin becomes itchy and sore, cracking and peeling away.

athlete's heart Athletes often have enlarged hearts. When this is a natural, physiological adaptation to regular endurance exercises, the condition is called athlete's heart. Those with athlete's heart often have a slow heart rate — considerably less than 60 beats per minute. It is believed to be a benign condition but may be hard to distinguish from abnormal, pathological changes associated with some heart diseases.

A320, A380 No hyphen.

at large No hyphen in *ambassador at large*, *delegate at large*, etc.

at least Two words.

ATM stands for *automated teller machine*. Do not write *ATM machine*.

atmospherics (mood, ambience) Avoid this pompous word; *atmosphere* is simpler and better.

attempt (verb) is often stilted; *try* is better.

attend You *attend* a meeting, school, college or church; but a doctor or a nurse *attends to* a patient, a salesman *attends to* a customer and the President's staff *attend to* her. In passive constructions, *to* is not needed. A patient, a customer or the President can merely be *attended*, rather than *attended to*. There is no such phrase as *attend on*. Some people use it out of confusion derived from *wait on*.

attorney general Lowercase, no hyphen. Plural *attorneys general*.

ATTRIBUTION SEE **SOURCING**.

audiovisual One word.

auger (a tool used for boring holes), **augur** (portend a good or bad outcome)

auntie Aunty, not auntie

au pair

autarchy (autocratic rule), **autarky** (economic self-sufficiency)

author Avoid this word as a verb; *write* is better: *George Orwell wrote* (not *authored*) *"Nineteen Eighty-Four"*. Use *author* for both men and women; do not use *authoress*.

auto means *car*, as in *the auto industry*. In India, it also means *autorickshaw*. Compounds in which *auto* means *autorickshaw* should be written as two words: *auto driver*, *auto fare*.

automaker One word.

auxiliary Note single *l*.

avail You do not *avail of* something, you *avail yourself of* it. Anyway, the expression, like all bureaucratese, is best avoided. Prefer *get* or *benefit from*.

avant-garde Note hyphen.

avatar Not *avtar* or *avataar*.

avenge, revenge Conventionally, *avenge* has been reserved for *just retribution* and *revenge* for *malicious retaliation*. According to Webster's New World College Dictionary, *avenge* implies the infliction of deserved or just punishment for wrongs, whereas *revenge* implies the infliction of punishment as an act of retaliation, usually for an injury against oneself, and connotes personal malice, bitter resentment, etc, as the moving force. However, as Burchfield points out in New Fowler's Modern English Usage, the distinction often goes unobserved.

Revenge is usually a noun, but can also be a verb in formal style; *avenge* is always a verb.

Both these sentences are fine: *He vowed to avenge his murdered sister*. | *He vowed to revenge his murdered sister*.

You *avenge* (or *revenge) yourself on somebody*: *He avenged* (or *revenged*) *himself on his father's killers*. An alternative construction is possible: *He vowed to be revenged* (but not *avenged*) *on his father's killers*.

You *avenge* (but not *revenge*) *something*: *AC Milan avenged last season's defeat*. | *He vowed to avenge his father's death*. It would be wrong to write *He vowed to revenge his father's death*.

Revenge as a noun: *Australia wanted to get revenge for their defeat in the World Cup.* | *She took revenge for being dumped by her lover.* | *Iran vowed to take revenge on Israel for the killing of a physicist in a bomb attack*.

Revenge as an adjective: *revenge attacks, revenge killings*.

SEE ALSO **VENGEANCE, REVENGE**.

average, mean, median, norm In everyday speech and writing, the word *average* is used for what is called *mean* in statistics. It is arrived at by adding a set of values and dividing the sum by the number of values. For example, if a batsman scores 24, 60, 50, 69 and 127 in five innings, the average

is *(24 + 60 + 50 + 69 + 127) / 5 = 66*. The median is the value that comes midway in the series if the values are arranged in an ascending or descending order. In the above example, the median score is 60 because if the scores are put in an ascending order (14, 50, 60, 69, 127), 60 comes midway. If there were six scores instead of five, the median would be the mean of the third and the fourth. The median is often a more useful guide than the mean, which can be distorted by figures at one extreme or the other. A norm is a standard that is required or regarded as normal; it can be an average.

Write *on average*, not *on an average* or *on the average*: *Prices have increased on average by 5%*.

(an) average of takes a plural verb: *An average of 5,000 jobs are being created every year*.

averse (unwilling or reluctant), **adverse** (opposed or unfavourable)

avocado(s)

avoid, evade SEE **EVADE, AVOID**.

Awacs Airborne warning and control system. There is no such thing as *Awac*.

awake, awaken SEE **WAKE, WAKEN, AWAKE, AWAKEN**.

award, reward An *award* is given for excellent performance; a *reward* is given in return of services rendered.

awestruck One word.

a while (noun), **awhile** (adverb) *Stay awhile* but *stay for a while,* not *stay for awhile*. The idea of *for* is implicit in *awhile*.

awol Lowercase; absent without leave. Acronym acceptable in all references.

axing Not *axeing*.

axis Plural *axes*.

ayes and nays

ayurveda, ayurvedic Lowercase. Other systems of medicine too are lowercase: *allopathy*, *homeopathy*.

***

No story is fair if reporters hide their biases and emotions behind such subtly pejorative words as refused, despite, admit and massive.
— **Ben Bradlee,** executive editor (1968-91), Washington Post

B

b (bit), **B** (byte) SEE ALSO **BIT**.

Ba'ath Party, Ba'athist

babu is often used as a synonym of *bureaucrat*, but many bureaucrats find it pejorative. Use with care.

baby boomer A person born during a baby boom, especially one born in the US between 1946 and 1964.

SEE ALSO **GENERATION X, GENERATION Y, GENERATION NEXT**.

babysit, babysitter No hyphen.

baccalaureate Lowercase, but cap *International Baccalaureate*.

bachelor If relevant, write *unmarried man*.

back(-) backache, backboard, backbone, backbreaking, backcourt, backdoor (adjective), backdate (verb), backdrop, backfield, backfire (verb), background, backhand, backlog, backpack, backpedal, backrest, backspin, backstage, backstreet, backstretch, backstroke, backswing, backtrack, backup (noun and adjective), backwoods, backyard

back-end, back-foot, back-room, back-seat (all adjectives); back-stabbing (noun)

back door, back foot, back office, back pain, back room, back seat (all nouns); back up (verb)

(-)back Compounds ending in *back* are one word when used as nouns or adjectives:

comeback, fastback, halfback, hatchback, rollback, setback, throwback

They are two words when used as verbs: come back, roll back, set back, throw back

piggyback (noun, verb, adjective and adverb)

back benches (parliamentary) Two words. But: *backbenchers*, *backbench revolt*.

back burner No hyphen. Avoid this overworked term.

back door (noun), **backdoor** (adjective, as in *He was a backdoor appointee*) Do not use *backdoor* as a verb, as in *He backdoored his admission*.

backlash A strong reaction to a previous protest or movement; unless there is a lash, there cannot be a backlash. An overworked word; avoid it.

backside is the part of the body that you sit on; do not use it when you mean simply *rear* or *back*.

bacteria Plural of *bacterium*; do not write *the bacteria is*.

Bafta Not all caps. British Academy of Film and Television Arts.

bagel

Baha'i An adherent of a religion founded by the 19th-century Iranian prophet Baha-ullah. Note apostrophe.

bail out, bale out You *bail out* a prisoner. You also *bail out* (rescue) a company or a person (from debt or other difficulty), or *bail* water *out of* a boat. But you *bale out* (jump out) *of* an aircraft that is going to crash. The distinction often goes unobserved and *bail out* is used in all these senses, especially in British English. Try to keep the distinction. Also remember, a bundle of hay, straw, cotton or wool is a *bale*; the pieces atop the stumps in cricket are *bails*.

bailout (noun) One word.

Baisakhi The day marks the beginning of a new solar year and is celebrated as a harvest festival in Punjab and some other parts of north India. It has great religious significance for Sikhs — on this day in 1699, Guru Gobind Singh established the Khalsa. Baisakhi corresponds to April 13 or 14 of the Gregorian calendar.

bait (deliberately annoy or taunt; entice by putting food on a hook or in a trap: *He baited the hook with a piece of meat*), **bate** (reduce the force or intensity of, as in *bated breath*)

baker's dozen means 13.

balance of payments, balance of trade A country's *balance of payments* is the difference between the amount of money it pays to other countries, especially for imports, and the amount it receives, especially from exports, over a particular period. When the money received by the country exceeds the money paid by it, it has a *balance of payments surplus*. When it is the other way round, the country has a *balance of payments deficit*.

A country's *balance of trade* is the difference in value between its imports and exports over a particular period.

Balance of trade includes imports and exports of goods only. Balance of payments considers all business with other countries: imports and exports of goods, and money earned from or paid for services and investments; for example, tourism or shares in companies.

balance sheet Two words.

balk To be unwilling to do something because it is difficult or dangerous. Do not write *baulk*.

ball(-) ballboy, ballcock, ballgirl, ballgown, ballpark, ballplayer, ballpoint, ballroom

ball-flower (an architectural ornament consisting of a ball in the flower-shaped hollow of a circular mould)

ball carrier, ball club, ball field, ball game

(-)ball baseball, basketball, football, hairball, handball, hardball, lowball, snowball, softball, volleyball

crystal ball

no-ball

balloted, balloting Note single *t*.

ballyhoo As a verb, *to create enthusiasm* or *to promote colourfully and vigorously*. As a noun, *a lot of noise and activity*.

baloney (foolishness or nonsense) Not *boloney*.

Banaras Hindu University *Banaras*, not *Benares*, in the university's name. The city, however, was known as *Benares* before the name *Varanasi* was adopted.

Band-Aid is a trademark. Generic terms are *plaster*, *sticking plaster*.

bandanna

B&B Bed and breakfast, as in *B&B accommodation*.

bandobust Not *bundobust*.

bandwagon One word.

Bangalore Bengalaru, not Bangalore

banister Note single *n*.

BANKRUPTCY

A company becomes bankrupt or insolvent when a court rules that the company is unable to meet its debts. The ruling may be sought either by the company voluntarily or by creditors. The court appoints an official receiver to manage and eventually realize the debtor's assets on behalf of the creditors. Terms like bankruptcy, insolvency and liquidation have different legal meanings. Be as precise as possible in reporting what a company or court says.

bantamweight Not *bantomweight*.

bar(-) barbell, barkeeper, barmaid, barroom, bartender

bar chart, bar code, bar graph

bar-hop (verb)

barbaric (savagely cruel, as in *a barbaric attack*), **barbarous** (crude or unsophisticated, as in *barbarous English*)

barbecue Not *barbeque*.

Barc Bhabha Atomic Research Centre.

Baroda Although the city's name has changed to Vadodara, certain names retain *Baroda*: Bank of Baroda, Baroda Cricket Association, Baroda cricket team, Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda and Baroda House (headquarters of Northern Railway in New Delhi).

barrel In the US, a *standard barrel* contains 31.5 gallons; in Britain, 36 imperial gallons. For international dealings in crude oil, the measure is different: 42 US gallons, or 35 imperial gallons.

SEE ALSO **GALLON** | **OIL STATISTICS**.

based out of Do not use this faddish but flawed expression. Write *based in*.

basically An overworked word. Rarely adds anything to a sentence. Avoid it.

basis Often bureaucratese. Instead of *The situation is being monitored on a day-to-day basis*, write *The situation is being monitored daily*.

bas-relief

batchmate One word. This Indian coinage is acceptable.

bated breath Not *baited breath*; *bated* is related to *abated*.

bath(-) bathhouse, bathmat, bathrobe, bathroom, bathtub

bath salts, bath towel

(-)bath acid bath, bubble bath, sponge bath

bloodbath

bathos (ludicrous change from the lofty to the ordinary in writing or speech), **pathos** (quality that evokes pity or sadness)

battalion Not *batallion*.

battle(-) battlefield, battlefront, battleground, battleship

battle-axe, battle-scarred

battle cry, battle fatigue, battle station(s)

battle royal Not *battle royale*.

bazaar Not *bazar*.

BC, AD SEE **AD, BC**.

BCE (before common era), **CE** (common era) These are non-religious alternatives to *BC* and *AD*. Use *BC* and *AD*, which remain the predominant forms throughout the world.

be-all and end-all Note hyphens.

beat The past tense is *beat* and the past participle *beaten*. The form *beat* as a past participle is a substandard Americanism. Do not write *He was beat*. Make it *He was beaten*.

beat a retreat, Beating Retreat The phrase is *beat a retreat*. It also takes such forms as *beat a hasty retreat* and *beat an embarrassing retreat*. The military ceremony held at Vijay Chowk in New Delhi on January 29 every year to mark the conclusion of the Republic Day festivities is *Beating Retreat*, not *Beating the Retreat*.

beatify In the Roman Catholic Church, to state officially that a dead person lived a holy life. This official statement is usually the first step towards making the person a saint. Do not confuse *beatify* with *beautify*, which means *to make something beautiful or more beautiful*.

beau(x)

bed(-) bedchamber, bedclothes, bedfellow, bedpost, bedridden, bedroll, bedroom, bedsheet, bedside, bedspread, bedspring, bedtime

bed-and-breakfast, bed-hop (verb), bed-wetting

bed jacket, bed linen, bed rest

bedouin A desert Arab. Same in singular and plural.

befitted, befitting Note double *t*.

beg the question In its original sense of a logical fallacy, the phrase means *to assume the truth of something you want to prove*. For example, you beg the question when you say "lying is wrong because we must always tell the truth" or "God is almighty because he is omnipotent".

However, the phrase has acquired the meaning *pose the question* or *prompt the question: Absurd as that is, it does beg the question of what equality is, of what feminists are working toward* (New York Times). | *It does beg the question of which other classics might be suited to a horror film makeover* (Guardian).

The stylebooks of both Guardian and New York Times, however, advise against the use of *beg the question* to mean *pose the question*. Avoid it if you do not want to be misunderstood.

behind bars Not *behind the bars*.

beleaguered Note the *e* after *u*. An overworked word, best avoided.

bellwether (not *bellweather*) originally meant a sheep (wether) wearing a bell and leading a flock; by extension, it means *a trend indicator*.

bemused has traditionally meant *confused* or *bewildered*. Of late, it has also acquired the meaning *amused in a curious and detached way*. Avoid its use in this sense if you do not want to be misunderstood.

bench Lowercase even while referring to a court bench.

benchmark One word.

(the) benefit (of the doubt) The expression is *the benefit of the doubt*. Do not omit the definite article preceding *doubt*.

benefited, benefiting Note single *t*.

Benelux Belgium, the Netherlands and Luxembourg.

beriberi A disease caused by thiamin (vitamin B1) deficiency. One word.

bermuda shorts (also *bermudas*) Lowercase. The sense is not *of Bermuda*; the shorts can be from anywhere. For the same reason, *french kiss* is lowercased. But: *Bermuda Triangle*, because it is a proper name.

beseeched, besought Use *beseeched* if you insist on this uncommon word.

beset Both *beset by* and *beset with* are correct. But it is a pompous word. Use alternatives like *harass* or *trouble*.

beside (at the side of), **besides** (in addition to)

beside the point Not *besides the point*.

besiege Not *beseige*.

(as) best *I'll do as best I can*, not *I'll do as best as I can*.

bestseller, bestselling No hyphen.

bet (verb) Past tense and past participle *bet*, not *betted*.

bête noire

BETTING ODDS

Three types of odds are in use: fractional, decimal and American.

Fractional odds are the conventional odds. They are common in the UK and also the most popular in India. Fractional odds multiplied by your stake equal your profit.

Arsenal to win vs Manchester Utd @4/5
stake: 100 units
profit: 4/5 x 100 units = 80 units
return: stake + profit = 180 units

Decimal odds, commonly used elsewhere in Europe, are also known as European odds. Whereas fractional odds tell you how much profit there is from a 1 unit stake, decimal odds show you how much money will be returned from a 1 unit stake. If a team is presented with odds @1.80, you will get 1.8 units back from a stake of 1 unit.

Arsenal to win vs Manchester United @1.80
stake: 100 units
return: 100 x 1.80 = 180 units
profit: return – stake = 80 units

To convert fractional odds to decimal odds, add 1 to the fraction. Fractional odds @4/5 will mean decimal odds @(4/5 + 1) = 1.80.

American odds are either positive or negative. For example, +400 or –125. Positive odds show how much profit you will make if you stake $100. If a team is presented with odds +400, you will make a $400 profit for a stake of $100. Negative odds show how much you will have to stake in order to gain a profit of $100. If a team is presented with odds of –125, you will have to stake $125 to gain a $100 profit. American odds of +400 will mean fractional odds of 4/1 or decimal odds of 5.0. American odds of –125 will mean fractional odds of 4/5 or decimal odds of 1.80.

In India, *odds* generally means *fractional odds*. Odds are normally quoted *against* a result. If bookmakers are quoting odds of *5-2 against* a particular team, then, if that team wins, a bet of Rs 100 will get you (5/2) x Rs 100 = Rs 250 plus the stake. This is expressed as *5-2*; *against* is commonly left unwritten.

However, if the odds are given as *3-2 on*, then a bet of Rs 300 will get you Rs 200 plus the stake. In effect, *3-2 on* means the same as *2-3 against*.

Express fractional odds like this: *5-2*, not *5/2* or *5-to-2*.

Remember: If the odds against something have lengthened, it is less likely to happen.

bettor A person who bets.

between, among SEE **AMONG, BETWEEN**.

between you and me Not *between you and I*.

between X and Y Not *between X to Y* or *between X-Y*.

Beverly Hills

beware may or may not be followed by *of*: *beware fake drugs*, *beware of dogs*.

Bharat Ratna India's highest civilian award.

SEE ALSO **PADMA VIBHUSHAN, PADMA BHUSHAN, PADMA SHRI**.

bi Do not use this slang word for *bisexual*.

bi(-) Compounds formed with *bi* are one word:

biannual, bicameral, bifocal, bilateral, bilingual, bimonthly, bipartisan, bisexual, biweekly

biannual (twice a year), **biennial** (every two years) The words are almost always misused. To avoid confusion, use *twice a year* or *every two years*.

Bible Cap when the reference is to the Old Testament or the New Testament. Otherwise lowercase: *Wisden is the bible of cricket lovers.* The adjective is *biblical* (lowercase) in all senses.

Bible Belt Not *Bible belt*.

bicentenary is a 200th anniversary; **bicentennial** is its adjective.

biceps Singular and plural; there is no such thing as *a bicep*.

bid Do not use in copy as a synonym of *effort*, *attempt* or *try*. Acceptable in headlines, but to be used sparingly. In the sense of greeting or saying goodbye, the past tense of *bid* is *bade*; in business uses and bridge games, the past tense is *bid*.

bidi Not *beedi*.

Big Apple means *New York*; it does not mean *the US*.

big-ticket (adjective)

bigwig

bilateral Instead of *India and the US are holding bilateral talks*, write *India and the US are holding talks*. Talks between two countries can be nothing but bilateral.

billion A billion is 1 followed by nine zeros. It is equal to 1,000 million, or 100 crore. Abbreviate *billion* to *bn*, not *b*. Even in copy use *bn* for sums of money, quantities or inanimate objects: *$20bn*, *1bn litres of water*. Otherwise, use *billion*: *five billion people*, not *5bn people*. In headlines, use *bn* or *billion*. Use *m* for *million* and *tn* for *trillion*.

SEE ALSO **MILLION** | **TRILLION**.

billionaire Not *billionnaire*.

binge-watch Watch many episodes of a show in one sitting.

bio(-) Compounds are one word:

biochemistry, biochip, biodata, biodegradable, biodiesel, biodiversity, bioengineering, bioethics, biofuel, biogas, biomass, biomedical, biomolecule, biophysics, biopiracy, biorhythm, biotechnology, bioterrorism, biowarfare

bird-hit

bird's-eye view

birth(-) birthday, birthmark, birthplace, birthright, birthstone, birthweight

birth canal, birth certificate, birth control (noun), birth rate, birth sign

birth-control (adjective, as in *birth-control pill*)

(-)birth childbirth

BIRTHDAY SEE **ANNIVERSARY**.

bisexual Do not use *bi*.

bit In computing, a bit (short for *binary digit*) is a single basic unit of information — an electrical pulse representing 0 or 1. Clusters of bits form *bytes*. The amount of information being sent over a communication line is expressed in bits per second, or bps.

biweekly means *every two weeks*. Sometimes, it is also used to mean *semi-weekly*, or *twice a week*. To avoid confusion, use *every two weeks* or *twice a week* as the case may be.

bizarre

black Uppercase Black and all racial designations derived from skin colour (Whilte, Brown, Yello). African-American is often used in place of Black in the US. The term *coloured* for a black person is considered offensive except in South Africa, where it refers to a person of mixed-race parentage.

In business stories, *in the black* means *in profit* in Britain, but *making losses* in some other places. Use *in profit*.

black(-) blackboard, blackbuck, blacklist, blackmail, blackout (noun), blacksmith

black and blue (as in *beat somebody black and blue*), black book, black bread, black diamond, black dwarf, black eye, black flag, black hole, black sheep, black spot

black-and-white (adjective, before a noun), black and white (when used after a noun or a verb)

Blade Runner

blame game Two words.

blasé

blast-off (noun), **blast off** (verb)

bleeding edge describes advanced technology that is still being developed and may cause problems because it has not been fully tested.

SEE ALSO **DISABILITIES**.

B-list Adjective used to describe a group of people who are considered to be fairly famous, successful or important, but not as much as the A-list people: *a fashion event full of B-list celebrities*. Avoid coinages like *C-list* and *Z-list*.

SEE ALSO **A-LIST**.

bloc, block A *bloc* is a coalition of people, political parties or countries with a common interest, as in *communist bloc*. The word *block* has a much wider range of meanings. As a noun it may denote a lump, a quantity of things considered as a single unit, a large building or an obstruction: *a block of wood*, *a block of shares*, *an office block, a mental block*.

blond, blonde The adjective is always *blond*, the noun is *blond* (male) or *blonde* (female).

SEE ALSO **BRUNET, BRUNETTE**.

blood sports

bloody mary A drink made of vodka and tomato juice.

blow means *a hard hit*: *He received a severe blow on the head.* | *The election result dealt a further blow to the Congress*. In this sense, you can strike a blow *at*, *against* or *to* something.

However, to strike a blow *for* someone or something means *to help or support someone or something*: *He claims to be striking a blow for gender equality by employing an equal number of men and women.* | *The court's decision strikes a blow for gay rights in India.*

blowback The unintended adverse results of a political action or situation: *The blowback from the Afghan conflict in Pakistan has meant that Asif Ali Zardari's government has lost control of much of the North-West Frontier Province.*

blue-blooded

blue chip (noun), **blue-chip** (adjective) *Infosys is among the blue chips on the Bombay Stock Exchange.* | *Infosys is a blue-chip stock*.

blue-collar workers

blue on blue A military term referring to an attack made by one's own side that accidentally harms one's own forces: *blue-on-blue incidents*.

blueprint Look for a simpler substitute like *plan*, *scheme* or *proposal*.

Bluetooth Wireless standard for short-range interconnection of mobile phones and other electronic devices. It allows users to connect without going through the phone company. *Bluetooth* has nothing to do with *blue* or *tooth*. It is an anglicized version of the name of the Viking king Harald Blátönn, who united Denmark and Norway. Bluetooth *unites* electronic devices.

bn Short for *billion*. SEE ALSO **BILLION**.

board Cap only when it occurs in a name.

Board of Control for Cricket in India In subsequent references, *the BCCI* or *the board* (not *the Board*).

boards (board exams) Lowercase.

body(-) bodybuilding, bodycheck, bodyguard, bodyline (bowling), bodyshaper, bodysurf, bodywork

body armour, body art, body bag, body blow, body clock, body corporate, body count, body double, body fluid, body language, body mass index, body odour, body piercing, body shield, body shirt, body shop, body stocking, body suit, body warmer

body-hugging (adjective)

body politic All the people of a particular country considered as an organized political group: *This new policy has touched a nerve in the American body politic*.

boffin Do not use as a synonym of *scientist*, except ironically or in direct quotations.

bogey (a thing that causes fear, often without reason; in golf, a score of one stroke over par), **bogie** (the chassis of a railway vehicle; do not use this word if you mean a railway carriage; use *coach* instead)

bohemian Lowercase. A person, especially an artist or writer, who lives in an unconventional, nonconforming way. Cap it only in references to Bohemia, the historical name of what is now the Czech Republic.

(-)bomb car bomb, fire bomb, petrol bomb

Hyphenate as an adjective: *a car-bomb attack*

Bombay Although the city's name has changed to Mumbai, some organizations retain *Bombay* in their names: Bombay Bar Association; Bombay high court; IIT, Bombay; Bombay Natural History Society; American School of Bombay; Bombay Stock Exchange. But: University of Mumbai, Mumbai Port Trust.

bona fide (in good faith, genuine, real; the opposite is *mala fide*), **bona fides** (the state of being exactly as claims or appearances indicate)

Bona fide, *bona fides* and *mala fide* are never hyphenated; do not italicize them. Here, they have been italicized for a different reason (SEE **WORDS AS WORDS**).

There is no such word as *malafides* or *mala fides*.

bonhomie

booby trap (noun), **booby-trap** (verb)

book(-) bookbinder, bookcase, bookend, bookkeeper, bookmaker, bookmark, bookseller, bookshelf, bookshop, bookstall, bookstore, bookworm

book bag, book club, book dealer, book fair, book jacket, book learning, book transfer, book value

(-)book bankbook, chequebook, guidebook, notebook, pocketbook, schoolbook, storybook, stylebook, textbook

reference book

Booker prize The full name is Man Booker Prize for Fiction.

BOOKS

Do not italicize book titles; put them in double quotation marks. Omit quotation marks for the titles of standard reference works like dictionaries or encyclopedias, and for religious books like the Gita, the Ramayana, the Quran and the Bible.

booster Additional vaccine dose to strengthen immunity.

bored with Not *bored of*.

borewell

Boston Strangler Name given to the murderer or murderers of several women in Boston in the early 1960s.

both Redundant in most phrases that contain *and*; *both politicians and bureaucrats* says no more than *politicians and bureaucrats*.

Do not mix up *both* and *as well as,* as in *The goal, according to a Wall Street Journal spokeswoman, is to capitalize on both the traffic that comes from search engines as well as to encourage people to subscribe to the Journal* (Cited in Style & Substance, Wall Street Journal's newsletter on style).

A preposition placed after *both* should be repeated after *and*: *both for me and for my brother.* If the preposition is placed before *both*, there is no need to repeat it after *and*: *for both me and my brother.*

botox Lowercase in generic sense; cap while referring to the trademark. Botox is a substance which is injected into the skin of the face in order to make the skin look smooth and young. It can also be used as a verb: *Do you think she's been botoxed?*

bottleneck

bottomline One word.

Botts' dots are round, non-reflective and raised pavement markers for use on roads.

SEE ALSO **CATSEYE**.

bougainvillea Not *bougainvillaea*.

boulevard

(-)bound deskbound, eastbound, housebound, northbound, snowbound

Hyphenate when *bound* follows a proper name or produces an unfamiliar coinage: India-bound, fame-bound, time-bound.

boundary Not *boundry*.

bourgeois (adjective), **bourgeoisie** (noun)

bow legs Legs that curve outwards at the knees; also called bandy legs. Adjectives: *bow-legged*, *bandy-legged*.

bow tie

box office (noun), **box-office** (adjective)

boy, girl A male older than 18 is a man, not a boy. A female older than 18 is a woman, not a girl.

boycott (organized refusal to buy a particular product or service), **embargo** (legal restriction against trade)

boyfriend One word. The term is informal and best reserved for teenagers.

bp Abbreviation for *basis point(s)*. SEE ALSO **PERCENTAGE POINT.**

BRACKETS

Brackets should be used sparingly. See if a pair of commas or dashes will do. When you use a parenthetical attribution, remember to use a second comma or dash; its absence can cause ambiguity.

Familiar initials like US, UN and Nato need not be spelled out even in first reference. Not-so-familiar names should be spelled out in first reference. If an

abbreviation or acronym that readers may not immediately recognize is to be used more than once, give it in brackets at first mention.

There is no need to give the abbreviation or acronym in brackets if it is familiar. In such cases, use the abbreviation or acronym in the next sentence or the next paragraph so that the reader is able to make the connection. To avoid alphabet soup, or a mass of initials, use terms like *the organization* or *the commission*.

A comma, a colon or a semicolon never directly precedes an opening or closing bracket.

Use square brackets in direct quotes when an interpolation is added to provide essential information: *"If you [the media] widen your focus, you will see thousands of BJP workers who have lifted me on their shoulders," Modi said.*

Use round brackets to describe an action that is not part of a dialogue, as in *Sanjay Dutt: (Laughs) I was very lucky*.

If the sentence is logically and grammatically complete without the information contained within brackets, the punctuation stays outside the brackets. (A complete sentence that stands alone in brackets starts with a capital letter and ends with a full stop.) — Guardian stylebook

braggadocio Boastful or arrogant behaviour.

Brahman (the Supreme Being), **brahman** (Hindu priestly caste), **brahmin** (in general reference to aristocracy, as in *Boston brahmins*)

braille

brainchild A cliché. Avoid.

brainstorm, brainstorming

brain-teaser

brand (verb) *Police branded him a terrorist*, not *Police branded him as a terrorist*.

brand-new (adjective) Hyphenated only when used before a noun. Two words when used after a noun: *The book is brand new*.

braveheart Inspired by the 1995 Mel Gibson movie, Indian newspapers use this word to refer to brave soldiers or children, or anyone who displays courage.

bread(-) breadbasket, breadboard, breadbox, breadstick, breadwinner

bread and butter (noun), bread-and-butter (adjective)

bread crumbs, bread line

break(-) breakaway (adjective), breakdown (noun), breakfast, breakneck, breakout (noun), breakthrough (noun)

break away, break down, break even, break off, break in, break out, break through, break up (all verbs)

break-dancing, break-dance, break-even (adjective), break-in (noun), break-off (noun), break-up (noun)

breastfeeding One word.

breaststroke One word.

breathable

breathtaking One word.

breech birth A feet-first delivery.

Bretton Woods Bretton Woods, in New Hampshire (US), was the site of the United Nations Monetary and Financial Conference in 1944, which led to the establishment of the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund in 1946. Hence, these two organizations are called Bretton Woods institutions.

bribe(-) bribe-giver, bribe-giving, bribe-taker, bribe-taking

bric-a-brac Miscellaneous objects or ornaments of little value.

brickbat (noun) One word.

bridegroom, bridesmaid

Bridget Jones's Diary (novel and film) Not *Jones'*.

bring, take Keep the difference between the two words in mind. If a person arrested in Hyderabad is taken to Surat by police, a possible headline for the Ahmedabad edition is *Accused brought to Surat*, but for other editions, *Accused taken to Surat*. In copy, go by the dateline. For instance, even in the Ahmedabad edition, if the copy has a Hyderabad dateline, the development mentioned above will be described as *The accused was taken to Surat*.

Britain Do not use *England* as a synonym of *Britain* or *the United Kingdom*. Great Britain (often referred to as Britain) comprises England, Scotland and Wales. The UK comprises Great Britain and Northern Ireland. In most contexts, *Britain* will do.

SEE ALSO **GREAT BRITAIN** | **UNITED KINGDOM**.

British, Briton(s), Brit(s) The people of Britain. Do not use *Britisher(s)*. You can write *an American* or *an Indian*, but you should not write *a British*. Instead write *a Briton*. Use *the British* as a collective noun for

the people of Britain. *Brit*, unlike *Jap*, is not considered pejorative and is acceptable in headlines.

SEE ALSO **ENGLISH, ENGLISHMAN(MEN), ENGLISHWOMAN(WOMEN)**.

British Isles The United Kingdom, the Republic of Ireland, Isle of Man and Channel Islands.

broach (initiate, pierce), **brooch** (an ornament)

broccoli Note double *c*, single *l*.

Brookings Institution In Washington; not *Institute*.

browbeat

brownie points

brunet, brunette The adjective is always *brunet*; the noun is *brunet* (male) and *brunette* (female).

SEE ALSO **BLOND, BLONDE**.

brussels sprouts

brutalize means *render brutal*. Therefore, *soldiers may be brutalized by the experience of war* means *soldiers may become brutal*. Although sticklers insist that the use of the word should be confined to this sense, most dictionaries recognize a second meaning: *treat brutally*. This usage is quite common; it is acceptable if the meaning is clear from the context.

Bt corn, Bt cotton Note lowercase *t* in *Bt*. *Bt* is short for the bacterium *Bacillus thuringiensis*.

budget Cap in expressions like *Union Budget*, *Union Budget 2010-11*. In subsequent references, *the budget*.

budget deficit SEE **FISCAL DEFICIT, REVENUE DEFICIT, PRIMARY DEFICIT**.

buffalo(es)

bug, tap A bug is a tiny microphone hidden in a room or other area to secretly record conversations. A tap is a device connected to a phone to capture conversations from the line. Both words are used as verbs too.

build-up (noun), **build up** (verb)

built-up (adjective)

bullfight, bullfighter, bullfighting

bullseye is the British spelling; *bull's-eye* is the form prevalent in American English.

bumblebee

bund Indian word for an embankment.

bundgala

bungalow Note the *a* after *g*.

bungee jumping No hyphen.

buoyant Not *boyant*.

buoyed up by Not *buoyed by*.

bureau(s)

burgeon For something to burgeon, it must be new, so do not write *India's burgeoning population*.

burglar

Burma SEE **MYANMAR**.

burned, burnt Use *burned* as a verb and *burnt* as an adjective: *burnt cakes*, *burnt wood*.

burqa Not *burka*.

bus Do not write *passenger bus*; *bus* is sufficient.

bush fire Two words.

businessman, businesswoman Use for individuals. When referring to a group use *business community*, *business people* or *business executives*. Do not use *businessperson* or *businesspersons*.

buss Kiss.

bus stop Two words.

buttermilk One word.

buyback (noun), **buy back** (verb)

buy-in (noun)

buyout (noun and adjective), **buy out** (verb)

buzzword One word.

by(-) byelection, bylaw, bylane, byline, bypass, byplay, byproduct, bystander, byway, byword

BYLINES, CREDIT LINES

All bylined stories by Times of India writers have a Times News Network, or TNN, credit line. There is no *By* before the writer's name:

Prakash Singh | TNN

New Delhi:

For a non-bylined story by a TOI writer, use the credit line only:

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

New Delhi:

Spell out *Times Insight Group*; do not use *TIG* as a credit line:

Prakash Singh
TIMES INSIGHT GROUP

A story with a single byline should normally have a single dateline. A byline like the following means that the writer is reporting from two places:

Prakash Singh | TNN

New Delhi/Kolkata:

If that is not the case, let the dateline be the place from where the writer is reporting and give credit to the inputs from the other place or places at the end of the story. If the inputs are crucial to the story, use a multiple dateline and a joint byline.

Syndication services like New York Times and Sunday Times, London, normally insist that bylines not be dropped from their articles. When in doubt, check with Times Syndication. In agency stories, give credit at the end of the story. An agency piece may be carried with a byline if it is, for instance, a gripping first-person account.

SEE ALSO **DATELINES**.

byte In computing, a unit of information consisting of eight bits. Write *soundbite*, not *soundbyte*.

SEE ALSO **BIT**.

***

This morning I took out a comma and this afternoon I put it back in again.
— **Oscar Wilde**

C

cabby Not *cabbie*; plural *cabbies*. *Cabby* is the spelling preferred by Concise Oxford Dictionary as well as the stylebooks of Guardian and New York Times.

cabdriver One word; but *yellow-cab driver, radio-cab driver*.

cabinet Cap when referring to the Union Cabinet. But *cabinet committee on political affairs*, *cabinet committee on economic affairs*, etc. Lowercase in references to state cabinets and kitchen cabinet.

cactus(es) In botanical contexts, the plural is *cacti*.

caddie (golf), **caddy** (tea), **Caddy** (the car)

cadre Generally used as a collective noun meaning *group* or *unit*: *a cadre of servicemen*, *a cadre of experts*, *a cadre of activists, a cadre of officers*. In this sense, *cadre* is singular and its plural is *cadres*, just as the plural of *group* is *groups*: *cadres of professionals*, *cadres of activists*. When *cadre* is used for an entire group but the emphasis is on individual members, it is treated as a plural noun, like *staff* or *crew*: *The CPM cadre are a committed lot*. The word can also be a singular noun and used for an individual member: *He has long been a CPI cadre*. | *Three CPM cadres were accused of rape and murder*.

caesarean section Lowercase; the shortened forms *c-section* and *c-sec* should be confined to headlines. Babies are delivered, not *born*, by this surgery.

caesar salad

caffeine Not *caffein*.

Cairene A native or inhabitant of Cairo. Plural *Cairenes*.

cakewalk

Calcutta Although the city's name has changed to Kolkata, some organizations retain *Calcutta*: Calcutta high court; University of Calcutta; IIM, Calcutta; Calcutta National Medical College; Rotary Club of Calcutta; Calcutta Stock Exchange; Calcutta Telephones. But: Kolkata Port Trust.

calendar Not *calender* unless you mean the machine with rollers between which paper or cloth is run to give it a smooth finish.

calibre Give calibres of weapons and ammunition in figures: *a .22 rifle* or *a .22-calibre rifle*, not *a 0.22 rifle* or *a 0.22-calibre rifle*.

Californian is a noun; the adjective is *California*, as in *California girls*.

call centre (noun), **call-centre** (adjective, as in *call-centre executive*)

camaraderie

Canada goose Not *Canadian goose*.

candle(-) candleholder, candlelight, candlepower, candlestick

canister

cannon (gun; singular and plural), **canon** (rule or standard, particularly of a church; plural *canons*)

cannot One word. But write *can not* as two words when the *not* forms part of another construction like *not only*: *She can not only sing but also dance*.

canvas (cloth or painting; plural *canvases*), **canvass** (to solicit votes or business)

capability Often stilted; *ability* or *capacity* is better.

capital Lowercase even if you mean the national capital or a state capital.

SEE ALSO **CAPITOL**.

CAPITALIZATION

Titles

Titles are used in three ways: (i) directly before names, (ii) before or after names and set off by commas, and (iii) without names. In all three cases, cap the following five Indian titles denoting constitutional offices: President, Vice-President, Prime Minister, Chief Justice of India and Speaker (of the Lok Sabha). Cap the above titles even when they refer to former Presidents, former Prime Ministers, etc.

Cap the following only when they are used directly before names: *president*, *vice-president* or *prime minister* of another country; *pope*; *chief justice* (of a high court); *justice*; and army, navy or air force designations. For example, *President Mahinda Rajapaksa*, *Prime Minister Brown*, *Justice Mukherjee*, *Lt Gen Sinha*. Generally, we do not use royal titles like *king* and *queen* but if they are to be used directly before names, for example, in quotes, cap them.

Except in situations mentioned above, lowercase all Indian and foreign titles. The following is a mere elucidation of what has been said above:

Write *acting Prime Minister*, not *Acting Prime Minister*.

Lowercase *chairman* (of the Rajya Sabha), *leader of the opposition*, *deputy speaker*, *minister*, *chief election commissioner*, *election commissioner*, *national security adviser*, *governor*, *lieutenant governor*, *chief minister*, *attorney general*, *solicitor general*, *advocate general* and *secretary*. For example, *home minister P Chidambaram*, *governor N N Vohra*, *chief minister Mayawati*.

Lowercase *chief justice* of a high court (when not used as a title directly before a name). Lowercase *pope*, as in *the election of a new pope*. But cap it when it is used as a title directly before a name: *Pope Benedict XVI*.

Lowercase *chairman*, *managing director* or *director* of a company.

SEE ALSO **TITLES**.

Other words

Write the Centre (Union govt), central govt, central ministries, central institutions, etc.

Lowercase ministry and department: home ministry, department of atomic energy, US department of state, etc.

Lowercase cabinet in all references.

Cap *Parliament*, *Supreme Court*, *Constitution*, *Army*, *Air Force* and *Navy* while referring to the Indian Parliament, Indian Supreme Court, Indian Constitution, Indian Army, Indian Air Force and Indian Navy. But lowercase assembly, govt and opposition.

Lowercase parliamentary and constitutional.

Lowercase parliamentary committee. For example, parliamentary standing committee on defence.

Lowercase high court when preceded by 'the', like the Delhi high court, the Bombay high court, the high court. Cap when mentioning it as a name, like Delhi High Court (without 'the')

Lowercase high commission, embassy, consulate, high commissioner, ambassador and consul general.

Lowercase communism, communist, socialism, socialist, leftist, left-winger, right, right-winger. Cap Left while referring to India's Left parties as a group and also while referring to the ideological Left. Cap Communist or Socialist if it is part of a party's name: Communist Party of India, Republican Socialist Party.

Upper house or lower house of India's Parliament should be in lowercase. Lowercase in the general sense of a chamber of parliament.

Cap Aborigines and Aboriginal while referring to native Australians, but lowercase aborigines and aboriginal in references to indigenous populations.

Cap Act, Bill and Ordinance only when using the full name, as in Representation of the People Act, Official Secrets Act, Broadcasting Services Regulation Bill; otherwise lowercase. In subsequent references, the act, the bill, the ordinance.

Lowercase administration, as in the Obama administration.

Lowercase internet, net, web, world wide web, website, chatroom, homepage.

Lowercase sensex, which has become an everyday word. But cap Nifty, which could mean effective or stylish if lowercased. The lowercase sensex is in the good company of lowercase names like sun, earth and internet.

Cap God (the Supreme Being). Otherwise lowercase: Ganesha is one of the Hindu gods. | Indra is the rain god. Lowercase personal pronouns referring to God. Lowercase god and goddess in references to false gods: Did you see that sex goddess in the corner?

Cap sea and ocean when using the full name: Black Sea, Red Sea, Caspian Sea, Atlantic Ocean, Pacific Ocean.

Lowercase seasons: spring, summer, autumn, winter.

Cap the names of aircraft: Concorde, Flogger, Tomcat, Boeing 747.

Lowercase euro. Other currencies too are lowercase: dollar, rupee.

Lowercase words derived from proper names when the sense is figurative rather than literal. For example, bermuda shorts, danish pastry, dutch courage, french fries, french kiss, russian roulette, machiavellian tricks. (Molotov cocktail is the only exception.) The meaning in these expressions is not of Bermuda, of Denmark, etc. The shorts or pastries can come from anywhere, and there are many machiavellis who play those tricks.

For words not mentioned here, see the individual entries for them.

capitol A building housing a state legislature or the federal legislature in the US. Cap it in reference to the building housing the US Congress.

cappuccino

capsize Never *capsise*.

CAPTIONS

Photo captions should normally explain what readers cannot see for themselves. Omit the obvious: *Pranab Mukherjee and Prakash Karat shake hands, a mother hugs her daughter*. Such information makes the reader say: "Am I blind?" For the same reason, do not write *share a joke* or *share a light moment*.

Use the present tense in captions about fresh news: *Maoists march in a rally in Kathmandu on Sunday*. If the caption includes information about something that happened yesterday or a few days ago, change the verb to a participle (*Maoists marching in a rally in Kathmandu on Wednesday)* or the past tense (*Maoists marched in a rally in Kathmandu on June 18*). Similarly, a caption recalling history should use the participle or the past tense, but never the past perfect tense.

With a mugshot, do not use a caption that merely gives the person's name. Pick an important or interesting point from the story and put it in the caption.

Generally, all captions should have kickers — lively but not frivolous or biased.

SEE ALSO **PHOTOGRAPHS**.

Caracas Capital of Venezuela. Do not confuse the spelling with *carcass*, which means *dead body of an animal*.

carat A unit for measuring the weight of diamonds and other precious stones, equal to 200 milligrams. Also, a unit for measuring the fineness of gold, equal to 1/24 part. Pure gold is 24 carats; gold that is 50% pure is 12 carats. American English uses *karat* for fineness of gold.

carbon dioxide When you use the chemical symbol, write CO_2, not *CO2*. Similarly, for water, H_2O, not *H2O*.

carbon footprint The amount of carbon dioxide and other greenhouse gases emitted through the combustion of fossil fuels by an organization as part of its daily operations. The concept also applies to individuals and households. A product or commodity too leaves carbon footprints on its way to the market.

SEE ALSO **ECOLOGICAL FOOTPRINT**.

carcade Do not use. Write *motorcade* instead.

carcass(es) Dead body of an animal. *Caracas* is the capital of Venezuela.

card(-) cardholder

card-carrying

(-)card scratchcard, smartcard, swipecard

credit card, debit card, sim card

cardiovascular

cardsharp (a person who cheats at cards), **card shark** (a skilful player of cards)

care(-) carefree, caregiver, caretaker, careware, careworn

(-)care childcare, healthcare

careen (to heel over, to sway or swerve while moving at high speed: *a motorcycle careening around sharp curves*), **career** (to go at top speed, especially in a headlong manner: *a car careered off the road*)

career girl, career woman Sexist terms. Do not use.

cargo(es)

Caribbean, the Note single *r* and double *b*.

carjack

Carlos the Jackal (no quotation marks, no commas) Mention his full name, Ilich Ramírez Sánchez, somewhere in the story.

carmaker One word.

carousal (a good time with drinking), **carousel** (conveyor-belt system for baggage collection)

car park Two words.

carpool (noun and verb) One word.

carry out Do not use as a synonym of *do*.

case Often you can do without it. *There are many cases of it being unnecessary* can be tightened to *It is often unnecessary*. *If it is the case that* simply means *if*. *It is not the case* means *it is not so*.

cash(-) cashpoint (British trademark for ATM, now genericized)

cash bar, cash book, cash cow, cash crop, cash discount, cash flow, cash on delivery, cash register

cash-and-carry (adjective), cash-strapped (adjective)

cashback Companies or shops offer *cashbacks* on debit card or credit card payments: you receive some cash, or sometimes just a rebate, on the purchases you make.

cash reserve ratio The level of minimum cash that banks must keep with the RBI in relation to deposits. If the RBI increases the cash reserve ratio, the amount available with banks goes down. This tends to push interest rates up. Increasing the cash reserve ratio is one of the methods employed by the RBI to contain inflation.

SEE ALSO **REPO RATE, REVERSE REPO RATE**.

casino(s)

casket Avoid this euphemistic word; use *coffin* instead.

cast(-) cast iron (noun), cast-iron (adjective)

cast-off (noun and adjective)

castaway (not *casteaway*) A person or thing cast out, an outcast. Original meaning: *a shipwrecked person*.

CASTE SEE **RACIAL, RELIGIOUS, REGIONAL AND LINGUISTIC LABELS** | **STEREOTYPES**.

CASTE NAMES
Lowercase caste names: *jat*, *lingayat*, *brahman*, *rajput*. Also: *dalit*. But cap religious designations: *Hindu*, *Muslim*, *Sikh*, *Jain*, *Christian*.

Cap a caste name when it is used as a surname.

catchphrase

catch-22 Lowercase unless referring to Joseph Heller's novel.

CAT scan SEE **CT SCAN**.

catseye One of a series of reflective studs set into a road as a safety device to guide drivers in the dark. It is a trademark, now genericized. For clarity, *reflective roadstuds* can be used. There is also a fictional character called Catseye.

SEE ALSO **BOTTS' DOTS**.

cat's-eye (gemstone)

cat's whiskers As in *He thinks he is the cat's whiskers* (he has a high opinion of himself).

causeway One word.

caution As a verb, prefer *warn*. For example, instead of *He cautioned that war was imminent,* write *He warned that war was imminent*. Generally, *warn* and *caution* are transitive verbs, but they are sometimes used as intransitive verbs, as in the examples above.

Cauvery Not *Kaveri*.

cave-in (noun), **cave in** (verb)

caviar Not *caviare*.

CBI Central Bureau of Investigation. It is a central government agency. A state government *recommends* or *asks for* a CBI inquiry; it cannot *order* a CBI inquiry. The CBI is under the department of personnel and training, not under the home ministry.

CCTV Closed-circuit television.

CD-ROM

CE, BCE See **BCE, CE**.

ceasefire One word as a noun. For example, *LTTE declared a ceasefire*. The verb is two words: *cease fire*.

celebrant, celebrator A *celebrant* officiates at a Christaian rite; a *celebrator* is a merrymaker.

celebutante The word is a cross between *celebrity* and *debutante*. It refers to a young woman from a rich family who receives excessive media attention, primarily for her wealth and lifestyle. Celebutantes are famous for being famous. Examples: Paris Hilton, Kim Kardashian.

cello(s)

cellophane Lowercase; it is now a generic term.

cellphone One word.

celsius Lowercase. Not *celcius*. All units named after scientists are lowercase; for example, *ampere*, *volt*, *watt*, *celsius*, *fahrenheit*. The abbreviation is the first letter (capped): *A* (ampere), *V* (volt), *W* (watt), *C* (celsius), *F* (fahrenheit).

Use figures for temperatures even below 10: *2 degrees celsius* or *2°C,* not *two degrees celsius*; also note *1 degree celsius* but *2 degrees celsius.*

Spell out rise or fall in temperature up to nine degrees: *The temperature rose by five degrees* (not *five degrees celsius*) *on Monday*. | *The temperature rose by 12 degrees* (not *12 degrees celsius*) *on Monday*.

To convert celsius to fahrenheit, multiply by 9, divide by 5 and add 32. You can also use an online converter.

SEE ALSO **CENTIGRADE** | **FAHRENHEIT**.

cemetery Not *cemetry*.

censor (to remove the parts of a book or movie that are considered to be offensive, immoral or a political threat), **censure** (criticize severely)

census Cap only if it is part of a name, as in *Census 2001*.

centenarian

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention The name of the US federal agency also known as CDC begins with *Centers*, *not Center*.

centigrade The same temperature scale as celsius. Use *celsius*.

SEE ALSO **CELSIUS** | **FAHRENHEIT**.

centimetre Abbreviation *cm* (no full stops, same singular and plural). Do not write *cms*.

Central Advisory Board of Education *CABE*, for short.

Centre, the Cap while referring to the Union government. Lowercase *central ministry*, *central aid*, *central institution*, etc.

SEE ALSO **CAPITALIZATION**.

centre(-) Some compounds are one word and some are two words:

centreboard, centrefold, centrepiece

centre back, centre field, centre forward, centre spread, centre stage

Centre Court (Wimbledon)

centre on Do not use *centre around*; if you want to use *around*, write *revolve around*: *The discussions centred on steps to make Delhi a safe city*. In certain contexts, *centre in* is used: *Most of the fighting was centred in the north of Iraq*.

century Lowercase and spell out from first to ninth: *the fifth century, the 21st century*. Hyphenate the adjective form: *18th-century philosophers*. Also: *the 1600s, the 1980s* (no apostrophe).

Cern Not all caps. European Organization for Nuclear Research, based in Geneva.

CFC Chlorofluorocarbon.

C'garh abbreviation for Chhattisgarh and Chd for Chandigarh in headlines. WB not to be used for West Bengal.

cha-cha-cha A dance of Cuban origin.

chador

chafe (feel annoyed or irritated, as in *People chafe when told what to do* or *Broadcasters chafed at the restrictions imposed by the government*; make or become sore by rubbing, as in *The collar chafed my neck* or *My feet are chafed*), **chaff** (as a noun, *husks of grain*; as a verb, *tease*)

chair As a noun, it can mean an endowed professorship: *Lucasian Chair of Mathematics*, *Jawaharlal Nehru Chair in International Environmental Law*. Avoid its use to mean *chairman* or *chairwoman*. Also avoid it as a verb meaning *lead a committee*; try *lead*, *head* or *preside over* instead. Similarly, avoid *co-chair* (noun and verb).

chairperson Use *chairman* or *chairwoman*, whichever is appropriate. Use *chairperson* for the head of an organization only if the organization uses the word as an official designation. Do not use *chairlady*.

SEE ALSO **(-)PERSON** | **SEXIST LANGUAGE**.

chaise longue Not *chaise lounge*. A couchlike chair with a back support and a lengthened seat.

chakka jam

challan can be used as a noun, or as a verb with past tense *challaned*.

challenged Do not use this euphemism for disabilities. Rather than *He is visually challenged*, write *He is blind* or *He is partly blind*.

SEE ALSO **BLIND** | **CRIPPLE, CRIPPLED** | **DEFORMED** | **DISABILITIES** | **HANDICAPPED** | **IMPAIRED** | **MENTAL HANDICAP, MENTALLY HANDICAPPED, MENTALLY ILL, MENTALLY RETARDED** | **VICTIM**.

champagne

Champions League (European football) No apostrophe.

Champs-Élysées Parisian boulevard leading from Arc de Triomphe.

chancy

changeable

changeover

channelled, channelling

Channel tunnel

chaperon, chaperone Although *chaperon* has long been the standard spelling, *chaperone* is now more common and preferred by dictionaries.

character (moral qualities), **reputation** (the way a person is regarded by others)

chargé(s) d'affaires

chargesheet Use only as a noun; as a verb, prefer *charge*.

charge that Do not use as a substitute for *allege that*.

charge with Not *charge of*, but *accuse of*.

chary A formal word meaning *wary*. Avoid.

chassis Singular and plural.

chaste is an old-fashioned word meaning *abstaining from extramarital, or all, sexual intercourse*. It can also mean *not showing sexual feelings*, as in *a chaste kiss on the cheek*. A third meaning is *plain*, as in *a chaste dress*. A common use of *chaste* in India is in sentences like *He spoke chaste Hindi*. Here, *pure Hindi* would be more appropriate.

chastise Not *chastize*.

chatline, chatshow Each is one word.

chauffeur

chav is British slang for *a young working-class person who dresses in casual sports clothes*. Avoid this derogatory word.

SEE ALSO **YOB**.

cheap Goods are cheap, prices are low. Do not write *cheap prices*.

cheater A person who cheats is a *cheat*, not a *cheater*.

check(-) checklist, checkmate, checkout (noun), checkpoint, checkpost, checkroom

check-in (noun), check-up (noun)

check in, check out, check up (all verbs)

cheer (verb) *Spectators cheered* (not *cheered for*) *the team*.

cheerleader One word.

cheese(-) Some compounds are one word and some are two words:

cheeseboard, cheeseburger, cheesecake, cheesecloth, cheesemonger

cheese cutter, cheese powder, cheese spread, cheese straw

chef de mission No hyphens.

Chek Lap Kok An island in the western waters of Hong Kong. By extension, the Hong Kong international airport situated on the island. The airport was designed by British architect Norman Foster and opened in 1998.

CHEMICAL ELEMENTS
Lowercase: *carbon, caesium, uranium*.

chequebook in British English, *checkbook* in American.

cherry-pick, cherry-picking

Chevy (Chevrolet) Not *Chevvy* or *Chevie*.

Chhath Hindu festival dedicated to the sun god. It is celebrated — mainly by people from Bihar, Jharkhand and eastern UP — on the sixth day of the Hindu lunar month of Kartik, six days after Diwali. Do not write *Chhat* or *Chat*.

Chhatrapati Shivaji International Airport is the official name of the Mumbai airport, formerly known as Sahar International Airport. The domestic terminal is still called Santa Cruz airport and the international terminal Sahar airport.

chickenpox One word.

chilblain Not *chillblain*.

childcare One word.

CHILDREN
Full name in first reference. In subsequent references, first name rather than surname if the child is 15 or younger. But use the surname if the seriousness of the story calls for it. For ages 16 and 17, use judgment but generally use the first name in light stories. Use the surname for those 18 or above.

SEE ALSO **JUVENILE OFFENDERS** | **NAMES**.

chilli(es) in British English, *chili(es)* in American.

chimpanzees are apes, not monkeys.

chip The phrase is *chip off the old block*, not *chip of the old block*.

chlorophyll

chock-a-block

chock-full

chocoholic, but *shopaholic* and *workaholic*.

chopper, copter Both are fine as conversational substitutes for *helicopter*.

chords (musical and in geometry), **cords** (vocal, spinal; also *umbilical cord*)

The phrase, perhaps an extension of the musical sense, is *strike* or *touch a chord*, not *a cord*: *The speaker struck a chord with his audience.*

christen Note that only people, not animals or inanimate objects, are christened. Besides, non-Christians may not like the word *christen* applied to them. In all contexts, *name* is a better verb.

christian name The term applies to Christians; *first name* is a general and better term.

Christmas Use *Xmas* only in headlines. Do not use *X-mas* or *X'mas*.

chronic, acute SEE **ACUTE, CHRONIC**.

church Lowercase for church as an institution, as in *Is the church relevant today?* Also: *Catholic church*, *Anglican church*. Cap when using the full name of a building of worship: *Holy Trinity Church.*

churchgoer

CIA Central Intelligence Agency of the US. *CIA* is fine even in first reference.

cigarette

CII Confederation of Indian Industry (not *Industries*).

circa means *approximately*; it does not mean *year*. It is used before an approximate date: *circa 1650.*

circumstances Write *in the circumstances* when you want to indicate merely that a situation exists. Use *under the circumstances* to indicate a situation in which action is necessitated or inhibited: *Under the circumstances, he had no choice but to resign.*

cissy Use *sissy*; plural *sissies.*

citrus (noun), **citrous** (adjective) In American English, *citrus* for both noun and adjective.

citywide One word.

(-)clad half-clad, snow-clad, steel-clad

ironclad

claimed This word suggests that you do not believe the statement in question. If that is not the case, use *said*.

claimed responsibility Avoid. Instead of *Al-Qaida claimed responsibility for the attack*, write *Al-Qaida accepted responsibility for the attack* or *Al-Qaida admitted it carried out the attack.*

clamour, clamouring But *clamorous*.

clampdown (noun), **clamp down** (verb)

class(-) classmate, classroom, classwork

class act, class struggle

class action (noun), class-action (adjective)

clean(-) cleanskin (somebody with no criminal record), cleanshaven

clean-cut, clean-up (noun)

clean up (verb)

clean chit is an Indian coinage, not used anywhere else. A person absolved of a charge or charges is said to have got *a clean chit*.

clear(-) clearway

clear-cut, clear-eyed, clear-headed, clear-minded, clear-sighted

clergy A collective noun, always plural. Do not write *a Sikh clergy*.

CLICHÉS

Clichés are words and phrases that have become meaningless with overuse. They irritate readers and have no place in good writing. Some of them to be strongly resisted are listed below:

are availing themselves of, at the end of the day, at this moment in time, attributable to, back burner, backlash, basically, bombshell, bonanza, boost, bottom line, brainchild, crisis, cutting edge, de-escalation, devout (as in *devout Hindu*, *devout Muslim*), dramatic, dyed-in-the-wool, elephant in the room, escalation, fash frat, fiercely independent, for real, game changer, giant, going forward, gourmet, have made available, having said that, high command, high-profile, horns of a dilemma, iconic, in a shocking incident, in connection with, in receipt of, in respect to, in the wake of, it's official, key, large-scale, lion's share, major, massive, meanwhile, mega-, methodology, million-dollar question, nip in the bud, ongoing, on the same page, phenomenon, politically correct, posh, predawn, prioritize, pulled no punches, pushing the envelope, quantum jump, quantum leap, raft of measures, ramp up, ratchet up, reportedly, rushed to hospital, ripe old age, scenario, sea change, sooner rather than later, space (as in *Bharti entered the retail space*), special, thinking outside the box, told TOI, touch base, upsurge, wake-up call, with a view to, whole range

Words overused in headlines: bash, bid, boost, eye, eyeing, flay, fuel, hike, hit, rap, row, signal, slam, spiral, set to, target

click (verb) Not *click on*.

cliffhanger

climactic (pertaining to a climax), **climatic** (pertaining to climate)

climbdown (noun), **climb down** (verb)

clingfilm A thin plastic film used for wrapping food.

clip-clop

clockwise, anticlockwise No hyphens; *anticlockwise* becomes *counterclockwise* in American English.

close call means the same as *close shave*.

(in) close proximity Write either *close* or *in proximity*.

close-up Noun and adjective; note hyphen.

clothesline One word; rope or wire on which you hang clothes to dry.

cloud computing Computer operations in which documents and data are created, edited and stored remotely on servers, and accessed by users via internet connections. The users do not need to have their own IT infrastructures and applications. *Cloud* is a metaphor for the internet.

cloud cuckoo land (no hyphen) Dreamland, also *la-la land*.

club(-) clubface, clubfoot, clubhand, clubhouse, clubman, clubroom, clubwear, clubwoman

club car, club chair, club class, club sandwich, club soda, club steak

club-class (adjective)

CNG Compressed natural gas. It is natural gas, or methane, used mainly as an auto fuel. It is the cleanest of all hydrocarbon fuels.

SEE ALSO **LNG** | **LPG** | **PNG**.

co(-) coefficient, coexist, coexistence, cohabitation, collateral, cooperate, cooperation, cooperative, coordinate, coordination

co-branded, co-chairman, co-chairwoman, co-defendant, co-ed, co-education, co-opt, co-owner, co-pilot, co-singer, co-star

coach A railway carriage. Do not use *bogie*. SEE **BOGEY, BOGIE**.

coal(-) coalfield, coalmine, coalminer

coast guard Lowercase; two words. *Coast Guard* in references to the Indian Coast Guard.

coastline

coat-tails

co-author, co-write Do not use. But *co-produce* and *co-sign* are fine.

cockfight One word as *bullfight*, *catfight*, *dogfight*.

co-ed It is dated and belittling when used for a female student in a co-educational school or college. But the adjective *co-ed*, as in *co-ed schools*, is fine.

coffee(-) coffeecake, coffeehouse, coffeepot

coffee bar, coffee break, coffee grinder, coffee maker, coffee mill, coffee shop, coffee table

coffee-table (adjective)

coffin Use this word instead of the euphemistic *casket*.

cognizable, cognizance Not *cognisable*, *cognisance*.

cognoscenti is plural and it means *experts*; the singular *cognoscente* is rarely used.

cold-blooded

cold war Lowercase. Write compound modifiers like this: *post-cold-war politics*, *pre-cold-war economies*.

Coliseum (London theatre), **Colosseum** (Rome)

collarbone One word.

collectible Not *collectable*.

COLLECTIVE NOUNS

Collective nouns — class, committee, crowd, family, flock, group, herd, jury, majority, orchestra, team, variety, etc — are generally treated as singular. But depending on the sense you want to convey, a collective noun sometimes needs to be treated as plural.

SEE ALSO **SINGULAR OR PLURAL?**

collector Not *collecter*.

collector's item

collision Avoid clumsy phraseology like *The Danish freighter was in collision with the German tanker*. Make it *The Danish freighter and the German tanker collided*.

Only two moving objects can collide. It is wrong, therefore, to write *The ferry collided with the jetty*. Use *hit* or *barged into*.

COLON

A colon indicates that what follows is an explanation or elaboration of what precedes it. What precedes the colon should normally be a complete sentence. What follows it may be a sentence, a phrase, a list or even a single word, as in these examples: *India is facing a terrifying problem: inflation.* | *There are seven continents: Asia, Africa, North America, South America, Antarctica, Europe and Australia.* | *The verdict is clear: if he does not play well, he will be out of the team.*

The colon should never be preceded by a space; it should never be followed by a hyphen or a dash.

The semicolon is not a substitute for the colon. All three sentences of the example above would be wrong if the colon were replaced with a semicolon.

Normally, lowercase the word after a colon. The word after a colon can be capped only when it begins a complete sentence introduced by what precedes it. In the last of the three examples above, *if* — the word after the colon — can be capped. In headlines, always cap the word after a colon.

Generally, use a colon rather than a comma to introduce a quotation. A comma can be used to introduce a quotation of one sentence or less.

Do not use a colon immediately after *is*, *are*, *was* or *were*. The second of the three examples above can be written as *The seven continents are Asia, Africa, North America, South America, Antarctica, Europe and Australia.*

If you are using *like*, *includes* or *including* to introduce a list, do not put a colon after it.

For clock times use a full stop, not a colon: *4.30am*, *9.20pm*.

Resist the staccato style that uses the colon merely as a substitute for a verb, as in *The reason: India has a population of more than a billion*.

colossal Note single *l* and double *s*.

colour Do not write a *red-colour car* or *a blue-colour sari*; *a red car* or *a blue sari* is what you mean.

colourblind

coloured(s) The term *coloured* for a black person is considered offensive except in South Africa, where it refers to a person of mixed-race parentage.

Columbia (as in District of Columbia, Washington DC; Columbia University, New York; Columbia Pictures; British Columbia, Canada; Columbia river; and Space Shuttle Columbia), **Colombia** (South American country frequently misspelled as *Columbia*)

combated, combating

comedian can be a man or a woman. Do not use *comedienne*.

comeuppance One word.

COMMA

Use commas to separate a word or phrase in apposition. *Shobha's husband Shekhar is a banker* implies that Shobha has more than one husband. Make it *Shobha's husband, Shekhar, is a banker*. Similarly, *Shyam's 20-year-old son, Anil, has been arrested* unless Shyam has more than one 20-year-old son. In careless writing or editing, the second comma is often omitted. Guard against this. It can be omitted only if, logically, it would come at the end of the sentence.

Use commas to set off non-essential clauses. SEE **THAT, WHICH**.

Use commas to separate elements in a series but, in general, do not use a comma before *and* or *or* in a series: *The most popular browsers are Internet Explorer, Firefox and Google Chrome*, not *The most popular browsers are Internet Explorer, Firefox, and Google Chrome*. However, a comma before *and* or *or* is sometimes necessary to avoid confusion: *The topics discussed at the meeting included road safety, communal harmony, and law and order.*

Use commas in compound sentences before conjunctions like *and*, *but* and *for*: *I cannot tell whether she is old or young, for I have never seen her.* However, the comma can be omitted if the clauses are short: *I missed lunch and I'm starving*.

A comma can be used to introduce a quotation of one sentence or less; for quotations of more than one sentence, use the colon. A comma may also introduce a paraphrase similar in form to a quotation but without quotation marks: *The point is, it is not essential.* | *The question is, is it necessary?*

Use the comma with *yes* and *no*: *Yes, I will go.* | *No, he is not here*.

In general, use the comma in figures in thousands and above: *1,365*; *11,280*. While placing commas in figures, keep this distinction in mind:

Figure	Indian system	International system
100000	1,00,000 (one lakh)	100,000 (100 thousand)
1000000	10,00,000 (10 lakh)	1,000,000 (one million)
10000000	1,00,00,000 (one crore)	10,000,000 (10 million)
100000000	10,00,00,000 (10 crore)	100,000,000 (100 million)

Remember, the comma is not used in designations of years, street numbers, room numbers, broadcast frequencies or telephone numbers.

For giving age, prefer commas to brackets: *Rishi, 25, is a good bowler* rather than *Rishi (25) is a good bowler.*

Use a comma if a day of the month is given with the year: *July 25, 2007*. The comma is essential before and after the year when the year follows a specific date: *the October 15, 2007, order*. Do not use the comma if only the month and the year are given: *July 2007*.

Do not put commas after house numbers: *10 Janpath*, *7 Race Course Road*, *10 Downing Street*.

Use commas to separate a series of adjectives equal in rank; if a comma can be replaced by *and* without changing the sense, the adjectives are equal in rank: *a quick, easy solution*, but *a cheap silk tie* — not *a cheap, silk tie* — because *silk tie* is equivalent to a single noun here.

Use a comma after a word used to address, greet or salute somebody: *Hello, friends*; *Sorry, dear*; *Goodbye, my countrymen*; *Good morning, friends*.

commander in chief Lowercase, no hyphens.

Commandments Cap in biblical contexts, as in *the Ten Commandments*.

commando(s)

commemorate

commence Avoid. *Begin* or *start* is better.

commented Normally, *said* is better.

commit Avoid expressions like *he committed a murder*, *he committed rape*. Instead write *killed*, *raped*. But *committed a crime* is fine. Do not forget to write *allegedly* or *accused* unless the guilt is proved.

committee

common(-) Most compounds are two words:

common ground, common law (noun), common room, common sense (noun)

common-law (adjective)

commonplace, commonsense (adjective), commonsensical (adjective)

common X has something in common *with* Y, but something is common *to* (not *between*) X and Y.

commoner A person who does not come from a royal or noble family; do not use it as a synonym of *common man*. In American English, *commons* is sometimes used for *common people*.

Commonwealth Games In subsequent references, *the games*. In headlines, *Games*. Avoid the abbreviation *CWG*.

communal In India, the use of the word is largely confined to such combinations as *communal riots*, *communal conflict* and *communal strife*. But it can also be used without implying something negative, as in *communal living*, which involves the sharing of work and property.

communiqué

communism

communist Lowercase in references to the ideology; cap in references to a specific party.

companion Appropriate for an unmarried partner of the same or the opposite sex.

compare to, compare with When you compare X *to* Y, you liken them, or regard them as similar: *Many commentators compared Obama to Kennedy*. When you compare X *with* Y, you weigh one against the other, or assess their similarities and differences: *Technology pundits compared Windows 7 with Windows Vista and said Windows 7 was much better*.

When *compared* is used to introduce a word, phrase or clause, either *to* or *with* can be used: *Compared to physics, maths seems easy.* | *The company made a profit of Rs 300 crore, compared with Rs 270 crore last year.*

In sentences like this, *with* can be used even though the idea is to convey only similarity: *His batting prowess compares with that of Tendulkar.*

COMPARISONS

Avoid confusing phrases like *times bigger, times taller*. Something *four times bigger* actually means *five times as big*. Write *five times as big. Four times smaller* does not exist because something can be decreased only *one time* before it vanishes. Write *one-fourth as small*.

complacence, complacency Use *complacency*. The adjective is *complacent*, not to be confused with *complaisant*, which means *willing to please others* or *willing to accept others' behaviour*.

complementary, complimentary Use *complementary* when two things or people fit together or one enhances the other: *The company's new plans are complementary to its existing business.* Use *complimentary* when you mean admiration or praise: *The boss was complimentary about her work*. Another meaning of *complimentary* is *free: complimentary passes, complimentary hotel accommodation.* Keep the same distinction between *complement* and *compliment*.

COMPOUND WORDS

A compound word that would be hard to decipher at a glance should be hyphenated. To avoid incongruity, a compound noun that is ordinarily one word should be separated when the first part is modified by an adjective; for example, *small-business man*, *private-school teacher*.

A compound modifier before a noun is usually hyphenated: *It was a well-written piece*. But omit the hyphen when the phrase follows what it modifies: *The piece was well written*.

Do not use hyphens after adverbs ending in *-ly*. For example: *wholly owned subsidiary, genetically modified food.*

SEE ALSO **HYPHEN**.

comprise means *consist of*. The whole comprises the parts: *The United Progressive Alliance comprises 12 political parties,* not *Twelve political parties comprise the United Progressive Alliance.*

Do not write *comprise of* or *comprised of*.

comptroller is really the same word as *controller*. It is used for a government official in charge of finance or audit, as in *comptroller and auditor general of India*.

concerned When it means *interested* or *involved*, put it after the noun: *I have called up all the ministers concerned.* When it means *anxious*, put it before the noun: *Concerned parents approached the principal.*

Ignoring the above distinction can result in incongruous constructions like this: *Three men were accused of molesting a woman on a bus. The concerned men were sent to jail.* The reader is left wondering why *concerned men* would molest a woman.

Concord (town in Massachusetts, US), **Concorde** (plane)

condescend

confectionery (sweets, cakes), **confectionary** (like a confection, of confectioners or their work)

confess (to), admit (to) Either word can be used in the sense of making an acknowledgment or admission. Except when it means *declaring your sins to God or a priest*, *confess* is usually followed by *to*: *The man confessed to being a spy*. | *He confessed to crimes he hadn't committed*. | *My husband confessed to having an affair with a woman in his office.* But: *He went to church and confessed his sins*.

Generally, *admit* is used without *to*: *She admitted theft.* | *He refused to admit his guilt.* | *She admitted having stolen the car.* | *No one has admitted responsibility for the bombing*. But in certain cases, *to* is required: *He refused to admit to the other charges.* | *After questioning by police, he admitted to the murder.*

Both *confess* and *admit* can be followed by *that*: *Rina confessed that she didn't know how to work the computer.* | *I am willing to admit that I do make mistakes.*

confidant (male), **confidante** (female)

confined People with illnesses or disabilities do not necessarily consider themselves confined to their beds, homes or wheelchairs; the term may exaggerate their limitations. Write instead that they use wheelchairs or are housebound or bedridden.

SEE ALSO **DISABILITY, DISABLED**.

conflate means *to combine, to mix*: *These two doctrines can be easily conflated.* | *Do not conflate today with tomorrow.* It does not mean *confuse*.

Cong man, Cong woman (not *Congman*, *Congwoman*) Short for a member of the Congress, the Indian political party. Use only in headlines.

Congo (river) Not *Zaire*.

Congo, Congo Republic For the country formerly called Zaire, use Congo. Its official name is Democratic Republic of Congo and capital is Kinshasa. Its western neighbour, with Brazzaville as capital, is Congo Republic, officially known as People's Republic of the Congo. It would be helpful to give the name of the capital when referring to either country.

Congress For the Indian political party, write just *the Congress*, not *Congress Party* or *Congress party*. The US Congress is the US parliament, comprising the Senate and the House of Representatives. Do not use *Cong* as an abbreviation for the US Congress.

congressional Lowercase.

Congressman, Congresswoman Cap while referring to a member of the Indian political party. Lowercase while referring to a member of the US Congress, but cap while using it as a title before the name of a member of the US Congress: *Congressman Ron Paul*, *Congresswoman Julia Carson*. The titles traditionally apply to members of the House of Representatives, not the Senate. The preferred title, though, is *representative*.

CONJUNCTION AT THE BEGINNING OF A SENTENCE
It is all right to start a sentence with words like *and*, *but* and *because*. It can lend starkness to your copy and create a dramatic effect. But do not use such constructions too often.

con man Two words.

connection Not *connexion*.

connote (to suggest or convey in addition to the explicit meaning), **denote** (to signify or refer to explicitly, to mean)

consensus (not *concensus*) Do not write *consensus of opinion* or *general consensus*. Write just *consensus*.

conservative Cap as a noun or adjective referring to a political party: *The scandal involved 20 Conservative MPs.*

considerable Avoid its lazy use as an adjective implying emphasis.

consider to Never use a construction like *The finance ministry is considering to increase tax rates*. Make it *The finance ministry is considering an increase in tax rates*.

SEE ALSO **ANNOUNCE TO**.

consist of introduces a full list: *A cricket team consists of 11 players*. Use *includes* to introduce a partial listing: *The team included five bowlers*.

Consolidated Fund

consortium(s)

constituency, constituents If you mean supporters, write *supporters*.

consult, consult with Write *consult*, not *consult with*.

consume People in our stories often *consume* chocolates, liquor, poison or even tea. Nobody will say you do not know English if you use the shorter and better *eat*, *drink*, *have* or *take*.

contagious, infectious Diseases spread by contact are contagious; those spread by air and water are infectious. Either can be used figuratively: *contagious laughter*, *infectious smile*.

contemptible (deserving contempt), **contemptuous** (showing contempt)

continent Lowercase after a name: *European continent*, *North American continent*. Cap *Continent* or *Continental* when it means *mainland Europe*.

continual (over and over again), **continuous** (unbroken)

controversial Attaching this word to a person, programme or institution without elaboration is an unfair shortcut. Specify the issue soon after the word appears.

convener Not *convenor*.

converter Not *convertor*.

convertible

conveyor belt In other senses too, *conveyor*, nor *conveyer*.

convince, persuade You *convince* people by giving them reason to believe something is true. You *persuade* people — by reasoning, pleading or coaxing — to do something. For example: *The high court was convinced of his guilt.* | *I persuaded her to see a doctor*.

Convince is followed by an *of* phrase or a *that* clause: *He convinced the teacher of his ability*. | *She convinced her sister that it was too late*.

Never write *convince to*, as in *She convinced him to go to a movie*.

Persuade is more versatile than *convince* and can be followed by any of the three constructions.

cookie Not *cooky*.

cooled, cooler, coolly

cooperate No hyphen, but *co-op* if contracted in headlines. In first-letters-capped headlines, *Co-op*, not *Co-Op*.

coordinate No hyphen.

Coordinated Universal Time SEE **UTC**.

copter, chopper Either is fine as a conversational substitute for helicopter.

copy In the sense of written matter for a newspaper or a magazine, *copy* is an uncountable noun. Hence, do not say *a copy* or *copies*. In any case, the word is newspaper industry jargon, not to be used in news writing.

copy(-) copybook, copycat, copyedit, copyeditor, copyright, copywriter

copy desk

coral is stuff found in sea; **corral** is a fenced area for horses, cows or other animals on a farm or ranch. As a verb it means *to gather a group of animals or people together and keep them in a particular place*. The past tense and past participle of *corral* is *corralled*.

cords, chords SEE **CHORDS, CORDS**.

corollary

coronavirus Any of a group of RNA viruses that cause a variety of diseases in humans and other animals.

corporate is an adjective, as in *corporate results*, *corporate leaders, body corporate*. As a noun, *corporate* is jargon. If you mean *companies* say so, instead of saying *a corporate* or *corporates*.

correspondents, newsmen, newspersons, scribes Use *reporters*.

coruscating Sparkling.

cost-effective

cosy is the British spelling; *cozy* is American.

cotton wool Two words.

councillor (member of a council), **counsellor** (adviser) In American English, *councilor* and *counselor*.

counsel (lawyer) remains *counsel* even in plural. Never use *counsels*. But *the counsel* is fine, as in *Is the counsel for the defence present?*

counter(-) Compounds are generally one word: counteract, counterargument, counterattack, counterbalance, counterblast, countercheck, counterclaim, counterclockwise, counterculture, countercurrent, counterespionage, counterexample, counterfeit, counterfoil, counterinsurgency, counterintelligence, counterintuitive, countermand, countermine, countermove, counteroffensive, counteroffer, counterpart, counterplan, counterplea, counterplot, counterpoint, counterpoise, counterproposal, counterproductive, counterproof, counterpunch, countersign, countersignature, counterterror, counterterrorism, countertop, countervail, counterweigh, counterweight

counter-revolution, counter-revolutionary

country(-) countryman, countryside, countrywide, countrywoman

country club

country-made An Indian coinage meaning *not made in a factory or under licence*: *a country-made revolver*.

coup de grâce Literally, *a stroke of mercy*. It is a blow or shot that brings death to a sufferer. Often the sense of mercy is not implied and the phrase simply means *a deathblow* or *a decisive finishing blow*:
Then came the coup de grâce: a crane and work crew, accompanied by police

escorts. With a groan and a clatter, the government of Moscow erased all evidence of lingering dissidence against the bygone Soviet Union (LA Times).

coup d'état Use just *coup* for a sudden and often violent change of government.

couple Two people in a married, romantic or sexual relationship may be treated as singular or plural depending on whether they are considered individually or collectively: *The couple were classmates at IIT.* | *The couple were married last month.* | *The couple is suing the car company.* | *The couple is the richest in the area.*

In general, the word causes fewer problems when treated as plural. When *couple* means *a handful* or *a few*, it is always followed by *of* and treated as plural.

Court of St James's is the official name of the royal court of the UK. Ambassadors or high commissioners to the UK are officially ambassadors or high commissioners to the Court of St James's. Use this expression only jocularly or for ceremonial flavour. Otherwise, write *ambassador* or *high commissioner to the UK*.

courthouse One word.

court(s) martial (noun) Two words. But hyphenate the verb: *court-martial*, *court-martialled*.

courtroom One word.

cousin brother, cousin sister Do not use. There are no such terms in English.

cover-up (noun), **cover up** (verb)

COVID: Disease caused by the SARS-CoVn2 virus

Cow Belt Avoid this pejorative term for Hindi-speaking states.

CPM Not *CPI(M)*. Communist Party of India (Marxist).

crack(-) crackbrained, crackdown (noun), crackhead (slang for a cocaine addict), crackpot

crack down (verb)

craft (noun) Singular and plural.

craft (verb) If you are looking for a word meaning *to make with skill*, [illegible] *in shape, fashion.*

crash-land (verb), **crash landing** (noun)

credible (convincing), **credulous** (gullible)

credit card is two words as is *debit card*.

CREDIT LINES SEE **BYLINES, CREDIT LINES**.

creditworthy, creditworthiness

crescendo(s) A crescendo is not a peak of intensity but a gradual increase in intensity. It is the trip to the peak. To say that *something reached a crescendo* is wrong.

cretin, cretinism A cretin is a person who is physically deformed and has learning difficulties because of a congenital thyroid deficiency. The condition is called cretinism. By extension, *cretin* means *a stupid person* and *cretinism* means *stupidity*. Do not use *cretin* and *cretinism* in this abusive sense.

crew refers not to individuals but to all the members of a group. In reference to individuals, use *crew members*, *members of the crew*, *crewmen*. Do not write *five crew, 10 crew*.

CRICKET

The following terms are hyphenated: all-rounder, follow-on (noun), hat-trick, hit-wicket, leg-before, leg-side, leg-spinner, off-break, off-spin, off-stump, silly mid-on, mid-off, no-ball, wicketkeeper-batsman.

Each of these is two words: extra cover, leg break, leg bye, short leg, square leg, third man.

Each of these is one word: scorecard, sightscreen, wicketkeeper.

Some other terms: lbw, Lord's (note the apostrophe), n.o. (not out), one-day international, Test, Twenty20, T20.

As a noun, *run-out* is hyphenated; as a verb, it is two words.

A batsman hits a *four* or a *six*, not a *4* or a *6*.

Remember: *innings*; not *inning,* which is a baseball term.

SEE ALSO **ALL-ROUNDER** | **BOARD OF CONTROL FOR CRICKET IN INDIA** | **MCC** | **N.O.** | **ONE-DAY INTERNATIONAL**.

cripple, crippled Do not use these offensive terms while mentioning disabilities. Instead of *He is a cripple* or *The boy was crippled by polio*, write *He has been unable to walk since an accident in 2005* or *The boy lost his legs to polio*.

SEE ALSO **AFFLICTED** | **CHALLENGED** | **DEFORMED** | **DISABILITIES** | **HANDICAPPED** | **IMPAIRED**.

crisis (plural *crises*) Try to find an alternative for this overworked word. Confine its use to a process reaching a turning point. A crisis does not deepen, grow, mount or worsen.

crisscross No hyphen.

criterion (singular), **criteria** (plural)

critical When describing the condition of an injured or sick person, write *X is in a critical condition* rather than *X is critical*.

criticize can be a partisan term when followed by a *for* phrase: *He criticized the government for being against the minorities*. That phrasing assumes that the government is actually against the minorities. Make it *He accused the government of being against the minorities*.

critique Avoid as a verb. Use *analyse*, *assess*, *comment on*, *criticize* or *review*.

crore means *10,000,000* (*10 million,* or *100 lakh*). Write *Rs 1 crore*, *Rs 15 crore* (not *crores*); but *crores of rupees*, *he made crores in property deals, crores of people*. Do not use with a foreign currency; instead of *$20 crore*, write *$200 million*.

SEE ALSO **LAKH**.

cross(-) crossbar, crossbones, crossbow, crossbreed, crossfire, crosshairs, crossover (noun), crossroads, crosswalk, crossword puzzle

cross country (noun), cross purpose, cross section

cross-check, cross-country (adjective), cross-current, cross-eye, cross-eyed, cross-examine, cross-holding, cross-index, cross-legged, cross-ownership, cross-question (verb), cross-reference (noun and verb), cross-voting

CROSS-REFERENCE

Give cross-references on the front page to related stories or special pages inside. Even on an inside page, give cross-references to related stories or packages going on other inside pages. If a package inside has been given a title, in the front-page cross-reference use the page title rather than FULL COVERAGE.

CRR SEE **CASH RESERVE RATIO**.

crucifixion Not *crucifiction*.

cruel, crueller, cruellest

crybaby One word.

crystal ball

crystallize

c-section Lowercase. SEE ALSO **CAESAREAN SECTION**.

CT scan No need to spell it out to *computerized tomography*. CT scans use x-rays to produce cross-sectional images of anatomical structures.

Previously, CT scan was also called CAT scan, short for *computerized axial tomography*. Use *CT scan* rather than *CAT scan*.

cul-de-sac(s)

cull does not mean *kill*; it means *pick* or *select*, and hence, by extension, *select or send an animal for slaughter*. As a noun, *cull* can mean *an animal selected for slaughter* or *an object being discarded*.

(-)culture counterculture, subculture

tissue culture

cumec A unit for measuring the flow of liquids, equal to one cubic metre (1,000 litres) per second. It is generally used for measuring the flow of water in rivers. To convert cumecs to cusecs (cubic feet per second), multiply by 35.315. To convert cumecs to million gallons per day (mgd), multiply by 19.

Remember, cumec is a measure of the rate of flow, not of volume.

SEE ALSO **CUSEC** | **MGD**.

cupful(s) SEE ALSO **SPOONFUL**.

curable

curb, kerb SEE **KERB, CURB**.

cure-all

currency depreciation, currency devaluation *Currency depreciation* means a fall in the value of a country's currency compared with the currencies of other countries. *Currency devaluation* is a deliberate reduction in the value of a country's currency by its government. When a country devalues its currency, the goods it imports tend to become more expensive. Its exports, however, tend to become less expensive and thus more competitive.

curriculum(s)

curry favour Not *carry favour*.

curtain raiser

cusec A unit for measuring the flow of liquids, equal to one cubic foot (28.317 litres) per second. It is generally used for measuring the flow of water in rivers. Sometimes, *cusec* is written as *second-feet*. To convert cusecs to million gallons per day (mgd), multiply by 0.538. To convert cusecs to cumecs, multiply by 0.028. In India, *gallon* means *the imperial gallon*, which is equal to 4.546 litres, or 0.161 cubic foot.

Remember, cusec is a measure of the rate of flow, not of volume.

SEE ALSO **CUMEC** | **MGD**.

cusp A pointed end where two curves meet. In astrology, the time when one sign of the zodiac ends and the next begins. Figuratively, *on the cusp* means *the beginning of change* or *a new era*: *a girl on the cusp of womanhood*.

customs (not *custom*) is the government department that collects taxes on goods brought into the country. Write *customs officer*, *customs duty*; not *custom officer*, *custom duty*.

cut back Delete *back*.

cutoff (noun and adjective), **cut off** (verb)

cut in (not *cut on*), as in *a cut in pay*, *a cut in prices*, *cuts in taxes*.

cut-throat

cut up Two words: *He is cut up about his story being rejected by the editor*.

CV is better than the pretentious *curriculum vitae*.

cyber(-) Compounds are generally one word:

cyberattack, cyberbullying, cybercafe, cybercrime, cyberlaw, cyberrevolution, cybersecurity, cyberspace, cyberstalking, cyberterrorism, cybervoting

cyber dhaba

cybersquatting Registering a web address which is the name of an existing company or a well-known person, with the intention of selling it to the owner for a profit.

cynical (believing the worst about people or the outcome of events; believing that people are always motivated by self-interest), **sceptical** (not convinced that something is true)

cypress (cone-bearing tree), **Cyprus** (Mediterranean island nation)

czar Not *tsar* or *tzar*.

Czech Republic Use *Czechoslovakia* only in historical contexts. The two countries after the division of Czechoslovakia are the Czech Republic and Slovakia.

***

There is only one recommendation which outranks the advice to get a good dictionary. Get two. I have over a hundred, and I use them all.
— **David Crystal**

D

dachshund A small dog with a long body and short legs.

dad Use it only in informal contexts. Lowercase except when it substitutes for a proper name: *I called my mom just before she and my dad were to leave for London*, but *I called Mom just before she and Dad were to leave for London*.

dais means *stage*; *Dias* is a Goan surname.

Dalai Lama, the Cap when using it as the name of the titleholder. Lowercase otherwise: *There have been 14 dalai lamas so far.* | *The 13th dalai lama died in 1933.*

dalit Lowercase.

damage (destruction), **damages** (money awarded by court as compensation for loss or injury)

damn it Two words. But like other profanity it should not be used without a compelling reason.

damper The phrase is *put a damper* (not *dampener*) *on something*. A damper is a device used on piano strings to make the sound less loud. A dampener dampens or moistens something. There is no such word as *dampner*.

dance floor

dandiya Lowercase. Not *dandia*.

Dane(s) refers to the people of Denmark; **Danish** can refer to the language, the people or anything of Denmark.

DANGLERS

Avoid constructions like *Having struck the deal with Arcelor, Ratan Tata's face appeared on TV*. The deal was struck by *Ratan Tata*, not by his *face*. The modifier *having struck the deal* is a dangler. Similarly, *Forced to resign as chief minister, Kumaraswamy's strategy kept on changing*. Who was forced to resign — Kumaraswamy or his strategy?

Such constructions are not only illogical, but can also be confusing and often ridiculous: *Arriving at the station, the sun came out.* | *Driving down the road, a deer leaped out in front of me.* | *Having died, they buried him.*

danse macabre (dance of death) Not *dance macabre*.

danseur is a male ballet dancer; **danseuse** is a female ballet dancer.

Dar es Salaam No hyphens. Dar es Salaam is Tanzania's largest city. It lost it status as the country's capital to Dodoma in 1996.

dargah Italicize or put in quotation marks.

dark(-) darkroom

Dark-Age (adjective), dark-eyed, dark-haired, dark-horse (adjective)

Dark Ages, dark horse (noun), dark matter, dark star

Dasara See **Dussehra**.

dash Put a space on either side of a dash. Not doing so makes the computer treat the word preceding the dash, the dash and the word following it as one word. This often results in what designers call rivulets — undesirable white space in a narrow newspaper column.

Use a pair of dashes to denote an interruption in thought in a sentence. Example: The Iraqi official who received the IOC's letter — Jassim Mohammed Jaafar, minister of sport and youth — rejected "this unfair decision".

When possible, use a pair of commas rather than dashes to denote an interruption: Iraq has only one medal, a bronze in weightlifting in 1960, since its first appearance at the Summer Olympics in 1948. But in the first example, where the Iraqi minister has been named, dashes are required because the part set off by them has a comma. A pair of dashes is also needed in the following sentence for clarity: The company's publications — newspapers and

magazines — are doing well. The second dash is omitted when, logically, it would come at the end of a sentence.

Use a dash for an emphatic pause: The first family of American tennis has yet to lose a set on its preferred surface — the power-enhancing grass at the All England Club.

Use the en dash (–), not the hyphen (-), for the minus sign.

data Strictly speaking, *data* is the plural of *datum* and should take a plural verb. But its meaning is much like the singular *information* or *news*, and it is often treated as singular. Both these sentences are correct: *This data was collected over five years.* | *These data have not yet been confirmed by the health ministry.*

Generally, treat *data* as singular.

databank

database

datable Able to be dated to a particular time.

DATE, DAY SEE **TIME, DATE, DAY, YEAR**.

DATELINES

A dateline should be a well-known place. If it is not so, it should be followed by the name of the state or the country in brackets. Unfamiliar datelines should be explained up front in the story: *This textile town 200km south of Chennai ...*

TOI style for dateline is upper-lower bold followed by a colon. For example, **Durg (Chhattisgarh):** or **Mountain View (California):**

If a story has equal or nearly equal contributions from two places, use a double dateline, like *New Delhi/Mumbai*. Putting the names of more than two places in a dateline is often clumsy. This can be avoided by removing the dateline and carrying the story with a drop cap.

Sometimes, there are stories that have nothing to do with the city where they are written. Such stories should always be carried without datelines, with drop caps.

SEE ALSO **BYLINES, CREDIT LINES** | **DROP CAPS**.

date rape Do not use this term if the intended meaning is *drug rape*.

day(-) daybreak, daydream, daylight, daylong, daywork

day care, day room, day school, day student, day trader, day trading, day trip

day-to-day, day-tripper

daylight-saving time

daylong One word.

Day 1, Day 2 Cap and use a figure; do not write *Day One*, *Day Two*.

daytime Similarly, *nighttime*.

DC stands for District of Columbia, as in *Washington DC*. Omit *DC* except when there is a possibility of confusion with Washington state.

D-Day The day on which something important is to begin. This American coinage is of World War I vintage. The best known D-Day is June 6, 1944 — the first day of the Allied invasion of France, which was under Nazi occupation. The *D* stands for *Day*. Similarly *H-Hour*, the *H* standing for *Hour*.

de(-) Except when *de* is followed by an *e* or a capital letter, compounds are one word:

deactivate, debrief, decaffeinated, declassify, dehumanize, demilitarize, detoxify, devaluation

de-emphasize, de-escalate, de-Stalinization

de-addiction (an Indian coinage, not found in dictionaries; but no harm in using it)

Hyphenate compounds that would otherwise be difficult to read: *de-ice*.

dead(-) deadbeat, deadbolt, deadline, deadlock, deadpan, deadwood

dead centre, dead end (noun), dead heat, dead letter box, dead weight

dead-end (adjective)

Dead Sea Scrolls

deaf Describe people as deaf only if they are totally without hearing. Otherwise, if it is relevant to the context, write that their *hearing is impaired*, they are *hard of hearing* or they *have only partial hearing*.

SEE ALSO **DISABILITIES** | **DUMB** | **HANDICAPPED** | **IMPAIRED** | **MUTE**.

deaf ears The phrase is offensive. Use *closed ears* or another substitute.

dealmaker, dealmaking

death(-) deathbed, deathblow, deathwatch

death camp, death chamber, death house, death knell, death penalty, death rate, death row, death squad, death trap

DEATH AND OBITUARIES

The death of a public figure or a celebrity is news. If the death is accidental or unexpected, the news value is greater. Basic information, like the person's full name, age, claim to fame, place of residence, day and place of death, and reason of death should come up front in the story. Quotations from people who closely

knew the person should get prominence. Routine condolences sent out by politicians, some of whom may not have even known the person, should be omitted or put at the end of the story. Survivors should be mentioned if they are public figures in their own right. Use *wife* or *husband*, not *widow* or *widower*, while referring to the dead person's spouse. A death story, if there is no separate obituary, should deal at length with the person's achievements and contributions to public life. If a crime or indiscretion was the person's claim to fame, it should figure up front. But a small or early indiscretion should not be blown up.

death by natural causes Death caused by naturally occurring disease or diseases; this includes death from organ failure in a person of advanced age. The term is loosely used to describe death that is not caused by injury, drugs, poisoning, etc.

death toll

debatable

debit card is two words as is *credit card*.

DEBT RATING

The two most widely followed rating companies worldwide are Moody's Investors Service and Standard & Poor's Ratings Services. Moody's assigns nine broad ratings: Aaa, Aa, A, Baa, Ba, B, Caa, Ca, C; with Aaa meaning *highest quality* and C *default*. It adds numerical modifiers (1, 2, 3) to indicate whether a bond is in the upper, middle or lower part of the range; for example, Aaa2, Ba3. Standard & Poor's has 10 main ratings: AAA, AA, A, BBB, BB, B, CCC, CC, C, D; with AAA standing for highest quality and D for default. If often uses a plus or a minus sign on grades from AA to CCC.

In India, Icra is an associate of Moody's and Crisil a Standard & Poor's company. Both Icra and Crisil use eight basic ratings: AAA, AA, A, BBB, BB, B, C, D.

debut Use it as a noun, not as a verb.

debutant is male; **debutante** is female.

decades Use figures: *the swinging 1960s* or *60s* (not *'60s*).

deceive

decimals Use figures for all numbers that contain decimals: *6.4cm of rain*. If the number is less than 1, use a zero before the decimal point: *0.25km*. An exception: *.22-calibre rifle*.

With a number less than 1, use a singular unit: *0.8 litre*, not *0.8 litres*.

Do not mix decimals and fractions in the same story.

decimate Literally, *to destroy one-tenth*; loosely, *to destroy heavily*. It does not mean *to wipe out*. As the notion of one-tenth remains, do not use *decimate* with other fractions or percentages, as in *The bomb decimated 50% of the division.*

decision making No hyphen in noun; hyphenate as adjective.

decor

decry is stilted and archaic-sounding. Use *deplore* or *denounce*.

deejay Use *DJ*.

deep(-) deepwater (adjective)

deep freeze (noun, as in *The project has been put in the deep freeze*)

deep-rooted, deep-sea (adjective), deep-seated

(-)deep ankle-deep, waist-deep

de facto Two words.

defence spending Prefer *military spending*.

defendant Not *defendent*.

defensible Not *defendable*.

definite (clearly stated, not vague), **definitive** (final, conclusive)

definitely A vague and overused modifier. Avoid.

deformed Use more specific and less disparaging terms while referring to disabilities.

SEE ALSO **CRIPPLE, CRIPPLED** | **DISABILITIES** | **HANDICAPPED** | **IMPAIRED**.

defreeze There is no such word. Use *unfreeze*.

defuse (render harmless, as in *defuse tension*, *defuse a bomb),* **diffuse** (spread over a wide area, as in *the gas diffused rapidly*)

déjà vu

delectable Not *delectible*.

SEE ALSO **STATES AND UNION TERRITORIES**.

Delhiite Not *Delhi'ite*.

delphic Lowercase. It means *deliberately obscure or ambiguous*.

delusion, illusion SEE **ALLUSION, DELUSION, ILLUSION**.

démarche means *a diplomatic step, representation or protest*. Try a simpler alternative or at least explain the meaning.

demigod One word.

demining The process of removing landmines from an area.

demolish, destroy Both mean *to do away with something completely*. Do not write *partially demolished* or *destroyed*; write *partially damaged*. *Totally demolished* or *destroyed* is a redundancy.

demonstrator

DENIALS

Never qualify a denial (*flatly denied*, *categorically denied*) unless quoting someone. A "no comment" is not a denial. Write *declined to comment* rather than *refused to comment*, which suggests that the person you spoke to was under an obligation to comment.

denote, connote SEE **CONNOTE, DENOTE**.

denouement

depart *The plane departed from IGI airport*, not *The plane departed IGI airport*.

department store Not *departmental store*.

dependant (noun), **dependent** (adjective) *Suman has four dependants.* | *Going to university is dependent on the grades you get.* In American English, both the noun and the adjective have the same spelling: *dependent*.

dependence

deplore You deplore a person's behaviour, not the person.

depositary (trustee), **depository** (storehouse) Remember: *American depositary receipts*, *global depositary receipts*.

deprecate (express disapproval of), **depreciate** (diminish in value over a period of time)

depreciation The gradual reduction in the value of a company's assets due to wear and tear or obsolescence. Estimated depreciation over a particular year is deducted from the income for that year as one of the costs of doing business.

depression Period of decreased business activity. Cap *Great Depression*, referring to the depression of the 1930s.

dept Abbreviation of *department*; use it only in headlines. Do not write *deptt*.

de rigueur Note the two *u*'s.

deroster An Indian coinage meaning *take somebody's name off the roster*. Generally used in reference to erring employees of an airline: *Air India has derostered nine of its employees*.

descendant (noun), **descendent** (adjective)

description Not *discription*.

desi No itals.

desiccate (not *dessicate*) Dry out. Try to use a simpler word.

design As a verb, it suggests shaping of physical things. For intangibles like laws and policies, use a more precise substitute like *intend, devise* or *plan*: *The company's no-smoking policy is intended to benefit all employees and visitors*.

designate Hyphenate, as in *Prime Minister-designate*.

desk jockey Derogatory term for *a person who works at a desk* or *an office worker*.

desktop No hyphen.

despair Not *dispair*.

despatch Write *dispatch* and use it only as a noun. Avoid *dispatch* as a verb; *send* is better in most cases.

desperate means *extremely bad or serious*, *rash or violent because of despair*, *having a great desire or need for something*; **disparate** *means not alike*, *different in kind*. There is no such word as *desparate*.

despite Do not write *despite the fact that*; use *although* instead.

dessert (sweet food eaten at the end of a meal), **just deserts** (what a person deserves as reward or punishment)

detente Avoid this diplomatic term. Instead use something conversational, like *easing of tensions*.

détenu, détenue French for *prisoner*. Prefer *détenu*. Better still, *detainee* or *prisoner*.

determine usually implies the truth of what is being reported: *Police determined he had not violated any traffic rules*. If that is not the case, use neutral terms like *said* or *concluded*.

device (noun), **devise** (verb)

devil Cap in references to Satan, but lowercase otherwise.

devil's advocate A Roman Catholic official whose duty is to examine the facts critically and raise objections in the case of a dead person named for beatification or canonization. By extension, the term has come to mean *a person who upholds what is regarded as the wrong side, for the sake of argument*.

devout It has become a cliché in expressions like *devout Muslim* or *devout Hindu*. Unless you explain what your criteria are, the reader is left wondering whether you mean somebody who prays or worships every day, or something less or more.

dexterous Not *dextrous*.

diagnose Sticklers object to sentences like *He was diagnosed with cancer*. Although the usage is now accepted by dictionaries, they insist that the disease, not the patient, is diagnosed. You may prefer *His condition was diagnosed as cancer* to keep them happy.

DIAL All caps. DIAL stands for Delhi International Airport (P) Ltd, which manages IGI airport in Delhi. DIAL is a consortium of GMR Group (54%), Airports Authority of India (26%), and Fraport and Eraman Malaysia (10% each).

diarrhoea is the British spelling; *diarrhea* is American.

diaspora Cap only in reference to the epoch in which the Jews were dispersed after the Babylonian exile or to the body of people who were dispersed then. Lowercase in other references to scattering of national or ethnic groups.

dicey Not *dicy*.

dicky, dickey Indian English for the boot of a car. Prefer *boot*. The American equivalent is *trunk*.

diehard One word.

diesel

dietitian Not *dietician*.

differ from (to be unlike), **differ with** (to disagree)

different from Not *different to* or *different than*. However, *different than* is sometimes idiomatic and useful; *different from* cannot be substituted for it: *The exercises recommended by him are quite different for men than for women*.

diffuse, defuse SEE **DEFUSE, DIFFUSE**.

digestible

dignitary

diktat (an authoritarian order), **dictate** (an authoritative order)

dilapidated Not *dillapidated* or *delapidated*.

dilemma Do not use it to mean simply a problem. *Dilemma* refers to a situation in which it is difficult to decide what to do, because all the choices seem equally undesirable.

dilettante(s)

dilly-dally Note hyphen.

DIMENSIONS, MEASUREMENTS, WEIGHTS AND PROPORTION

When they consist of two or more elements, or when a decimal is used, write them in figures, even those below 10: *3 by 5*; *6 feet 5 inches by 10 feet 9 inches*; *6 feet 1 inch tall*; *10 years 6 months 20 days old* (no commas).

When giving a single dimension or measurement below 10, spell it out even if it includes an ordinary fraction: *four and a half kilometres long* (no hyphens).

diminutive Not *dimunitive*. The word has three *i*'s and is related to *diminish*. Also: *diminution*, not *dimunition*.

dim sum (not *dim sim*) Chinese dish.

diphtheria Not *diptheria*.

director general No hyphen in this and similar titles: *secretary general*, *attorney general*.

dis(-) Compounds are one word even if *dis* is followed by a word beginning with *s*: dissatisfaction, disservice, dissimilar.

DISABILITIES

Mention disabilities only when they are pertinent to the story. If such a description is necessary, mention what the disability is and how much the person's physical or mental performance is affected. Report disabilities without straying either into sentimentality or condescension. Avoid emotional descriptions like afflicted, stricken or confined. Preferably, write disabled people or people with disabilities rather than the disabled or the handicapped. Avoid terms that stereotype or stigmatize people.

The following table gives some terms that should not be used and acceptable alternatives to them:

Not to be used	Acceptable alternatives
a cripple, crippled, handicapped (adjective)	describe the disability without using these words
victim of, suffering from, afflicted by, crippled by	person who has, person with
wheelchair-bound, confined to a wheelchair, in a wheelchair	uses a wheelchair
invalid	disabled person
mentally handicapped, backward, retarded, slow	person with learning difficulties
the disabled, the handicapped, the blind, the deaf	disabled people, blind people, deaf people
deaf and dumb, deaf-mute	deaf and speech-impaired, hearing- and speech-impaired

SEE ALSO **CRIPPLE, CRIPPLED** | **DEFORMED** | **HANDICAPPED** | **IMPAIRED**.

disc, disk As a general rule, *disk* is American and *disc* is British. But even in American English, *disc* is used for optical discs. For example, *compact disc (CD)* or *digital versatile disc (DVD)*. In both forms of English, *disk* (short for *diskette*) is used for products using magnetic storage: *floppy disk*, *hard disk*.

discernible Not *discernable*.

discharge, release Patients are *discharged* from hospital, not *released*. Prisoners are *released* from jail, not *discharged*.

disco(s)

discom (not *distcom*) Electricity distribution company.

discomfit (verb) has no connection with *discomfort*. It means *thwart*, *defeat*, *embarrass*. The noun is *discomfiture*.

discover A shorter and better substitute is *find*.

discreet (careful about what one says or does, keeping silent or preserving confidences when necessary), **discrete** (separate)

disfranchise Not *disenfranchise*.

disinformation False information deliberately spread to mislead

disinterested (unbiased), **uninterested** (indifferent)

disorient Not *disorientate*.

dispel, dispelling, dispelled

dispensable Not *dispensible*.

dispose of Never write *dispose off*.

Disprin Trademark. Prefer *aspirin*.

dissect has a double *s*; *bisect* has only one *s*.

dissociate Not *disassociate*.

dist for *district* should be used only in headlines.

distil, distiller

distinct (clear, different), **distinctive** (characteristic)

distracted driving If you use a mobile phone or any other digital device while driving, you are guilty of distracted driving.

distributor Not *distributer*.

ditto marks (”) Do not use them even in tabular material.

dive The past tense is *dived*, not *dove*.

divorcee (man or woman) Do not describe a person as a divorcee unless marital status is relevant to the story. Do not introduce a person like this: *Renu, a 30-year-old divorcee*. The information can be given later in the story and in a more sensitive manner: *Renu is divorced* or *Renu's marriage ended in a divorce*.

Diwali

DJ Not *deejay* for disc jockey.

dockyard One word.

DOGS

Dog breeds are normally lowercase: *alsatian*, *borzoi*, *doberman*, *labrador, rottweiler*. Exceptions: *Irish setter, Jack Russel*, *Yorkshire terrier*.

dogfight

do-gooder

Dolly the sheep

domino(es)

doomsday

door(-) doorbell, doorkeeper, doorknob, doorman, doormat, doorstep, doorway

door key, door prize, door to door (adverb)

door-to-door (adjective)

doppelganger Lowercase. It means *an apparition or double of a living person*. Avoid this uncommon word.

dos and don'ts No apostrophe in *dos*. Also: *ifs and buts*, *ayes and nays*.

DoT Department of telecom.

dotcom Not *dot-com*.

double(-) double-barrelled, double-blind, double-breasted, double-check, double-cross (verb), double-date (verb), double-edged, double-faced, double-fault (verb), double-jointed

double agent, double cross (noun), double date (noun), double fault (noun), double jeopardy, double quick, double standard, double whammy (twofold blow)

doubleheader, doublespeak, doubletalk, doublethink, doubletree

doubt The phrase *no doubt that* is sometimes confused with *no question that*. The meanings are opposite. *There was no doubt that he was lying* means he was lying. *There was no question that he was lying* means he was not lying.

(the benefit of the) doubt The expression is *the benefit of the doubt*. Do not omit the definite article before *doubt*.

douse Do not use *douse* as a synonym of *pour,* as in *He doused petrol* on her. Correct ways of using *douse*: *The woman was doused with kerosene before being burned.* | *The car was doused in* (or *with*) *petrol and set alight.* | *He doused the clothes in soapy water.* | *She doused the candle's flame with her fingertips.*

dove Use *dived* as the past tense of *dive*.

down(-) downbeat, downcast, downfall, downgrade, downhearted, downhill, download, downpour, downright, downstage, downstairs, downstream, downswing, downtown, downtrodden, downturn, downwind

down payment

down-to-earth

(-)down Most nouns and adjectives formed with *-down* are one word; some are hyphenated:

breakdown, climbdown, countdown, crackdown, knockdown, lowdown, rundown (noun meaning *a brief review or summary*), shootdown, shutdown, slowdown, touchdown, turndown

let-down, run-down (adjective meaning *worn-out*), sit-down (noun)

download, upload You *download* data from the internet or from a bigger system to your own computer so that you can view or use the data. You *upload* data from your computer to the internet or to a bigger system in order to let other people view or use the data.

downmarket

downplay Use *play down*.

Down's syndrome is the British spelling; *Down syndrome* is American. Do not use *mongol* or *mongoloid* for people with this syndrome.

downtown Write *central Delhi*, not *downtown Delhi*. Do not use *downtown* as a synonym of *downmarket area*.

doyen (male), **doyenne** (female)

Dr No full stop; use only for a medical doctor or in direct quotations. Even if a person has a medical degree but the degree has no relevance to the story, do not put *Dr* before the person's name. For example, *Harsh Vardhan*, not *Dr Harsh Vardhan*, for the Delhi BJP leader.

draconian Lowercase except in references to ancient Greece.

draft, draught Use *draft* for a sketch, a detachment of men, a money order; and *draught* for a drink, the depth to which a ship sinks in water, a current of air in a confined space.

draftsman (of document), **draughtsman** (of drawing)

drama queen A person given to often excessively emotional performances or reactions: *John McCain is acting more like a drama queen than a president, and his erratic behaviour is turning off voters* (Guardian).

dramatic A much overworked word. If an event is dramatic, this should be clear from the story and it should not be necessary to say so.

draperies is preferred to *drapes*.

dreamed, dreamt Use *dreamed*.

dress code

dressing room

drive-in (noun)

driving licence in British English, *driver's license* in American.

DROP CAPS

Use only in a story without a dateline. If the story begins with a quote, do not omit the opening quotation marks. Use a three-character drop — the opening quotation marks and the first letter. Better still, rephrase the intro so that it does not begin with a quote. While using a picture or an icon as a left indent, do not use a drop cap.

SEE ALSO **DATELINES**.

dropout (noun), **drop out** (verb)

drugs is generally used as a synonym of *narcotics*. If a person is taking medication, the better word is *medicine(s)*.

drunk, drunken *Drunk* means *intoxicated*, *inebriated*. *Drunken* usually denotes a habitual state: *given to drink*, *alcoholic*. *Drunken* also frequently describes not a person or group of people, but their *brawl*, *orgy* or *party*.

drunk driving, drunken driving, drink-driving
Use *drunk driving*. It is preferred to *drunken driving* because *drunken* implies a habitual state. If *driving* is used as a verb, *driving drunk* can be a convenient equivalent to *drunk driving*. Do not hyphenate *drunk driving* unless using it as a modifier before a noun. The British variant, *drink-driving,* is not so familiar in India and virtually unknown in the US.

drunkenness

dry-clean, dry-cleaning

dryer (noun meaning *a machine used for drying something*), **drier** (adjective, as in *drier*, *driest*), **dryly** (adverb)

dry land

DSP (not *DySP*) for deputy superintendent of police.

dual (of two), **duel** (a fight between two people)

dub Avoid in the sense of naming or labelling. Use *call* or *describe*.

due to Sentences in which the *to* after *due* is part of an infinitive are beyond reproach: The *session is due to begin on Monday.* | *The film is due to be released on Friday.* Traditionalists object to the use of *due to* after a verb or at the beginning of a sentence. The argument is that being an adjective, *due* needs a noun to modify. According to this view, *The shutdown was due to rain* is right because *due* in this sentence modifies *shutdown*, a noun, but *The school was shut due to rain* is wrong because *due* does not get a noun to modify. This usage, however, is now considered standard (Concise Oxford Dictionary, Collins English Dictionary), but thought inelegant by some authorities (Garner's Modern American Usage). If you want to stick to the traditional view, use *due to* only when it can be replaced by *caused by*; otherwise, use *because of* or *owing to*.

Do not write *due to the fact that*. Replace it with *because*.

dugout

DUI Driving under the influence of alcohol or drugs.

du jour Literally, *of the day*, as in *soup du jour* on a restaurant's menu. By extension, *currently popular or important*: *Crowdsourcing is a trend du jour*.

dumb Do not use this disparaging term for somebody who cannot speak. Instead use *mute* or say the person cannot speak, preferably specifying why.

SEE ALSO **DEAF** | **DISABILITIES** | **HANDICAPPED** | **IMPAIRED**.

dumbfound, dumbfounded

duo Use it only for a group of two closely connected people or things. Do not use it as a fancy substitute for *two*. Write *two*.

Durga Puja

Dussehra is the north Indian spelling. In south India, *Dasara*.

dutch Lowercase in *going dutch* (sharing the expenses of a meal). The logic of lowercasing is the same as for *french fries* and *french kiss*.

dutch courage Confidence gained from drinking alcohol.

duty-free

DVD Digital versatile disc. Formerly *digital videodisc*.

dwarf Plural *dwarfs*. Verb forms: *dwarves*, *dwarved*.

dwelled, dwelt Use *dwelled* when you mean *lived*. With the preposition *on* or *upon*, use *dwelt*: *He dwelt on the advantages of yoga*.

Dyal Singh College Not *Dayal*. The college is in Delhi.

dyed-in-the-wool Having strong beliefs or opinions that are never going to change. Avoid this cliché.

dyeing refers to changing colours; **dying** refers to death.

dyke (not *dike*) An embankment. Do not use *dyke* to mean *lesbian*.

dynamo(s)

dysentery Not *dysentry*.

dyslexia Write *Aman has dyslexia*, not *Aman is dyslexic* or *Aman suffers from dyslexia*.

***

exclusive
term used by tabloid newspapers to denote a story that is in all of them.
— **Guardian stylebook**

E

each takes a singular verb because it refers to one: *Each of us has the right to vote*. But a plural verb is required when *each* follows the noun or pronoun: *We each have the right to vote*. The subject in this case is *we*, not *each*.

each and every Choose one or the other.

each other, one another Two people look at each other; more than two look at one another. In the possessive: *each other's books*, not *each others' books*. Either phrase can be used when the number is indefinite: *People help each other*. | *People help one another*.

ear(-) earring, earshot

earmark

earnings per share, or EPS, is a measure of a company's profitability. It is calculated by dividing the net profit by the total number of shares.

earth, moon, sun Lowercase. Cap when the words are used as proper names, especially in the context of astronomy and usually in juxtaposition with other heavenly bodies. In such a case, omit the preceding *the*: *After spending 195 days in space, Sunita Williams returned to Earth*.

In some contexts, *the* is used before *earth*; in some contexts it is omitted:
We could feel the earth shake as the truck came closer.
More than two-thirds of the earth's surface is sea.
I cleaned off the earth clinging to my shoes.
This diamond ring cost me the earth.

He wants to be the most powerful man on earth.
Nothing on earth would persuade me to marry you.
What on earth are you doing?

EARTHQUAKES

For expressing the intensity of an earthquake, seismologists now prefer a scale called "moment magnitude" scale. The Richter scale has been superseded. The new scale takes into account how much of the earth moved and how far. Older scales, including the Richter and the Mercalli, reflected local effect but not necessarily the overall severity.

Write *a 7.1-magnitude earthquake*, *a magnitude 7.1 earthquake* or *a 7.1 earthquake.*

Do not write *Richter scale* unless you are sure seismologists have expressed the intensity of the quake on this scale.

The moment magnitude scale as well as the Richter scale is logarithmic: a magnitude 8 earthquake releases 32 times as much energy as a magnitude 7 earthquake and about 1,000 times as much energy as a magnitude 6 earthquake.

Comparing earthquakes measured on different scales could be misleading, because the attributes measured by these scales are not the same. The moment magnitude of the 1906 San Francisco earthquake was 7.6, the Alaskan earthquake of 1964 about 9.0 and the 1995 Kobe (Japan) earthquake 7.0; in comparison, the Richter magnitudes of these earthquakes were 8.3, 9.2 and 6.8 respectively.

east, eastern, the east Lowercase except when it is part of a name: *east Delhi*, *eastern philosophy*, *eastern food*. But: *Middle East, East Bank, East Bengal Football Club*. Also: *Eastern Europe* in reference to the former communist bloc.

Easter Day (not *Easter Sunday*) is the Sunday between Good Friday and Easter Monday. The Saturday before Easter Day is Easter Eve or Holy Saturday (not *Easter Saturday*, which is the Saturday after Easter).

Easter egg Apart from its traditional meaning associated with Easter, *Easter egg* also denotes a hidden message or feature, like a videogame, in a software, document or website.

eastern hemisphere The part of the earth comprising Europe, Africa, Asia and Australia.

easygoing

easy virtue In stories related to sexual crime, this highly judgmental and disparaging term is sometimes used by police. Do not use it. If it is essential to the story, use it only in a quote attributed to a person who has been identified by name.

ebitda Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization. Spell out in first reference.

Ebola An extremely contagious virus causing an acute, usually fatal haemorrhagic fever. The virus is spread through contact with bodily fluids of infected people and by airborne particles.

ebook

EC, EU Use *European Union* (*EU*) instead of *European Community* (*EC*). The Treaty on European Union came into effect on November 1, 1993, and formally created a new entity, the EU, with responsibilities expanded beyond the EC's focus on economic and trade issues.

echo chamber Closed environment where one hears only reinforcing opinions

eco(-) ecosphere, ecosystem, ecotype, ecowarrior

eco-friendly

ecocide Heedless or deliberate destruction of the natural environment.

E coli Not *e coli*. The abbreviation stands for *Escherichia coli*, the bacteria that contaminate food and water. *Escherichia* is the genus name. Always cap genus names, as in *Homo sapiens*. No itals. The italicization here is for a different reason (SEE **WORDS AS WORDS**).

ecological footprint is a measure of human demand on nature. Your ecological footprint is equal to the land and marine area needed to regenerate the resources you consume and to absorb the corresponding waste.

SEE ALSO **CARBON FOOTPRINT**.

ecology, ecological Not synonymous with *environment* or *environmental*. *Ecology* and *ecological* refer to the interdependence between living organisms and the environment.

SEE ALSO **ENVIRONMENT, ENVIRONMENTAL**.

e-commerce Marketing and shopping on the internet. At the start of a sentence: *E-commerce*. In a first-letters-capped headline: *E-Commerce*.

ecstasy Not *ecstacy*. Cap when referring to the drug Ecstasy.

Ecuador, Ecuadorean

ecumenical

-ed, -t SEE **PAST TENSE AND PAST PARTICIPLE FORMS**.

edgy Nervous or tense. Do not use it in the sense of *trend-setting* or *intense*.

Editors Guild of India

educationist Not *educationalist*.

-ee *Divorcees*, *employees*, *evacuees*, *detainees*, *referees* and *refugees* are fine but do not use *attendees* (those attending), *draftees* (conscripts), *escapees* (escapers), *retirees* (the retired) or *standees*.

eerie

effect SEE **AFFECT, EFFECT**.

effectively means *with effect*. In other contexts, *in effect* may be more appropriate. *The matter was effectively dealt with last year* means *it was handled well last year*. *The matter was, in effect, dealt with last year* means *it was more or less settled last year*.

effete means *weak* or *ineffectual*; it does not mean *effeminate*.

eg Abbreviation of the Latin *exempli gratia*, which means *for example*. No full stops. Keep it for charts and tables; put a comma before *eg*. In copy, use *for example*.

(with) egg on one's face Not *an* or *the egg on one's face*.

egg roll Two words.

EGM Extraordinary general meeting.

EGoM Empowered group of ministers.

e-governance

Eid-ul-Fitr, Eid-ul-Zuha In headlines, use *Eid*. Eid-ul-Fitr is the Muslim festival celebrated at the end of the fasting month of Ramzan, the ninth month of the Muslim calendar. Eid-ul-Zuha is the Muslim festival marking the climax of the annual pilgrimage (haj) on the 10th day of the 12th month of the Muslim calendar.

Eiffel Tower, the

800-pound gorilla A powerful person or organization that is dominating or uncontrollable: *The company is the 800-pound gorilla of telecom.*

There is another phrase — *gorilla in the room*, or *800-pound gorilla in the room* — which seems to have resulted from a mix-up between *800-pound gorilla* and *elephant in the room*. In meaning, it is similar to *elephant in the room*: *"The subject of these travails becomes an 800-pound gorilla nobody mentions," writes [Conrad] Black* (Guardian).

These faddish expressions are best avoided in careful writing.

SEE ALSO **ELEPHANT IN THE ROOM**.

either means *one or the other of two*. Care should be taken to avoid ambiguity when using *either* to mean *both* or *each*. Instead of *MCD wanted to build shops on either side of the road*, write *MCD wanted to build shops on each side of the road* or *MCD wanted to build shops on both sides of the road*.

either, either ... or Used as a subject, *either* takes a singular verb: *Has either of you finished the story? Either Radha or Rumu is going to the meeting*. When *either ... or* links two subjects, the verb agrees with the subject that is closer to it. If one of the subjects is singular and the other plural, put the plural subject second and use a plural verb: *Either Priya or her brothers are coming to dinner*.

In an *either ... or* sentence, the terms that follow the two words should be parallel in form and purpose: *I'm going to buy either a mobile or a camera* (not *either buy a mobile or a camera*).

The same rules apply to *neither* and *neither ... nor*.

elbow room Two words.

elder, eldest; older, oldest In all ordinary contexts, *older* and *oldest*.

Use *elder* and *eldest* in kinship contexts: *eldest brother*, *elder sister, elder of the two sisters, eldest of five siblings*. With *than*, use *older*: *I am older than my sister*.

Even in kinship contexts, American English prefers *older* and *oldest*. In British English too, *older* and *oldest* are now the dominant forms in speech, but *elder* and *eldest* are still preferred in writing.

In certain contexts, only *elder* can be used: *elder statesman*, *Elders* (members of the Upper House), *his elders and betters*, *elder brethren* (in a church context).

elderly Use the term with care. People in their 50s will obviously object to being called elderly. Some people in their 60s may also object. It is better to be specific when describing the ages of people, or medical or social policies.

SEE ALSO **AGES OF PEOPLE AND ANIMALS**.

El Dorado Mythical city of gold.

(-)elect Lowercase even if it is attached to a title that is capped: *President-elect*. For plural, add an *s* to the first term: *MPs-elect*.

election The word is not always used in plural. Often the singular form is desirable. Write *general election*, not *general elections*.

Election Commission Cap *E* and *C*; lowercase while referring to state election commissions. Do not use the stand-alone abbreviation *EC* for a state or Union territory election commission. *Karnataka EC* or *Delhi EC* is fine.

electra complex The male equivalent is *oedipal complex*.

ELECTRICAL UNITS

m in scientific terms stands for *milli* (1mW is 1,000th of a watt), whereas *M* denotes *mega* (1MW is a million watts).

amperes (A), volts (V), watts (W), megawatts (MW), milliwatts (mW), joules (J)

kilo (k, lowercase) means *1,000*: kilovolts (kV), kilowatts (kW), kilojoules (kJ)

One unit of electricity as shown in your bill is 1kWh (kilowatt-hour).

electrocardiogram The abbreviation is *ECG* in British English. American English prefers *EKG*, based on the German spelling.

electrocution means *death by electric shock*, so do not write *electrocuted to death* or *died of electrocution*.

elephant in the room A major problem or controversial issue that is obviously present but avoided as a subject for discussion. Avoid the phrase; it has become a cliché.

SEE ALSO **800-POUND GORILLA**.

11th hour But *11th-hour* as a modifier before a noun: *an 11th-hour push*. No need to spell out as *eleventh*.

ELLIPSIS (...)

An ellipsis consists of three full stops. Put a space before and after an ellipsis. Guard against the full stops comprising an ellipsis breaking into two lines on the page.

Use an ellipsis to indicate omission of one or more words in condensing quotes, texts and documents. Avoid omissions that would distort the meaning.

If an omission falls at the end of a sentence, place the regular full stop right after the last word, followed by a space, then the ellipsis: *Workers of the world, unite. …*

Avoid using an ellipsis at the beginning or the end of a direct quote; write like this: *"We are a coalition government, and that limits our options in some ways, … privatization happens to be one such area," Manmohan Singh said.*

Not like this: *"… we are a coalition government, and that limits our options in some ways, … privatization happens to be one such area … ," Manmohan Singh said.*

While omitting one or more whole paragraphs, put an ellipsis at the end of the paragraph preceding the omitted material. There is no need for an ellipsis at the beginning of the next paragraph.

SEE ALSO **OMISSION OF WORDS**.

El Niño, La Niña El Niño is a periodic climate phenomenon in which Pacific waters along the coast of Ecuador and Peru become unusually warm. It occurs every 4 to 12 years around Christmas (hence the name El Niño, or the Christ Child), causing changes in global weather patterns, including increased rainfall in some areas and drought in others. Some of the worst droughts in India occurred during El Niño years.

La Niña (meaning *Little Girl*) is the opposite of El Niño. In this phenomenon, the central and eastern Pacific waters become unusually cold. La Niña too occurs every 4 to 12 years and causes changes in global weather patterns, including temperatures colder than normal in some regions and warmer than normal in others. During La Niña years, monsoon rains have been heavier in India.

El Salvador Its people are Salvadorans and capital is San Salvador.

elude (escape), **allude** (refer indirectly or briefly)

In his speech, the Prime Minister alluded (not *eluded*) *to the India-US nuclear agreement*.

elusive (difficult to catch, as in *an elusive thief*; or difficult to remember, as in *an elusive thought*), **illusive** (based on illusion; deceptive or unreal)

They played well but victory remained elusive (not *illusive*).

Elysée Palace

email No hyphen.

For clarity, an email address should ideally be contained in one line of type: *ap.chandra@timesgroup.com*

EMAIL INTERVIEW

If an interview has been conducted on email, mention this in the copy. If you do not, readers will feel cheated, for they can figure out from the lack of counterquestions to answers or from the missing description of the atmosphere.

embargo(s)

embargo, boycott SEE **BOYCOTT, EMBARGO**.

embarkation Not *embarcation*.

embarrass, embarrassment Note double *r* and double *s*.

emcee Use *MC*.

emigrate, immigrate SEE **IMMIGRATE, EMIGRATE**.

émigré A man or woman who has emigrated for political reasons. Do not use it as a fancy synonym for *emigrant*.

eminent (prominent), **imminent** (about to happen)

Emmy Award(s) In subsequent references, *the award(s)*, *the Emmy(s)*.

empanel, impanel Use *empanel*, which is more familiar to Indian readers. It is the preferred spelling in both American English and British English (Garner's Modern American Usage).

empathic Not *empathetic*.

emphasize You *emphasize something*, not *emphasize on something*. Similarly, you *stress something*, not *stress on something*.

employee Not *employe*.

emporium(s)

empty-handed

enamoured of, not *by* or *with*.

encumbrance Not *encumberance*.

encyclopedia Not *encyclopaedia*, which should be used only in the full name of Encyclopaedia Britannica.

Endeavour Although the American spelling of the word is *endeavor*, the space shuttle is *Endeavour*.

ended, ending Use *ended* for the past, *ending* for the future: *In the financial year ended last July, the company made a profit of Rs 150 crore.* | *In the financial year ending next July, the company hopes to make a profit of Rs 300 crore.*

endgame One word.

end user Two words.

energy, power *Energy*, measured in joules or calories, is the capacity of matter or radiation to work. *Power*, measured in watts or horsepower, is the energy supplied or consumed per unit of time. Energy can be likened to distance, power to speed.

SEE ALSO **WATT**.

enervate Deprive of strength or energy.

enforce But *reinforce*.

English, Englishman(men), Englishwoman(women) Use with care. The terms refer only to the people of England, not to all Britons, who can also be from Scotland, Wales or Northern Ireland.

enormity, enormousness *Enormity* refers to something horrifying, outrageous, extreme: *the enormity of the crime*, *the enormity of the disaster*, *the enormity of the task*. *Enormousness* refers only to size: *the enormousness of the web*.

enquire, enquiry Use *inquire*, *inquiry*.

enrol, enrolling, enrolment are the British forms but in American English, double *l*.

en route Not *on route*.

en suite An en suite bathroom is joined onto a bedroom: *Each bedroom has an en suite bathroom*. An en suite bedroom has a bathroom joined onto it: *The house has five bedrooms, all en suite*.

ensure (make certain), **insure** (buy or issue insurance)

enthral, enthralling

entitled, titled Do not use *entitled* to mean *titled*.
All employees are entitled to health insurance.
Jhumpa Lahiri's latest book is titled "Unaccustomed Earth".

entrepreneur Not *entreprener*.

envelop (verb), **envelope** (noun)

environment, environmental Not synonymous with *ecology*, *ecological*. *Environment* and *environmental* refer to the conditions that affect an organism, whereas *ecology* and *ecological* refer to the interdependence between the organism and the environment.

envision Use *envisage*.

EOW Economic offences wing.

epaulette (American spelling *epaulet*) is a decoration on the shoulder of a uniform; **amulet** is a charm against evil.

epic (adjective) means *heroic* and *legendary*. Reserve it for these senses.

epicentre The point on the earth's surface directly above the focus of an earthquake or an underground nuclear explosion. Do not write *epicentre* when you mean *centre*. While using *epicentre* figuratively, keep its original meaning in mind and do not write awkward sentences like *The epicentre of their game is international*.

epilepsy Do not define people by their medical condition: *an epileptic seizure* but not *an epileptic person*. Say (if relevant) *Maya, who has epilepsy*; not *Maya, an epileptic*.

epithet, expletive An epithet is a term of description, not always disparaging. An expletive is a swearword or obscenity.

SEE ALSO **OBSCENITIES**.

eponymous means *giving his or her name to*, as in *Romulus, the eponymous founder of Rome*. The eponymous character of a book, play or film is the one mentioned in the title: *Shantaram is the eponymous hero of Gregory David Roberts's famous novel*. The word applies to the character, not the work. Hence, it is wrong to say *Shantaram, the eponymous novel*.

equal *More equitable* (not *more equal*) *distribution of wealth*.

equally as Do not use both words; one will do.

equator, equatorial Lowercase.

Eritrea, Eritrean

ERM Exchange rate mechanism.

escalate, escalation In most cases *rise* or *increase* is simpler and as effective. *Escalate* may be used when talking of a step-by-step increase.

escrow An account that holds money or securities until certain conditions are fulfilled.

Eskimo(s) Prefer *Inuit* (singular *Inuk*) while referring to the people. Use *Eskimo* for the language they speak.

ESP Extrasensory perception.

especially, specially *Especially* means *particularly*: *I love all sports, especially tennis.* | *The cake was especially good. Specially* means *for a special purpose*: *I bought this book specially for you.* | *This hall is specially designed to meet the needs of a newspaper*.

A simple test: Ask yourself whether the word in question can be replaced by *particularly*. If not, use *specially*.

espresso The coffee is *espresso*, not *expresso*.

(-)esque Familiar compounds ending in *-esque* are not hyphenated: Kafkaesque, picturesque, statuesque. Normally, do not hyphenate coinages if the context is clear: *Tendulkar played a Boycottesque innings.*

estimate In the context of economic trends and business performance, use *estimate* to refer to an approximate calculation of performance up to the present or a date in the past. Use *forecast* when referring to expected future performance based on available data. Use *projection* to refer to probable future performance based on current trends or assumptions of likely developments.

Do not use *estimate* as a verb meaning *predict*, *project* or *forecast*.

etc Avoid. If you must use it, put a comma before it. Never use *etc, etc*.

ethics Singular in reference to the branch of philosophy; plural when it means *moral principals*.

ETM Estimated time of arrival.

EU for European Union. Headquarters are in Brussels, Belgium.

EUPHEMISMS

Beloved of bureaucrats, social scientists and the military, euphemisms seek to cloak reality, usually unpleasant, in innocuous words. For example, *a price increase* becomes *tariff rationalization*, *layoffs* become *rightsizing* or *downsizing* and *civilian casualties* become *collateral damage*. Do not use such euphemisms unless they are attributed to somebody.

euro Lowercase like other currencies — dollar, rupee.

Eurodollars are deposits denominated in US dollars at banks outside the US, especially in Europe, and thus are not under the jurisdiction of the US Federal Reserve. Do not confuse with euros.

Eurotunnel (one word) is the company that owns and operates the Channel tunnel.

evade, avoid *Evade* suggests deceit or irresponsibility. *Avoid* is the more neutral term in a context like taxes or punishment. Tax evasion is always illegal; tax avoidance can be legal.

evangelist In lowercase, it means *a preacher who tries to persuade people to become Christians*. By extension, it has also come to mean a zealous advocate, as in *a technology evangelist*, *an open-source evangelist*.

It is capped in reference to Matthew, Mark, Luke and John — the Evangelists who wrote the Gospels.

even(-) even-handed, even-money (adjective), even-tempered

even break, even money (noun)

evensong

even-steven (not *even-stephen*) Fair and equal in competition or distribution of resources: *an even-steven transaction*; *it was even-steven*; *it will be an even-steven race*.

ever can often be dropped from phrases like *first-ever* and *best-ever*; *first* and *best* say as much.

ever(-) evergreen, everlasting, evermore

ever-changing, ever-faithful, ever-present, ever-ready

every(-) everybody, everything, everywhere

everybody, everyone Always singular.

every day (noun and adverb: *it happens every day*), **everyday** (adjective: *an everyday mistake*)

everyone, every one The one-word form means *all the people* or *everybody*: *Police questioned everyone in the room.* The two-word form means *individually each one of a group*: *Every one of you must bring your passport.*

every time Two words.

evildoer

evoke (to bring to mind), **invoke** (to call upon solemnly): *In a speech evoking memories of the civil war, he invoked God's help in preventing fresh bloodshed.*

ex- Reserve it for headlines; use *former* in copy. An exception: *ex-serviceman*. The form *ex-Punjab CM* sounds more natural than *Punjab ex-CM*, but the latter style may sometimes be desirable to avoid ambiguity.

Do not hyphenate Latin phrases formed with *ex* even when using them as modifiers before nouns: *ex gratia*, *ex officio*, *ex dividend*, *ex parte*, *ex post facto*. Do not italicize these phrases. Here, itals have been used for a different reason (SEE **WORDS AS WORDS**).

exaggerate Note single *x* and double *g*.

exam, examination There is nothing wrong with the shorter form.

Remember that an examinee *takes* an exam; it is the examiner who *gives* the exam.

excepting Prefer *except* or *except for*.

exceptional (unusual, unusually good), **exceptionable** (objectionable)

exception that proves the rule The verb *proves* in this expression is a literal translation of the Latin *probare*, which means *tests*. If you say something is the exception that proves the rule, you mean that the very presence of an exception shows that there is a rule, even if unwritten, in the first place: *Most members of the party executive are above 50 but this 32-year-old man is an exception that proves the rule.*

Do not apply this phrase to every exceptional case you come across. And never use it to defend a rule that has been shown not to work.

excerpts from Not *excerpts of*.

exclamation mark It is rarely needed in news writing. When overused, it loses impact. Use sparingly, that too only in quotations of shouted or deeply emotional phrases.

Use a comma after a mild interjection. Use a full stop at the end of a mildly exclamatory sentence.

When you use an exclamation mark, you should not put a full stop after it.

excoriate Censure severely.

exec Shortened form of *executive*; avoid in copy.

execute, execution *Execute* means *to kill somebody in compliance with a military order or judicial decision*. It is not a synonym of *kill*, *murder* or *assassinate*. Terrorists do not *execute* a person; they *kill* the person.

SEE ALSO **ASSASSIN, KILLER, MURDERER** | **ASSASSINATE, ASSASSINATION** | **MURDER, KILLING, HOMICIDE**.

existing Prefer *present*.

exorbitant

exorcise Not *exorcize*.

expatriate Never *expatriot*.

expect, anticipate These are not synonyms. If you anticipate something, you not only expect it but also take precautionary action to deal with it.

expectant, expecting An *expectant mother* or *an expectant father* is a person who is going to have a baby. If a woman is pregnant, she *is expecting*. Do not write *expecting mother*.

experiment Avoid the euphemistic use of *experiment*, as in *She was experimenting with marijuana*.

explained Normally, *said* is better.

extempore, impromptu Both describe unprepared or unrehearsed acts, but their meanings are slightly different. If you deliver a speech without the aid of notes or other props, your speech is extempore, no matter whether you were scheduled to speak or not. If you are not scheduled to speak, but improvise and deliver a speech, your speech is impromptu.

While *extempore* is normally used to describe a speech, lecture or comment, *impromptu* can be used to describe any act or event: *an impromptu dance*, *an impromptu party*.

extra(-) Compounds in which *extra* means *outside* are generally one word:

extracurricular, extrajudicial, extramarital, extraordinary, extrasensory, extraterrestrial, extraterritorial

Compounds in which *extra* means *beyond the usual size or extent* are hyphenated:

extra-dry, extra-fine, extra-large

extrovert Not *extravert*.

exuberance

eye (verb) means *to look at closely or with interest*. Do not use it as a substitute for *consider* or *plan*.

eyeful The correct expression is *get an eyeful*, not *get an eyefull*.

eyeing

eye level

eye of a storm The literal meaning is *the calm region at the centre of a storm*. Idiomatically, it means *to be very much involved in an argument or problem that affects a lot of people*. Example: *The man in the eye of the storm is accused of selling secrets to the enemy*.

eye-opener

eyewash One word.

eyewitness One word, but *witness* is preferable.

***

Get your facts first, then you can distort them as you please.
— **Mark Twain**

F

face Do not write *I know him by face*. Make it *I know him by sight*.

Do not write *I told him on his face what I thought of him*. Make it *I told him to his face what I thought of him*.

facelift

face-off (noun), **face off** (verb)

facilitate *Help* is shorter and better.

facility A word that can mean almost anything, especially in American usage. Be specific. Even in subsequent references, use a precise word: *base, building, depot, factory, laboratory, office, plant, warehouse.*

facsimile If you mean the conventional *fax* process, use that word instead.

fact-finding (adjective)

factoid The word was coined by Norman Mailer in his 1973 biography of Marilyn Monroe. He defined it as "something that everyone knows is true, except it ain't". It is now being increasingly used to mean *an insignificant but true piece of information*. Today, this sense is nearly universal and must be accepted as standard (Garner's Modern American Usage).

fact sheet

faculty Plural faculties. *Faculty* is a collective term. For individuals, use *faculty members* or *members of the faculty*. Do not say *four faculty*, *10 faculty*.

fade(-) fadeaway (noun)

fade away (verb), fade in (verb), fade out (verb)

fade-in (noun), fade-out (noun)

faeces, faecal These are the British spellings; *feces* and *fecal* are American.

fag end

fahrenheit Lowercase. Cap the abbreviation *F*. Although India long ago adopted the metric system, in which celsius is the scale of temperature, fahrenheit is still widely used in the country as a measure of body temperature. To convert fahrenheit to celsius, subtract 32, multiply by 5 and divide by 9.

SEE ALSO **CENTIGRADE** | **CELSIUS**.

fail-safe

FAIRNESS AND IMPARTIALITY

In a story covering any sort of conflict, give all parties an opportunity to be heard. People or organizations criticized in a story must get a chance and adequate time to respond in the same story. Every effort must be made to reach those criticized. If they cannot be reached, say what effort was made, over how long a time and why it did not succeed. *Could not be reached for comment* is a perfunctory explanation.

Guard against words that undermine neutrality. Never use *sources alleged* or even a sophisticated variant of this phrase if the sources are not identified.

The New York Times policy on fairness and impartiality is worth bearing in mind: "An accusation that would not be acceptable if made outright cannot be implied through sly juxtaposition, the print equivalent of a cocked eyebrow. …

"Special care must be taken when partisan information comes from news sources who are identified incompletely or not at all. They should not be permitted the appearance or the reality of hiding behind the newspaper when attacking others."

SEE ALSO **ACCUSED** | **ALLEGE, ALLEGED, ALLEGEDLY** | **ANONYMOUS SOURCES** | **SOURCING**.

fair play Two words.

fairytale One word.

fait accompli Plural *faits accomplis*.

fake notes worth Do not write *Fake notes worth Rs 15 lakh were seized*. Fake notes are worth nothing. Make it *Fake notes totalling Rs 15 lakh were seized*.

fake news False or misleading information presented as news.

Falangist (Spain), **Phalangist** (Lebanon)

fallacious

fallacy Faulty reasoning.

fallopian tubes

fallout (noun), **fall out** (verb)

fall through the cracks Not *fall between the cracks*.

FALSE TITLES

Do not create titles out of mere descriptions, as in *Pedestrian Raj Kumar was hit by a Blueline* or *Kidnapper Sidharth killed the boy*. Rephrase these sentences to: *Raj Kumar, a pedestrian, was hit by a Blueline.* | *The kidnapper, Sidharth, killed the boy*. Occupational descriptions may be used as titles, as in *film star Salman Khan*, *astronaut Sunita Williams*, *Australia captain Ricky Ponting*, *weightlifter Kunjarani Devi*.

SEE ALSO **TITLES**.

famously Usually redundant and irritating. Avoid.

Fannie Mae, Freddie Mac Fannie Mae is Federal National Mortgage Association. Freddie Mac is Federal Home Loan Mortgage Corporation. Both are private companies supported by the US government. They supply money for mortgages.

FAQ No need to spell out

far(-) faraway (adjective), farseeing, farsighted, farsightedness

far-fetched, far-flung, far-off, far-ranging, far-reaching

far away (adverb), far out (adjective meaning *avant-garde*, *unusual*, *excellent*; hyphenated when placed before a noun)

Far East comprises Australia, China, Japan, New Zealand, North Korea, South Korea, Mongolia, Taiwan and the easternmost part of Russian Siberia. In a more extended sense, it includes Southeast Asia (Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand and Vietnam); in this sense, it is better to say *Far East and Southeast Asia*.

farm(-) farmhand, farmhouse, farmland, farmworker, farmyard

farm club, farm out (verb), farm team

farmers' market

farm-to-table Food sourcing directly from producers to consumers.

Farsi, Persian Use *Farsi*, which is the word used by Iranians for their language. Use *Persian* only in classical contexts. If a university course or department is called Persian, do not change it to *Farsi*.

farther, further Keep *farther* for physical distances. *Further* is more versatile of the two. It can be used for distance as well as time — and also metaphorically.

fascism, fascist Lowercase except in reference to Mussolini's party or movement.

fash frat Do not use this awkward cliché for *fashion fraternity*.

fast breeder reactor Fast neutron reactor designed to breed fuel by producing more fissile material than it consumes.

fast track (noun), **fast-track** (verb, adjective)
Avoid *fast-track* as a verb.

Fatah Palestinian party; do not write *al-Fatah*.

fatality Use *death*.

fat cat Hyphenated only if used as a modifier before a noun: *fat-cat salaries*. Use the term sparingly.

father Cap when it substitutes for a proper name: *I called Father just before he and Mother were to leave for London*. Also, cap when it is used as a religious title: *Father Stephen Sinn*.

Father's Day The third Sunday in June.

fatwa is an authoritative ruling on a point of Islam, not a sentence of punishment.

fault line

faux In the sense of *artificial* or *imitation*, this word is pretentious. Keep it for art and design writing.

faux pas The plural too is *faux pas*.

fave (not *fav*) Clipped form of *favourite*.

favour, favourable

fax The original term, *facsimile*, is considered archaic in this sense.

faze (to confuse or shock: *I wasn't fazed by his comments*), **phase** (to make something happen gradually in a planned way: *The new tax will be phased in over three years.*)

FBI The US Federal Bureau of Investigation. *FBI* is acceptable even in first reference.

fears, hopes Beware of hopes and fears. They represent opinions and, hence, need attribution. You should not refer to *hopes for a settlement of Middle East problems* or *fears of another oil price increase* without saying who is doing the hoping or fearing.

featherbedding The labour practice of requiring more workers than necessary to do a job. It is not a neutral term. What the management calls featherbedding the union may call a necessity.

For bedclothes, *feather bedding* is two words.

featherweight

Federal Reserve System The US central bank. It is supervised by the Federal Reserve Board. In subsequent references, use *the Federal Reserve* or *the Fed*.

feel Avoid its use in contexts like this: *Many Congressmen feel that Rahul Gandhi should be Prime Minister*. Only Congressmen can say what they feel. Instead of *feel*, use a more direct verb or phrase like *are of the opinion*, *are of the view*.

feel-good factor

feet, foot *A six-foot-tall man*, not *a six-feet-tall man*. But: *The man is six feet tall*.

feisty Not *fiesty*.

fellow (adjective) Do not hyphenate *fellow American, fellow citizen, fellow traveller, fellow worker*.

female, male Each word is a noun as well as adjective. First, the noun usage. While talking of people, use *woman*, *man*, *boy* or *girl*, rather than *female* or *male*. Write, for example, *Three women have joined the company's board*. Do not write *Three females have joined the company's board*, which is found demeaning by many people who say it sounds as if the reference is to animals, not humans.

Use *female* or *male* only when you need an all-inclusive term covering *she*s or *he*s of all ages, especially in biological or demographic contexts: *Females represented 60% of the respondents in the survey.* | *Most of the students on the campus are males.* | *The President expressed concern at the worsening male-female ratio.* However, *women's rights* includes the rights of all *she*s.

The adjective usage poses two problems. First, when you write things like *female doctor* and *male nurse*, you imply that the profession is the preserve of the other sex. This must be avoided. But there are times when such description is legitimate and necessary, as in *Chanda Kochhar is the first female chief of ICICI*. She *is* the first female chief of a major Indian bank, and that, in fact, may be the story. Second, should we say *female chief* or *woman chief*? Some people, extending the "demeaning" argument cited above, insist on *woman chief*. Others find *female chief* more natural; they argue that the parallel construction is *male chief*, not *man chief*. The race between *female* and *woman* is neck and neck, but *woman* seems to be winning.

When the reference is not to people, do not use *woman* as an adjective. Thus, *female condom* or *female fertility* cannot become *woman condom* or *woman fertility*.

SEE ALSO **LADY, GENTLEMAN** | **(-)PERSON** | **SEXIST LANGUAGE** | **SPOKESPERSON**.

feng shui The Chinese practice of deciding the right position for a building and for placing objects inside it in order to make people feel comfortable and happy.

Ferozeshah Kotla Cricket ground in Delhi.

ferreted

ferris wheel

fertility rate A population's fertility rate is the average number of children born to a woman during her lifetime.

festschrift Lowercase. This German word means *a collection of writings published in honour of a scholar*: *"India's Economic Reforms and Development: Essays for Manmohan Singh" is a festschrift published in 1998 on Singh's 65th birthday*.

fetus Not *foetus*. The original Latin word is *fetus*. The latest editions of Concise Oxford Dictionary and Collins English Dictionary recommend *fetus*.

few, a few The meanings are quite different. *Few* has a rather negative sense: *hardly any*. *A few* has a somewhat positive sense: *some, but not many*.

Few cars were parked there means *hardly any cars were parked there*.

A few cars were parked there means *some cars were parked there*.

Quite a few means *a considerable number*: *I've been there quite a few times*.

SEE ALSO **LITTLE, A LITTLE**.

fewer (smaller in number; for example, *fewer coins*), **less** (smaller in quantity; for example, *less money*)

Never use *very less*. *Very little* or *very few* is correct. Also, use *less* with a number that describes a quantity considered as a single bulk amount: *The boy was born less than three years ago.* | *I eat less than 10 grams of sugar a month.* | *The camera costs less than Rs 40,000.*

few who The construction *one of the few who* needs a plural verb: *You are one of the few friends who understand my problems*.

fiancé (man), **fiancée** (woman) But *divorcee* for both sexes.

fiasco(s) An overused word. Avoid.

Fiberglas A trademark for fibreglass or glass fibre.

Ficci Not all caps. Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry.

fidayeen Lowercase, plural. It means *people who are ready to kill themselves for a cause*. The singular is *fidayee*, which is rarely used; in the singular sense, use *guerrilla*.

Fide Not *FIDE*. Fédération Internationale des Échecs, or World Chess Federation.

fief Land, domain; *fiefdom* is redundant.

(-)field airfield, battlefield, coalfield, gasfield, hayfield, infield, minefield, oilfield, outfield

ice field

field marshal Note single *l* in marshal.

fiery Not *firey*.

fig leaf

figurehead One word.

FIGURES SEE **NUMBERS**.

FIs Financial institutions.

FIIs Foreign institutional investors.

filesharing

filibuster (Not *fillibuster*) To make a long speech to obstruct the passage of legislation. A legislator who uses this method is also a *filibuster*, not a *filibusterer*.

Filipino (male native of the Philippines), **Filipina** (female native of the Philippines), **Philippine** (adjective of *the Philippines*)

fillip Not *filip*.

filmmaker But *film star*.

filmy, filmi The word *filmy* means *thin and almost transparent*, as in *a filmy gown*. It can also mean *covered with a thin film*, *hazy* or *misty*, as in *filmy eyes*. In the sense of movie, the adjective of *film* is *filmi*, an Indian coinage.

finalize, finalized Prefer *complete*, *completed* or *finish*, *finished*.

fine print Two words.

finesse

fine-tooth comb Never *fine tooth-comb*.

fine-tune

fingerprint One word.

finmin is acceptable for *finance ministry* in headlines. Do not use it for *finance minister*. Resist coinages like *oilmin*.

firearms

firefighter, firefighting

firewall A security system that protects a computer or network from being used or looked at by unauthorized people. It allows or blocks traffic into and out of a computer or network.

firing line The people who do the firing; if they are aiming at you, you are *in the line of fire*, not *in the firing line*.

firm A business partnership: *a law firm*, *an accountancy firm*. Do not use *firm* in references to an incorporated business. Use *company* or *corporation*.

first(-) first aid (noun), first class (noun), first cousin, first floor (noun), first generation, first love, first strike

first-aid (adjective), first-class (adjective), first-degree burn, first-degree murder, first-floor (adjective), first-generation (adjective), first-hand, first-past-the-post, first-rate (adjective), first-strike (adjective)

firstborn, firstling

first come, first served Always hyphenate when it is used as a modifier before a noun: *first-come-first-served basis*. Otherwise, no hyphens: *Some seats are reserved; some are first come, first served*. The comma between the two parts of the phrase is sometimes omitted.

first lady Lowercase. Do not use it as a title before a name. In the Indian context, the term applies to the wife of a president or governor. Do not use it for a woman president or for the wife of a prime minister or chief minister.

firstly, secondly, thirdly Use *first*, *second*, *third*.

first-timer

fisc Government treasury or exchequer.

fiscal deficit, revenue deficit, primary deficit *Fiscal deficit* is the extent to which the government has to use borrowed funds to meet all its spending requirements after it has exhausted its income streams. *Fiscal deficit* equals *total expenditure – (revenue receipts + loan recoveries + other receipts)*. *Revenue deficit* is the difference between revenue expenditure and revenue receipts. It denotes the extent to which running expenses outstrip regular income streams. *Primary deficit* is the difference between fiscal deficit and interest payments. *Budget deficit* (or *budgetary deficit*), a measure no longer used by the Indian government, is the difference between total expenditure and total receipts.

fiscal policy, monetary policy *Fiscal policy* means a government's taxation and spending policy. *Monetary policy* means the policy adopted by a central bank, like the Reserve Bank of India, to influence the cost and availability of credit.

SEE **REPO RATE, REVERSE REPO RATE** | **CASH RESERVE RATIO**.

Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Act *FRBM Act*, for short.

fiscal year Write *the 2006-07 fiscal year*, not *fiscal 2006-07*.

fit (verb) Past tense and past participle *fitted*, not *fit*.

fitful has nothing to do with being fit; it means *not continuous* or *starting and stopping often*, as in *a fitful sleep*, *a fitful burst of energy*. *In fits and start*s means *fitfully*.

fit to a T Not *fit to a tee*.

fjord Not *fiord*.

flag(-) flagbearer, flagman, flagpole, flagship, flagstaff, flagwoman

flag-waving

For a ship with Indian flag, *Indian-flag ship*, not *Indian flagship*.

flail (to move one's arms and legs around without control), **flay** (to strip off the skin by whipping; figuratively, to criticize severely)

flair (natural ability, talent), **flare** (flame, to burn brightly, to say something in an angry way)

flak A type of anti-aircraft fire, and by extension, *severe criticism*.

flamboyant Not *flambuoyant*.

flammable means the same *as inflammable*. Prefer *flammable*, which is unambiguous. The opposite is *non-flammable*.

flare, flair SEE **FLAIR, FLARE**.

flare up (verb), **flare-up** (noun)

flash mob A public gathering of complete strangers, organized through the internet or mobile phones, who perform a pointless act and then disperse. Do not use the term to refer to other forms of public gathering. Compounds: flash mobber, flash mobbing.

SEE ALSO **MOB**.

flashpoint

flaunt, flout *To flaunt* is to show off, as in *flaunt wealth*; *to flout* is to defy or show disregard, as in *flout the law*.

flautist is the British spelling; *flutist* is American.

fledgling Not *fledgeling*.

flexitime

flier SEE **FLYER**.

flight numbers Cap them as proper names: *Flight 118, Flight 304*.

flimflam Old-fashioned informal word meaning *nonsense*.

flip-flop

flip side

floating stock, float SEE **SHARES OUTSTANDING**.

floodlight, floodlighting, floodlit

floodwaters

flotation Not *floatation*.

flounder, founder *To flounder* means *to perform a task badly*, *like someone stuck in mud*; *to founder* means *to fail*. *A business might be foundering because its bosses are floundering*.

flout, flaunt SEE **FLAUNT, FLOUT**.

flowed (past tense and past participle of *flow*), **flown** (past participle of *fly*)

flowerbed, flowerpot

fluorescent

Flushing Meadows (not *Meadow*) Home of the US Open tennis championships, in New York.

flyer is the British spelling; *flier* is American. The word can mean *a pilot*, *a passenger*, *a leaflet* or *a fast vehicle*. It could be confusing if used in the same story for *pilot* as well as *passenger*.

Also: *frequent flyer*, *high-flyer*.

flypast A ceremonial flight of aircraft past a person or a place.

FMCT Fissile Material Cutoff Treaty.

focused, focusing Not *focussed*, *focussing*.

foe This word meaning *enemy* is useful in headlines but it is a formal word; *enemy* is more common.

foetid is the British spelling; *fetid* is American.

fogey Not *fogy*.

(-)fold Compounds are one word: twofold, threefold, twentyfold, hundredfold, thousandfold, millionfold. Hyphenate when using it with a figure: 10-fold, 100-fold.

folk(-) folklore, folklorist, folktale

folk art, folk dance, folk hero, folk medicine, folk music, folk singer, folk song

folk-dance (adjective)

follow(-) follow-through, follow-up

following Use *after* instead: *after the crash,* not *following the crash*.

fondle To stroke lovingly. Do not use *fondle* in descriptions of rape, assault or unwelcome advances, where *grab*, *grope* or *touch* may be more appropriate.

F1 Short for *Formula One*. SEE ALSO **FORMULA ONE**.

font (type face), **fount** (source, as in *fount of knowledge*)

Food and Agriculture Organization Not *Agricultural*. *FAO* in subsequent references.

Food and Drug Administration (of the US) FDA is acceptable in subsequent references.

foodgrain is Indian English; British English and American English use just *grain*. Prefer *grain*, but *foodgrain* is fine in established terms like *foodgrain production*.

foodstuff

fool(-) foolhardy, foolproof, foolscap

foot To the extent possible, use the metric system: centimetre, metre, etc. One foot is equal to 30.48cm. For an approximate conversion to centimetres, multiply by 30. For example, 5 feet equals 150cm.

(on) foot You walk to a place *on foot*, not *by foot*. Example: *It takes an hour on foot or 10 minutes by car*.

foot, feet *A six-foot-tall man*, not *a six-feet-tall man*. But: *The man is six feet tall*.

foot(-) football, footboy, footbridge, footfall, footgear, foothill, foothold, footlights, footlocker, footloose, footman, footmark, footnote, footpad, footpath, footplate, footprint, footrace, footrest, footrope, footsore, footstep, footstool, footwear, footwork

foot-candle, foot-pound

foot brake, foot passenger, foot soldier

foot-and-mouth disease Not *hoof-and-mouth disease*.

FOOTBALL

Each of these is one word: crossbar, flagpost, goalkeeper, goalpost, kickoff (noun), midfield, midfielder, offside, playoff, shootout, touchline.

Each of these is two words: free kick, goal kick, goal line, corner kick, penalty area, own goal.

These are hyphenated: head-butt, throw-in (noun).

Some other terms: Champions League (European football), no apostrophe; defender (not defenceman); Fifa (not *FIFA*); forward (striker); Glasgow kiss (head-butt); goalie (acceptable for *goalkeeper*); Serie A (Italian League first division); Uefa (not *UEFA*).

Self-goal is an Indian coinage for *own goal*. Use *own goal*.

for, since Use *for* to indicate a period of time and *since* to indicate a point of time: *I have known her for 10 years.* | *I have known her since 1999.* Both *for* and *since* require *has been*, *have been* or *had been*. *He was living in Delhi for 20 years* is wrong. Make it *He has* (or *had*) *been living in Delhi for 20 years.*

for all its worth But *for what it's worth*.

forbear (refrain), **forebear** (ancestor)

forbearance means *being patient and forgiving towards somebody who has done something wrong*. In law, it means *an intentional delay in collecting a debt or demanding performance on a contract*. In the telecom sector, the regulator shows forbearance towards an operator by not interfering in fixing tariff. While using this word, explain the meaning.

forbid The past tense is *forbade*.

forbid, prohibit Use *to* after *forbid* and *from* after *prohibit*: *He was forbidden to go*. | *He was prohibited from going*. It is wrong to say *He was forbidden from going*.

fore(-) Most compounds are one word:

forearm, forecast, forecastle, foreclose, foreclosure, forecourt, foredoom, forefather, forefeet, forefinger, forefoot, forefront, foregone, foreground, forehand, forejudge, foreknowledge, foreman, forename, forenoon, foreordain, forepaws, foreplay, forerunner, foresail, foresee, foreshadow, foreshock, foresight, foreskin, forestall, forestay, foretaste, foretell, forewarn

forecast The past tense and past participle is *forecast*, not *forecasted*.

forego (precede, as in *foregone conclusion*), **forgo** (go without, as in *If you have diabetes, you must forgo sweets*)

foreign

foreign currency If a story mentions amounts of money in foreign currency, convert it to rupees or US dollars (if the context is international) at the latest exchange rate and give the figure in brackets. If the context is Indian, amounts of money mentioned in US dollars too should be converted to rupees at the latest exchange rate and given in brackets.

forensic means *used in or connected with a court of law*. A forensic expert could be a solicitor or a scientist. For clarity, write *forensic scientist*, *forensic medicine*.

forever, for ever One word when it means *continually: He's forever going on about how great a player he was*. Two words when it means *always* or *for a very long time*: *I will love you for ever*. | *She takes for ever to get dressed*. In American English, *forever* is one word in both senses and is becoming so in British English as well. When in doubt, let it be one word.

forfeit Not *forefeit*.

for free Avoid. Prefer *free* or *for nothing*.

forgivable

formal, formally Often redundant, especially in expressions like *formally announced*.

formatting, formatted

former Avoid uses of *former* and *latter* that force the reader to go back to previous sentences or paragraphs. Rephrase and name names.

Guard against this error: *Former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee resigned after the defeat of the BJP in the 2004 Lok Sabha elections*. There would have been no need for him to resign if he was already *former Prime Minister*.

formula The plural is *formulas*, except in mathematical contexts, where it is *formulae*.

Formula One Cap. The short form of *Formula One* is *F1*, not *Formula 1*, *F-1* or *F 1*.

for-profit Use *commercial* or *profit-making*. Also: *non-profit* rather than *not-for-profit*.

for real Avoid this cliché.

forsake, forsook, forsaken

forswear (not *foreswear*) A formal word for *renounce*: *The country has not forsworn the use of nuclear weapons.*

forthcoming means *going to happen soon*. It can also mean *made available when required* or *willing to divulge information*: *Help was not forthcoming*. | *She's never forthcoming about her plans.*

There is a similar word, *upcoming*, which means *going to happen*. But experts and stylebooks consider it inelegant and advise against its use. (See Bernard Kilgore's quote at the beginning of the chapter on U.)

fortnight Use *two weeks.*

fortuitous does not mean *fortunate*; it means *happening by chance*.

fortuneteller, fortunetelling

forty Not *fourty*.

forum Plural *forums*; *fora* is archaic and best confined to contexts involving Roman history.

founder, flounder SEE **FLOUNDER, FOUNDER**.

fount, font SEE **FONT, FOUNT**.

fourth estate The press and journalists. Lowercase.

four-wheel drive But *a four-wheel-drive vehicle.*

fowl Singular and plural.

FRACTIONS

In everyday life people think in fractions, not decimals. Use *a quarter*, *a third*, *a half* rather than *25%*, *33%*, *50%*. In an intro for an opinion poll, for instance, it is better to write *Two Germans in three prefer* ... than *Sixty-nine per cent of Germans prefer* ... . The precise figure should be given lower in the story. Do not mix decimals and fractions in the same story. For example, do not write *25% of Germans prefer this whereas two-thirds prefer that.*

one-third, two-thirds, three-quarters, two-tenths, one-twentieth, one twenty-first, 20 one-hundredths, one-103rd, twenty-five 103rds

two and a half, half a kilometre (no hyphens)

frame up (verb), **frame-up** (noun)

framework

franchisee, franchiser

Franco(-) Use *French(-)*: *French-American, French-German.*

Frankenstein Strictly, *Frankenstein* means *a person destroyed by his or her own creation*. The title character in Mary Shelly's 1918 novel, Frankenstein is a young medical student who creates a monster that destroys him. However, for a long time the word has also been used to mean *Frankenstein's monster* (a creation that brings disaster and is beyond the control of its creator) or *anything that becomes dangerous to its creator*.

freak Both *freak weather* and *freakish weather* are fine.

Freddie Mac SEE **FANNIE MAE, FREDDIE MAC**.

free(-) freebooter, freehand (adjective), freelance, freeloader, freeloading, freestyle, freethinker, freethinking, freeway, freewheel, freewheeling, freewill (adjective)

free-for-all (noun and adjective), free-form (adjective), free-spoken, free-standing, free-trade (adjective)

free agent, free fall, free hand (noun), free port, free trade (noun), free will (noun)

free fall Two words.

free rein Not *free reign*. The allusion is to horses, not kings or queens.

free world A heavily loaded term. Keep it for opinion pieces and direct quotes.

French, Frenchman(men), Frenchwoman(women)

french Lowercase compounds formed with *french* except when the meaning is *of France*: french fries, french kiss, french letter, french window.

fresco(es)

freshman Never *freshwoman* or *freshperson*. If *-man* is to be avoided, write *first-year-student*.

freudian slip

friendly In sports contexts, use the term *exhibition game* or *exhibition match* somewhere up front in the story if that is what you mean.

friendlily Yes, this word exists, but *in a friendly way* will be more easily understood.

front(-) frontbench, frontline

front-foot (adjective), front-page (adjective)

front foot (noun), front man (noun), front page (noun)

frontrunner, frontrunning Do not describe a candidate as frontrunner without attributing the ranking.

frostbite

F-16 Fighter plane. Note hyphen.

fuchsia

fuel fuelled, fuelling

Führer Title assumed by Hitler as leader of Nazi Germany. The word means *leader*.

Fujiyama, Mount Fuji Not *Mount Fujiyama* because *-yama* means *mountain*.

(-)ful SEE **SPOONFUL**.

Fulbright scholarship Not *Fullbright scholarship*. Named after US educator, writer and politician James William Fulbright.

fulfil is the British spelling; *fulfill* is American.

fullback

FULL STOP

The best thing about a period (full stop), says the New York Times stylebook, is that it can mean two readable sentences instead of a single cumbersome one, especially in a lead paragraph.

A full stop, rather than the exclamation mark, should be used to end mildly exclamatory sentences.

If an inverted sentence is intended not as a question, but as a request, invitation or instruction, a full stop can be used in place of the question mark. Such sentences are called rhetorical questions. Example: *Can you open the window.*

Do not put a full stop after a question mark or an exclamation mark.

Do not use full stops in abbreviations, except when their absence can cause ambiguity: *No. 1*, *n.o.* (not out).

full time Hyphenate only when using it as an adjective: *Ashish is a full-time student.* But: *Sushil works full time in a coffee shop.*

fulsome Not *fullsome*. *Fulsome* has a tone of disapproval; it means *excessive and insincere*. Avoid it as a synonym of *lavish*, as in *fulsome praise.*

fun Avoid using it as an adjective, as in *a fun vacation*.

fund, funded, funding Confine the verb *fund* to financial contexts. In general contexts, use *finance* or *pay for*: *The survey was paid for by the government* rather than *The survey was funded by the government*.

fundamentalist The word means *conservative in religious or doctrinal beliefs*. A fundamentalist is not always a militant or terrorist and not all militants or terrorists are fundamentalists.

fundraiser, fundraising

funnel British *funnelled, funnelling*; American *funneled, funneling*.

furore is the British spelling; *furor* is American.

further, farther SEE **FARTHER, FURTHER**.

fuselage An aircraft's main part, in which people sit or goods are carried.

fusillade A quick series of shots fired from a gun, or a quick series of objects thrown: *a fusillade of bullets.* Figuratively, *a fusillade of questions*.

future plans Write just *plans*.

F-word

***

A poet must master the rules of grammar before he attempts to bend or break them.
— **Robert Graves**

G

gaff (hook or spar; *blow the gaff* means *to give away a secret*), **gaffe** (blunder, indiscretion)

Gaia In Greek mythology, Earth — personified as a goddess, who is the daughter of Chaos, and the mother and wife of Uranus.

Gaia hypothesis First formulated in the 1960s by James Lovelock, this ecological hypothesis proposes that living and non-living parts of the earth be viewed as a complex interacting system — a single organism.

gaiety, gaily

GAIL The company's official name is GAIL (India) Limited. Do not expand it to *Gas Authority of India Ltd*.

gale According to the US National Weather Service, a gale has a speed of 39 to 54 miles an hour.

SEE ALSO **HURRICANE**.

gallon A gallon equals four quarts. A US standard gallon is roughly 3.8 litres. A British imperial gallon is roughly 4.5 litres.

Gallup poll Invented by the American statistician George Gallup in the 1930s, Gallup poll has acquired a generic meaning: *a public opinion poll*.

Gambia Not *the Gambia*.

gambit An opening strategy that involves a sacrifice in return for general advantage. Therefore, do not write *opening gambit*; *gambit* is sufficient. Do not use *gambit* if you are not talking of an opening strategy. Use *ploy* or *tactic*.

gameplan, gameshow

gaming If you mean gambling, write *gambling*. *Gaming* is a euphemism, which should be confined to official names and quotes. The word *gaming* in the sense of videogames could be confusing; write *videogames* or *computer games*.

gamut The complete range of something. *To run the gamut* is to experience, display or perform the complete range of something: *She had run the gamut of human emotions from joy to despair*.

gamy, gamier, gamiest

Gandhigiri

Ganga Not *Ganges*.

Gangaram Hospital Hospital in Delhi. Do not write *Sir Gangaram Hospital*.

gang rape (noun), **gang-rape** (verb)

gas (noun) Plural *gases*, not *gasses*.

gas (verb) gases, gassed, gassing.

gasify, gasification Note single *s*.

gaslighting Manipulating someone into doubting their reality.

gatecrash (verb) One word.

Gatwick airport London's second largest airport.

gauge (not *guage* or *gage)* rhymes with *rage* and refers to a measuring instrument or measurement: *pressure gauge*, *petrol gauge*, *narrow gauge*, *broad gauge*, *a 27-gauge needle*, *a 12-gauge shotgun*.

By extension, *gauge* also means *something that helps you make a judgment about a person or a situation*: *Newspaper circulation is a good gauge of a market's size*. It is also used as a verb: *I tried to gauge her mood*.

Do not confuse *gauge* with *gauze*, which rhymes with *cause* and refers to a thin, transparent material with very small holes in it (*gauze dressing*, *gauze bandage*) or a material made of thin threads of metal or plastic (*wire gauze*). A *gauzy* dress is transparent or nearly transparent.

Gauhati Although the city's name has changed to Guwahati, some organizations retain *Gauhati* in their names: Gauhati high court, Gauhati University. But: IIT, Guwahati.

gauntlet, gantlet A *gauntlet* is a strong glove with a long loose wrist. It also refers to the metal glove worn by medieval soldiers. When you *throw down the gauntlet*, you invite somebody to fight. When you *take up the gauntlet*, you accept somebody's invitation to fight.

A *gantlet* is the convergence of two parallel railway tracks in a narrow place. It also means an ordeal in which a person is forced to run between two lines of men facing each other and armed with clubs or whips to beat the victim: *Some witnesses had to run the gantlet of television cameras and reporters.* In this sense, the spelling *gauntlet* is also used, especially in British English.

gay The word is now universally used as a synonym of *homosexual*. Do not use it in other senses. *Gay* may refer to men as well as women. In specific references to women, *lesbian* is preferred. The use of *gay* as a noun has a derisive tone. Use it only as an adjective. Say *He's gay*, not *He's a gay*; *gay men and lesbians,* not *gays and lesbians*.

SEE ALSO **BISEXUAL** | **LESBIAN** | **LGBT** | **SEXUAL ORIENTATION** | **STRAIGHT**.

GB is gigabyte(s). In telecommunications, a gigabyte is one billion bytes. When used for computer memory, a gigabyte denotes 2^{30}, or 1024^3, bytes. This is equal to 1,073,741,824 bytes. **Gb** is gigabit(s) and **Gbps** gigabit(s) per second.

gelatin Not *gelatine*.

gender, sex Gender — the grammar term for classification of words as masculine, feminine, common and neuter — acquired an additional meaning in the 19th century: the state of being male or female. Since then, in cultural, social and political contexts, it has become a euphemism for *sex*. Confine *gender* to idioms like *gender bias* and *gender gap*. Use *sex* in non-grammar contexts and in unambiguous phrases like *sex change*, *sex determination* and *sex discrimination*. But use *gender* to avoid confusion with physical sex or to avert double meaning.

general election Lowercase. SEE ALSO **ELECTION**.

Generation X,Y etc We divide history into generations because it helps us understand how groups of people shaped -- and were shaped by -- the times they lived in. A generation is a cohort of people born within roughly 15-25 years who experienced major events, technologies and cultural shifts at similar life stages. We will skip Lost Generation (1883-1900), Greatest Generation (1901-1927) and Silent Generation (1928-1945) to begin with Baby Boomers (1946-1964)

Baby Boomers (1946-1964): Born during the post-WWII baby boom, they came of age during the 1960s-70s social upheavals. They were shaped by the Vietnam War, Cold War and civil rights movements. They were associated with economic expansion, suburban growth and corporate leadership.

Gen X (1965-1980): Sometimes called the "Latchkey Generation", they grew

up with rising divorce rates and dual-income households. They witnessed the end of Cold War. They were early adopters of personal computers and MTV culture and seen to be independent, sceptical and pragmatic.

Gen Y (Millennials, 1981-1996): They were the first generation to grow up with the internet. They were shaped by the Sept 11 attacks and the global financial crisis. Characterised as tech-savvy, collaborative and socially conscious. In India, this is the first major liberalisation-era cohort (post-1991 reforms.)

Gen Z (1997-2012): True digital natives with smartphones from childhood. They have been shaped by social media, climate anxiety and pandemic disruptions. They came of age during the Covid-19 pandemic. They are more financially cautious and politically aware at a young age.

Gen Alpha (2013-2025): They are the children of the Millennials. They have grown up with AI, tablets and voice assistants. Their education has been heavily influenced by pandemic-era digital schooling.

Some emerging terms are: Gen Beta (2025-2039); Xennials (1977-1983); Zillennials (1993-1998)

Geneva Conventions Four treaties and three additional protocols that set international standards for the humanitarian treatment of prisoners of war and civilians caught up in war. The singular term *Geneva Convention* refers to the agreements of 1949, negotiated in the aftermath of World War II, updating the terms of the first three treaties and adding a fourth treaty.

genie Not *jinni*.

gentleman SEE **LADY, GENTLEMAN**.

genus, species In biological names, cap the first, or generic, Latin name for the class of plant or animal and lowercase the species that follows: Homo sapiens, Escherichia coli (E coli), Tyrannosaurus rex.

geriatric does not mean *elderly*; it is applied to medical treatment for the elderly, as in *geriatric hospital*. Do not use it as a disparaging term for the old.

Germanys (not *Germanies*) is the plural of *Germany*. The plural might be needed in historical contexts. From 1949 to 1990, there were two Germanys — West Germany (Federal Republic of Germany, or FRG) and East Germany (German Democratic Republic, or GDR). GDR merged into FRG in 1990.

gerrymander To divide a voting area to give one political party a majority in as many constituencies as possible, or to manipulate unfairly to gain advantage.

get Do not write *He got promoted*. Make it *He was promoted*. Similarly, *He was transferred, He married*; not *He got transferred, He got married*.

getaway (noun), **get away** (verb)

get-together (noun), **get together** (verb)

gibe, jibe, jive In British English, *jibe* is the word if you mean *taunt*. In American English, *gibe* is preferred in this sense.

In both British English and American English, *jibe*, as a verb, also means *to be in accordance with* or *to agree*: *Their stories didn't jibe*.

In American English, *jibe* has another meaning — *to change direction when sailing with the wind behind you, by swinging the sail from one side of the boat to the other*. In this sense, the British spelling is *gybe*.

Jive, an American word, means *deceptive or nonsensical talk*; as a verb it means *to talk nonsense*. Originally, it was a jazz term used for a kind of music or dance, or for the jargon of jazz musicians.

GI Geographical Indication (GI) is a sign used on products -- such as agricultural, natural or manufactured goods -- that have a specific geographical origin and possess qualities, reputation or characteristics essentially attributable to that origin. It acts as a certification of authenticity, linking a product to its region, reputation or traditional craftsmanship.

gig workers and economy The gig economy is a labour market defined by short-term, flexible and freelance jobs, often facilitated by digital platforms (e.g. Amazon, Flipkart, Blinkit, Zomato etc) rather than traditional full-time employment. Gig workers are independent contractors, freelancers or on-demand workers who perform specific tasks or projects, offering flexibility, independence and specialised skills.

gig Also a single performance by jazz or pop musicians. You can *do*, *play* or *have* a gig. The word is also used as a verb, as in *He has gigged with various bands*.

giga- Compounds formed with *giga-*, which means *one billion*, are not hyphenated: gigabyte, gigacycle, gigaton, gigawatt. But hyphenate coined terms like *giga-discovery*.

SEE ALSO **GB**.

gild the lily Shakespeare's original words from "King John" are: "To gild refined gold, to paint the lily." But *gild the lily* is established as a phrase and recognized by dictionaries. It means *to overembellish* or *to spoil something that is already good or beautiful by trying to improve it*.

gilt-edged securities Government securities on which interest payments and final repayments are guaranteed.

girl Keep this word for references to those below 18.

girlfriend One word. The term is informal and best reserved for teenagers.

girlie Not *girly*.

giveaway (noun), **give away** (verb)

global Beware of excessive use. *Global* is correct for something that affects the whole globe. For example, *the threat of global warming*. However, companies often talk of their global networks, usually an exaggeration.

globetrotter

glycerine is the British spelling; *glycerin* is American.

GM crops, GM food

GMT Greenwich Mean Time; no need to spell it out. GMT has been replaced by UTC as the world standard.

SEE **UTC**.

go The phrase is *in one go*, not *at one go*.

go-ahead (noun)

goal(-) goalpost

goal line

gobbledygook (pompous or unintelligible jargon) Although British English also uses *gobbledegook*, the original and more common spelling is *gobbledygook*.

go begging, go a-begging Use the first; the second is old-fashioned.

go-between (noun)

God Cap *God* only in reference to the Supreme Being of any religion. Lowercase in other contexts: *rain god, warrior god*. Lowercase gods and goddesses in references to deities of polytheistic religions.

Lowercase personal pronouns referring to God: *he, him, thee, thou*. Even most church publications now follow this practice. Lowercase *god* and *goddess* in references to false gods: *Marilyn Monroe, the 1950s sex goddess, was born Norma Jean Mortenson.* | *To his fans, he's a god.*

God(-) God-fearing, God-given; but Godspeed.

god(-) godchild, goddaughter, godfather, godforsaken, godlike, godmother, godsend, godson

(-)goer churchgoer, concertgoer, gymgoer, moviegoer, operagoer, partygoer, theatregoer

go-go A go-go dancer, or go-go girl, performs in a bar or club, dancing energetically to pop music with a strong beat, often in an erotic manner and wearing very little clothing. In business and finance, *go-go* refers to a period

characterized by a dramatic increase or growth: *go-go years for Indian carmakers*, *go-go mutual funds*, *a go-go stock market*.

goings-on

go-kart Not *go-cart*.

gold When *gold* is used as a substitute for *gold medal*, its plural is *golds*: *He won 4 golds*, not *He won 4 gold*.

GoM Group of ministers. SEE ALSO **EGoM**.

good(-) goodbye, goodnight. But: good morning, good day.

Good Friday The Friday before Easter.

goodness, for goodness' sake

goodwill (noun and adjective) One word. But: *ill will*.

goof (noun and verb) Not *goof-up* or *goof up*.

google is now common as a lowercase verb meaning *search for something on the internet*. Remember that Google objects to the lowercasing of its name.

GOP can be used as a synonym for the US Republican Party in headlines or direct quotes. Generally, no need to spell it out to *Grand Old Party*. Avoid using the term for India's Congress.

gorilla

Gorkha, Gurkha The spelling in India and Nepal is *Gorkha*; the British spelling is *Gurkha*. After Independence in 1947, India changed the spelling of *Gurkha regiment* to *Gorkha regiment*.

go-slow (noun), **go slow** (verb)

gospel(s) Cap in reference to any of the four books of the Bible or in the sense of the Christian message. Otherwise lowercase: *Take my word as gospel truth*. | *She is a gospel singer*.

got, gotten Except in phrases like *ill-gotten wealth*, use *got*.

gourmand, gourmet A gourmand is a person who enjoys eating, sometimes to excess. Be careful while using this word. It may convey a pejorative sense.

A gourmet is a connoisseur, or excellent judge, of good food. The word has become a cliché, especially as an adjective. Tour operators and hotels publicize not only *gourmet buffets* but also *gourmet massages*. Prefer *food lover, judge of fine cooking* or *epicure*.

Gov, guv Use *Gov* or *Governor* as a title before the name of a US state's governor: *Gov Arnold Schwarzenegger*, *Governor Bobby Jindal*. Otherwise, the short form of *governor*, to be used only in headlines and not as a title before a name, is *guv*.

govt Singular, lowercase.

government in exile No hyphens.

governor(s) general No hyphen.

grade, grader Hyphenate compounds like *12th-grade student*, *first-grader*.

graduate (verb) Use active voice: *He graduated from the university* rather than *He was graduated from the university*. Never drop *from*: *He graduated from Harvard*, not *He graduated Harvard*.

graffiti Strictly speaking, *graffiti*, meaning *scrawls on a wall*, is plural; *graffito*, rarely used, is the singular. Usage now allows *graffiti* as a singular when it means *the practice or phenomenon of drawing on walls*: *Graffiti has persisted at the park for years*. In references to the scrawls themselves, treat *graffiti* as a plural. For a single wall marking, use *scrawl*, *marking* or *drawing*.

gram Not *gramme*. Abbreviation *g*, not *gm*. Kilogram is *kg*, not *kgm*.

grammar Not *grammer*.

Grammy Awards, Grammy(s)

grand(-) granddaughter, grandfather, grandma, grandmother, grandnephew, grandniece, grandson

grandad, granddad Both spellings are correct. Use *grandad*. But there are two *d*'s in *granddaughter*; never write *grandaughter*.

grand dame Plural *grandes dames*.

grandmaster (chess) Lowercase.

grandmother Describe a woman as a *grandmother* or *mother*, only when this is relevant to the story. The best test is, would you have used *grandfather* or *father* if it were a man? Headlines like this appear in newspapers: *Grandmother murdered in south Delhi*. Maybe the woman was just 40 and the murder had nothing to do with her being a grandmother.

grand prix Lowercase, plural *grands prix*. Cap it only when it is part of a name: *Australian Grand Prix*, *European Grand Prix*.

Grand Slam Cap in reference to the four main tournaments in tennis — the Australian Open, the French Open, Wimbledon and the US Open. Cap also in reference to the four main golf tournaments — the Masters, the US Open, the British Open and the PGA Championship. Otherwise lowercase.

grant(s)-in-aid

grassroots One word, always plural; *grassroot* is wrong.

grateful, thankful SEE **THANKFUL, GRATEFUL**.

great(-) All relationship words formed with *great* are hyphenated: great-aunt, great-grandchild, great-granddaughter, great-grandson, great-grandfather, great-great-grandfather, great-uncle. The meaning changes if you do not use a hyphen. *Great grandfather*, for example, does not mean *grandfather's father*. It means *distinguished grandfather*.

Great Britain includes England, Scotland and Wales, but not Northern Ireland.

SEE ALSO **BRITAIN** | **UNITED KINGDOM**.

green Lowercase: *a green activist*, *the green movement*. But cap in proper names: *Green Party*.

greenfield site A site that has not been built on before; one that has been built on before is a *brownfield* site.

greenhouse effect

Green Revolution

greenwashing by an organization is the publishing of information that makes people think the organization cares about the environment.

grey is the British spelling; *gray* is American.

grievous Not *grievious*.

grill Do not use as a substitute for *interrogate*. Use *interrogate* or *question*.

grisly (gruesome, ghastly), **grizzly** (greyish, as in *grizzly bear*)

gross The word is used to refer to total earnings, income, profit or revenue before taxes and other costs are taken away. The opposite is *net*. Be specific.

gross domestic product GDP. The total value of the goods and services produced *in* a country in a specified period.

gross national product GNP. The total value of all the goods and services produced *by* a country in a specified period, including those produced by its citizens and enterprises abroad.

grotto(es) A grotto is a small picturesque cave.

ground (basis) Often the plural form is used: *An Egyptian woman has filed for divorce from her husband on the grounds he has not showered since they married.*

groundbreaking

groundsman is British; *groundskeeper* is American.

groundswell (noun)

groundwork

ground zero Lowercase. But *Ground Zero* for the site in New York where the World Trade Center stood.

grovel British *grovelled*, *grovelling*; American *groveled*, *groveling*.

grow With a direct object, *grow* sounds natural only in references to living things: *grow flowers*; *grow wheat*; *grow a beard*. The use of *grow* to mean *expand* in expressions like *grow the business* and *grow revenue* is jargon. However, the use of *grow* as a verb with business or revenue as the subject is fine: *His business is growing*. | *The company's revenue grew by 80% last year*.

grown-up (noun and adjective)

gruelling is the British spelling; *grueling* is American.

G7, G8, G20 No hyphen.

G-string

Guantánamo A city in southeast Cuba. The US established a naval base on Guantánamo Bay in 1903, when the site was leased to it under a treaty. The treaty was renewed in 1934. Consent of both governments is needed to revoke it. Since 1960 the Cuban government has refused to accept the token annual rent of $5,000 from the US and pressed for the surrender of the base. The US also has a prison camp at Guantánamo for hundreds of people accused of having Taliban or al-Qaida links. The nickname *Gitmo*, derived from the postal abbreviation *GTMO*, is acceptable in headlines.

guarantee

gubernatorial A stilted word. Rather than *gubernatorial office* or *gubernatorial campaign*, write *governor's office* or *campaign for governor*.

Gudi Padwa Maharashtrian New Year's Day, celebrated on the first day of the Hindu month of Chaitra. It occurs sometime between March-end and early April. In Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka, the day is celebrated as Ugadi.

guerrilla Not *guerilla*.

guest Do not use as a verb.

guesthouse One word.

guide(-) guidebook, guideline, guidepost

guide dog

guinea pig

Guinness World Records Known until 2000 as "The Guinness Book of Records", and in previous US editions, "The Guinness Book of World Records".

Gulf Use for the Middle East Gulf. Do not use either *Arabian* or *Persian Gulf* in this sense.

Gulf Stream Two words in reference to the ocean current. But *Gulfstream aircraft*; the company that makes these aircraft is called Gulfstream Aerospace Corporation.

gun(-) gunbattle, gunboat, gunfight, gunfire, gunman, gunmetal, gunpoint, gunpowder, gunrunner, gunship, gunshot, gunsmith

gun dog, gun carriage, gun control, gun lobby

gun-shy, gun-toting

gung-ho

gurdwara Not *gurudwara*.

Gurkha, Gorkha SEE **GORKHA, GURKHA**.

gutka Not *gutkha*.

guttural Not *gutteral*.

Guyana (formerly *British Guiana*, now independent), **French Guiana** (still a French overseas territory), **Dutch Guiana** (now the independent republic of Suriname)

Guy Fawkes Night No apostrophe.

gypsy Not *gipsy*. Lowercase when using it generically to mean *one who is constantly on the move*. Cap in references to the nomadic people of Europe who are believed to be descendants of 14th-century immigrants from northern India. These people, also known as Roma, are now found all over the world.

***

I once used the word OBSOLETE in a headline, only to discover that 43% of housewives had no idea what it meant. In another headline, I used the word INEFFABLE, only to discover that I didn't know what it meant myself.
— **David Ogilvy**

H

Haaretz Israeli newspaper; old spelling *Ha'aretz*.

habeas corpus A writ to produce a prisoner before a court. It literally means *produce the body*. Note the spelling *habeas*; do not write *habeus*.

had better *You had better leave this place* or *You'd better leave this place*, not *You better leave this place*.

hades Lowercase.

haemorrhage is the British spelling; *hemorrhage* is American.

haggle You haggle with somebody *over* something. Do not write *He is haggling a car loan*. Make it *He is haggling over a car loan*.

Hague, The Even in the middle of a sentence write *The Hague*.

hail Keep this word for expressions like *hail a taxi*. Avoid its stilted use, as in *A man hailing from Dehradun was arrested in Delhi*. The sentence would be just fine without *hailing*: *A man from Dehradun was arrested in Delhi*. Instead of *He hails from Dehradun*, write *He comes from Dehradun*.

hair(-) hairball, hairbrush, haircut, hairdo, hairdresser, hairdressing, hairline, hairpiece, hairpin, hairsplitting, hairstyle

hair dryer, hair follicle

hair trigger (noun)

hair-raising, hair-trigger (adjectives)

(-)haired longhaired

black-haired, brown-haired, fair-haired (having blond hair; or favourite, as in *the fair-haired boy of the family*), red-haired

hair's breadth (noun), **hair's-breadth** (adjective)

haj, haji

haka Maori war dance.

half No hyphen when used adverbially: *You look half dead.* | *It was half wine, half water*. Hyphenated when used adjectively: *He got it half-price.* | *A half-eaten sandwich lay on the table.*

The preposition *of* can often be omitted after *half*: *Only half (of) the guests arrived.* | *Half (of) the time he was asleep.* | *Half (of) the fruit was bad.*

half past, half a dozen, half an hour, one and a half (no hyphen)

half(-) Most adjectives are hyphenated:

half-afraid, half-baked, half-cooked, half-done, half-full, half-hearted, half-hourly

halfway (adverb and adjective)

Nouns can be one word, hyphenated or two words:

halfback, halftime (sports), halftone, halftrack, halfwit

half-holiday, half-life (radioactivity), half-moon, half-truth

half dollar, half dozen (noun), half nelson, half note (music), half pay, half sole, half time (except in sports)

half-brother, half-sister Your half-brother or half-sister has either the same mother or the same father as you have.

SEE ALSO **STEPBROTHER, STEPSISTER**.

half-mast

hall(-) hallmark, hallway

hallelujah Exclamation of praise to God.

Halley's comet Named after the English astronomer Edmund Halley, who discovered that the comet appears every 75 years. It was last seen in 1986 and is to return in 2061.

Halloween

halo(es)

halve is a transitive verb, so it is wrong to write *The company's losses halved*. Make it *The company halved its losses* or *The company's losses fell by half*. Losses — or anything else — may, however, double, because *double* can be used both transitively and intransitively.

ham-fisted, ham-handed

hamster (rodent) The word does not have a *p*.

hand(-) handbag, handball, handbill, handbook, handcuff, handful(s), handgun, handheld, handmade, handout (noun), handrail, handshake, handspring, handstand, handwriting

hand-me-down, hand-picked

hand grenade, hand out (verb)

(-)hand beforehand, longhand, shorthand

left-hand (adjective), right-hand (adjective)

handgun Any firearm that can be held and fired with one hand — a revolver, a semi-automatic, a derringer or a single-shot pistol.

handicapped Do not use this word to refer to people with disabilities or learning difficulties. Use more specific terms when possible. SEE **DISABILITIES**.

SEE ALSO **CHALLENGED** | **CRIPPLE, CRIPPLED** | **DEFORMED** | **IMPAIRED** | **MENTAL HANDICAP, MENTALLY HANDICAPPED, MENTALLY ILL, MENTALLY RETARDED** | **VICTIM**.

hands-off, hands-on Hyphenated only as modifiers before nouns.

hand-to-hand, hand-to-mouth Hyphenated only as modifiers before nouns.

hangar (aircraft shed), **hanger** (hook from which clothes are hung)

hanged, hung If a person is executed or commits suicide by hanging, use *hanged*: *He was found guilty of murder and hanged.* | *He hanged himself from a ceiling.*

In other senses, use *hung*: *A heavy gold necklace hung around her neck.* | *She hung her head in shame.* | *His future hung in the balance.*

hangover

hanky-panky

Hans Raj College Not *Hansraj*. The college is in Delhi.

Hanukkah Jewish festival of lights. It usually occurs in December but sometimes in late November.

Hapsburg Not *Habsburg*.

hara-kiri Not *harakiri*.

harass, harassment Note single *r* and double *s*.

hard(-) hardball, hardcore (adjective), hardcover, hardwood

hard-bitten, hard-boiled, hard-earned, hard-hearted, hard-wired, hard-working

hard core (noun), hard landing, hard pressed, hard rock

hardline (adjective), **hardliner** (noun), **hard line** (noun, as in *take a hard line*)

hardscape Man-made features used in landscape architecture. For example, paths or walls, as contrasted with vegetation.

harebrained Not *hairbrained*.

harelip Considered offensive. Use *cleft lip*.

Harkat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami HuJI.

Harkatul Mujahideen

hark back means *return to an earlier point*.

Harper's Bazaar

hashtag Tagged keyword on social media using the # symbol.

hat-trick Note hyphen.

haves, have-nots

Hawaiian

Hawkeye US navy aircraft for airborne early warning and battle management.

Hawk-Eye A computer system used in cricket, tennis and other sports to track the path of the ball.

hawk-eyed Vigilant.

hay(-) hayfield, hayloft, haymaker, hayride, haystack, haywire

hay fever

head (noun) Try to be specific and use titles like president, chairman, director. Vagueness suggests superficial reporting.

head (verb) Do not write *head up*.

head(-) headache, headband, headboard, headboy, headdress, headfirst, headgear, headgirl, headhunt, headhunter, headlight, headlong, headmaster, headmistress, headphone, headrest, headroom, headset, headstone, headstrong, headteacher, headwater, headway, headwear, headwind

head collar, head count, head office, head start

head on (adverb), head-on (adjective)

head-butt

HEADLINES

In headlines of fresh-news stories, use the present tense. When recalling history or freshly reporting a past development, use the past tense. Never use the past perfect tense.

Use active verbs. Do not use long and uncommon words. Prefer conversational words to formal.

Do not rely solely on the intro for what you want to say in the headline; look for interesting points in the story. Ask yourself or your colleagues why a story is being carried and why it is being given a particular display. The answer could provide you a headline.

In reporting an accident, a crime or a disaster, with a range of estimates of dead and injured, use the conservative figure.

Round off figures in headlines. For example, *Sensex rises 550 points* rather than *Sensex rises 549.61 points*. In copy and charts too, round off figures to one decimal point unless accuracy demands otherwise. Beware, in certain contexts rounding off may be misleading. For example, there is a significant difference between *Inflation falls to 4.4%* and *Inflation falls to 4%*. For the same reason, never round off interest rates.

A shoulder headline (strapline) may begin with a verb, but only when the implied subject is identical with the actual one in the main headline.

Avoid clichés like *bash*, *flay*, *hike*, *rap* and *slam*. Be sparing in the use of verbs like *bid*, *boost*, *crisis*, *hit*, *fuel*, *row*, *set to*, *signal* and *target*.

Avoid ambiguity. We once had this headline: *Brown says takes seriously claim British captive dead*. Never write such convoluted headlines.

Avoid headlines that suggest the newspaper is taking sides. Always attribute statements, conclusions and, especially, allegations. Do not use a question mark to mean *maybe* or to suggest tentativeness. Avoid putting a headline in quotation marks unless the story is an interview.

Puns are welcome but avoid overused puns or smart phrases. Also, avoid puns or any wordplays that may not be clear to readers or may irritate them. When in doubt, test your wordplay on colleagues.

Do not use *the* unless a headline sounds grammatically wrong or confusing without it.

Avoid alphabet soup — vague abbreviations or acronyms that may baffle readers.

Just because a word does not fit, do not coin a vague abbreviation like *bldg* for building, *devpt* for development, *hsg* for housing or *indl* for industrial.

If words like *is*, *are*, *was*, *a* and *the* are to be dropped to make a headline fit, drop the leftmost ones in the headline first. Retaining them in the beginning of a headline and dropping them later can cause confusion.

Headlines should be written for readers rather than sources. For example, the headline of a story on interest rate cuts should focus on what the reader gains from the rate cut, not on what impact the cut may have on the bank. The headline of a story on the health ministry approving a costly machine for AIIMS should normally be on what patients gain from the machine.

Avoid label headlines like *CII holds conference on banking*. Say what happened at the conference.

Do not break names or sums of money in two lines. For example, do not put *L N* in one line and *Mittal* in the next, or *Rs 500* in one line and *crore* in the next. The same goes for a term standing for a name; for example, *home ministry*.

Look at the page in totality. In different headlines on the same page, do not repeat principal words. In the same headline, do not repeat principal words and avoid repetition of even "little" words. (In the headline "Govt won't be cowed down by separatists: PM", *be*, *down* and *by* are "little" words; the rest are principal words.)

Do not italicize names of films and books in headlines; put them in single quotation marks.

Avoid the use of a comma or an ampersand to mean *and*. Be careful about the distinction between the hyphen and the comma. The hyphen is used in a headline as a substitute for *between ... and*, whereas the comma can substitute for *and*. Hence, *UPA-Left talks fail*; not *UPA, Left talks fail*. *Congress, BJP against elections*; not *Congress-BJP against elections* unless the Congress and the BJP have decided to work as a combine.

In headlines, cap the word after a colon. Use a semicolon to separate two parts of a headline if a comma has been used in either part.

In first-letters-capped headlines, cap both parts of a hyphenated compound. But when a hyphen is used merely to separate doubled vowels or to clarify pronunciation, lowercase the part after the hyphen: C*o-op, Pre-empt.*

Avoid dashes in headlines. They take too much space and look ungainly. Usually, the meaning can be conveyed with a colon.

Do not use hyphens in sums of money. Write *$20 billion deal, $20bn deal, Rs 15 crore contract, Rs 15cr contract*; but hyphenate when the currency's name is spelled out: 20-*billion-dollar deal, 15-crore-rupee contract.*

Do not use the question mark in a headline where, if it is accidentally dropped, the meaning can change from a possibility to a fact. Avoid the question mark as a headline shorthand for speculation. Readers want information, not questions. However, a question mark can be used effectively in the headline of a story raising an issue of grave public concern: *Who will pay for these deaths?*

In headlines, use single, not double, quotation marks.

headquarters Never *headquarter*. *Headquarters* can be singular or plural, depending on the context: *Coca-Cola's headquarters are in Atlanta* but *Headquarters has approved a new marketing strategy*.

The abbreviation is *HQ,* not *HQs* or *Hqs*.

Do not use *headquarter* as a verb. For example, *Microsoft has its headquarters in Redmond*, not *Microsoft is headquartered in Redmond.*

healthcare One word.

hearsay (rumour, gossip), **heresy** (a belief that disagrees with the official principles of a particular religion)

heart(-) heartache, heartbreak, heartbroken, heartburn, heartfelt, heartland, heartstrings, heartwarming

heart-rending, heart-searching, heart-stopping, heart-to-heart, heart-throb

heart attack, heart beat, heart failure, heart massage, heart rate

(-)hearted half-hearted, hard-hearted, lion-hearted, soft-hearted

downhearted, wholehearted

heart condition A vague term. Everybody has a heart condition. Use *heart ailment*, *heart disease*.

heat(-) heatproof, heatstroke, heatwave

heat death, heat exhaustion, heat lightning, heat pipe, heat rash, heat shield

heat-resistant, heat-seeking, heat-treat

Heathrow airport In London. It is one of the world's busiest airports.

heaven Generally, lowercase. Cap when it means *God*: *I can only say, Heaven help you*.

heavyweight

hectare An area equal to 100 ares, 10,000 square metres, or 2.47 acres.

heinous Note *ei*.

heir apparent (an heir whose claim cannot be set aside by the birth of another), **heir presumptive** (an heir whose claim may be set aside by the birth of another)

heliport

hell Lowercase.

hello Not *hallo* or *hullo*. Use a comma after *hello* and other forms of address, greeting or salutation: *Hello, friends*; not *Hello friends*.

helmeted Avoid expressions like *helmeted troops*, *helmeted police*. Write *soldiers in helmets* or *policemen in helmets*.

help (noun) When the word means *servant* or *employee*, as in *domestic help* or *farm help*, do not form a plural by adding an *s*. For example, *five domestic helps* is wrong. But *help* can be used as a plural collective noun, as in *Her domestic help were juggling more than they could handle*.

help wondering *I cannot help wondering*, not *I cannot help but wonder*.

helter-skelter

hemisphere Lowercase: *northern hemisphere*, *southern hemisphere*.

henpecked

he or she, his or her, him or her Use these terms as a last resort to avoid an unintended assumption of maleness or femaleness. The preferred solution is the use of the plural: *Government officials must be aware of their duties* rather than *A government official must be aware of his or her duties*. If this does not work, rephrase the sentence.

Never use *s/he*.

her Do not use for ships and nations, except in quotes. Use *it* or *its* instead.

herculean Lowercase.

here Guard against its use in a story with no dateline or a multiple dateline.

here(-) hereabouts, hereafter, hereby

Do not use pompous words like *herein*, *hereinafter*, *hereto*, *heretofore*, *hereunder* and *herewith*.

heroin (the drug), **heroine** (female hero)

(a) hero's welcome Not *heroes' welcome*.

heyday Never *heydays*.

Hezbollah (not *Hizbullah*) The name means *party of God*.

hiccup Not *hiccough*.

hide(-) hideaway, hidebound, hideout (noun)

hide-and-seek, hide-hole

hide out (verb)

hierarchy Note the sequence *ie*.

hi-fi

high(-) highlight, hightop (shoe), highrise, highway

high beam, high chair, high blood pressure, high fidelity (noun), high frequency (noun), high jump, high profile (noun)

high-fidelity (adjective, often shortened to *hi-fi*), high-five (noun), high-flyer, high-frequency (adjective), high-handed, high-profile (adjective), high-tech (in headlines, *hi-tech* is fine)

highbrow It can be disparaging. Use with care.

high command Avoid its clichéd use. Prefer *Congress leadership* to *Congress high command*.

high commission An embassy of one Commonwealth country in another. For example, *the Canadian high commission in New Delhi*, *the Indian high commission in Canberra*. Lowercase.

high commissioner The ambassador of one Commonwealth country to another. Lowercase.

HIGH COURTS

There are 21 high courts in India. Some are named after states, some after cities. Not all high courts are located in state capitals. In some cases, names of cities or states have changed but the high courts retain their old names. Give the correct

names of high courts in stories. When in doubt, refer to the following table:

Name	Seat	Bench/benches
Allahabad	Allahabad	Lucknow
Andhra Pradesh	Hyderabad	
Bombay	Mumbai	Aurangabad, Nagpur and Panaji
Calcutta	Kolkata	Port Blair circuit bench
Chhattisgarh	Bilaspur	
Delhi	New Delhi	
Gauhati	Guwahati	Kohima, Aizawl and Imphal; circuit benches at Agartala and Shillong
Gujarat	Ahmedabad	
Himachal Pradesh	Shimla	
Jammu & Kashmir (note the ampersand)	Summer HQ Srinagar; winter HQ Jammu	Both Srinagar and Jammu benches function throughout the year
Jharkhand	Ranchi	
Karnataka	Bangalore	
Kerala	Kochi	
Madhya Pradesh	Jabalpur	Gwalior and Indore
Madras	Chennai	Madurai
Orissa*	Cuttack	
Patna	Patna	
Punjab and Haryana	Chandigarh	
Rajasthan	Jodhpur	Jaipur
Sikkim	Gangtok	
Uttaranchal*	Nainital	

*The spelling of Orissa has changed to Odisha, but the high court is still Orissa high court. Uttaranchal has been renamed Uttarakhand, but the high court is still called Uttaranchal high court.

higher-up(s)

highfalutin means *pompous*. Sometimes, *lowfalutin* is jocularly used as the opposite of *highfalutin*.

high jinks Not *hijinks*.

high street Lowercase and without hyphen, as in *high street prices*. Cap in proper names, as in *Kensington High Street*.

high tea means *substantial early evening meal including tea*; it does not mean *classy tea*.

hijack Use it only as a verb. Use *hijacking* for the noun and the modifier, even in headlines.

hike A hike is a walk. Do not use it as a noun or verb meaning *increase*. Let people take hikes through the countryside or woods.

Hill Do not write *the Hill* for *Capitol Hill*. It is Washington jargon.

hindrance Not *hinderance*.

Hinduism, Hindutva *Hinduism* means *the Hindu religion and its practices*. *Hindutva* is the political ideology of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and allied organizations. Do not use the two words interchangeably.

hip-hop

hippie A rebel against middle-class values; *hippy* means *a person with large hips*.

hippo(s)

hippopotamus(es)

Hispanic Descended from a Spanish-speaking land or culture. *Hispanic* does not denote a race; neither does *Latino*. *Hispanic* may apply to Puerto Ricans, Texans of Mexican origin, or immigrants from Spain or Latin America. *Latino* (feminine *Latina*) is acceptable for Hispanics who prefer that term. When possible, be specific: write *Cuban*, *Brazilian* or *Puerto Rican* rather than *Hispanic*.

historic (important in history), **historical** (connected with the past) When applied to current events, the word *historic* often suggests hyperbole. Use it with caution.

history Do not use the redundant *past history*.

history-sheeter

hit The terms *hit or miss* and *hit and run* are not hyphenated when used as nouns. But as modifiers before nouns: *hit-or-miss*, *hit-and-run*. If *hit and run* or *hit-and-run* does not fit in a headline, *hit-run* can be used.

hitchhike, hitchhiker

hi-tech Acceptable in headlines. In stories, prefer *high-tech*.

hitherto Do not use this pompous word.

hit list Two words.

hitman One word.

HIV positive No hyphen. Do not write *HIV virus*; *HIV* stands for *human immunodeficiency virus*.

SEE ALSO **AIDS**.

Hizbul Mujahideen *Hizb*, for short.

hoard (something hidden away, to hide away), **horde** (a throng or group)

Hobson's choice Take it or leave it, no choice at all.

hocus-pocus Meaningless talk intended to hide the truth.

Hodgkin's disease Named after Thomas Hodgkin, the English physician who first described the disease of the lymph nodes.

ho-hum (boring)

hoi polloi means *common people*, *the masses*. Use with care; it can be derogatory. *The hoi polloi* is quite common but technically redundant, because *hoi* means *the* in Greek. *Hoi polloi* literally means *the many*.

(-)holder householder, jobholder, leaseholder, officeholder, policyholder, shareholder, stockholder

But: preferred-stock holder.

hold-up (noun and adjective), **hold up** (verb)

hole-in-one (golf)

holidaymaker

HOLIDAY REFERENCES

Do not attach a holiday tag to an event unless the tag is relevant. *Diwali-eve blasts in Delhi in 2005* is fine because the occasion was chosen by terrorists to create panic, but *Boxing Day tsunami in 2004* is not.

Holland Do not use as a synonym of *the Netherlands*. The people of the Netherlands are *Dutch*. Use *Holland* only in references to North Holland and South Holland provinces of the Netherlands or in historical references to the western region of the Netherlands. In football and hockey stories, *Holland* for the Dutch team is fine.

Holy Communion

Holy Father The pope. Use only in quotes or for special effect.

holy grail Also *grail*. Lowercase in general references to an object of prolonged endeavour. Cap in reference to the cup or plate that, according to

medieval legend, was used by Jesus at the Last Supper, was later lost and became the object of many a chivalrous quest.

Holy See means *holy seat*. The term refers to the pope and the central government of the Roman Catholic church.

home(-) homebound, homebuyer, homecoming, homeland, homemade, homeowner, homesick, homespun, homestretch, hometown, homework

home guard, home loan, home rule, home run, home schooling, home truth, home video

home-schooled, home-schooler

home in Not *hone in*.

homely In British English and Indian English, *homely* means *having the warm and familiar qualities associated with a home*. In American English, it means *unattractive*. Choose another word if you do not want to be misunderstood.

homemaker The word is preferred because it does not define marital status and can be used for both men and women. But it is unfortunately becoming a synonym of *housewife*. Do not use it unless a person's status as homemaker is relevant to the story.

homeopathy Not *homoeopathy*.

homepage The opening page of a website.

homogeneous (uniform, of the same kind), **homogenous** (a biology term meaning *having a common descent*) The first is often misspelled as *homogenous*.

Homo sapiens SEE **GENUS, SPECIES**.

homosexual The word applies to both men and women. Therefore, do not write *homosexuals and lesbians*, although you can refer to homosexual men and women.

SEE ALSO **GAY**.

honcho (noun) means *the one in charge*. The terms *head honcho* and *top honcho*, though redundant, are also used; *head honcho* is far more frequent than *top honcho*. As a verb meaning *follow through* (as in *Honcho this and don't let it get lost in the bureaucracy*), *honcho* is considered non-standard.

H-1B (not *H1B* or *H1-B*) Non-immigrant visa for employment in a speciality occupation in the US.

honey(-) honeybee, honeybunch, honeycomb, honeydew, honeymoon, honeysuckle, honeytrap

honey pot

honorarium(s)

honour, honourable are the British spellings; *honor*, *honorable* are American.

hooch Strong alcohol that has been made illegally.

hoof-and-mouth disease Use *foot-and-mouth disease*.

hooky Not *hookey*.

hoopla Great excitement, bustle, showy publicity, ballyhoo. William Safire calls it *devices and techniques to stimulate enthusiasm*. His description: "In politics, hoopla is a necessary ingredient to campaigns to give them bounce, youthfulness, and a sense of fun."

hopefully Some sticklers frown upon the use of *hopefully* in the sense of *it is hoped*, as in *Hopefully, we will win*. They insist that the word can be used only to mean *in a hopeful manner*, as in *"Are you free tonight?" she asked hopefully*. However, most experts accept the use of *hopefully* in the former sense as well. They argue that *hopefully* is a sentence adverb like *frankly*, *happily*, *honestly* and *sadly*. If *Sadly, we lost is right* then there is nothing wrong with *Hopefully, we will win*. The logic is sound, but *hopefully* should have no place in news stories except in direct quotes. After all, it is not a reporter's job to hope that something happens.

horde (a throng or group), **hoard** (something hidden away, to hide away)

(stir up a) hornet's nest

horror-struck

hors de combat Out of action due to injury or damage.

hors d'oeuvre(s) A small amount of food, usually cold, served before the main part of a meal.

horse(-) horseback, horsecar, horsedrawn, horseflesh, horsefly, horsehair, horsehide, horselaugh, horseman, horseplay, horseradish, horseshoe, horsewhip, horsewoman

horse opera, horse race, horse racing, horse riding (noun), horse sense, horse trade (noun), horse trader, horse trading

horse-riding (adjective), horse-trade (verb)

horsepower Singular and plural.

horsy Not *horsey*. Comparative forms *horsier*, *horsiest*.

hospitalized Avoid. Use *taken to hospital*, but not *rushed to hospital*.

host Avoid using it as a verb except in direct quotations. Use alternatives: *give a party*, *play host to 100 delegates*.

As a noun, prefer *host* to *hostess* for a woman host.

hot(-) hotbed, hothead, hotheaded, hothouse (greenhouse), hotplate, hotpot, hotshot, hotspot (an area where computers can connect to the internet wirelessly, a trouble spot, or an area of intense heat)

hot air (noun), hot button (noun), hot cross bun, hot dog, hot key, hot pants, hot pepper, hot pool, hot potato, hot seat, hot spring, hot stuff

hot-air balloon, hot-and-sour soup, hot-blooded, hot-tempered, hot-water bottle

hot-button issue An issue that ignites anger, fear, enthusiasm or other passionate response.

hotchpotch is the British spelling; *hodgepodge* is American.

hotdog

hotel Do not use as a synonym of *restaurant*.

hotline is one word as is *helpline*. A hotline is a direct telephone line for use in an emergency, especially between heads of government.

hourglass

hour hand

hourlong One word.

house Lowercase in the general sense of a chamber of parliament, but cap in *Upper House* or *Lower House* of India's Parliament. A Lok Sabha committee or a Rajya Sabha committee can be called a house committee, but a parliamentary committee is not a house committee.

house(-) houseboat, housebound, housebroken, housebuilder, housebuilding, housecoat, housedress, housefly, household, househusband, housekeeper, housemaid, houseman, housemate, housemother, houseplant, housetop, housewares, housewarming, housework

house arrest, house organ, house party

house full Also *full house*. An occasion in a theatre when there are no empty seats. Do not use *houseful*, which is a noun referring not to the house but to the people who make the house full: *There were a houseful of guests at the party*.

SEE ALSO **SPOONFUL**.

House of Commons In subsequent references, *the Commons*, which takes a singular verb.

House of Lords In subsequent references, *the Lords,* which takes a singular verb.

House of Representatives In subsequent references, *the House*.

housewife Use *homemaker*. SEE ALSO **HOMEMAKER**.

hovercraft

however When used in the sense of *nevertheless*, *however* always needs a comma after it, and before, when in the middle of a sentence: *Their joy, however, was short-lived*.

howitzer

how to *I know how to drive* is the correct form. *I know driving* is wrong.

howzat For special effect, *howzzat* is fine. Do not write *howzaat*.

HQ Not *HQs* or *Hqs*. SEE ALSO **HEADQUARTERS**.

HRD Human resource development, as in *HRD minister* or *HRD ministry*.

HTML Hypertext markup language, the format used for creating documents on the world wide web. Lowercase in web addresses.

HTTP Hypertext transfer protocol. Lowercase in web addresses.

HuJI Harkat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami.

human, human being Either is fine, but *human* is preferred.

Human Genome Project

humankind Rather than *mankind*.

humble pie The phrase is *eat humble pie*, not *eat a humble pie*.

humerus The bone between the elbow and the shoulder. Do not confuse it with *humorous*.

humour, humorist, humorous

Humvee Modern military vehicle that succeeded the jeep. The word is derived from HMMWV, or high-mobility multipurpose wheeled vehicle. Hummer is the civilian version.

hundred Never write *a 100*; *100* is already *a hundred* or *one hundred*. Similarly, *a 1,000* is wrong; write *1,000*, *a thousand* or *one thousand*.

hunger strike, hunger striker

hunky dory (satisfactory, fine, OK) Two words, no hyphen.

hurly-burly

hurricane According to the US National Weather Service, a storm becomes a hurricane if winds near its centre reach or exceed 74 miles an hour.

SEE ALSO **GALE**.

hush-hush

hustings (singular and plural) means *an election campaign*, not *an election*.

hybrid working: Mix of remote and in-office work.

hydro(-) hydrocarbon, hydrodynamic, hydroelectric, hydroelectricity, hydrophobia, hydropower, hydrostatics, hydrotherapy

hygiene, hygienic

hyper(-) hyperactive, hypercritical, hyperinflation, hyperlink, hypermarket, hypersexual, hypertension

HYPHEN

Use the hyphen to form a compound adjective: *two-tonne vessel*, *three-year deal*, *19th-century artist*, *30-kilometre stretch*, *25-year tax holiday*.

To avoid confusion, use the hyphen in words like *re-form* (form again) and *re-sign* (sign again) when the intended meaning is different from the usual meaning.

Verb-preposition combinations like *break up*, *let down* and *sell off* are written as separate words when used as verbs but are hyphenated or written as one word when used as nouns or adjectives. To test whether a combination is being used as a verb, convert the verb in the combination to past tense. If it makes sense in the past tense as well, the combination is a verb. For example, the headline *Government to sell off stake in MTNL* can be converted to *Government sold off stake in MTNL* and it would still make sense. Hence, *sell off* is a verb and should not be hyphenated. Consider another sentence: *Left opposes PSU selloff*. Conversion of *sell* to past tense yields *Left opposes PSU sold off*, which makes no sense. S*elloff* is a noun here and needs to be hyphenated or written as one word, depending on the house style. We write it as one word.

Do not use a hyphen after an adverb ending in *-ly*. For example, *politically naive, wholly owned, genetically modified.* The same goes for compound adjectives formed with *once*: *once famous dancer, once celebrated musician*.

A hyphen is needed with short and common adverbs: *ill-prepared report, much-needed lesson, well-established.* But drop the hyphen when the words follow the nouns they modify: *The practice is well established* (not *well-established*).

Do not use the hyphen in a compound modifier when the meaning is clear: *sales tax revenue, foreign aid plan*, but *tax-cut plan*, *low-tax regime*.

Some compounds, typically those beginning with nouns, keep their hyphens regardless of their position in a sentence: *The movie was tax-free.* | *He is health-conscious*.

If the first word relates as much to the third as to the second, the hyphen can be misleading. Terms like *traffic police plans*, *fast breeder reactor* and *airport departure lounge* are best left without hyphens. Also, do not use the hyphen in these forms: *navy blue shirt*, *dark green paint*.

In some compounds, the hyphen is needed to avoid ambiguity, as in *unfair-practices charge*. Similarly, *Embraer is a small-plane manufacturer*. Sometimes, a solid word may have to be broken to avoid ambiguity: *small-business man*, not *small businessman*.

When a modifier consisting of two or more words is joined together by quotation marks, the hyphen is redundant. Thus, both *look-east policy* and *"look east" policy* are correct, but *"look-east" policy* is not. A long phrase serving as a modifier should be set off by quotation marks rather than hyphenated: *the Left's "blow hot, blow cold" approach*.

Use the suspensive hyphen in situations like this:
The contest is for five-, seven- and nine-year-old children.

Hyphenate two-word numbers from *twenty-one to ninety-nine*.

Use a hyphen in a compound denoting national origin: *Indian-American*, *Chinese-American*. But *Jewish American* and *French Canadian*, because both words denote current group membership rather than origin.

Do not use a hyphen in a title consisting of a principal noun with modifiers: *commander in chief, lieutenant general*, *attorney general*, *solicitor general*, *director general*, *secretary general*.

Do not use a hyphen in place of *to* except with figures: *This ballpoint pen should cost five to six rupees*. *The book will cost you 200-250 rupees* is fine because figures have been used for numbers.

hypocrisy Not *hypocracy*. It is not a form of government.

***

The internet feeds off the main press, and the main press feeds off the internet. They're working in tandem.
— **Matt Drudge**

I

i, not *I*, on the editorial page of The Times of India and on the comments page of Sunday Times of India.

I, me *It's me* or *It's I*? The first has the force of idiom behind it; the second is grammatically sound but stilted. Use the first.

If the sentence is long, recast it. Instead of *It was I who won the lottery*, write *I was the one who won the lottery* or simply, *I won the lottery.*

In a title containing no verb, either *I* or *me* can be used, *me* being informal. The Richard Rodgers and Oscar Hammerstein musical is "The King and I", whereas the Michael Moore film is "Roger and Me".

ICBM(s) Intercontinental ballistic missile(s). *ICBM* is fine in first reference but the term should be explained somewhere in the story.

ice(-) iceberg, iceboat, icebound, icebreaker, icecap, iceman

ice-cold, ice-skate (verb)

ice bag, ice cream, ice field, ice milk, ice pack, ice pick, ice skate (noun), ice storm, ice water

ice age Lowercase.

iced tea Not *ice tea*.

ID Abbreviation of *identity* or *identification*: *Police officers checked IDs at the gate.* | *Are you carrying your ID card?*

Do not use *ID* as a verb.

ID card No hyphen, not *I-card*.

identical with is the preferred form, but *identical to* is acceptable.

idiosyncrasy Not *-cracy*; it is not a form of government.

IDSA Institute of Defence Studies and Analyses (not *Analysis*).

Id-ul-Fitr, Id-ul-Zuha Use *Eid-ul-Fitr*, *Eid-ul-Zuha*.

ie Abbreviation of the Latin *id est*, which means *that is*. No full stops. Keep it for charts and tables; put commas before and after *ie*. In copy, use *that is*.

IED Improvised explosive device.

if, whether In an indirect question that expects a *yes* or *no* answer, either can be used: *She asked me if* (or *whether*) *I needed any help*. *If* is more conversational; *whether* is rather formal. With verbs like *consider*, *discuss* and *decide*, *whether* sounds more natural.

Also, the two words are interchangeable when there is a choice: *I didn't know whether* (or *if*) *I should take up journalism*. But *whether* is preferred with an *or* construction: *I didn't know whether I should become a copyeditor or a reporter.*

Sometimes, *if* can be ambiguous: *Would you let me know if you are coming to the party?* The sentence can mean *let me know whether you are coming to the party*. It can also mean *let me know if and only if you are coming to the party*. If you really expect a response, say *Would you let me know whether you are coming to the party?*

if ... was/were When an *if* clause introduces something hypothetical or unreal, *were* is often used instead of *was*. The grammatical name for this use of *were* is *subjunctive*.

If I were finance minister, I'd do things differently.
If I were rich, I would buy all the diamonds in this shop.
If Manoj were here, he would know what to do.

These sentences would be correct with *was*, but *were* is preferred in formal writing (Practical English Usage by Michael Swan, Oxford University Press; Cambridge Guide to English Usage by Pam Peters, Cambridge University Press).

SEE ALSO **SUBJUNCTIVE**.

if and when Write either *if* or *when*.

ifs and buts

iftar Not *iftaar*.

IIMs Indian Institutes of Management. Till 2007, there were six of them: Ahmedabad, Bangalore, Calcutta, Indore, Kozhikode and Lucknow. From the 2008-09 academic session, Shillong got an IIM — Rajiv Gandhi Indian Institute of Management.

In 2009, the Union government decided to set up six new IIMs. Four of these were to start functioning from 2010-11 at Tiruchirappalli, Ranchi, Raipur and Rohtak. The remaining two — likely to be set up at Kashipur in Uttarakhand and Udaipur in Rajasthan — were to start functioning from 2011-12.

Write *IIM, Ahmedabad,* or *IIM-Ahmedabad*, not *IIM/Ahmedabad*.

IITs Indian Institutes of Technology. There are 16 IITs. Till 2007, there were seven of them: Bombay, Delhi, Guwahati, Kanpur, Kharagpur, Madras and Roorkee. From the 2008-09 academic session, six more IITs came into being: Bhubaneswar, Gandhinagar, Hyderabad, Patna, Punjab (campus being built at Roopnagar) and Rajasthan (campus likely to be built at Jodhpur).

From the 2009-10 academic session, IT (BHU, Varanasi) became an IIT and two more IITs came into being: Indore and Mandi (Himachal Pradesh).

Write *IIT, Kanpur,* or *IIT-Kanpur*, not *IIT/Kanpur*.

ill(-) Compounds formed with *ill* are hyphenated only when they are used as modifiers before nouns:

ill-advised, ill-bred, ill-conceived, ill-considered, ill-defined, ill-equipped, ill-fated, ill-gotten, ill-humoured, ill-looking, ill-mannered, ill-natured, ill-prepared, ill-spent, ill-starred, ill-suited, ill-tempered, ill-timed, ill-treated, ill-used

No hyphen if the words follow the nouns they modify: *He is ill tempered*.

ill, sick See **sick, ill**.

illegal (forbidden by law, as in *illegal mining*), **illicit** (forbidden by law or custom, as in *illicit liquor*, *illicit affair*)

illegal immigrant Do not use the shortened form *illegal*.

illegible refers to bad handwriting or defaced printing that is not clear enough to read; **unreadable** means *too dull or difficult to read*.

illegitimate Do not call a child of unmarried parents *illegitimate*. Also, avoid *born out of wedlock*. If the parents' marital status is relevant, simply

say that the parents are not married or that the child is the son or daughter of a single mother or father.

illusion, delusion SEE **ALLUSION, DELUSION, ILLUSION**.

illusive, elusive SEE **ELUSIVE, ILLUSIVE**.

iMac, iPad, iPhone, iPod, iTunes If any of these words occurs at the beginning of a sentence, cap *i*: *IMac, IPad, IPhone, IPod*, *ITunes*. Cap *i* in all-caps or first-letters-capped headlines.

imaginable

imaginary Not *imaginery*.

imam

Imax (short for *Image maximum*) is a film format created by Canada's Imax Corporation. Imax has the capacity to display images of far greater size and resolution than conventional film-display systems.

IMD India (not *Indian*) Meteorological Department. In subsequent references *IMD*, *Met office* or *weather office*.

immigrate, emigrate *Immigrate* means *to come and live in a country after leaving your own*. *Emigrate* means *to leave your own country to go and live in another*. The action is the same, the reference point different. From a US perspective, you say *He immigrated to the US from India in 1990*. From an Indian perspective, you say *He emigrated from India to the US in 1990*.

imminent (about to happen), **eminent** (distinguished)

immolate means to *sacrifice, especially by burning*. It does not mean *to burn*.

immoral (evil, wicked), **amoral** (not concerned with morality)

immune to Not *immune from*.

impact As a verb, it means *strike with force*. Do not use it to mean *affect*; in that sense it is technical jargon.

impaired In references to people with difficulties, it usually means *a correctible or less than total loss of a function or ability*. Someone with less than total hearing may be called *hearing-impaired*.

SEE ALSO **BLIND** | **CHALLENGED** | **DEAF** | **DISABILITIES** | **HANDICAPPED**.

impala (singular and plural) A large African antelope. Cap when *Impala* refers to the car.

impanel, empanel Use *empanel*. SEE ALSO **EMPANEL, IMPANEL**.

impassable (impossible to cross, as in *the mountains are impassable*), **impassible** (not susceptible to pain or injury), **impassive** (not showing emotion, as in *his impassive face showed no reaction at all*)

impeachment is the constitutional process accusing a president or judge of a crime in an attempt to remove him. To say that a president was impeached does not necessarily mean he was removed. The attempt may have failed, as in Bill Clinton's case after the Monica Lewinsky scandal.

implausible

implement A pompously bureaucratic verb. Use simpler terms like *carry out*, *put in effect*, *fulfil*, *accomplish* or *do*.

imply, infer A speaker or writer implies something by insinuating or suggesting indirectly. A listener or reader infers something by drawing a conclusion from what is said.

importantly, more importantly Some purists object to the use of *importantly* or *more importantly* as a sentence modifier at the beginning of a sentence. But Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary and Merriam-Webster's Dictionary of English Usage accept it.

Both *more important* and *more importantly* are fine at the beginning of a sentence, but use *more important* if you want to avoid nitpicking.

impostor Not *imposter*.

impresario Not *impressario*.

impromptu Done or said without preparation or advance thought.

SEE ALSO **EXTEMPORE, IMPROMPTU**.

improvise (never *improvize*) It does not mean *improve*. It means *make something from whatever is available* or *give a performance without preparation*.

in When *in* precedes a noun and means *fashionable* or *faddish*, it should be put in quotation marks: *It's the "in" thing; it makes us girls feel good.* But: *Short skirts are in again*.

in, at With anything smaller than city — town, locality in city, or village — use *at*; with city or anything bigger, use *in*: *The match was played in Melbourne.* | *The accident occurred at Rajouri Garden, a colony in west Delhi*.

in, into, in to If movement is implied, use *into*: *He fell into the river*, not *He fell in the river*. When *in* is part of a verb phrase preceding *to*, *in* and *to* must be written as two words: *He dropped in to see me.* | *She tuned in to a different station.*

SEE ALSO **ON TO, ONTO**.

in, on *In the team* is British; *on the team* is American. Similarly, *in the street* is British; *on the street* is American. In both forms of English, the correct expression is *on the outskirts*, not *in the outskirts*.

in(-) inboard, inbound, incoming, indoor, infield, infighting, inpatient

in-flight (adjective), in-group (noun), in-house (adjective and adverb), in-law, daughter-in-law, father-in-law

Latin terms with *in* are two words, without hyphens: in absentia, in camera, in extremis, in loco parentis, in toto, in utero, in vitro. Whenever possible, use English equivalents of these terms.

(-)in break-in, cave-in, sit-in (nouns)

in addition to Use *as well as* or *besides* instead.

inadmissible

in a shocking incident Do not begin a story with this cliché. Better still, never use it.

inasmuch as

inbox

incel A member of an online community of young men who consider themselves unable to attract women sexually. Typically associated with views that are hostile towards women and men who are sexually active.

in charge (in command, having supervisory power) Do not use the semi-literate, hyphenated form *in-charge*.

incident A minor happening or disturbance. When used for accidents or events that have serious consequences the word seems to trivialize them.

include, including Use only when listing some components of a whole: *The European Union includes Belgium, the Netherlands and Luxembourg*. If all the components are being listed, use *comprise*: *Benelux comprises Belgium, the Netherlands and Luxembourg*.

If the expression preceding *including* is negative, use *not even*: *No political party, not even the CPM, was ready for elections*. Use *not even* if the emphasis is on smallness of numbers: *Few style guides, not even this one, can claim to be exhaustive* or *Few style guides, this one included, can claim to be exhaustive*.

income tax Do not hyphenate even as a modifier. However, hyphenate I-T (income tax) to avoid confusion with IT (information technology)

incommunicado

incredible (unbelievable), **incredulous** (unbelieving)

Independence Cap in references to India's freedom from British rule.

Independence Day can be shortened to *I-Day*, but not *I-D*, in headlines.

SEE ALSO **ANNIVERSARY**.

independent Lowercase even when it refers to a legislator who is not a member of any political party.

in-depth Avoid as a modifier preceding a noun, as in *in-depth study*. If you must use the phrase, make it *a study in depth* (without a hyphen).

indestructible

index Plural *indexes*, except for scientific and economic *indices*.

India-born, Indian-born *India-born* means *born in India of Indian or foreign parents*. *Indian-born* means *born of Indian parents in India or abroad*.

Indian Diamond Institute In Surat, Gujarat.

indicated Best avoided because it implies subjective interpretation by the reporter.

Indira Gandhi International Airport *IGI airport* is acceptable even in first reference when the context is clear. *IGI* is acceptable in headlines.

indiscrete (not divided into parts), **indiscreet** (not careful about what one says or does, especially when this embarrasses or offends somebody)

indispensable Not *indispensible*.

individual Try not to use it as a substitute for *man*, *woman* or *person*. Keep it for contexts in which a person is being distinguished from a group: *Companies pay more taxes than individuals.* | *This is a heavy burden for small-business men who pay taxes as individuals*.

Indochina No longer hyphenated. Indochina is the territory comprising Cambodia, Laos and Vietnam. When referring to talks, relations or agreements between India and China, use *India-China* or *China-India,* not *Indo-Chinese* or the old-fashioned *Sino-Indian*.

indoor (adjective), **indoors** (adverb)

industrial action Avoid this euphemism. If you mean a strike, say so. If you do not mean a strike, be specific.

inequity (unfairness), **iniquity** (wickedness)

in excess of Do not use this pretentious phrase. Write *more than $4 million*, not *in excess of $4 million*.

in fact It can often be omitted. If you must use it, write it as two words.

infarction (as in myocardial infarction, or heart attack; *infarction* means *the death of a localized area of tissue as a result of the blocking of its blood supply, usually by a blood clot, air bubble or fragment of tissue*), **infraction** (violation, breaking of a rule or law)

infectious, contagious SEE **CONTAGIOUS, INFECTIOUS**.

infer, imply SEE **IMPLY, INFER**.

infiltrator Use sparingly. Do not use as a substitute for *immigrants* — legal or illegal. Reserve *infiltrators* for those coming into the country covertly to carry out violent activities. For example, terrorists crossing the LoC in Kashmir.

SEE ALSO **TERRORIST**.

inflammable means the same as *flammable*. Use *flammable*, which is unambiguous. The negative is *non-flammable*.

inflammatory means *intentionally arousing angry or violent feelings*.

inform Transitive verb; must always be followed by a direct object. *The spokesman informed* is wrong; *The spokesman informed reporters* is right.

infrared Not *infra-red*.

ingénue An innocent, inexperienced, unworldly young woman, especially in a movie role.

initiate Try to use *begin*, *start* or *open*.

injuries, wounds Wounds are sustained in combat; injuries are caused by accident or criminal attack. Be as specific as possible: *His right leg was broken*, not *His leg was broken*. Avoid hospital usage. Rather than *He sustained an arm fracture*, write *His left arm was broken*.

Prefer *He suffered injuries* or *He was injured* to *He sustained injuries* or *He received injuries*.

Note that *injury* implies something more serious than *hurt*.

innings Not *inning*, which should be used only in references to baseball.

innocent, not guilty Report a plea or a verdict as it was made in court. If it was *not guilty*, do not report it as *innocent*. Do not write *He pleaded innocent*. A defendant is presumed innocent and therefore never needs to prove innocence; it is guilt that must be proved. Hence a plea or verdict is *not guilty*, rather than *innocent*.

innocuous Note double *n*.

innuendo(es)

inoculate Note single *n*.

in order to Delete *in order* unless it is part of a quotation.

inorganic growth, organic growth Business jargon. Avoid these terms; if you must use them, explain the meaning in a subsequent sentence.

inpatients Similarly, *outpatients*.

input To avoid jargon, use the word only in its technical sense — data or programs entered into a computer, or the process of entering them. For past tense and past participle of *input*, prefer *inputted* to *input*.

inquire, inquiry Not *enquire*, *enquiry*.

Insas assault rifle Insas is an acronym for Indian National Small Arms System.

inshallah God willing.

insignia Singular and plural.

insist means *to declare firmly or persistently, often in the face of disbelief*. The word should be used with care because it suggests you do not believe the person you are quoting.

in so far as is the British spelling; **insofar as** is American.

in spite of Not *inspite of*.

install Not *instal*. Derivatives: *installation*, *instalment*.

Also: *installed*, as in *installed as president*.

instil instilled, instillation. The American spelling is *instill*.

institute, institution Both words are used in names of organizations. Check and use the correct word. *Institution* is also used to mean *an established law or custom*, or *a well-established and familiar person or thing* (as in *He is a national institution*).

insure (buy or issue insurance), **ensure** (make certain)

intact One word.

Intelsat Formed as an intergovernmental consortium — International Telecommunications Satellite Organization — in 1964, Intelsat became a private company in 2001. It is the largest provider of fixed satellite services worldwide. It owns and operates about 50 communications satellites.

intense (of great force, strength, degree or amount), **intensive** (needing concentrated effort or resources)

The land is under intensive (not *intense*) *cultivation*.

intensely, intently *He listened intently* (not *intensely*).

inter(-) Compounds are one word except when *inter* is followed by a proper noun:

interact, interaction, interactive, interatomic, interbreed, intercity, interchange, intercollegiate, intercom, interconnect, intercontinental, intercourse, intercultural, interdepartmental, interdependent, interdisciplinary, interfaith, intergovernmental, interlink, interlocking, intermarriage, intermarry, international, interoffice, interpersonal, interplay, interracial, interstate

inter-American

inter alia Two words, no hyphen. Avoid this Latin phrase and use the English equivalent *among other things*.

intercede

intern Noun and verb.

International Air Transport Association IATA.

International Bank for Reconstruction and Development The World Bank's official name, which is rarely used.

International Committee of the Red Cross ICRC.

International Court of Justice (at The Hague), the world court, the court.

International Monetary Fund IMF is acceptable in subsequent references.

International Olympic Committee Note *Olympic*, not *Olympics*. Headquarters are in Lausanne, Switzerland.

International Space Station

internet, the Lowercase.

internet address For clarity, confine an internet address within a single line of type when possible, or treat it as a separate paragraph. If an address must break between lines, the split should occur directly before @, / or . (dot) without an inserted hyphen, which could be misleading.

Interpol International Criminal Police Organization. Headquarters are in Lyon, France. *Interpol* can be used in all references.

INTERPRETATION

Stories should be written in such a way that the significance of the events or words reported is immediately clear, without compromising accuracy, balance or sourcing. Quotes from people with vigorous opinions can be woven in to write a lively, even provocative, story without expressing, either directly or by the use of loaded words, a value judgment or forecast. Named sources should be used wherever possible. When this cannot be done, the nature of the quoted sources must be explained as specifically as possible: *Home ministry officials who attended the meeting said*. Where such comment is not immediately available, background can be used to put a development in context and thus make its significance clear.

interpretative Not *interpretive*.

interview with *The finance minister said in an interview with* (not *to*) *the BBC* or *The Times of India*.

intifada (religious struggle or uprising) Lowercase.

intimate (verb) is a formal word meaning *to make known indirectly*; *hint* or *imply*. You *intimate* something *to* somebody.

intra(-) Compounds are not hyphenated:

intracity, intraday, intranet, intraparty, intrastate, intrauterine, intrazonal

invalid Not valid or of no worth; do not use to refer to disabled or ill people.

investible

investigate A transitive verb, it is not followed by *into*. *Police are investigating the case*, not *Police are investigating into the case*. But: *Police investigation into the case is still incomplete*.

invite Use only as a verb, not as a noun.

invoke, evoke SEE **EVOKE, INVOKE**.

IOU

IP address Internet Protocol address. The numeric address given to a computer connected to the internet.

irascible Note single *r*.

IRDA All caps. Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority.

iridescent Note single *r*.

ironclad

Iron Curtain Cap in references to the Soviet bloc's isolation during the cold war.

ironic means *using or displaying irony*; it does not mean *strange* or *paradoxical*.

irreconcilable Not *irreconciliable*.

irrelevant

irreligious implies not only lack of religion but also hostility to it; **unreligious** implies merely lack of religion. A related word is *non-religious*, which applies not so much to individuals as to institutions and activities; it means *secular*.

irresistible

ISBN International Standard Book Number. It is a classification used to identify books. Its 13 digits denote the publisher, the country of origin and the title.

ISDN Integrated Services Digital Network, a technology that enables digital transmission of voice and data through telephone lines.

-isation, -ization SEE **-IZATION, ISATION**.

-ise, -ize SEE **-IZE, -ISE**.

-ish Compounds formed with *-ish* as a suffix are not hyphenated unless they include a number: bluish, boyish, bullish, prudish, sweetish. But: 30-ish.

ISI Inter-Services Intelligence, the Pakistani spy agency. *ISI* also stands for Indian Statistical Institute.

Iskcon International Society for Krishna Consciousness.

Islamic (Belonging to Islam, as in *Islamic law*, *Islamic architecture*), **Islamist** (A person who sees Islam as a political and social ideology as well as a religious one, as in *Islamist terrorists*, *Islamist separatists*)

issue Avoid *issue* as an all-purpose substitute for *problem*.

Note that you *take issue* (not *join issue*) with somebody over something. You *join battle* with somebody.

IT (information technology), **I-T** (income tax)

ITALICS

In news copy, use italics sparingly. In headlines, do not use italics; use single quotes instead.

Do not italicize Indian-language or foreign words that have been assimilated into English; do not even put them in quotation marks. Some examples: ad hoc, amicus curiae, apropos, avant-garde, bona fide, cognoscenti, de facto, de jure, déjà vu, en masse, en route, ex officio, ex parte, fatwa, hoi polloi, laissez-faire, mala fide, prima facie, quid pro quo, raison d'être, realpolitik, status quo, status quo ante, vice versa, vis-à-vis, zeitgeist.

Italicize Indian-language or foreign words and phrases that have not been assimilated into English. If the word or phrase is uncommon, give its English equivalent in brackets. Sometimes, such words can also be put in double quotation marks in copy and in single quotation marks in headlines. However, use either italics or quotation marks, not both.

Do not italicize proper names even if they are from an Indian language or a foreign language.

Do not italicize the names of newspapers, newspaper supplements, magazines or other periodicals; do not even put them in quotation marks. Do not italicize Times News Network or TOI.

Do not italicize genus and species names; do not even put them in quotation marks.

Do not italicize book titles; put them in double quotation marks in copy and in single quotation marks in headlines. Omit quotation marks for the titles of standard reference works like dictionaries or encyclopedias, and for religious books like the Gita, the Ramayana, the Quran and the Bible.

Do not italicize the names of aircraft, ships, spacecraft and trains; do not even put them in quotation marks.

Do not italicize the titles of albums, films, film festivals, plays, national anthems, operas, paintings or other works of art, songs and TV programmes. Put them in double quotation marks in copy and in single quotation marks in headlines.

Italicize quotes if they are in a different language. Italicize punctuation marks which are part of such quotes. If you are using a non-English quote, give its English translation in brackets unless you think the meaning is clear to everyone.

itinerary Plural *itineraries*.

it is understood, it is believed Avoid. All information in a story should be sourced, even if sources are not specifically identified.

it may be recalled Never use. If you want to recall something, just do so.

its (possessive form of *it*), **it's** (contraction of *it is*)

itself, only SEE **ONLY, ITSELF**.

IUD Intrauterine device (contraceptive)

Ivy League universities Brown University, Columbia University, Cornell University, Dartmouth College, Harvard University, Princeton University, University of Pennsylvania and Yale University

Note that Ivy League does not include many top US universities, like California Institute of Technology, Johns Hopkins University, Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Stanford University and UC Berkeley.

-ization, -isation When there is a choice between *-ization* and *-isation*, use *-ization*. See also the next entry.

-ize, -ise When there is a choice between *-ize* and *-ise*, use *-ize*. Whereas both forms are used in British English, the *-ize* form has the sanction of tradition (it is derived from the Greek *-izein* through the Latin *-izare*) as well as modernity. Apart from being the standard form in American English, and hence in most word-processing software programs, *-ize* is also preferred by Fowler's Modern English Usage, and Oxford, Collins, Chambers and Cambridge dictionaries.

Note that the following take only the *-ise* form, even in American English: advertise, advise (verb), apprise, arise, chastise, circumcise, comprise, compromise, despise, devise, disguise, enfranchise, excise, exercise, exorcise, improvise, incise, revise, supervise, surmise, surprise and televise.

Also in the same category are the following nouns, which are sometimes used as verbs: demise, enterprise, franchise and merchandise.

In British English, *prise* (force something open) is always thus spelled; in American English *prize* is more common in this sense.

Some words always take the *-ize* form, even in British English: capsize, prize (the noun meaning *reward* and the verb meaning *value highly*), seize, size.

SEE ALSO **-YSE, -YZE**.

***

Anyone not acquainted with journalists could be forgiven for assuming that they must talk something like this: "I last night went to bed early because I this morning had to catch an early flight."
— **Bill Bryson**

J

jack-in-the-box(es)

jackknife

jack(s) of all trades

jack-o'-lantern(s)

Jacuzzi Cap; it is a trademark. Generic terms are *whirlpool bath* and *spa bath*.

jailbird

jailbreak

jailer Not *gaoler*.

Jaish-e-Muhammed

Jamaat-ud-Dawa *JuD*, for short.

Jamaica rum Not *Jamaican rum*.

Jammu & Kashmir Not *Jammu and Kashmir*; in headlines, tables and charts, use *J&K*, not *J-K*.

jam-packed

Jamia Millia Islamia

Jana Gana Mana Put the titles of anthems in quotation marks. Do not italicize.

J&K is the abbreviation of *Jammu & Kashmir*. Do not write *J-K*.

Jang (Not *Jung*) Pakistani newspaper.

Janmashtami

Jap As a term for *Japanese*, it is pejorative. Do not use it.

JARGON

Jargon is the specialized language concerned with a particular subject, culture or profession. It is characterized by pretentious syntax, vocabulary or meaning. Avoid it.

Prefer the familiar word to the far-fetched. Prefer the short word to the long and the single word to the circumlocution. Prefer the concrete word to the abstract.

Avoid pompous words like *ongoing*, *escalating*, *prestigious*, *meaningful*, *facility*. Words like *confrontation* substitute vagueness for the crisp precision of *clash*, *dispute* or *war*. Political and military jargon is full of euphemism. It usually conceals more than it reveals. Unless you are directly quoting someone, turn jargon into clear English.

Although we use professional jargon in discussing our work — *obits*, *copy*, *story*, *paras*, *rejigs* and the like — we should not use it in stories, and words like *obituary* should be written in full.

Java man (anthropological) Not *Java Man*.

jaywalk means *to walk in or across a road without regard for approaching traffic*.

Jeddah Not *Jedda* or *Jiddah*.

jeep Lowercase in generic sense. Cap in reference to the trademarked vehicle. The current owner of the trademark is Chrysler.

Jehovah's Witness(es)

Jell-O A brand name belonging to US-based Kraft Foods for a number of gelatin desserts, including fruit gels, puddings and no-bake cream pies.

jerry-built (cheaply or shoddily built), **jury-rigged** (rigged for temporary or emergency use, improvised)

Jersey Do not use it as a short form for *New Jersey*.

Jerusalem The status of the city is disputed by Israelis and Arabs. Do not use it as a synonym of *Israel*, as in *the Jerusalem government*.

jet lag (noun), **jet-lagged** (adjective)

jetliner Prefer *airliner* or *jet*.

(the) jet set Rich and fashionable people who travel a lot.
Also: *jet-setter*, *jet-setting* (nouns).

Jew Because of long-standing prejudice, many non-Jews and even some Jews are nervous about using the word *Jew*, but the word is in fact respectful and inoffensive. However, it is extremely offensive to use *Jew* or *Shylock* to mean *a tight-fisted or unscrupulous person*. It is also considered offensive to use *Jewess* for a Jewish woman.

jewellery is the British spelling. The American spelling is *jewelry*.

jibe SEE **GIBE, JIBE, JIVE**.

jihad (not *jehad*) Holy war carried out by Muslims against the enemies of Islam.

Jnanpith India's highest literary award. The organization that gives the award is Bharatiya Jnanpith.

Johns Hopkins University

joint sitting, joint session, joint meeting When members of the two houses of Parliament convene together to vote on a bill, it is a *joint sitting*. So far, there have been only three joint sittings, the latest of which was in 2002 to deliberate and vote on the Prevention of Terrorism Bill, 2002.

When the two houses convene together to hear the President's address, it is a *joint session*. When they convene together to hear a foreign dignitary, it is a *joint meeting*.

Joneses As in *keeping up with the Joneses*.

Josip Broz Tito Marg Road in Delhi.

joyride

judgment Not *judgement*. A court decision or your ability to make sensible decisions.

judicial (pertaining to judges or the courts), **judicious** (prudent)

jugular The phrase is *go for the jugular*, not *go for the jugular vein*.

jumbo jet An extra-large airliner like the 747.

junior Abbreviate to *Jr*, not *Jun* or *Jnr*.

juniormost Use *most junior*. Similarly, *most senior*, not *seniormost*.

junkie(s) In its original meaning, *an addict*, the word is brutal slang. In other uses like *political junkie*, it remains slang, besides being a cliché that slights the enormity of addiction.

junta A political clique or a government formed by such a clique, usually after a coup. Do not confuse it with *janata*, the Sanskrit word meaning *people*.

jury-rigged, jerry-built SEE **JERRY-BUILT, JURY-RIGGED**.

just deserts Not *just desserts*. The expression is not related to the sweet course eaten at the end of a meal; it comes from the verb *deserve* and means *what a person deserves as reward or punishment*.

SEE ALSO **DESSERTS**.

justice, judge, magistrate Only Supreme Court and high court judges are justices. They can be called *justices* or *judges*. Lower judiciary has judges and magistrates; keep the distinction between the two. Do not use *justice* for a member of lower judiciary.

juvenile offenders Do not reveal the identity of a juvenile offender, suspect or accused. Guard against carrying pictures of juvenile offenders. In stories about sexual assault, do not reveal the identity of child victims. The identities of even adult victims of sexual assault should not be revealed. The same applies to child witnesses in criminal cases. There can be exceptions to this rule but you must consult the editor.

When someone's identity is not to be revealed, avoid all details that could provide a clue.

Jyllands-Posten Danish newspaper.

***

A writer is somebody for whom writing is more difficult than it is for other people.
— **Thomas Mann**

K

k Lowercase when using it for *1,000 times* in headlines: *Rs 20k crore*. Cap in all-caps or first-letters-capped headlines. Do not use *k* in copy; in headlines too, use it sparingly, not as a lazy substitute for three zeros.

K Cap when using it as an abbreviation for *kilo* in references to computer data or memory. In this context, *K* actually means *1,024*.

Kaaba Islam's most sacred shrine at the centre of the great mosque in Mecca. The qibla, the direction Muslims face during prayer, is the direction from their location on earth towards Kaaba.

kaffeeklatsch Not *coffee klatch*. A social gathering for informal conversation at which coffee is served.

kaftan Not *caftan*.

kaizen A Japanese business philosophy of continuous improvement.

Karmapa, the Cap when using it as the name of the titleholder. Lowercase otherwise.

karat SEE **CARAT**.

kar seva, kar sevak Italicize or put in quotation marks.

Karva Chauth

KB is kilobyte(s), **Kb** kilobit(s) and **Kbps** kilobit(s) per second.

keen(-) keen-edged, keen-eyed, keen-sighted, keen-witted

(-)keeper Compounds are generally one word:

barkeeper, beekeeper, bookkeeper, gatekeeper, housekeeper, peacekeeper, scorekeeper, shopkeeper, storekeeper, timekeeper

tollgate keeper

Kellogg's Corn Flakes But: *cornflakes* (generic).

kerb, curb The British spelling in the sense of *the edge of a pavement* is *kerb*; the American spelling is *curb*. The word *kerb* is also used in reference to unofficial trading in shares, as in *kerb deals*.

kerosene Not *kerosine*, which is the preferred form in technical and industrial usage.

ketchup Not *catchup* or *castup*.

key An overworked word. News writing is full of terms like *key provisions*, *key role*, *key evidence*, *key interest rate*, *key confidant*, even *key backing*. Look for more precise substitutes. Resist the faddish use of *key* as an adjective (without *the*) after a noun: *youth are key*. Use words like *crucial*, *central*.

key(-) keyboard, keyhole, keynote, keypad, keystone, keystroke, keyword

key club, key money, key punch, key ring

KGB The former Russian secret police and intelligence agency. The initials stand for Komityet Gosudarstvennoy Bezopasnosti, or Committee for State Security.

kharif A crop that is harvested at the beginning of winter.

SEE ALSO **RABI**.

Khmer Rouge Usually plural. Cambodian communist guerrillas. A Khmer is a Cambodian.

kibbutz is a communal farm in Israel; **kibitz** means *to chat* or *to give unwanted advice*.

kick-ass (adjective) means *strong* or *effective*. The word is not used as a verb. The phrase *kick ass*, as in *X kicked Y's ass*, is considered vulgar by Webster's New World College Dictionary and Merriam-Webster's Dictionary.

kickback (noun)

kickoff (noun), **kick off** (verb)

kick-start

kid gloves

kidnap, kidnapping Use *kidnap* only as a verb. For the noun and the modifier, use *kidnapping*.

SEE ALSO **ABDUCT, KIDNAP**.

kids is fine as a synonym of *children*, but use *children* if the context is serious.

Kilimanjaro (African mountain) Not *Mount Kilimanjaro*, because *kilima* means *mountain*.

kilobyte A kilobyte is about a thousand bytes (1,024 bytes, to be exact).

SEE ALSO **BIT** | **BYTE** | **GIGABYTE** | **MEGABYTE**.

kilogram, kilojoule, kilowatt Abbreviate to *kg*, *kJ*, *kW* for plural as well as singular (not *kgs*, *kJs*, *kWs*).

kilometre Not *kilometer*. Use *km* (no full stops, same singular and plural) at all references. Spell out *kilometre* when it is not preceded by a figure: *hundreds of kilometres*. To convert to miles roughly, multiply by five and divide by eight; precisely, multiply by 0.621.

kiloton A measure of explosive force equal to that of 1,000 tons of TNT. The atomic bomb dropped on Hiroshima on August 6, 1945, was a 12.5-kiloton weapon. The unit can be abbreviated to *kt*, but prefer *kiloton* for clarity.

kilowatt-hour(s) kWh.

kimono(s)

kin is a collective plural meaning *relatives*; one person is a *kinsman* or *kinswoman*.

kind SEE **TYPE, KIND, SORT**.

kindergarten, kindergartener A kindergarten is a school for children. Note spelling.

King James Version (of the Bible)

King's Cross Area in London.

king-size

Kiwi Except in sports contexts, do not use this word to mean a New Zealander. Lowercase *kiwi* when it means a bird or a fruit.

km Never *kms*. SEE ALSO **KILOMETRE**.

kmph Kilometres per hour.

knave, nave SEE **NAVE, KNAVE**.

knee(-) kneecap, kneehole, kneejerk, kneepad

knee-deep, knee-high

knee breeches

kneeled, knelt Use *knelt*.

Knesset Israeli parliament. Except in detailed references to the system or in passages conveying local colour, use *parliament*.

knickknack A small ornamental object, trinket.

knit For past tense and past participle, prefer *knitted* to *knit*. But use *knit* in expressions like *close-knit family*.

knockdown (noun), **knock down** (verb)

knockout (noun), **knock out** (verb)

knot A measure of speed, not distance. It tells you how many nautical miles a vessel or aircraft travelled in one hour. Hence, do not write *knots per hour*. Do not convert to miles per hour. One nautical mile equals 1.15 statute miles.

knowhow Use a simpler word like *skill*.

knowledgeable

koala Not *koala bear*. Koalas are bear-like Australian marsupials, not bears.

Kohinoor

Korea Do not use *Korea* as a short form of *North Korea* or *South Korea*.

kosher Lowercase. The word means *fit to eat according to Jewish dietary laws*; it is also a slang term meaning *all right*, *proper*, *correct*.

kowtow One word.

krona, krone The Swedish currency is *krona*; plural *kronor*. In Denmark and Norway, the currency is *krone*; plural *kroner*. Iceland's currency is *krona*; plural *kronur*.

kudos is an uncountable noun, always singular. Instead of *She received many kudos*, write *She received much kudos*.

Kuomintang Not *Kuomingtang*. Do not write *Kuomintang party*; *tang* means *party*.

***

I speak two languages:
Body and English.
— **Mae West**

L

labelled Do not add an *as*: *Police labelled the accident a hit and run*, not *Police labelled the accident as a hit and run*.

Labor Australian Labor Party, but *labour* is spelled as *labour* in Australian English.

lack Use it only to mean a shortage of something that is needed or desirable: *A lack of rain takes a toll on crops*, but *The absence* (not *lack*) *of rain makes the place a perfect holiday spot*.

lacklustre

lacuna Plural *lacunae*.

Ladbrokes (the betting company), **Ladbrokes.com** (its website)

lady, gentleman The words are obsolete except in jesting contexts and in phrases like *gentlemen's agreement*, *first lady*, *ladies and gentlemen* (a formal form of address), *lady luck* and *ladies' man*. *Lady* is required also in certain other contexts where *woman* would be considered rude: *Which of you ladies wants to sing?* | *Where are you going, lady?*

Except in contexts like these, use *woman*. Similarly, use *man* rather than *gentleman*.

Do not use *lady* as a modifier, as in *lady president*, *lady constable*, *lady doctor*, *lady victim*; many women find it offensive. Write *woman president*, *woman constable*, *woman doctor*, *woman victim*.

Refer to *women's* (not *ladies'*) competitions, events, etc. Make an exception only when *lady* or *ladies* is part of a proper name: *Ladies Professional Golf Association*.

Use the description *woman* only if it is relevant to the story, not because you think it is unusual for a woman to be a constable or a doctor.

SEE ALSO **FEMALE, MALE** | **(-)PERSON** | **SEXIST LANGUAGE** | **SPOKESPERSON**.

Laffer Curve A graph that illustrates the theory that if tax rates rise beyond a certain level, they discourage economic growth, thereby reducing government revenues. The theory, laid down by American economist Arthur Laffer, says that tax cuts produce non-inflationary economic growth and increase productivity.

lag Your rival does not *lag* you; he may *lag behind* you. When you *lag* a water pipe, you cover it with insulating material.

lager beer

Lagos is Nigeria's largest city and former capital. Since 1991, Abuja has been the capital of the west African country.

La Guardia Not *LaGuardia* for the airport in New York.

laissez-faire Not italicized.

lakh means *100,000* (*one hundred thousand*). Write *Rs 1 lakh*, *Rs 20 lakh* (not *lakhs*), but *lakhs of rupees*, *he made lakhs in property deals, lakhs of people*. Do not use *lakh* with a foreign currency; instead of *$20 lakh*, write *$2 million*. Do not use the spelling *lac*.

SEE ALSO **CRORE**.

lakshman rekha Lowercase; not *laxman rekha*.

lambast This colloquial verb is overworked; use it sparingly. The American spelling is *lambaste*.

lambswool One word. In American English, *lamb's wool* (noun), *lamb's-wool* (adjective)

lame duck (noun), **lame-duck** (adjective)

lamp post

Lancet Do not call it *British medical journal*; there is a different publication called *British Medical Journal*. While describing Lancet, use a phrase like *the London-based medical journal*.

land(-) landfall, landfill, landgrave, landholder, landlady, landlocked, landlord, landmark, landmass, landmine, landowner, landscape, landslide, landward

land bank, land contract, land grant (noun), land office, land reform

land-grabber, land-grabbing, land-grant (adjective)

(-)land cropland, dreamland, farmland, grassland, highland, inland, lowland, wonderland, woodland

landmark Use it as a noun or adjective, not as a verb. Ration its use; do not treat it as an all-purpose synomym of *significant*.

languid (flagging, inert)

languor, languorous Not *-our*.

Lao The language of Laos. The adjective is *Laotian*. There is also an ethnic group called Lao.

lap dancer, lap dancing No hyphen in nouns, but *lap-dancing* (adjective), as in *lap-dancing club*.

laptop No hyphen.

largely Use it in the sense of *mostly* or *mainly*, as in *What she said is largely true*. Do not use it to mean *in large numbers* or *in large quantities*, as in *The chief minister addressed a largely attended rally*.

large scale (noun), **large-scale** (adjective)

largesse The American spelling is *largess*.

larva Plural *larvae*.

Lashkar-e-Taiba Not *Lashkar-e-Toiba*.

lasso(s)

last, past *Last year*, in 2010, means *2009*. If you mean the 12 months up to the time of writing, write *the past year*. Similarly, *the last 10 years*, in 2010, means *the years from 2000 to 2009*.

The same goes for *the past month* and *the past week*.

last, past, latest, previous *Last* can mean *final* and hence should not be used as a synonym of *latest*. *"Ford County" is John Grisham's last book* means he is not going to write any more books. *"Ford County" is John Grisham's latest book* means it is his most recent book.

The last few days means *the final few days*; *the past few days* means *the most recent few days*.

If the point of reference is not the present, then *previous* is required, and *last* is wrong. If you have just mentioned Windows 7, then Windows Vista is the *previous* (not *last*) version of Microsoft Windows.

Last Supper

late (dead) Use *the late* only with the name of a person who has recently died. For example, it is not needed in *the late Jawaharlal Nehru*. Avoid this redundancy: *She is the widow of the late Rajesh Pilot*. And guard against this error: *Economic reforms were started by the late Prime Minister Narasimha Rao*. Surely, he was alive when he started the reforms.

SEE ALSO **FORMER**.

lathicharge

Latino (feminine *Latina*) Hispanic, descended from a Spanish-speaking land or culture. Neither *Latino* nor *Hispanic* denotes a race.

latitude, longitude Write like this: *28°61N, 77°23E*.

latter Avoid uses of *latter* and *former* that force the reader to glance back. Rephrase or name names.

laughing stock Two words. In American English, one word: *laughingstock*.

launch Strictly, the verb applies to *putting a boat in water* or *sending a rocket into space*. Other things can be *started*, *opened* or *introduced*. If you must use *launch*, let it remain a transitive verb with an object. Do not let something launch itself, as in *Business-news channel to launch next month*.

launch pad Two words.

launderette Not *laundrette*. But the 1985 film directed by Stephen Frears is "My Beautiful Laundrette".

law(-) lawbook, lawbreaker, lawgiver, lawmaker, lawman, lawsuit

law and order (noun)

law-abiding, law-and-order (adjective)

law and order Singular, as in *There is* (not *are*) *no law and order in the city*.

lawnmower One word.

lay, lie The verb *lay* (*lays*, *laying*, *laid*, *laid*) means *put down* or *place*. It always requires a direct object, the thing that is put or placed: *Bricklayers lay bricks*, *hens lay eggs, hens are laying eggs*, *hens laid eggs last week*.

The verb *lie* (*lies, lying, lay, lain*) means *recline* or *occupy a location*. It does not take an object: *People lie on beaches*, *a book lies on a desk*, *the dog is lying fast asleep*, *clothes lay all over the floor*, *these computers have lain idle since the office shifted to the other building*.

Confusion arises because the past tense of the above *lie* is *lay*. The other *lie* (make a false statement) takes the forms *lies*, *lying*, *lied*, *lied*.

lay(-) layman, layoff (noun), layout (noun), layover (brief stop, stopover), layperson, laywoman

lay off (verb), lay out (verb)

lay off (verb), **layoff** (noun) Use only in the sense of removal of employees to reduce a workforce or cut costs, not for dismissals over job performance.

lay waste (to) means *destroy*. The traditional form is *lay waste*: *The place has been laid waste by war*. | *The junta has laid waste the country's economy*. | *The junta has laid the country's economy waste*. But *lay waste to* has become more common and is acceptable: *The junta has laid waste to the country's economy*. | *Climate change laid waste to Mayan agriculture*.

lazybones One word.

lbw Lowercase.

leach (to cause a liquid to filter down through some material), **leech** (a bloodsucker, a parasite, to cling as a parasite)

leader A leader is a person who leads an organization or a country. Do not use it as a synonym of *politician*. *Congress leader Sonia Gandhi*, but not *Congress leader Digvijay Singh*.

leader of the opposition Lowercase.

leak In news reporting, a *leak* is an intentional disclosure by someone who chooses to remain anonymous. A leak may be unsolicited or induced by a reporter. Sometimes, other news organizations' stories are unfairly dismissed as leaks. Do not attribute a disclosure to a leak without knowing the exact circumstances.

leaned, leant Use *leaned*.

Leaning Tower of Pisa

leaped, leapt Use *leaped*.

leapfrog

leap year Lowercase.

learned, learnt Use *learned*.

lectern, podium A speaker stands *at* or *behind* a lectern and *on* a podium.

lectureship is the prevalent form, except at Oxford University, where *lecturership* is preferred.

left, leftist Lowercase in references to ideology. Cap *Left* and put *the* before it in references to the Left as a political grouping, as in *The Left opposed the India-US nuclear deal*.

left(-) leftover

left brain, left field, left fielder, left guard, left hand (noun), left wing (noun)

left-hand, left-handed, left-hander, left-wing (adjectives)

legendary Often an exaggeration. Use sparingly.

legerdemain Prefer the simpler *sleight of hand*.

legionnaires' disease

Légion d'honneur The anglicized form *Legion of Honour* is also fine.

legroom

leg up No hyphen, as in *giving somebody a leg up*.

leisure

leitmotif Not *leitmotiv*.

Leonardo da Vinci In subsequent references, *Leonardo*; not *da Vinci*. Leonardo had no other name; he is called Leonardo da Vinci because he was born in the town of Vinci.

lesbian Adjective and noun. *Lesbian women* is redundant.

SEE ALSO **SEXUAL ORIENTATION**.

lese-majesty is the British spelling. American English has preserved the French form: lèse-majesté. The word means *treason committed against a sovereign,* and by extension, *slighting behaviour towards a person to whom deference is due.*

less, fewer SEE **FEWER, LESS**.

(very) less It is wrong to say *I have eaten very less.* Surely, you would not say *I have eaten very more*. The correct form is *I have eaten very little* or *I have eaten little*.

less than The phrase tends to play down an amount: *less than Rs 1 lakh*. And *nearly* tends to play it up: *nearly Rs 1 lakh*. A neutral alternative is *about Rs 1 lakh*.

let-down (noun), **let down** (verb)

let it be Do not use in the sense of *leave it alone*. Write *leave it alone* or *let it alone*.

let off A court lets you off when it decides not to punish you or gives you a lighter punishment than expected: *The court let him off with a warning*. A person already in jail is *released*, not *let off*.

letter(-) letter bomb, letter box, letter carrier, letter opener

letterhead, letterpress

letter-perfect, letter-quality

letter(s) rogatory

let-up (noun), **let up** (verb)

leukaemia is the British spelling; *leukemia* is American.

level British *levelled*, *levelling*; American *leveled*, *leveling*.

level crossing

level playing field No hyphen.

LGBTQ+ An abbreviation referring to lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender and queer/questioning people. The acronym keeps expanding because language becomes more precise, people seek visibility and representation, and identities become socially recognised over time. Hence, the plus sign. Let's look at the definitions:

Lesbian: A woman attracted to women.

Gay: A person attracted to people of the same sex; commonly refers to men.

Bisexual: Attracted to more than one gender.

Transgender: A person whose gender identity differs from the sex assigned at birth.

Queer: An umbrella term for sexual and gender minorities. Use cautiously. Acceptable when individuals self-identify with it.

New additions: Intersex (Born with natural variations in sex characteristics that do not fit typical male/female definitions); Sex assigned at birth (Label given based on physical anatomy); Asexual (Experiences little or no sexual attraction); Nonbinary (Does not identify exclusively as male for female.)

A few important points: 1. Sexual orientation is not the same as gender identity. It refers to attraction; 2. Gender identity refers to internal sense of gender; 3. Being transgender does not imply any particular sexual orientation; 4. Intersex refers to biological variation, not orientation or identity; 5. Not everyone uses labels, and some reject categorisation entirely.

reference rate for short-term interest rates. Typically, the benchmark Libor is the three-month rate.

The company got a two-year bridge loan at 200 basis points above Libor.

Libid, or London interbank bid rate, is the rate at which banks take deposits from one another.

licence, license In British English, the noun ends in *ce*, the verb in *se*: *I now have a driving licence.* | *The company has been licensed to sell this product.* In American English, *license* is the spelling for both the noun and the verb.

lie, lay SEE **LAY, LIE**.

lieutenant governor Lowercase; no hyphen. *LG* can be used in headlines. Do not write *lt gov Tejendra Khanna spoke at the function.* Make it *Tejendra Khanna, lieutenant governor, spoke at the function.*

life(-) lifebelt, lifeblood, lifeboat, lifebuoy, lifeguard, lifelike, lifeline, lifespan, lifestyle, lifetime, lifework

life cycle, life expectancy, life force, life history, life insurance, life jacket, life preserver, life science, life sentence, life vest

life-and-death (adjective), life-giving, life-or-death (adjective), life-saver, life-saving, life-size, life-support

lifelong One word.

lifer A person who has been given a life sentence. Do not use the word as a synonym of *life sentence*.

lifestyle Avoid it as a euphemism for sexual orientation or habits.

lift Do not use as a synonym of *raise* or *increase*, as in *Central bank lifts discount rate.*

light (verb) For past tense and past participle, prefer *lit* to *lighted*.

light(-) lightbulb, lighthouse, lightproof, lightship, lightweight

light breeze, light guide, light horse, light meter, light pen

light-fingered, light-footed, light-handed, light-headed, light-hearted, light-minded

(-)light firelight, flashlight, gaslight, highlight, lamplight, limelight, searchlight, sidelight, sunlight

lightning Flash of bright light produced by a discharge of atmospheric electricity. Things can move at *lightning speed*. A *lightning strike*, also called wildcat strike, is a sudden strike without the usual warning.

Lightening is the -ing form of the verb *lighten* (*to make lighter* or *to brighten*).

light year A measure of distance, not time. It is the distance light travels in one year: about 9.5 billion km or 5.9 billion miles.

likable Not *likeable*.

like, such as Both are fine but *such as* is rather formal. The use of *like* to mean *such as* was formerly thought to be undesirable in formal writing, but has now become acceptable (Collins English Dictionary). The New York Times stylebook says that the phrase *such as* is stilted in introducing an example. It finds *like* more fluid and recommends *multinational companies like Coca-Cola* rather than *multinational companies such as Coca-Cola*. However, in expressions like *such companies as Coca-Cola, such as* does not sound stiff.

There is an old reasoning that *like* excludes and *such as* includes. Going by that reasoning, *cities like Varanasi have a unique place in Indian history* would suggest that the writer has in mind, say, Ujjain or Nashik. Modern usage — both British and American — does not bear this out.

like in SEE **UNLIKE IN**.

likely *He is likely to win* or *he will very likely win. He will likely win* is non-standard in American English as well.

likewise

lily Not *lilly*. Plural *lilies*. SEE ALSO **GILD THE LILY**.

limousine

limpid The word has nothing to do with *limp*. It means *clear and transparent*: *limpid eyes*, *limpid stream*.

linchpin Not *lynchpin*.

linage (number of lines), **lineage** (descent)

line(-) linebacker, lineman (a person who sets up or repairs telephone or electric lines), linesman (sports official), lineup (noun)

line judge, line drawing, line drive, line up (verb)

(-)line airline (*air line* in some names), coastline, deadline, shoreline, sideline, skyline, streamline, waistline

LINGUISTIC IDENTITY SEE **RACIAL, RELIGIOUS, REGIONAL AND LINGUISTIC LABELS | STEREOTYPES**.

link can be followed by *with* or *to*. While using it as a noun, prefer *with*.

linoleum

lion's share is a cliché. It means *the whole thing* or now usually *the biggest and best portion*.

lip-synch lip-synched, lip-synching, lip-syncher

liquefaction, liquefy Not *liquification* or *liquify*, but *liquidate* (convert assets into cash or wind up the affairs of a company; also, kill).

liquor can be any alcoholic drink, especially a strong one; **liqueur** (pronounced *lik-cure*) is a highly flavoured, sweet and strong alcoholic drink, taken in small qualities after meals.

liquorice is the British spelling; *licorice* is American.

(on the) list, (in the) list The conventional form, given in most dictionaries, is *on the list*. But the widely used *in the list* is acceptable; in fact, sometimes it sounds more natural.

litchi

literally Do not use *literally* when you mean *figuratively*. Instead of *I felt literally dead from fatigue*, write *I felt dead from fatigue*.

litre Abbreviation *l*. American spelling *liter*.

littérateur

little, a little The meanings are quite different. *Little* has a rather negative sense: *hardly any* or *not as much as expected*. *A little* has a positive sense: *some*.

The new traffic rules have done little to improve the situation means *the traffic situation has not improved*.

The new traffic rules have done a little to improve the situation means *the traffic situation has improved somewhat*.

SEE ALSO **FEW, A FEW**.

livable

live, put up, stay You *live* in your place of residence on a rather long-term basis. You *stay* at a hotel or a guesthouse temporarily. *Put up* is similar in meaning to *stay* and is generally used in passive constructions: *I was hoping you would put me up for a few days*.

living room (noun), **living-room** (adjective)

LNG Liquefied natural gas. It is natural gas, or methane, converted to liquid form for ease of transport and storage.

SEE ALSO **CNG** | **LPG** | **PNG**.

LNJP Hospital The name of this Delhi hospital, earlier known as Irwin Hospital, is Lok Nayak Hospital. There is no *Jayaprakash* in the name. The abbreviation *LNJP* has become so common that it is acceptable but do not spell it out to *Lok Nayak Jayaprakash* as is often seen in newspapers.

(-)load busload, carload, shipload, truckload

load shedding (noun), **load-shedding** (adjective, as in *load-shedding schedule*)

loan A noun. Do not use it as a verb; use *lend* instead. In the past tense, *lent* rather than *loaned*.

loath (adjective), **loathe** (verb) *You are loath* (not *loathe* or *loth*) *to admit a mistake*. But: *You loathe people who don't listen to you*.

LoC Short for *line of control*.

local In the sense of a local person, use as a noun, not as an adjective.

LOCALITY NAMES
Write like this, without hyphens: *GK I*, *GK II*, *Sector 38*.

located Often redundant, as in *The Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium is located in Delhi*. Delete it.

lock(-) lockjaw, locknut, locksmith

lock-up (noun)

lockdown Restriction of movement during emergencies.

lock-in, lockout (nouns) but **lock in, lock out** (verbs)

log(-) login, logon, logoff (nouns)

log in, log on, log off (verbs)

log jam Two words.

Lok Sabha MP If you spell out *MP*, you will see the awfulness of the phrase: *Lok Sabha member of Parliament*. Write *Lok Sabha member*.

long(-) longboat, longhair, longhand, longhorn, longlist, longshore (adjective), longtime (adjective)

long division, long house, long jump, long run, long shot, long term, long time, long wave (nouns)

long-drawn-out, long-lived, long-playing, long-range, long-standing, long-suffering, long-term, long-wave, long-winded (adjectives)

(-)long One word if *long* attaches to a one-syllable word ending in a consonant:

daylong, hourlong, monthlong, weeklong, yearlong

Hyphenated if *long* directly follows a vowel or a word of more than one syllable:

decade-long, minute-long, mile-long, second-long

Do not attach *long* to a plural: *a delay of weeks*, not *a weekslong delay*.

Shorten expressions like *five-hour-long drive* to *five-hour drive*.

longlist A list from which suitable candidates are selected; not *long list*, because a longlist is not necessarily long.

loo Use *lavatory* or *toilet*.

look forward (to) *I look forward to meeting you* is right; *I look forward to meet you* is not.

looking to Do not use as a substitute for *hope to*. Avoid constructions like *Japan was looking to restore good relations with Moscow*. It is all right to say *Japan was looking to Washington for support*.

lookout (noun), **look out** (verb)

lopsided One word.

lorry Use *truck*.

loose (not *fixed*), **lose** (not to have something any more)

Lord's The London cricket ground. Note the apostrophe.

lovable Not *loveable*.

lovemaking

lover is a suitable term for a partner in a literary or historic liaison or a highly visible romance between public personalities — in show business, for example. While writing about more private people, use *companion* or *partner*.

low(-) lowball, lowborn, lowboy, lowbred, lowbrow, lowdown, lowland, lowlife, lowlight, lowrise

low beam, low blood pressure, low blow, low comedy, low frequency (noun), low tide, low water

low-cal, low-class, low-cost, low-end, low-frequency (adjective), low-grade, low-key, low-level, low-lying, low-minded, low-necked, low-pitched, low-priced, low-proof

(adjective meaning *low in alcohol content*), low-rent (adjective), low-spirited, low-tech, low-tension, low-water mark

LPG Liquefied petroleum gas, which is the commonly used cooking fuel in India. LPG is a mixture of hydrocarbon gases, mainly propane and butane. Do not use *cooking gas* as a synonym of LPG; *cooking gas* could also mean PNG.

SEE ALSO **CNG** | **LNG** | **PNG**.

LPGA Short for *Ladies* (not *Ladies'*) *Professional Golf Association*.

LSD Acceptable in all references to lysergic acid diethylamide.

lullaby Not *lullabye*.

lumbar (relating to the lower back), **lumber** (junk furniture, sawn timber)

lump sum (noun) Two words.

lunar Lowercase.

lunchroom

Lutyens' Delhi Not *Lutyen's* or *Lutyens's*. Named after the architect Edwin Lutyens.

luxuriant (profuse in growth, as in *luxuriant hair*, *luxuriant vegetation*), **luxurious** (characterized by luxury, expensive, as in *a luxurious hotel*)

(-)ly Do not use a hyphen after an adverb ending in *-ly*. For example, *politically naive, wholly owned, genetically modified.*

Lycra is a trademark. Generic terms include *spandex*, *elastic* and *stretch fabric*.

lynch

***

You don't want to mislead the reader for even a nanosecond. So even if readers could eventually figure out what the writer meant, that's no reason to lead them down the wrong path.
— **Merrill Perlman,** former director, copy desks, NY Times

M

m Short for *million*. SEE ALSO **MILLION**.

μ Greek letter for *m*; pronounced *mew*. In measurements, especially pollution figures, it is used as a symbol for *micro-* (one-millionth). Do not make it *u* as has happened in this newspaper. Use *micron* or *one-millionth* in copy. If μ is used in tables and charts, explain the meaning.

machiavellian Lowercase.

machine gun (noun), **machine-gun** (adjective and verb), **submachine gun**

Mach 1, Mach 2 Not *Mach one*, *Mach two*. Something travelling at Mach 1 would be travelling at the speed of sound (1,235kmph, or 770mph, at sea level). Something travelling at Mach 2 would be travelling at double the speed of sound.

Machu Picchu

mackintosh (raincoat), **Macintosh** (computer; generally called Mac)

macro(-) macrobiology, macroclimate, macrocosm, macroeconomics, macronutrient, macroscopic

mad(-) madcap, madman, madwoman

Madame Tussauds (not *Tussaud's*) The group has dropped the apostrophe from its name.

madeira Wine and cake.

Madras Although the city's name has changed to Chennai, some organizations retain *Madras* in their names: Madras Fertilizers Ltd; Madras high court; IIT, Madras; Madras Institute of Technology; Madras Medical College; University of Madras. But: Chennai Port Trust.

madrassa Not *madrasa*, *madarsa* or *madrasah*.

mafia (plural) A member of the mafia is *mafioso* (plural *mafiosi*).

MAGAZINE NAMES SEE **PERIODICAL NAMES**.

magistrate SEE **JUSTICE, JUDGE, MAGISTRATE**.

maglev Short for *magnetic levitation*.

Magna Carta Not *the Magna Carta*.

magnitude SEE **EARTHQUAKES**.

Magsaysay award Not *Magsasay* or *Magasasay award*. Often called Asia's Nobel prize, it is named after Ramon Magsaysay, the third president of the Philippines.

Mahabharata Not *Mahabharat*.

Mahalaxmi (not *Mahalakshmi*) Racecourse in Mumbai.

Mahashivaratri One word. Note the *a* after *v*.

maintain Use this word with care. Like *claim*, it suggests the writer is sceptical about the statement quoted.

maintenance Not *maintainance*.

maître(s) d'hôtel Use the less pretentious *headwaiter(s)*. Keep the clipped *maître d'* for direct quotations and light contexts.

major An overused adjective. Do not use it as a lazy substitute for *big*, *chief*, *important* or *main*.

majority A majority is more than a half. Write *a majority*, not *the majority*, unless referring to an organized faction. Do not use *majority* as an alternative for *most of*. When *a majority* is used in an abstract sense, it is singular: *A two-thirds majority is needed to amend the Constitution*. It is plural when it denotes the elements making up the majority: *A majority of MPs opposed the bill*.

majorly Do not use.

make(-) makeover (noun), makeshift, makeup (noun)

make over (verb), make up (verb)

make-believe, make-work

(-)maker automaker, bookmaker, carmaker, dealmaker, dressmaker, drugmaker, filmmaker, glassmaker, haymaker, holidaymaker, homemaker, lawmaker, merrymaker, moneymaker, moviemaker, peacemaker, steelmaker, troublemaker, winemaker

Other combinations, not so well established, should remain two words: carpet maker, coffee maker, decision maker, pen maker, policy maker, tea maker

mala fide SEE **BONA FIDE**.

Malagasy Singular and plural. Language or people of Madagascar.

Malay, Malayan, Malaysian *Malay* (noun or adjective) refers to a member of a Polynesian ethnic group found on the Malay peninsula, or to the language of that group. *Malayan* refers to any inhabitant of that peninsula. *Malaysian* (noun or adjective) refers to any inhabitant of Malaysia.

male, female SEE **FEMALE, MALE**.

malpractice(s)

man, mankind In general references to humans, use words like *humans*, *humanity*, *humankind*, *human race* or *people*. Phrases like *common man* and *man in the street* can often be replaced by *ordinary people* or *average person*.

man, manned, manning A department or project should be *staffed* rather than *manned*. *Policemen manning a barricade* should be rephrased to *policemen on duty at a barricade*. But *man* is fine in set phrases like *unmanned level crossing*.

manageable

man-day, man-hour These are set business terms, but see if phrases like *a day of work* or *an hour of work* can be used to better reflect the shared role of the sexes.

Mandovi (river in Goa), **Mandvi** (town in Gujarat)

manic, manically

manifesto(s)

manifold (many-featured), **manyfold** (multiplied many times)

manila (envelope), **Manila** (capital of the Philippines)

man-made can often be replaced by terms like *artificial*, *synthetic* and *manufactured*, which better reflect the shared role of the sexes.

manner born If you do something *as (if) to the manner born*, you do it very well and very naturally as if it is usual and easy for you. The phrase comes from Shakespeare's "Hamlet". The variant *to the manor born*, though used widely, is considered incorrect by many authorities.

manoeuvre, manoeuvring in British English; *maneuver*, *maneuvering* in American English.

manpower Use terms like *labour, personnel* and *staffing* instead.

mantel (shelf), **mantle** (cloak; also, an important role or responsibility)

mantelpiece Not *mantlepiece*.

many(-) many-hued, many-sided

many a always takes a singular verb: *Many a battle was fought at Panipat.*

Maori Singular and plural.

MAPS

Guard against publication of maps, especially from foreign sources, that show Indian territories like Kashmir and Aksai Chin as disputed or outside India.

Marathi manoos Not *Marathi manus*.

Mardi Gras

margin The difference between two values. If X won an election by getting 100,000 votes and X's nearest rival got 80,000 votes, the margin is 20,000. Do not say *X won by a margin of 100,000 to 80,000.*

marijuana Not *marihuana*.

marine Lowercase, like *soldier*.

mark (verb) Resist the use of *mark* to mean *is*, *are* or even *signify*.

market capitalization, generally called *market cap*, is the total market value of all of a company's shares outstanding. It is computed by multiplying the number of the company's shares outstanding by the current market price of one share. The investment community uses market cap, rather than sales or total asset figures, for determining a company's size.

The stocks of large, medium and small companies are referred to as *large-cap*, *mid-cap* and *small-cap* respectively. There are no exact figures to define these terms but it is generally agreed that stocks with a market cap of Rs 10,000 crore or more are large-cap. Stocks with a market cap of Rs 100 crore or more but less

than Rs 10,000 crore are considered mid-cap and those with a market cap of less than Rs 100 crore are called small-cap. These figures change, depending on market conditions. Always check.

SEE ALSO **SHARES OUTSTANDING**.

marriage, wedding *Marriage* refers to the state or relationship of being husband and wife: *the institution of marriage*. *Wedding* is a marriage ceremony. Hence, you say *wedding anniversary*, *wedding cake*, *wedding dress*, *wedding party*, *wedding present* or *wedding reception*. *Marriage* cannot replace *wedding* in any of the examples cited in the previous sentence.

The Sharmas celebrated their 25th wedding anniversary last month.
The Sharmas celebrated 25 years of their marriage last month.
Their marriage (not *wedding*) *is on the rocks.*

married Do not use the superfluous *got*: *he married* rather than *he got married*. Do not use phrases like *he has a wife*, which imply *he owns his wife*.

Marseille (not *Marseilles*) French city and football club.

marshal The military rank has only one *l*. But *Marshall Plan*, and *Marshall Islands* in the Pacific.

marshal (verb) To gather or organize. British English *marshalled*, *marshalling*; American English *marshaled*, *marshaling*.

martial is used for *warlike*, as in *martial law*, which indicates a military government, involving the suspension of ordinary government. *Martial arts* are fighting sports like judo and karate.

mashup A combination of elements from different sources used to create a new song, video, website, etc.

Mass A Mass is *celebrated*, not *said*.

massive An overused adjective, it is best reserved for things of great bulk.

masterful (domineering, overpowering), **masterly** (skilful)

master plan Two words.

master's degree Informally, *master's*; never *masters*.

masterstroke

(the) Masters Tournament (golf) Not *Masters'*. Also called *the Masters*, *the US Masters*.

matcha Powdered Japanese tea, now a global trend.

materialize Do not use as a synonym of *appear*, *come about* or *happen*.

maths is the British form; *math* is American.

matter-of-fact (adjective), **matter-of-course** (adjective)
But: *as a matter of fact*, *as a matter of course*.

mawa, mewa Both are Hindi-Urdu words; *mawa* means *khoya (thickened milk)* and *mewa* means *dry fruits*.

may, might Use *may* when the possibility remains open. Use *might* when referring to past possibilities that did not happen.
He may have survived the bomb blast — it is possible but we do not know.
Had he left the place early, he might have survived the bomb blast — he did not leave the place early and died.

In a simple sentence expressing possibility, both *may* and *might* are correct but *might* is more tentative. In *He might play today*, the possibility of his playing is more remote than in *He may play today*.

Similarly, in polite questions, *might* is more tentative than *may*.
Might I use your phone?
May I use your phone?
The first implies that you are overanxious to let the owner of the phone decide whether you can use it. In fact, even *May I* can sound overpolite, and *Can I* takes its place.

maybe (adverb meaning *perhaps*), **may be** (verb)

May Day (May 1), **mayday** (distress signal)

May 1 is Labour Day worldwide. In the US, the first Monday in September is Labor Day. So is it in Canada, where it is spelled as *Labour Day*.

mayhem means *violent disorder*; it does not mean *murder*.

mayonnaise

mayoral (adjective), **mayoralty** (noun)

MB is megabyte(s). When used for computer memory or data storage capacity, a megabyte is equal to 2^{20} bytes, or 1,048,576 bytes. **Mb** is megabit(s) and **Mbps** megabit(s) per second.

MC Not *emcee*.

MCC Short for *Marylebone Cricket Club*.

McMahon Line (not *McMohan Line* or *Macmohan Line*) Border between Tibet and Assam in British India, negotiated between Tibet and Britain at the end of the Simla Convention in 1913-14. It was named after Henry McMahon, the British government's foreign secretary for India and the chief British negotiator of the convention. The line extends along the crest of the Himalayas for 885km from Bhutan in the west to the great bend of the

Brahmaputra in the east. It is regarded by India as the legal border with China. China refuses to recognize the boundary on the ground that the Tibetan government was not sovereign.

me, I SEE **I, ME**.

mean SEE **AVERAGE, MEAN, MEDIAN**.

mean(-) meanspirited, meantime, meanwhile

In astronomical sense, *mean time* is two words, as in *Greenwich Mean Time*.

means can be singular or plural. It is generally singular in expressions like *means of transport*, *means of communication*, *means of expression*: *Is there any means of contacting him?* | *The internet is the most powerful means of communication*.

Means is plural when it refers to money: *His means are modest*.

Means to an end is singular, as in *For him, work is just a means to an end*.

meanwhile, in the meantime Both mean the same thing, but *meanwhile*, being shorter, is preferred. *In the meanwhile* is wrong.

Meanwhile is too abrupt a transitional phrase when a story moves to reporting another event. *In another development* is similarly skimpy. Try to express the actual relationship of events in a few words.

SEE ALSO **TRANSITIONAL WORDS AND PHRASES**.

meatloaf (baked loaf of meat), **Meat Loaf** (singer)

mecca Lowercase in metaphorical sense, as in *Lord's is considered the mecca of cricket*. Cap when referring to the city in Saudi Arabia.

medallist is the British spelling; *medalist* is American.

meddle (verb meaning *interfere*), **mettle** (noun meaning *courage* or *excellence of character*)

SEE ALSO **METTLE**.

Médecins sans Frontières International medical aid charity, abbreviated as *MSF*. Do not call it *a French NGO*.

media Collective term for newspapers, television and radio. Strictly, plural, but increasingly used as singular. Dictionaries too accept the singular usage. But stick to the plural usage, if only to avoid nitpicking. When *medium* means *a person claiming to be able to communicate with the spirits of dead people*, its plural is *mediums*.

median SEE **AVERAGE, MEAN, MEDIAN**.

MEDICAL STORIES

Handle stories about new threats to health or claimed cures for AIDS, cancer and other scourges with great care. They play on the hopes and fears of millions of people. If a story making dramatic claims to cure a serious illness does not come from a reputable, named source, it must be checked with recognized medical experts before being carried. If such a story is carried, it should include whatever balancing or interpretative material is available from such authorities.

medicine SEE **DRUGS**.

medieval Not *mediaeval*.

Mediterranean Cap. Note double *r*.

meet (noun) means *a sports event*. Avoid its use in other contexts. Instead of *UPA-Left meet*, write *UPA-Left meeting*.

meet (verb) *He met party leaders,* not *met with* or *met up with party leaders.*

mega(-) Compounds are generally one word:

megabucks, megahit, megalith, megaphone, megastar, megaton

Hyphenate terms coined for effect (*mega-merger*, *mega-series*), but ration that use to avoid triteness.

megabyte MB. A megabyte is about a million bytes (1,024 kilobytes, or 1,048,576 bytes to be exact).

megahertz MHz; a unit of frequency equal to a million hertz, or a million cycles per second.

megawatt MW; a unit of power equal to a million watts.

SEE ALSO **MW**.

mehndi Not *menhdi* or *mehendi*.

melee A noisy, confused fight involving a number of people. A riot is not a melee.

meme A cultural or behavioural element passed on by imitation or other non-genetic means. The word, rhyming with *seem*, was coined on the pattern of *gene* by Richard Dawkins in his 1976 book, "The Selfish Gene".

memento(es) Not *momento(es)*.

memorabilia Plural.

memorandum(s)

ménage à trois Also *ménage*; an arrangement in which a married couple and the lover of one of them live together.

menservants, men drivers Not *manservants*, *man drivers*. Also: *women voters*, *women activists*. But: *man-haters*, *woman-haters*, *maneaters*.

menswear One word, no apostrophe; in American English, *men's wear*.

mental handicap, mentally handicapped, mentally ill, mentally retarded Be careful while writing about mental health issues. Do not use offensive words like loony, maniac, psycho and schizo; write person with or person has. Do not use schizophrenic as a noun. Instead of he is schizophrenic, write he has schizophrenia. Similarly, he has ADHD.

mental hospital Not *mental asylum*.

meow, miaow The preferred spelling in both British English and American English is *meow*.

Mercedes-Benz Note hyphen. In subsequent references, *Mercedes*. The plural is *Mercedes-Benzes or Mercedeses*. The possessive is *Mercedes-Benz's* or *Mercedes's*; the plural possessive is *Mercedes-Benzes'* or *Mercedeses'*.

merry-go-round

messiah Cap only in religious uses.

Met Clipped form of *meteorological*. Do not use *Met* as a noun. *The Met office predicted a rainy day,* not *The Met(s) predicted a rainy day*.

mete out a punishment Not *meet out a punishment*.

meter (measuring device)**, metre** (unit of length, rhythm in poetry) In American English, *meter* in all senses.

metrosexual Not *meterosexual*.

mettle When you are *on your mettle*, you are ready or have been forced to do your best: *The economic slowdown put the IT industry on its mettle* (not *on its metal*).

mewa, mawa SEE **MAWA, MEWA**.

mexican wave The rippling effect produced when the spectators in successive sections of a sports stadium stand up while raising their arms and then sit down. It gained worldwide notice during the Football World Cup finals in Mexico in 1986.

mezzanine

mgd for million gallons per day. A unit for measuring the flow of water. To convert mgd to cusecs, multiply by 1.858. To convert mgd to cumecs, multiply by 0.053. In India, *gallon* means *the imperial gallon* (4.546 litres, or 0.161 cubic foot).

Remember, mgd is a measure of the rate of flow, not of volume.

SEE ALSO **CUMEC** | **CUSEC**.

MIAL All caps. MIAL stands for Mumbai International Airport Private Ltd, which runs the Mumbai airport. It is a joint venture owned by a GVK-led consortium (74%) and Airports Authority of India (26%).

Mibor, Mibid Mibor is Mumbai interbank offered rate and Mibid is Mumbai interbank bid rate.

SEE ALSO **LIBOR**.

mice is the plural of *mouse* in reference to computer gadgets as well as small rodents (AP stylebook, Garner's Modern American Usage).

micro(-) Compounds are generally one word:

microbiology, microchip, microcircuit, microclimate, microcomputer, microcosm, microcredit, microeconomics, microfilm, microgram, micronutrient, microphone, microscope, microsecond, microwave

Hyphenate when the second element begins with a capital letter or an *o*: micro-organism.

microchip Use *chip* instead.

mid(-) midafternoon, midair, midbrain, midcourse, Mideast, midfield, midfielder, midleg, midlife, midline, midmorning, midmost, midnight, midocean, midpoint, midrange, midrash, midrib, midriff, midrise, midsection, midship, midsize, midstream, midsummer, midterm, midtown, midway, midweek, midwest, midwife, midwinter, midyear

mid-America, mid-Victorian, mid-1980, mid-1980s, mid-19th century

Midas touch Not *Midas' touch*.

mid-Atlantic But *transatlantic*.

midday One word, no hyphen. But the afternoon newspaper published from Mumbai and Delhi is Mid Day.

middle(-) middlebrow, middleman, middleweight

middle age (noun), Middle Ages, middle class (noun), middle school

middle-aged (adjective), middle-class (adjective), middle-of-the-road (adjective), middle-sized

middle age Generally considered to mean 40 to 65. But when citing a study or finding, specify its definition.

Middle East Not *West Asia*. In copy, use *Middle East*. In headlines, use *Middle East* or *Mideast*. The region comprises Iran, Iraq, Israel, Kuwait, Jordan, Lebanon, Oman, Bahrain, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Syria, Turkey, United Arab Emirates and Yemen in west Asia, and Egypt and Sudan in northeastern Africa.

midnight technically ends a day. While reporting that something comes into effect at midnight — for example, a strike, a price increase or a ceasefire — be clear about the day in question. Do not use *12 midnight*; *midnight* is adequate. Do not use *12am*; it often causes confusion.

MiG-21, MiG-29

might SEE **MAY, MIGHT**.

Milad-ul-Nabi

mileage Not *milage*.

MILITARY OPERATIONS

Cap their names; do not put in quotation marks.

MILITARY RANKS

A military rank should be capped only when it is used as a title: *Major General Ajit Singh*; in subsequent references either *Singh* or *the general*, not *the major general*. Do not hyphenate military ranks, except *sub-lieutenant*.

Be careful while mentioning ranks; recheck them, especially when reporting a war or a skirmish. Commissioned ranks in the Indian armed forces:

Air Force	Army	Navy
Marshal of the Air Force	Field marshal	Admiral of the fleet
Air chief marshal	General	Admiral
Air marshal	Lieutenant general	Vice admiral
Air vice marshal	Major general	Rear admiral
Air commodore	Brigadier	Commodore
Group captain	Colonel	Captain
Wing commander	Lieutenant colonel	Commander
Squadron leader	Major	Lieutenant commander
Flight lieutenant	Captain	Lieutenant
Flying officer	Lieutenant	Sub-lieutenant

Field marshal, marshal of the Air Force and admiral of the fleet are honorary ranks. Officers on whom these ranks are conferred do not retire.

India has had only two field marshals (K M Cariappa and Sam Manekshaw), one marshal of the Air Force (Arjan Singh) and no admiral of the fleet.

militate, mitigate *Militate against something* means *be a powerful factor in preventing it*. *Mitigate* means *ease* or *soften*.

mill(-) millowner, millstone, millwork

(-)mill sawmill, windmill

coffee mill, flour mill, paper mill

millennium Note double *l* and double *n*; plural *millennia*. Technically, a millennium, the thousand-year period, begins with a "01" year — 1, 1001, 2001, etc — because there was no year 0. But in popular consciousness, eras begin with 1000, 2000, etc. That informal usage is fine in references to celebrations and social or cultural turning points (New York Times stylebook).

millimetre Abbreviation *mm* (no full stops, same singular and plural). Even in first reference, no need to spell it out. Never *mms*.

million A million is 1 followed by six zeros. It is equal to 10 lakh, or one-tenth of a crore. Abbreviate *million* to *m*, not *mn*. Even in copy, use *m* for sums of money, quantities or inanimate objects: *$100m*, *50m tonnes of coal*, *30m doses of vaccine*; but use *million* for people: *one million people*. In headlines, use *m* or *million*.

SEE ALSO **BILLION** | **TRILLION**.

millionaire Not *millionnaire*.

milquetoast Pronounced *milk toast* but not so spelled. A milquetoast is a meek or submissive person. The usage derives from Caspar Milquetoast, a timid and ineffectual comic-strip character drawn by Harold Webster from 1924 to 1952.

mimeograph

mimic, mimicked, mimicking

min Clipped form of *minute(s)*. Use only in headlines. Do not write *mins*.

(-)minded fair-minded, high-minded, money-minded, open-minded

mindset

minefield

minesweeper

mini(-) minibike, minibus, minicab, minicomputer, miniskirt, minivan

mini-series

minimal Very small, as small as possible. Not a synonym of *small*.

miniratna Lowercase; status conferred on public sector companies by the government. Similarly, *maharatna*, *navratna*.

MINISTERS, MINISTRIES

Do not use *Union* when there is no counterpart in states: *defence minister*, not *Union defence minister*; *railway minister*, not *Union railway minister*. The areas that fall exclusively under the Centre's jurisdiction are mentioned in the Union List of the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution. These include atomic energy, defence, civil aviation, communications (post and telecom), foreign affairs, broadcasting, railways, shipping (maritime), and petroleum and natural gas.

Prefer conversational descriptions rather than the formal names of ministries or formal designations of ministers: *foreign minister* rather than *external affairs minister*; *oil minister* rather than *petroleum and natural gas minister*; *personnel minister* rather than *minister for personnel, public grievances and pensions*; *environment minister* rather than *minister for environment and forests*.

When a minister holds charge of more than one ministry, mention only the designation that is relevant to the context. India may have a minister for chemicals, fertilizers and steel, but in a story on steel prices, the description *steel minister* is sufficient.

minority (noun and adjective) Use the word only for a group. Do not use it for individuals, as in *The applicants included three minorities*. Make it *The applicants included three minority members*.

minus sign Do not use the minus sign in copy or headlines; use it only in charts and tables.

Use the en dash (–), not the hyphen (-), for the minus sign. The command for the en dash is Alt0150.

minuscule Not *miniscule*; the word is related to *minus*.

miracles Keep *miracles* for religious stories. In disaster reports we can do without its clichéd use, as in *"It was a miracle no one was killed," said a rescue worker*.

MIRV(s) Multiple independently targetable re-entry vehicle(s).

mischievous Not *mischievious*.

mishap means *a minor accident with negligible consequences*. People are not killed in mishaps.

mishmash

misinformation False or inaccurate information.

misspell No hyphen.

misspelled, misspelt Use *misspelled* as a verb and *misspelt* as an adjective.

mistake Write *make a mistake*, not *commit a mistake*.

mistakable, unmistakable Not *mistakeable*, *unmistakeable*.

misstep

mitigate, militate SEE **MILITATE, MITIGATE**.

MIXED METAPHOR

A metaphor is an implied comparison. When you say *Lord's is the mecca of cricket*, you are using a metaphor. (The grammar term for a direct comparison, using *as* or *like*, is *simile*; for example, if you say *Sehwag played like Tendulkar*, you are using a simile.) Trouble arises when two incompatible images are combined, resulting in a *mixed metaphor*. It is ridiculous to say *A leopard can't change his stripes,* because leopards do not have stripes. Look at this example cited by R L Trask in "Mind the Gaffe": *It was clear that the germs of a compromise policy would have to be sown*. The problem here is that *germs* are not *sown*. If *germs* is replaced with *seeds*, the sentence will be fine.

This comes from one of our stories: *The BJP has fallen back on old hands to pull itself out of the Liberhan setback*. Two mixed metaphors in one sentence. There is no quick fix here; careful writing is what is needed.

mix-up (noun), **mix up** (verb)

MLC Member of Legislative Council. Do not use this abbreviation for *medico-legal certificate*.

mm millimetre; singular and plural.

mob Use this word with care; never use it for a political protest. The neutral *crowd* is usually better unless there is an outbreak of unorganized violence.

SEE ALSO **FLASH MOB**.

moccasins

mockingbird One word.

modalities Use *means* or *procedures*.

modus operandi (singular) The plural *modi operandi* is rarely used.

mohalla No itals.

Mohd Short for the name *Mohammed*, as in *Mohd Kaif*. Do not make it *Md*.

SEE ALSO **MUHAMMAD**.

molotov cocktail Lowercase.

mom, mommy, momma Not *mum*, *mummy*.

Use only in informal contexts. Lowercase except when the words substitute for a proper name: *I called my mom just before she and my dad were to leave for London*, but I *called Mom just before she and Dad were to leave for London*.

monetary policy SEE **FISCAL POLICY, MONETARY POLICY**.

moneyed Not *monied*.

money laundering (noun), **money-laundering** (adjective)

moneylender

moneymaker, moneymaking

moneys, monies Use *money* or *funds* instead.

monger(-) fishmonger, rumourmonger, scandalmonger, warmonger

mongoose(s)

monsoon Not *monsoons* or *monsoon season*. Monsoon itself is the season when most of India gets rain: *The monsoon breaks in June.*

Mont Blanc (the mountain), **Montblanc** (the pen maker)

Montessori

monthlong One word.

MONTHS

In copy, headlines and graphics, for months from August to February write Aug, Sept, Oct, Nov, Dec, Jan and Feb. Write Mar, Apr, Jun and Jul; May is always May. Do not put a full stop after the abbreviated name of a month. Abbreviate up to three letters but spell out the name if it has four letters.

moolah Not *moola*.

moon Generally lowercase. SEE **EARTH, MOON, SUN**.

moon(-) moonbeam, moonlight, moonlit, moonrise, moonscape, moonset, moonshine, moonstone, moonstruck

moose The plural too is *moose*.

moped

more honoured in the breach The line *more honoured in the breach than the observance* from Shakespeare's "Hamlet" refers to a custom that is *better* broken than observed. It does not mean a rule that is *more often* broken than observed.

more than, over Prefer *more than*: *There were more than 20,000 people at the game.* | *The job will cost more than Rs 1,000.* But: *She is over 18, not She is more than 18.*

The phrase *more than* is useful in many contexts but is sometimes opinionated. *More than Rs 5 crore* may seem to suggest that the sum is much larger than Rs 5 crore. *About Rs 5 crore* is more neutral.

more than one Though plural in meaning, the phrase takes a singular verb: *More than one reporter is working on the story*. The verb becomes plural in constructions like these: *More than one of the reporters are working on the story*. | *More reporters than one are working on the story*.

morning-after pill

mortgage

mortuary Not *morgue*.

mosquito(es)

mother Cap when it substitutes for a proper name: *I called Mother just before she and Father were to leave for London*. Cap also when it serves as a religious title directly before a name: *Mother Teresa*.

Describe a woman as a *mother* or *grandmother* only when the description is relevant to the story. The test is: If it were a man, would you have described him as a *father* or *grandfather*?

mother(-) motherboard, motherhouse, motherland

mother country, Mother Nature, mother of vinegar, mother tongue

mother-in-law, mother-naked, mother-of-pearl

Mother's Day The second Sunday in May.

motocross Not *motorcross*.

motor(-) motorbike, motorboat, motorcade, motorcar, motorcycle, motorman

motor drive, motor home, motor pool, motor scooter, motor ship, motor vehicle

motto(es)

Mount Fuji, Fujiyama Not *Mount Fujiyama*, because *-yama* means *mountain*.

mourn Write *Fans mourned Michael Jackson*, not *Fans mourned Michael Jackson's death*.

mouse potato A person who spends a great deal of time using a computer.

moustache is the British spelling; the American spelling is *mustache*.

mouthpiece

mouthwatering

movable

move to Avoid this phrase. It is often used to give a spurious sense of physical action when in fact the only action has been verbal: *Clinton moved to head off congressional opposition to his budget plans when he said ...*

moviemaker

mow down Not *mow into,* as in *The bus mowed into a crowd, killing seven people. Mow* does not mean *ram,* it means *kill*; *ram into* is fine.

MP Member of Parliament. Do not write *Lok Sabha MP* or *Raya Sabha MP*. A person can be a *Lok Sabha member*, not a *Lok Sabha member of Parliament*.

mph Miles per hour. Prefer *kmph* or *kilometres per hour*. Convert miles to kilometres.

MP3, MP3 player

Mr, Mrs, Ms, Miss Use in direct quotations only. When a person's gender is not clear from the first name or the story's context, indicate the gender by using *he* or *she* in a subsequent reference.

MRI Magnetic resonance imaging.

MSP Minimum support price.

mufti Muslim legal expert; cap when using as a title before a name. Also an old-fashioned word for civilian clothes worn by military or police staff.

mugging An assault in a public place, with an intent to rob.

Mughal, mogul Use *Mughal* for the dynasty that ruled India from the 16th to the 19th century. Use *mogul* when you mean a rich and powerful person: *media mogul*, *movie mogul*.

Muhammad Use this spelling for the Prophet Muhammad. The word is also a common Muslim name with various spellings. Use the spelling preferred by the person concerned. In India, the prevalent spelling is *Mohammed*, often shortened to *Mohd* at the beginning of a name. Do not make it *Md*. In the US, *Mohammed* is the usual spelling for the prophet's name.

Muharram The first month of the Islamic calendar. The 10th day of the month is the martyrdom day of Husayn, the grandson of the Prophet Muhammad and the third imam of the Shias, who was brutally killed on the battlefield of Karbala. Shias *observe* the day as Muharram or Ashura. Never write *Muharram was celebrated*.

mujahideen (people fighting a jihad) is plural. The singular is *mujahid*.

mull (ponder) is often used without *over*, especially in headlines. Dictionaries prefer the form with *over*. Use *mull over* in copy; in headlines *mull* is fine.

"Editors now generally accept mull without over. Not my style: when conveying a message of 'thinking long and hard,' pulling my chin, going 'Hmmmmm,' I would never use the clipped form; it goes counter to the meaning of 'examining in detail,' and the word picture loses the turning, stirring connotation."
— William Safire, author and columnist, in New York Times

Do not write *mull to*, as in *The government is mulling to cut taxes*.

multi(-) multicultural, multiculturalism, multidisciplinary, multifaceted, multifarious, multilateral, multilingual, multimedia, multimillionaire, multinational, multiparty, multiplet, multiplex, multiprocessor, multipurpose, multistage, multitasking

multi-crore, multi-ethnic, multi-institutional, multi-user, multi-utility

multiple organ failure Also *multi-organ failure*.

multiplication sign Use lowercase x: *2* x *5*, not *2* X *5*.

Mumbaikar

mumbo jumbo

murder, killing, homicide *Murder* is the unlawful and malicious or premeditated killing of one human being by another. It can also be a killing done while committing another crime, like robbery or rape. Every killing is not a murder; stick to *killing* unless the word *murder* has been used by police in a criminal charge or trial. *Homicide* is the general legal term for the killing of one human being by another. *Manslaughter* is the term used in

English or American law for what is called *culpable homicide not amounting to murder* in Indian law; it is homicide without malice aforethought.

SEE ALSO **ASSASSIN, KILLER, MURDERER** | **ASSASSINATE, ASSASSINATION** | **EXECUTE, EXECUTION**.

murmur

Murphy's law It says: If anything can go wrong, it will.

Muslim A follower of Islam. Do not use *Moslem*.

mute Someone who cannot speak. Do not use *dumb*.

SEE ALSO **DEAF** | **DISABILITIES** | **HANDICAPPED** | **IMPAIRED**.

mutual describes a reciprocal relationship between two people or things: *mutual admiration*; *the feeling is mutual*. Except in established idioms, like *mutual friend* or *mutual fund*, it does not mean merely *shared*.

MW (megawatt) Caps; *mw* is wrong, whereas *mW* means *milliwatt*.

Myanmar Not *Burma*. But for the people, use *Burmese*.

myself SEE **(-)SELF, (-)SELVES**.

***

Her journalism, like a diamond, will sparkle more if it is cut.
— **Raymond Mortimer,** commenting about Susan Sontag

N

Nafta North American Free Trade Agreement.

naive, naively, naivety British English prefers *naivety*; American English *naiveté*.

NAMES

Generally, follow the spelling preferred by the individual or organization whose name is being used. Consult official documents or websites.

Use a person's full name — given name or initials and surname — in first reference. In subsequent references, use the surname. But use the first name in subsequent references if the use of surname can cause confusion, especially if the story has too many people with common surnames like Singh.

Make an exception to the rule of using the full name in first reference only if it is known that a person prefers to be identified by a single name.

Separate initials with spaces: *V P Singh* (not *VP Singh*). Do not separate initials with spaces if the initials are used in place of the full name in copy or headlines: *VP*, *LK*, *MGR*, *IGI*, *LA*. Do not use full stops in initials. Leave out middle initials: *Colin Powell*, not *Colin L Powell*. The name of the 43rd US president is written as *George W Bush* to distinguish him from his father.

When the name of a company or organization does not indicate what it makes or does, the story should. For names of people, companies and places, SEE **APPENDIX 1: LISTS OF NAMES**.

Many Indian celebrities, looking for better luck, change the spellings of their names on the advice of numerologists. Always check and be consistent.

When in doubt about a foreign name not listed in this style guide, follow the AP spelling.

The following is a brief account of the special characteristics of names in different parts of the world:

Arab names

Although Arabic has only three vowels — a, i and u — all of which can be lengthened, it has several consonants that have no equivalents in English. There are two kinds of *s*, *d* and *t*, and two glottal sounds. This means a name can be transliterated in many different ways. For consistency, choose a spelling that is widely accepted and stick to it.

This general principal followed by AP may be useful: Use an English spelling that approximates the way a name sounds in Arabic.

Arab names commonly have two or three parts. In first reference, follow the individual's preference. In subsequent references, use only the final name.

Note that in some parts of the Arab world, French rather than English transliterations are used. For example, *Rashid* becomes *Rachid* in Algeria and Egyptian film director Youssef Chahine, credited with launching the career of Omar Sharif, uses a French spelling instead of the English transliteration *Shaheen*.

al- means *the*. It can occur in as diverse forms as *as-*, *ash-*, *ad-* or *ul-*; these can be safely written as *al-*. In names of individuals, *al-* is not capped (Bashir al-Assad) and can be dropped after first mention (Assad). In names of places, it can be dropped altogether.

Some Arabs, including Syrians and Egyptians, prefer to use *el-* in place of *al-*. *Allah* (al-Lah; literally, *the God*) is written as one word and capped.

abdul means *slave of* and so cannot correctly be used on its own. There are standard combinations — *slave of the merciful one*, *slave of the generous one*, etc — all of which indicate that the person is a servant of God. In transliteration, *abd* (slave) is lowercase as in *Ahmad abd al-Rahman al-Saqqaf*, except when used at the beginning of a name. Some people, especially in the non-Arab world, use *Abdul* as a name.

abu (father of) and **bin** (son of) are similar. When they appear in the middle of a name they are lowercased and used in combination with the following part of the name, as in *Faisal abu Ahmadal-Saqqaf*, *Faisal bin Ahmad al-Saqqaf*. Some Arabs run *abd* or *abu* into the following word, as in *Abdelrahman Munif*.

Use *Muhammad* for the prophet's name and for most Muhammads living in Arab countries. If someone's preferred spelling is different, respect it: *Mohamed Al Fayed*, *Mohamed ElBaradei*. The spelling *Mohammed* is considered archaic and disrespectful by many Muslims in Britain but is widely used in India and the US.

Burmese names

A Burmese name typically includes a courtesy title: *U* for a man, *Daw* for a married woman, *Mah* for an unmarried woman, and *Maung* or *Ko* for a young man or a boy. In first reference, if a government or military title is used, the courtesy title is dropped. For example: *Gen Than Shwe*. After first mention: *Than Shwe*.

Aung San Suu Kyi, the Nobel laureate, gets her name from three relatives: *Aung San* from her father, *Kyi* from her mother and *Suu* from her grandmother. After first mention, she is called Suu Kyi.

Dot not use the courtesy titles. An exception: U Thant (third secretary general of the UN) is so called even after first mention.

Chinese names

The system in vogue for rendering Chinese names and words into English is Pinyin, published by the Chinese government in 1958. Following the adoption of this system, *Peking* became *Beijing* and *Mao Tse-tung* changed to Mao *Zedong*.

Note that Chinese names are written with the surname first. Hence, Hu Jintao is Hu in subsequent references.

Mainland China: Names are in two parts. Examples: *Mao Zedong*, *Zhou Enlai*, *Jiang Zemin*.

Hong Kong and Taiwan: Names are in two parts, with the second part hyphenated. Examples: *Tung Chee-hwa*, *Chiang Kai-shek*, *Ma Ying-jeou*. When a building, park or something else is named after a person, the name becomes three parts, as in *Chiang Kai Shek Cultural Centre*.

Dutch names

In Dutch names, a surname is often preceded by a particle like *van*, *de* or *der*, or sometimes two of these. In the Netherlands, the particles are not capped: *Frederique van der Wal*, *Simon van der Meer*, *Abraham Benjamin de Villiers*. When a Dutch name is cited alone, the particles, if any, are almost always included (*van de Meer*) unlike what usually happens in German, French and Spanish. In South African names, the particles are sometimes capped.

Write *Van Gogh* when just the surname is used (as in *a Van Gogh masterpiece*) but *van Gogh* with the given name (as in *a masterpiece by Vincent van Gogh*).

French names

French surnames are sometimes preceded by particles: *de*, *d'* or *du*. When a surname is cited alone, the particle is usually dropped. But there are exceptions like *de Gaulle* (for Charles de Gaulle) and *de Beauvoir* (for Simone de Beauvoir).

German names

German surnames are sometimes preceded by the particle *von* or *van* in a family of Dutch origin. When the surname is cited alone, the particle is usually dropped. Thus the composer Ludwig van Beethoven is *Beethoven*, not *van Beethoven*.

Indonesian names
Many Indonesians have just one name: *Sukarno*, *Suharto* (do not use the spellings *Soekarno* or *Soeharto*). For those who have their names in two or three parts, the practice regarding which part of the name should be used after first reference varies: Susilo Bambang Yudhoyono is *Yudhoyono* after first mention but Megawati Sukarnoputri is *Megawati*.

Japanese names
As in western and most of the Indian names, the given name comes first, followed by the surname.

Korean names
Like Hong Kong and Taiwan names, Korean names are in two parts, with the second part hyphenated: *Kim Jong-il*, *Kim Dae-jung*, *Ban Ki-moon*.

Malaysian and Singaporean names
In Muslim Malay names, the given name generally comes first. It is the given name that is used after first mention. Therefore, Mahathir Mohamad is *Mahathir* and Anwar Ibrahim is *Anwar* after first mention. But there are exceptions: Abdullah Ahmad Badawi is *Badawi* after first mention. Always check.

The names of Chinese-origin Malaysians, like Chinese-origin Singaporeans, are in three parts: *Kong Cho Ha*, *Chor Chee Heung*. After first mention: *Kong*, *Chor*.

Portuguese and Brazilian names
In Portuguese and Brazilian names, the given name is followed by the mother's family name, which is followed by the father's family name (just the reverse of the Spanish practice): *José Dias Coelho*, *Luís Filipe Madeira Caeiro Figo*, *José Manuel Durão Barroso*.

After first mention, use only the father's family name, unless the person prefers or is widely known by a multiple last name.

Some Portuguese use *e* (for *and*) between the two names: *Miguel Horta e Costa*. After first mention: *Horta e Costa*.

When a surname is preceded by *da*, *do*, *dos* or *das*, include it in subsequent references: Andres Varela da Costa would be *da Costa* after first mention.

Russian names
Names that have become famous in English should retain their familiar forms: *Peter the Great*, not *Pyotr*; *Tchaikovsky*, not *Chaikovsky*; *Rachmaninoff*, not *Rakhmaninov*.

Generally, Russian names with the *sky* ending are so spelled, unlike similar-sounding names in Polish, which end in *ski* (Jaruzelski). Many Russian surnames end in *ov* or *ev*, not in *off* or *eff*.

If a person has a preference for an English spelling that is different from the one that would result from transliteration, follow the person's preference. Russian women's surnames generally have an *a* at the end: *Anna Pavlova*, *Valentina*

Tereshkova. But do not put an *a* at the end of the surname if a woman appears in the story as the wife of a leading figure: *Raisa Gorbachev*, *Svetlana Medvedev*.

Spanish names
They are generally in three parts: given name, father's family name, mother's family name (just the reverse of the Portuguese practice): *Penélope Cruz Sánchez*, *Xavier Hernández Creus*, *Rafael Nadal Parera*. After first reference, use only the father's family name unless the individual prefers or is widely known by a multiple name. Some people use *y* (for *and*) between the mother's family name and the father's family name: *José Ortega y Gasset*. After first mention: *Ortega y Gasset*.

Some Spaniards join their two surnames with a hyphen: *Arantxa Sanchez-Vicario*.

Some Spanish names can be very long. For instance, Pablo Picasso was named *Pablo Diego José Francisco de Paula Juan Nepomuceno María de los Remedios Cipriano de la Santísima Trinidad Martyr Patricio Clito Ruiz y Picasso*, in honour of various saints and relatives. In such cases, stick to the familiar two-word name.

Thai names
Given name comes before surname: *Thaksin Shinawatra*, *Samak Sundaravej*. But after first mention, given name is used: *Thaksin left the country*. | *Samak reshuffled his cabinet*.

Vietnamese names
A Vietnamese name typically consists of the family name followed by two given names. For example, *Nguyen Tan Dung*. After first mention, *Dung*. An exception: *Ho Chi Minh* (*Ho* after first mention).

nano(-) Prefix meaning *one-billionth of a unit*, as in *nanosecond*, *nanotechnology*.

naphtha Not *naptha*.

narcoanalysis Not *narco-analysis*.

narrow-minded

Nasa Acceptable even in first reference to the National Aeronautics and Space Administration of the US.

Nasdaq The largest electronic screen-based stock market is known by this name, no longer spelled out as National Association of Securities Dealers Automated Quotations system.

nation Reserve the word for a group of people united by language, culture or history. In other contexts, use *country*.

national Use *citizen*, if that is the intended meaning.

national anthem(s) Lowercase this term, but cap the principal words of the anthem's name and put them in quotation marks: "Jana Gana Mana". Do not italicize.

National Assembly Pakistani parliament.

National Centre for Disease Control Earlier known as National Institute of Communicable Diseases.

National Commission for Protection of Child Rights

National Commission for Women Not *National Women's Commission*.

National Highways Authority of India

National Institutes of Health Note the plural in the name of this US agency.

National Investigation Agency For short, *NIA*.

nationwide One word. The term *nationwide broadcast* is rarely necessary. When a head of state or government appears on television or radio you can safely assume the broadcast is nationwide.

Nativity Cap when the reference is to the birth of Jesus.

Nato Acceptable even in first reference to the North Atlantic Treaty Organization.

natural parents Use *biological parents* or *birth parents* to avoid a suggestion that adoptive parenthood is unnatural. Mention adoptive status only when it is relevant. Similarly, *biological family* or *birth family*, not *natural family* or *real family*.

naught means *nothing*; **nought** means the figure *0*. Things come to *naught*, not to *a naught*.

nauseated, nauseous People are *nauseated* when they feel sick, and things that make them feel sick are *nauseous*: *The ride is nauseous; the rider is nauseated*. Sticklers insist that *nauseous* should not be used to mean *nauseated*.

Nauseous, however, is widely used to mean *nauseated*. Dictionaries recognize the use of *nauseous* in this sense. However, it is better to avoid *nauseous* altogether so as not to cause confusion. Use *nauseated* to mean *experiencing nausea* and *nauseating* to mean *causing nausea*.

nautical mile A nautical mile equals about 6,076 feet, or 1,852 metres. The term *mile*, without a modifier, usually means the *statute mile*, which equals 5,280 feet, or about 1,609 metres.

Navaratra But *Navratri* in reference to the festivities in Gujarat. Do not write *Navaratras*.

nave (the long central part of a church), **knave** (the jack in a pack of cards)

navratna Lowercase; status conferred on public sector companies by the government. Similarly, *maharatna*, *miniratna*.

navy Cap in references to the Indian Navy. SEE ALSO **ARMY**.

navy blue No hyphen.

NAVY RANKS SEE **MILITARY RANKS**.

Naxalism, Naxalite Cap. Do not use *Naxal* for *Naxalite*. Will you write *Mao* for *Maoist*?

Nazi Cap. But lowercase *nazism*.

NE Headline shorthand for the northeastern region of India. No hyphen.

Neanderthal Not *Neandertal*.

near, near to Do not use *to* except in contexts like these: *She was near to crying*. | *She was near to tears*. | *We came near to being killed*. | *The support the team got was near to hysteria*. | *The two banks were near to a merger deal*.

near(-) nearby (adjective and adverb), nearsighted, nearsightedness

near at hand, near collision, near disaster, near escape, near miss

near-term (adjective)

nearly tends to magnify an amount: *nearly Rs 1 lakh*. And *less than* tends to minimize the sum: *less than Rs 1 lakh*. A more neutral alternative is *about*, as in *about Rs 1 lakh*.

nearsighted is American English; *shortsighted* is British.

necessary, necessity

neck and neck Hyphenate only when it is used as a modifier before a noun: *It's a neck-and-neck race*, but *the race is neck and neck*. Do not write *neck to neck*.

need (noun) can be an uncountable noun or a countable noun. In sentences like these, it is an uncountable noun; it does not take a plural form and is not preceded by *a*: *There is need to consider all options*. | *There is need to build a police organization with a new code of ethics and behaviour*. | *The house is in need of a thorough clean*.

Need is also used as a countable noun; it takes a plural form or is preceded by *a*: *satisfy a need*; *meet children's special needs*.

NEGATIVES

These can be troublesome; for instance, if the word *not* is dropped or mutilated to *now*. Try to avoid using *not* when other forms can be found: *decided against* rather than *decided not to*, *unnecessary* rather than *not necessary*. *He declined to comment* rather than *He would not comment*.

negligee Woman's nightgown.

Negro(es) Do not use except in historical contexts.

neither, neither ... nor SEE **EITHER, EITHER ... OR**.

neo(-) neoconservative, neocon, neoliberal, neonatal

Nepalese Not *Nepali*, except in names like Nepali Congress.

nerve-racking Not *nerve-wracking*.

nest egg Money that a person has saved for a future purpose, often for retirement.

net The word is used to refer to earnings, income, profit or revenue after taxes or other costs are taken away. The opposite is *gross*. Be specific.

net, the Lowercase; the internet.

netbook SEE **NOTEBOOK, NETBOOK**.

Netherlands, the

net worth (noun) Not *networth*.

neutron

nevertheless Similarly, *nonetheless*.

new Often redundant, as in *Company announces it will build a new plant*. By definition, any plant being built must be new.

new(-) newborn, newcomer, newfangled, newfound

new-fashioned

new blood

New Delhi, Delhi In datelines, use *New Delhi*, not *Delhi*. Also, use *New Delhi*, not *Delhi*, when the name of the capital substitutes for *India*.

New England Region in US northeast comprising Connecticut, Maine, Massachusetts, New Hampshire, Rhode Island and Vermont.

New Jersey, New Orleans Do not drop *New* in headlines.

newlywed

news(-) newsboy, newscast, newsdealer, newsgroup, newshawk, newshound, newsletter, newsmagazine, newsmaker, newsman, newsmonger, newspaper, newspaperman, newspaperwoman, newspeople, newsprint, newsreader, newsreel, newsroom, newsstand, newsweekly, newswoman, newsworthy

news agency, news agent, news conference, news desk, news gathering, news release, news report, news service, news writer, news writing

news conference Use this phrase rather than *press conference*, which implies exclusion of the non-print media.

newsmen, newspersons, correspondents, scribes Use *reporters*.

NEWSPAPER NAMES SEE **PERIODICAL NAMES**.

New Year's Day, New Year's Eve Also: *New Year* (the holiday, not the 12-month period), *Chinese New Year*, *Parsi New Year.*

next of kin

niece

night Generally, the phrase is *at night*, as in *Most of us sleep at night*. Use *in the night* or *in the middle of the night* if the action you are referring to occurred at a particular time during night, as in *The rain came in the night*. You can write *at the dead of night* or *in the dead of night*.

night(-) nightcap, nightclothes, nightclub, nightdress, nightfall, nightgown, nightmare, nightshade, nightshirt, nighttime, nightwatchman

night blindness, night life, night light, night owl, night school

one-night stand

nightlong One word.

NIH National Institutes (not *Institute*) of Health, a US agency.

nimby Lowercase. Acronym for *not in my backyard*. The term is used to describe opposition to a new project by residents, even if they themselves and those around will benefit from the construction. *Nimby* and its derivatives like *nimbyism* and *nimbyist* are applied to opponents of a development project, implying that they have narrow, selfish or myopic views.

nincompoop

ninety

nip and tuck A facelift. It also means *neck and neck,* as in *The presidential contest is nip and tuck.*

Nip/Tuck An Emmy and Golden Globe award-winning American television medical drama series.

nitpicking (noun), **nit-pick** (verb)

nitty-gritty is slang and overworked. Never write *nitty-gritties*.

n.o. for *not out* in cricket; to avoid confusion with *no*, use full stops.

No. for *number*; to avoid confusion with *no*, use a full stop. Use it only before figures, as in *No. 1*, *No. 2;* do not use it as a stand-alone substitute for *number*.

Noah's Ark (not *Arc*) in reference to the large vessel built by Noah at God's command; *ark* means *vessel*. Noah's Arc is an American TV series.

Nobel prize Nobel peace prize, Nobel prize for literature, Nobel prize for physics.

NOBILITY SEE **ROYALTY, NOBILITY**.

no-brainer Something so obvious or simple that you do not need a brain to know it.

no-fly zone

no-frills As in *a no-frills airline* or *a no-frills hotel*.

noisome (offensive, very unpleasant, as in *noisome smells*), **noisy** (clamorous)

nolo contendere (Latin for "I do not wish to contest") In US law, a plea by which a defendant in a criminal case does not make a defence but does not admit guilt either. The effect is the same as with a plea of guilty. But the defendant is not prevented from denying the same charge in another proceeding. Terms like *no contest* or *no-contest plea* are acceptable in all references.

no man's land No hyphens. Buffer zone or neutral zone.

nom de guerre An assumed name under which a person engages in combat. For example, Prachanda was the nom de guerre of Pushpa Kamal Dahal, the Nepalese Maoist leader who became prime minister.

nom de plume Pen name.

non(-) In American English, familiar *non-* compounds are generally one word. In British English too, the trend is to write them as one word. Although Concise Oxford Dictionary still hyphenates the following compounds, Collins English Dictionary recommends the fused form without a hyphen. For the moment, we retain the hyphen:

non-acceptance, non-aggression, non-aligned, non-alcoholic, non-appearance, non-bailable, non-being, non-believer, non-binding, non-combatant, non-commissioned officer, non-committal, non-competitive bid, non-completion, non-compliance, non-confrontational, non-cooperation, non-durable, non-existence, non-existent, non-governmental organization, non-interference, non-issue, non-legal, non-partisan, non-payment, non-productive, non-profit, non-proliferation, non-resident, non-standard, non-stop, non-violence, non-violent

The following are not hyphenated in either variety of English:

nonconformist, nondescript, nonentity, nonpareil

Compounds formed with proper names or not-so-familiar compounds are hyphenated in either variety of English:

non-American, non-Indian

non-contributory pension plan, non-cumulative preferred stock, non-current asset, non-cyclical stock, non-negotiable, non-nuclear, non-person, non-refundable, non-starter, non-use

nonagenarian

Non-Aligned Movement *NAM* is acceptable in subsequent references.

nonetheless One word. Similarly, *nevertheless*.

no-no

no-nonsense

nonplussed is the British spelling; *nonplused* is American.

non-profit Prefer to *not-for-profit*.

non sequitur (a conclusion that does not follow from the premises) No hyphen; *sequitur*, not *sequitar*.

noon Do not write *12 noon*; *noon* alone is sufficient. Do not use *12pm*; it often causes confusion.

no one is singular. Do not write *no-one*.

nor means *and not*, so it should not be preceded by *and*.

Nordic countries Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway and Sweden. Scandinavia comprises only Denmark, Norway and Sweden. To avoid confusion, list the countries later even if you use *Nordic* or *Scandinavian* in an intro for the sake of brevity.

normality, normalcy Both mean the same thing. Although some stylebooks and dictionaries insist on *normality*, *normalcy* is perfectly normal.

north Cap only when it is part of a proper name, as in *North Korea*. Lowercase in references to the northern parts of a country.

northeast Lowercase in references to the northeastern parts of a country.

north pole Lowercase.

northwest Lowercase in references to the northwestern parts of a country.

nosedive One word.

nosy Not *nosey*.

notable

notebook, netbook Apart from its conventional meaning of *a book used for writing or taking notes*, *notebook* now also means *a small laptop computer*. A *netbook* is a smaller laptop with less memory.

noted Avoid. You can *note* only established facts, not claims or opinions.

not guilty, innocent SEE **INNOCENT, NOT GUILTY**.

not only ... but also The words that follow the first part (*not only*) and the second part (*but also*) must be parallel in form. If the first is a noun, the second too should be a noun, and so on. To ensure this, it is important where in the sentence *not only* and *but also* are placed. The desired symmetry is lost

in a sentence like *She not only learned Korean but also Japanese*. Rephrase it to *She learned not only Korean but also Japanese*.

The *also* in the construction is generally preferred, but may be omitted if a term like *even* or *as well* provides the balance or the second part of the sentence describes an action more sweeping than the first: *The workers want not only a pay increase but reduced hours as well.* | *The song is popular not only in the north, but nationwide*.

not to, to not Use *not to*: *He decided not to touch a cigarette again*. Do not write *He decided to not touch a cigarette again*. Remember Shakespeare's line: "To be, or not to be: that is the question."

SEE ALSO **SPLIT INFINITIVE**.

notwithstanding

nought, naught SEE **NAUGHT, NOUGHT**.

novelist Single *l* in both British English and American English.

nowadays One word.

NSG National Security Guard (not *Guards*).

Nuclear Suppliers Group No apostrophe in *suppliers*.

SEE ALSO **POSSESSIVES**.

nucleus (singular), **nuclei** (plural)

nuisance

NUMBERED EXPRESSIONS

A designation consisting of a noun and a numeral is capped as a proper name: *Article 19*, *Class X*, *Day 1*, *Flight 306*, *Page 1*, *Phase 2*, *Room 512*, *Route 417*, *Section 144*, *Terminal II*.

numberplate One word.

NUMBERS

Spell out from *one* to *nine*. Also spell out *first*, *second*, *third* up to *ninth*. Use figures for numbers above nine.

Exceptions:

— Spell out numbers, even 10 or above, at the beginning of a sentence.

— Use figures for all numbers in headlines and graphics, but in headlines write *one* rather than *1*.

— Use figures for sums of money: *Rs 2 crore, $3 million*.

— Use figures for days of the month: *July 2, 2008*.

— Use figures for degrees of temperature even below 10: *2 degrees celsius* or *2°C,* not *two degrees celsius.* But spell out rise or fall in temperature up to nine degrees: *The temperature rose by five degrees on Monday*.

— Use figures for percentages: *2%, 6%*.

— Numbers that include decimals can be expressed only in figures: *3.2, 6.5.*

— Use figures for ages of people.

— Use figures for results of voting and court rulings.

— Use figures for building numbers.

— Use figures for latitudes and longitudes.

— Use figures for dimensions, measurements, weights and proportions when they consist of two or more elements. For example, *He is 5 feet 9 inches*.

— Use figures in numbered expressions: *Article 19, Day 1, Flight 306, Class X, Page 1*.

— Use figures for sports points, scores and times.

Even in the middle of a sentence, spell out numbers used figuratively: *Let a thousand flowers bloom*. | *May you live to be a hundred*. | *There are a thousand ways of doing it*. | *I wish I had a million dollars*.

In sums of money when a range is given, repeat the words like *lakh*, *crore* and *million*: *Rs 10 million to Rs 20 million*, not *Rs 10 to 20 million*. Do not hyphenate the simple modifier form: *$20 billion deal*, *Rs 20 crore scheme*; not *$20-billion deal*, *Rs 20-crore scheme*. But hyphenate when the currency's name is spelled out: 20-*billion-dollar deal, 15-crore-rupee contract.*

When using the words *thousand*, *lakh*, *crore*, *million*, etc, spell out figures up to nine: *two thousand*, *five lakh*, *six crore*, *three million*, *five billion*.

If a series contains parallel items including some numbers below 10 and some above 10, for consistency use only figures: *5 girls and 10 boys*. However, spell out *one,* if it has been used as a pronoun: *He is one of the 10 students in his class.*

When talking of a rise or a fall, do not put a comma between the figures: *The company's net profit rose from Rs 400 crore to Rs 550 crore*. But put a comma when the margin of rise or fall is mentioned: The company's net profit rose by Rs 150 crore, to Rs 550 crore.

Use figures for a thermometer reading: *20°C* (in headlines and charts) and *20 degrees celsius* (in copy). Spell out rise or fall in temperature up to nine

degrees: *The temperature rose by five degrees on Monday*. | *The temperature rose by 12 degrees on Monday*.

In headlines, do not use *1* for *one*: *One killed in accident* rather than *1 killed in accident*; better still, *Man killed in accident* or *Woman killed in accident*. Similarly, instead of *1st*, write *first* in headlines.

Round off figures in headlines. For example, *Sensex rises 550 points* rather than *Sensex rises 549.61 points*. In copy and charts too, round off figures to one decimal point unless accuracy demands otherwise. Beware, in certain contexts rounding off may be misleading. For example, there is a significant difference between *Inflation falls to 4.4%* and *Inflation falls to 4%*. For the same reason, never round off interest rates.

If totals do not add up because of rounding off, this should be explained.

numbskull Not *numskull*.

numerous Prefer *many,* which is shorter and better.

***

Short words are best and the old words when short are best of all.
— **Winston Churchill**

O

oasis Plural *oases*.

OBITUARIES SEE **DEATH AND OBITUARIES**.

object(s) d'art

obligate Use *oblige* instead.

oblivious The traditional meaning is *forgetful* or *unmindful*. In this sense, *oblivious* is followed by *of* and you can only be oblivious of something you once knew: *Oblivious of his vow, he started drinking again.* However, the prevalent meaning of the word today is *unaware of*, *unconscious of* or *indifferent to*. In this sense, it can be followed by *of* or *to*: *She became oblivious to what was going on around her*.

Sometimes, the distinction between the two meanings of *oblivious* is blurred: *Oblivious of the danger, he opened the door.*

Many believe that *oblivious to*, more common in American English than in British English, is wrong. But *oblivious to* is now widely used in British English and accepted by Oxford Dictionary of English, Collins English Dictionary and Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English, among others.

OBSCENITIES
Use them only if they are in direct quotes and if the story would be seriously weakened by their omission. Do not quote mindless obscenities. Consider allowing them only when people prominent in public life use them in a context

that gives their remarks great emphasis or puts their fitness to hold office in question. Always consult the editor before allowing an obscenity in the paper.

If these are to be used at all, write them with asterisks: *f***, f***ing, c***, s****.

observer(s) The word is often a mask for *reporter(s)*. Use a more specific and convincing phrase. If you actually mean *reporter(s)*, say so outright.

obsolescent, obsolete If something is obsolescent it is on the way to becoming obsolete.

obtuse (mentally slow or emotionally insensitive), **abstruse** (difficult to understand)

occasion

occur, occurred, occurrence

occur, take place Prefer *occur* for accidents or chance happenings and *take place* for scheduled events.

ocean The five oceans in descending order of size are Pacific Ocean, Atlantic Ocean, Indian Ocean, Antarctic (or Southern) Ocean and Arctic Ocean. Lowercase *ocean* standing alone or in plural uses.

oceangoing

o'clock No space between *o'* and *clock* but a space between the figure and *o'clock: 5 o'clock, 9 o'clock*. Otherwise, *o'* as a contraction of *of* should be followed by a space: *a couple o' times*.

octogenarian Two *o*'s. Do not write *octagenarian*.

octopus(es)

odd(-) odd-looking, odd-numbered

(-)odd 50-odd, 100-odd

odd lot An amount smaller than the usual unit of trading; specifically, a quantity of less than 100 shares of stock in a transaction. The opposite is a round lot, which is exactly 100 shares.

Odisha Not *Orissa*, except in historical references. Use *Odia*, not *Oriya*, for the language and the people. The high court remains Orissa high court.

oedipal complex The female equivalent is *electra complex*.

of Avoid disrupting the flow of phrases connected by *of*. *He died of heart failure on Monday* is smoother than *He died on Monday of heart failure*.

of all time Avoid expressions like *best cricketer of all time*, *best actor of all time*.

of course is set off by a comma — or a pair of commas if it comes in the middle of a sentence — when it is used as an aside meaning *obviously* or *expectedly*: *Tendulkar, of course, played well.* When the use is emphatic, no comma is required: *Do you love me? Of course I do.*

off(-) offbeat, offhand, offline, offset, offshoot, offshore, offside, offspring, offstage

off-centre, off-colour (adjective, before a noun), off-key (adjective, before a noun), off-limits (adjective, before a noun), off-putting, off-road, off-season (noun, adjective and adverb), off-the-shelf, off-track

off key (adjective, after a noun; and adverb), off limits (adjective, after a noun)

(-)off Compounds formed with *-off* are generally one word in American English. In British English, many of them are hyphenated but the trend is to write them as one word. For the moment, we write only the more common among them as one word:

cutoff, layoff, kickoff, logoff, payoff, playoff, selloff

blast-off, break-off, cast-off, face-off, far-off, hands-off, one-off, send-off, rip-off, run-off, show-off, spin-off, stand-off, take-off, tip-off, trade-off, turn-off, write-off

Remember, the compounds are always written as two words when used as verbs.

office bearer But *officeholder*.

OFFICIAL TITLES

Be careful while using idiomatic phrases rather than official titles to describe officials or official bodies. Descriptions like planning chief and watchdog commission may often be necessary in intros where use of the full title would be clumsy. In such cases, put the actual designation later in the story. Do not use idioms with pejorative overtones; for example, *trade union boss*.

SEE ALSO **TITLES**.

offspring The plural too is *offspring*.

oh Not *O*. The interjection *O*, always capped, should be confined to quotations from classical texts. *Oh* should be capped only at the beginning of a sentence. It may be directly followed by a comma at the beginning or in the middle of a sentence but then an exclamation mark is usually needed at the end of the sentence.

oil(-) oilcan, oilcloth, oilcup, oilfield, oilskin, oilstove

oil burner, oil colour, oil painting, oil shale, oil well

OIL STATISTICS

A barrel of oil is equivalent to 159 litres. One barrel per day (bpd) of crude oil production is equivalent to about 50 tonnes a year. Oil production and export figures are usually expressed in barrels per day (bpd), although they are sometimes quoted also in tonnes per year. Convert tonnes per year to barrels per day by dividing by 50. As with all conversions, give an approximate conversion of an approximate figure and do not convert to more decimal places than are given in the original figure. The Opec conversion factor is 7.4 barrels per tonne.

SEE ALSO **BARREL** | **GALLON**.

OK Do not write *okay*. Even *OK* should be reserved for features and informal contexts. Do not use it as a verb except in a direct quotation. Verb forms are *OKs*, *OK'd* and *OK'ing*. These are best avoided except in direct quotes.

old(-) old-boy (adjective), old-fangled, old-fashioned, old-school (adjective), old-timer, old-world (adjective meaning *belonging to past times*)

Old World (noun meaning *the world known before the discovery of the Americas*)

Old City The walled part of Delhi. Also the walled part of Jerusalem.

older, oldest; elder, eldest SEE **ELDER, ELDEST; OLDER, OLDEST**.

old masters Lowercase. The great artists before the 18th century.

Olympic Games or just *Olympics*. In subsequent references, *the games*. Always cap *Olympics* or *Olympic*.

omelette is the British spelling; *omelet* is American.

omission

OMISSION OF WORDS

Indicate the omission of words from a quoted passage by using an ellipsis (three full stops with space before and after): *We will fight ... and we will win*. If the words omitted come at the end of a sentence and are followed by another sentence, the word after the ellipsis is capped: *We will fight and we will win ... We will never surrender.*

Drop words in this way only if the deletion does not alter the sense of the quote.

SEE ALSO **ELLIPSIS**.

on again, off again Hyphenate when the phrase precedes a noun, as in *an on-again-off-again plan*. Otherwise, no hyphens: *the plan was on again, off again*. The comma between the two parts of the phrase is sometimes omitted.

once Compound adjectives formed with *once* are not hyphenated: *once famous dancer, once celebrated musician*.

once-over Quick appraisal.

one In first-person pieces, avoid *one* as a synonym of *I*. Note also that first-person writing is resorted to in news columns only as an exception.

one(-) oneupmanship

one-dimensional, one-horse (adjective meaning *petty* or *inferior*), one-liner, one-off, one-on-one (adjective, before a noun), one-piece (adjective), one-shot, one-sided, one-stop, one-to-one (adjective, before a noun), one-way

one on one (adverb), one to one (adverb)

one another, each other SEE **EACH OTHER, ONE ANOTHER**.

one-day international (cricket) Lowercase; do not write *One-day international*. British and Australian newspapers including Guardian, Times (London), Daily Telegraph, Independent, Sydney Morning Herald and Age do not cap it. Terms like *one-day captain* and *one-day team* too are fine as the meaning is clear from the context. For variation, use *ODI* as a noun or a modifier.

one in, one of, one out of Should a phrase like *one in five*, *one of five* or *one out of five* take a singular verb or a plural one? Some say the verb should be governed by *one* and hence it should be singular (Garner's Modern American Usage, Usage & Abusage by Eric Partridge). Others argue that the phrase is plural in essence; it is a ratio corresponding to a group within a population, and does not mean just one person or thing (Guardian stylebook). According to Cambridge Guide to English Usage, plural agreement predominated in data analysed for the Longman Grammar (1999). Use a plural verb; it is more logical.

one of the *One of the reasons for her success* is wordy. Rephrase it to *a reason for her success* or *one reason for her success*.

She is one of the journalists who write (not *writes*) *well*. The subject is *journalists*, not *one*.

one or more makes a plural: *one or more areas*, *one or more languages*.

onetime (former), **one-time** (just once)

ongoing Usually tautological (for example, *ongoing crisis*). Use *continuing*, *developing* or *proceeding*.

online One word.

only should preferably go immediately before the word or phrase it qualifies. *Only Jet flies to Dubai on Sunday* means that on a Sunday Jet is the only airline operating to the city. *Jet flies only to Dubai on Sunday* means that on Sunday the only Jet flight operating is to Dubai. *Jet flies to Dubai only on Sunday* means that the airline has only one flight a week to Dubai.

only, itself The two are often wrongly used in Indian writing or speech to put emphasis on a word, as in *He was attacked here itself.* | *I met her last month only*. Rephrase the first sentence to *It was here that he was attacked*. The second sentence can become *I met her only last month* or *It was only last month that I met her*.

onscreen One word when used as an adjective.

onstage (adjective and adverb)

on to, onto Use *onto* if you would use *into* in a similar sentence. For example, *He drove onto the field* because you would write *He drove into the city*. If *on* forms a complete phrase with the previous verb, write *on to* as two words: *He moved on to a new assignment*. A similar example involving *in to*: *He tuned in to Radio Mirchi*.

SEE ALSO **IN, INTO, IN TO**.

Opec Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries. The acronym *Opec* can be used in first reference, preferably with a descriptive tag. But it should be spelled out later in the copy. Opec has 12 members: Algeria, Angola, Ecuador, Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, Libya, Nigeria, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, United Arab Emirates and Venezuela. Angola joined on January 1, 2007. Ecuador returned to Opec after 15 years in October 2007. Indonesia withdrew from Opec in January 2009 after it became a net importer of oil. The headquarters of Opec are in Vienna, Austria.

opencast

ophthalmologist Not *opthalmologist*.

opinion The word can be followed by *about* or *on*: *He gave his opinion about the story*. | *Everyone has an opinion on the subject*.

But you have a high or low opinion *of* somebody or something.

OPINION POLLS AND SURVEYS

In a story about the results of an opinion poll or a sample survey, always mention the name of the organization that conducted the poll or the survey, the size of the sample, and how and where the poll or the survey was carried out. Give the margin of error too.

opossum (also *possum*) A small animal that lives in trees and carries its young in a pouch. It is the only North American marsupial.

When you *play possum*, you feign sleep or death in order to trick somebody.

oppn This abbreviation for *opposition* can be used in headlines. Keep it lowercase, like *govt* for *government*.

opposition, the Lowercase.

oppression

oral, verbal SEE **VERBAL, ORAL**.

ordinance (a decree), **ordnance** (artillery)

organdie is the British spelling; *organdy* is American.

organic growth, inorganic growth Business jargon. Avoid it; if you must use it, explain the meaning in a subsequent sentence.

orient, oriental Lowercase, except as part of a name.

Orissa Use *Odisha*. SEE ALSO **ODISHA**.

Oscar, Oscars SEE **ACADEMY AWARDS**.

others Beware of this word when reporting such things as accidents. It is usually unnecessary, as in *50 people were killed and 200 others injured*. Delete it.

out(-) outback, outbid, outboard, outbound, outbuilding, outclass, outcry, outdated, outdo, outdoor, outfield, outflank, outfox, outgoing, outgrow, outgun, outhouse, outmanoeuvre, outpatient, outspoken

out-and-out, out-of-pocket

(-)out bailout, blackout, breakout, buyout, checkout, dropout, fallout, handout, hideout, knockout, layout, lockout, payout, printout, pullout, sellout, shakeout, shootout, shoutout, sickout, standout, takeout, timeout, tryout, walkout, washout, wipeout

cop-out (noun), fade-out

Remember, the compounds are two words when used as verbs.

outage Jargon for *failure*, *shutdown* or *cutoff* of electricity or water. Use the simpler words.

outcaste (a person who has no caste or has been expelled from his or her caste), **outcast** (a person rejected by his or her society or social group) Note that the meanings overlap; all outcastes are outcasts, but not the other way round.

outed A gay person is *outed*, but a paedophile is *exposed*.

outgoing Use it only in the sense of *friendly* or *genial*, as in *an outgoing personality*. In the sense of *leaving office*, use *departing*.

out of bounds But as a modifier before a noun, *out-of-bounds*: *The town is out of bounds for foreign reporters*. | *This is an out-of-bounds area*.

out of court But as a modifier before a noun, *out-of-court*: *They settled out of court*. | *They went for an out-of-court settlement*.

output (verb) For past tense and past participle, prefer *outputted* to *output*.

outside Never write *outside of*.

outsize Not *outsized*.

Oval Office The oval-shaped office of the US president in the White House. Often used figuratively to represent the position, authority or power of the US president.

over If an activity is finished, you say it is *over*: *The war is over*. | *The Test match is over*. If a commodity is finished, *it has run out* or *you have run out of it*.

over, more than SEE **MORE THAN, OVER**.

over(-) overachieve, overact, overactive, overambitious, overarching, overarm, overbearing, overcharge, overconfidence, overcrowd, overdose, overdraft, overdrive, overindulgence, overreach, overreact, override, overripe, overrule, overrun, oversensitive, overtime

over-the-counter (adjective)

over the counter (adverb)

(-)over changeover, hangover, holdover, makeover, takeover, turnover, walkover (all nouns)

carry-over (noun)

overage (too old) One word. The word has another meaning: *excess* or *surplus*; do not use it in that sense.

overall, over all One word as an adjective, as in *overall winner*, *overall responsibility*. Two words as an adverb, as in *Over all, it's a good strategy*.

One word as a noun meaning *a loose coat*. Also: *overalls* for *dungarees*.

overseas Do not write *overseas* when you mean *foreign*. France is not overseas from Germany but is foreign to Germany.

overshare To divulge excessive personal information in a blog or broadcast interview, prompting reactions ranging from alarmed discomfort to approval.

Oz is fine as a noun or adjective referring to Australia.

***

I don't mind your thinking slowly; I mind your publishing faster than you think.
— **Wolfgang Pauli,** Nobel laureate physicist

P

P Abbreviation of *page*; do not use *Pg*. Give a space between *P* and the number that follows: *P 1*, *P 10*, not *P1*, *P10*.

paan (betel leaves) Not *pan*.

pacemaker

padayatra (not *padyatra*) Italicize or put in quotation marks.

paddler Table tennis player.

Padma Vibhushan, Padma Bhushan, Padma Shri Do not use them as titles before names. Remember, each of these is two words.

paean Song of praise.

paediatric, paediatrician are the British forms; *pediatric* and *pediatrician* are American.

painkiller

PAINTINGS
Put their names in quotation marks and cap the principal words.

paise is the plural of *paisa*.

palaeo(-) is the British spelling, *paleo(-)* is American.

palaeography, palaeolithic, palaeontology, Palaeozoic

palate (part of the mouth), **palette** (an artist's paint board)

pallbearer

Palme d'Or Golden Palm, the highest prize given to a competing film at the Cannes film festival.

pan(-) Prefix meaning *comprising all*. Lowercase and generally hyphenated: *pan-African*, *pan-American*, *pan-German*. But: *pandemic*.

Panchen Lama, the Cap when using it as the name of the titleholder. Lowercase otherwise.

pandemic Global outbreak of disease.

Pandora's box

panel, panelled, panelling

Panjab University Not *Punjab University*.

panjandrum A self-important, pompous person in authority.

panicky

pantsuit

pantyhose

papal Lowercase unless it is part of a name or title.

paparazzi Plural. The singular, *paparazzo*, is considered pretentious in English writing.

paper(-) paperback, paperbound, paperhanger (counterfeiter), paperweight, paperwhite, paperwork

paper clip, paper cutter

papier-mâché

Pap test (or *Pap smear*) A test for cervical or vaginal cancer. Named after its developer, George Papanicolaou, a US anatomist.

par, on a par with, par for the course Stocks trade *at par* (at face value), *above par* or *below par*: *He sold the shares at par*. A person's performance can be *below* or *under par*, or *not up to par*.

When X is at the same level as Y, *X is on a par* (not *on par*) *with Y*.

Par for the course means *normal* or *expected*: *The flight was delayed again, but that is par for the course.*

PARAGRAPHS

There can be no prescribed length for a paragraph, but short paragraphs are preferred in newspaper writing. Remember that enormous paragraphs, especially in a narrow newspaper column, tire readers. Each new paragraph should represent some kind of break, however small, in the continuity of the text. While placing a story on a page, do not merge or break paragraphs in an abrupt fashion.

parallel, paralleled, unparalleled

paramilitary No hyphen.

paraplegia Total or partial paralysis of both legs. Quadriplegia is the paralysis of all four limbs.

Pardo Palace A royal palace on the outskirts of Madrid; the Madrid art gallery is *the Prado*.

pare (peel, trim or cut), **pair** (two)

PARENTHESES SEE **BRACKETS**.

parenting is social service jargon. See if substitutes like *rearing children*, *parenthood* and *being a parent* work.

Parkinson's disease

Parkinson's law It says: Work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion.

parley Avoid this old-fashioned word. Use *talks*, *meeting* or *conference*.

parliamentarian Prefer *member of parliament* or *MP*. In American English, *parliamentarian* also means *an expert on parliamentary procedure*. Avoid using the word in this American sense.

parliamentary

parole, probation *Parole* is a release of a prisoner before the completion of sentence on the condition of good behaviour. *Probation* is a suspension of the sentence of a person who has been sentenced but not yet jailed. A probation too is granted on the condition of good behaviour.

partially, partly *Partially* means *to a limited degree* (as contrasted with *completely*) whereas *partly* connotes *a part and not the whole* (as contrasted with *wholly*). *The building is partly airconditioned* implies that only part of the building was meant to be airconditioned. *The building is partially airconditioned* implies that the airconditioning work has still to be completed.

participate Use the simpler *take part*.

PARTICIPLES AS NOUNS

When a present participle (-ing form of a verb) directly follows a noun or a pronoun, it often plays the role of a noun. In such a case, the previous word should be possessive (*his*, *her*, *women's*).

Opposition leaders complained about the Prime Minister's missing the meeting. (It was the missing they complained about, not the Prime Minister. Hence, the possessive.)

Doctors advise against pregnant women's smoking. (The advice is against smoking, not pregnant women. Hence the possessive.)

Sometimes a sentence works without a possessive: *He saw the bus hitting a pedestrian*. In fact, *bus's hitting a pedestrian* would be awkward.

partner An appropriate noun for an unmarried companion of the same sex or the opposite sex. But if there is ambiguity and *partner* could also imply *a business partner*, use *companion*. As a verb, *partner* is best kept for dancing contexts. For other alliances, *team up* or *form a partnership* is better.

part time (noun and adverb), **part-time** (adjective)

partway Adverb. To some point, degree or extent.

party The expression *throw a party* has become trite; *give*, *hold*, *organize* or *sponsor a party* is better. Also, avoid *party* as a verb except in light or joking contexts.

Pashtuns (not *Pushtuns* or *Pushtoons*) The biggest ethnic group in Afghanistan. The language of Pashtuns is Pashto.

pass(-) passbook, passkey, passport, password

pass-fail, pass-through

pass code

passerby, passersby No hyphen.

past, last SEE **LAST, PAST**.

pasteurize

pastime

PAST TENSE AND PAST PARTICIPLE FORMS

There are some verbs whose past tense and past participle can have either an *-ed* ending or a *-t* ending. Use the *-ed* form: *burned, dreamed, leaned*, *leaped, learned, smelled, spelled, spilled, spoiled, wreaked*. Exception: *knelt*.

PAST TENSE VS PRESENT PERFECT TENSE

If you are not specifying *when*, use the present perfect tense for events in the recent past: *The RBI has increased the repo rate*. But: *The RBI increased the repo rate on Thursday* or *last week*.

The use of the past tense for the present perfect tense is an American practice. An American says, "Honey, I shrunk the kids", but a Briton would say, "Honey, I have shrunk the kids."

pathos (quality that evokes pity or sadness), **bathos** (ludicrous change from the lofty to the ordinary in writing or speech)

patrolled, patrolling

pavilion Note single *l*.

pawn(-) pawnbroker, pawnshop

pawn ticket

pay(-) payback (noun), paycheque, payday, paygrade, payload, paymaster, payoff (noun), payout (noun), payphone, payroll, payscale

pay dirt

PDA Personal digital assistant.

pdf Lowercase. Portable document format.

peace(-) peacekeeper, peacemaker, peacemaking, peacemonger, peacetime

peace conference, peace march

peacenik

Pearl Harbor (not *Harbour*)

peasant In China, there are "rich peasants" and "poor peasants". In the rest of Asia and some parts of Europe, *peasant* means *a small farmer or farm labourer*. To some people, the word may sound primitive and derogatory. Use *farmer*, *rich farmer* or *poor farmer* instead.

peccadillo(es) A minor sin or fault.

pedaller (cyclist), **peddler** (drug dealer), **pedlar** (hawker)

pekinese (dog) Lowercase.

Peking man (anthropological) Do not change to *Beijing man*.

pell-mell

pelt Prefer *The mob pelted the policemen with stones* to *The mob pelted stones at the policemen*. Other examples of how *pelt* is used: *Hailstones pelted the roof.* | *Rain pelted the windows*.

penalty box (hockey, ice hockey, rugby)

pendant (noun), **pendent** (adjective meaning *hanging* or *pending*)

penknife

penny-wise and pound-foolish

pent-up

people, persons SEE **PERSONS, PEOPLE**.

People's Bank of China China's central bank.

per Avoid. *She earns Rs 50,000 a year* is better than *She earns Rs 50,000 per year*. When used, *per* should ideally be followed by another Latin word: *per capita*, not *per head*. But use *per* if the construction otherwise sounds awkward. For example, in these phrases, *per* cannot be replaced by *a*: *kilometres per hour*, which is written as *kmph*; *four tickets per member, per-student fee*, *per-unit cost*.

perceive

per cent in British English; *percent* in American English. Use % in headlines and copy. Use figures even for numbers below 10. At the beginning of a sentence, spell out the figure and write *per cent*: *Twenty per cent of the city's residents have cars*.

A percentage is followed by *of*: *In this city, 60% of children play computer games*; not *In this city, 60% children play computer games*.

Note that a 100% increase yields twice the original figure, 200% three times, 300% four times, etc. It is a common error to assume, for instance, that a 400% rise means *a fourfold increase*; in fact, it means *a fivefold increase*.

percentage Write *percentage*, not *%age*.

percentage point Do not confuse *percentage points* with *percentage*. If a bank raises its interest rate to 11% from 10%, it is an increase of 10% (not 1%), or one percentage point. One percentage point is equal to 100 basis points. If the US Federal Reserve cuts its key interest rate to 2.25% from 3%, it is a reduction of three-quarters of a percentage point, or 75 basis points, not 0.75%.

In headlines, use *bp* as an abbreviation for basis point(s): *Fed cuts rate by 25bp* (not *0.25%*). Financial Times uses *bp*; AP and Reuters use *bps*.

Spell out percentage points up to nine.

perception Prefer *belief* or *view*.

PERIODICAL NAMES

Use them in roman type, without quotation marks. Drop *The*, except in *The Times of India* and *The Economic Times*. Retain the definite article in the names of non-English publications: *La Monde*, *Der Spiegel*.

Times, London, *Times of London* or *Times (London)*, not *London Times*.

Add the word *magazine* or *newspaper*, lowercased, if it is needed for clarity: *Time magazine*.

Do not italicize the names of periodicals. Here, itals have been used for a different reason (SEE **WORDS AS WORDS**).

perk Shortened form of *perquisite*.

permanent representative Official term for the head of a country's diplomatic mission to an international organization like the UN. Permanent representatives are hardly permanent. Use representative or chief representative. For example, *India's chief representative at the UN*, *Britain's chief representative at the EU*.

permissible

persecution (oppression), **prosecution** (the process of trying to prove in court that a person is guilty of a crime), **the prosecution** (a person or organization, together with lawyers, trying somebody in a court of law)

Persian, Farsi SEE **FARSI, PERSIAN**.

Persian Gulf Use *Gulf*.

(-)person Do not use contrived words formed with *(-)person*. Write *spokesman* or *spokeswoman* rather than *spokesperson*. Similarly, *chairman* or *chairwoman*, not *chairperson*. The stylebooks of Economist, Guardian, Times (London), New York Times and AP advise against the use of words formed with *(-)person*. The New York Times stylebook calls such words "ostensibly desexed". It says: "Thoughtful writing is un-self-conscious: it sidesteps offence without calling attention to the pitfalls. It may, for example cite, spokesmen or spokeswomen, but will refer to a mixed group as press officers rather than the ostensibly desexed spokespersons."

SEE ALSO **CHAIRPERSON** | **SEXIST LANGUAGE** | **SPOKESPERSON**.

persona non grata It is often possible to use the simpler *declared unwelcome*.

personnel is plural, so *a BSF personnel* is wrong. Write *a BSF jawan* or *a BSF officer*.

persons, people The plural of *person* is *people*; *persons* is used only in public notices and other formal contexts, as in *absconding persons* or *missing persons* in a statement from police.

People can also mean a racial, national, religious or linguistic group. In that sense, the plural is *peoples*.

persuade, convince SEE **CONVINCE, PERSUADE**.

Peter principle It says: Employees are promoted until they reach their level of incompetence.

Pg Do not use as an abbreviation of *page*; use *P* instead.

PGA Professional Golfers' Association. Note the apostrophe. The PGA Tour is a separate organization.

pharaoh (not *-oah*) The adjective is *pharaonic*.

pharmacopoeia An official book giving information about medicines. The same spelling in American English.

phenomenon Plural *phenomena*. Avoid the clichéd use of *phenomenal* meaning *outstanding* or *big*.

Philippines, the Always singular. The people of the Philippines are Filipinos (male) and Filipinas (female); adjective *Filipino* for both sexes, but *Philippine* in, say, *a Philippine island* or *the Philippine president*.

philistine

phishing The practice of tricking people by getting them to give their passwords and financial or personal information over the internet or by email, and then using these to steal money from them: *The bank's clients were lured to a phishing site and asked to provide their personal details and account numbers*. Phishing often involves sending customers an apparently legitimate email requesting account information.

phone Write *on the phone* rather than *over the phone*.

phoney is the British spelling; *phony* is American.

phosphorus Noun; *phosphorous* is the adjective.

photo(-) photocell, photocopy, photoelectric, photoengraving, photoflash, photoflood, photogenic, photograph, photosensitive, photosynthesis

photo call, photo finish, photo opportunity

PHOTOGRAPHS

Crop those portions of a photograph that are not relevant or do not provide perspective. Sometimes, cropping leads to a loss of perspective. Be careful.

Use the stamp size for mugshots only; if there are more faces than one in a stamp-size picture, they look rather tiny, like dots.

In mugshots, blur the background. Blurring the background in big photographs is trickier. It should not be so intense as to make a photograph look unnatural.

SEE ALSO **CAPTIONS**.

Photostat is a trademark; the generic word is *photocopy* (noun and verb).

piano(s)

pick(-) pickpocket, pickup (noun and adjective)

pick-me-up (an alcoholic drink taken to raise one's spirits)

pick up (verb)

picket (noun and verb) Never *picketer*.

picnic, picnicking

pico A prefix denoting one-trillionth of a unit.

pièce de résistance

piecemeal

piecework

pigeonhole Verb and noun.

piggyback

pigheaded

pile up (verb), **pile-up** (noun)

pill, the

pillbox

pillion The phrase is *ride pillion*, not *ride on pillion*.

pillow fight

PIN Personal identification number. Hence, *PIN number* is redundant.

pinch British: *at a pinch*; American: *in a pinch*.

pinch-hit (baseball term) To do something for someone else who is suddenly not able to do it.

pinch-hitter, pinch-runner

pingpong A synonym for *table tennis*.

pinpoint

pinstripe As in *pinstripe suit*.

PIO Person of Indian origin.

pipe dream Two words.

pipeline

pit bull terrier Also *pit bull*.

pit stop

plainclothesman A police officer who wears civilian clothes while on duty. Plural *plainclothesmen*. To avoid implying maleness, write *plainclothes officer, officer in plainclothes* or *officer in civilian clothes*.

Plan Cap in references to the government's five-year Plans: *11th Plan*.

(on a higher) plane Not *plain*.

PLANETS

There are eight of them: Mercury, Venus, Earth, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus and Neptune. In August 2006, the International Astronomical Union voted on a new definition of planet that reduced Pluto to the status of a "dwarf planet".

Cap *Mercury*, *Venus*, *Mars*, *Jupiter*, *Saturn*, *Uranus* and *Neptune*.

Cap *Earth* when it is used in the context of astronomy and in juxtaposition with other heavenly bodies. In such a case, omit the preceding *the*: *All the astronauts returned to Earth*.

SEE ALSO **EARTH, MOON, SUN**.

Planning Commission In headlines, *Plan panel* is fine.

plaque

plaster of paris Lowercase.

plateau(x)

play(-) playact, playback (noun), playbill, playbook, playboy, playfellow, playgirl, playgoer, playground, playhouse, playlist, playmaker, playmate, playoff, playroom, plaything, playwright

PlayStation

play-by-play, play back (verb), play off (verb)

plc Not *PLC*. For example, *BP plc*. The initials *plc* after a UK or Irish company's name indicate that it is a public limited company.

plea bargain (noun), **plea-bargain** (verb), **plea bargaining** (noun), **plea-bargaining** (adjective) *Plea bargain* is an arrangement in court by which the defendant agrees to plead guilty to a lesser charge in exchange for having more serious charges dropped. The verb takes no direct object: *The lawyer advised his client to plea-bargain*, not *The lawyer advised his client to plea-bargain the case*.

plead The past tense is *pleaded*, not *pled*.

plebeian

plethora Not just *a lot* but *an excess*.

PLO Palestine (not *Palestinian*) Liberation Organization.

plough is the British spelling; *plow* is American.

ploy Use this word with caution; it suggests deviousness.

PLURALS SEE **SINGULAR OR PLURAL?**

plus Do not use *plus* as a substitute for *and*. Use *plus* as a preposition (*three plus two*), as a noun (*Her knowledge of computers is a definite plus*) or as an adjective (*Another of the hotel's plus points is that it's right in the middle of town.* | *Most children start school when they're five plus.*)

Use a singular verb in a sentence like *Five plus four is nine.*

pm (time) Lowercase, no full stops, no space after the figure: *3.20pm*, not *3.20 pm*. Note the full stop in the figure; do not use a colon instead. Do not use a redundant expression like *8pm this evening*; just *8pm* is fine. Also: *5pm*, not *5.00pm*.

PNDT Act Pre-natal Diagnostic Techniques (Regulation and Prevention of Misuse) Act. *Prenatal* is one word, but it is hyphenated in the act's name.

PNG Piped natural gas. It is natural gas, or methane, supplied through pipelines to households and used as cooking fuel.

SEE ALSO **CNG** | **LNG** | **LPG**.

pocket(-) pocketbook (purse or small book), pocketknife

pocket borough, pocket money, pocket mouse

pocket-size, pocket-sized

podcast As a noun, a recorded programme of talk or music made available over the internet as a digital file that can be downloaded to a computer or a portable device. As a verb, *to make a programme available as a podcast*. It is a portmanteau of the words *iPod* and *broadcast*.

podium, lectern A speaker stands *on* a podium and *at* or *behind* a lectern.

poetess Use *poet*.

Poila Baisakh (not *Poela* or *Pohela*, not *Boishakh*) Bengali New Year's Day, celebrated on the first day of the month of Baisakh. It corresponds to April 13 or 14 of the Gregorian calendar.

point-blank

pointed out Avoid this expression if the statement is in any way contentious; it suggests the reporter accepts that what the speaker is saying is a fact. The plain *said* is better.

point man (a person in the forefront of an activity), **pointsman** (a person who operates railway points; the person is called *switchman* in the US)

pole(-) pole dance, pole dancer, pole dancing

pole position (the leading position at the start of a race)

pole vault (noun), pole-vault (verb), pole-vaulter

polemic (noun) A strong verbal or written attack. The adjective is *polemic* or *polemical*. It is not a common word; avoid it.

police Use a plural verb and a plural pronoun: *Police do not rule out foul play in the tourist's disappearance but they are* (not *it is*) *still looking for leads*. Do not use *the* before *police* except in expressions like *the Delhi police*, *the Mumbai police*. If you use *Delhi Police* or *Mumbai Police* as a proper name with *police* capitalized, do not put *the* before it. *Delhi Police said they had arrested five people*, not *The Delhi Police said they had arrested five people*.

Police is a collective noun. Do not say *five police*, *10 police*. Say *five policewomen*, *10 policemen, 10 cops*. Never use *policeperson(s)*.

police officer Not *police official*.

policyholder

policy maker (noun), **policy making** (noun), **policy-making** (adjective)

politburo

politic, as a verb, takes the forms *politicking*, *politicked*; as an adjective, *politic* means *prudent* or *wise*.

politics is singular when it means *political science*. It can be singular or plural when it means *ideas and activities relating to gaining and using power*.

polls The phrase is *go to the polls*, not *go to polls*.

pollster

polo neck (noun), **polo-neck** (adjective)

polyamory The state or practice of having more than one open romantic relationship at a time.

pompom An ornamental ball or tuft of silk, wool or feathers used on clothing or draperies or waved in pairs by cheerleaders. Hence, *pompom girls*.

pom-pom A rapid-firing automatic weapon.

pontiff Not a formal title. Always lowercase.

pooh-pooh

pope Cap only when using it as a title before a name, as in *Pope Benedict XVI*. Otherwise lowercase: *The pope will visit the US soon*.

populace means *common people*; it does not mean *population*.

pore (gaze intently), **pour** (make a liquid flow into a container)
You *pore over* maps or documents but *pour a liquid*.

porn, porno Both words are slang. In copy, use *pornography* or *pornographic*.

portland cement

Portuguese Singular and plural.

posh There are two problems with this word: it has become a cliché, and it sometimes has a derogatory connotation. Use a substitute like *affluent* or *upmarket*. Keep *posh* for Posh Spice.

position In finance, *position* means *a trader's or investor's financial commitment to a particular security*. You hold a *long position* when you own shares or futures contracts. A *short position* means that you have sold shares or contracts even though you did not own them.

possess, possession, possessive, possessor

POSSESSIVES

Form a possessive by adding *'s* to a singular noun even if the noun already ends in an *s*: *Congress's, Charles's, Burns's, RSS's, US's* (not *Congress', Charles', Burns', RSS', US'*). Do not extend the rule to coin awkward possessives like *his's, Jains's and selectors's*.

With classical names and some established terms, make an exception to the rule. For example, *Lutyens' Delhi, Archimedes' principle, Jesus' tomb, Moses' laws* (not *Lutyens's Delhi*, *Archimedes's principle*, *Jesus's tomb*, *Moses's laws*).

The *s* after the apostrophe is omitted in certain common expressions: *for conscience' sake, for appearance' sake, for goodness' sake*. It is also omitted when a word that is technically plural expresses a singular idea: *Tata Motors' cars, the United States' citizens*.

If a word ends in two sibilant sounds (*ch*, *j*, *s*, *sh* or *z*) separated only by a vowel sound, drop the *s* after the apostrophe: *Texas' population*, *Kansas' politicians*. But keep the *s* after the apostrophe if the word ends in a silent sibilant letter: *Illinois's*, *Malraux's*.

If a word ends in *ss*, add *'s* to form a possessive: *witness's*, *hostess's*. But use only an apostrophe if the next word begins with an *s*: *hostess' seat*, *witness' story*.

If two or more words are joined by *and*, form their possessive by adding *'s* only to the last word if the possession is joint: *George and Laura Bush's daughters*, *Rahul and Priyanka's mother*. Use *'s* after each word if the possession is individual: *Rahul's and Priyanka's speeches*.

In possessives of plural words formed with *s* or *es*, place the apostrophe at the end of the word: *boys' hostel, reporters' bylines, Mercedeses' doors.*

Names of organizations sometimes omit the apostrophe: *All India Bank Officers Confederation, Nuclear Suppliers Group.* Respect the organization's preference.

A double possessive like *a friend of Vivek's* can be used only when the word following *of* is an animate object and the word before *of* is only a part of the animate object's possessions. Remember, you say *a friend of mine*, not *a friend of me*. A double possessive is especially helpful in making a distinction between *a picture of her father* (in which we can see him) and *a picture of her father's* (a picture owned by her father). However, when such distinction is not required, it is all right to use a single possessive form like *a friend of Vivek*.

In forming possessives of inanimate objects, prefer the *of* construction: *rules of journalism*, rather than *journalism's rules*. However, sometimes the *'s* construction is more natural: *He drank to his heart's content*.

post Do not use as a synonym of *after*, as in *Post the meeting, everybody went home.*

post(-) postbox, postcard, postcode, postdoc, postdoctoral, postgraduate, postman, postmark, postmaster, postmodern, postmortem, postnuptial, postpaid, postscript, PostScript (in computing, a language used as a standard for describing pages of text)

post-bellum (occurring after a war, specifically after the American Civil War), post-coital, post-date, post-free, post-haste, post-industrial, post-operative, post-partum, post-pubescence, post-war, post-cold-war

post meridiem (literally, *after noon*; abbreviation *pm*), post office, post road, post time (the scheduled starting time of a horse race)

poster boy, poster child, poster girl

Post-it Notes Trademark; cap *P* and *N*.

postmortem One word. It is a countable noun. Write *a postmortem*, or *the postmortem* if a definite article is needed: *A postmortem was carried out on Aarushi's body to determine how she had been killed; the postmortem report was questioned by experts.*

potato(es)

potbelly

pothole

pound The British currency. In case of ambiguity, use pound sterling. One pound (£1) equals 100 pence (100p). The singular of *pence* is *penny*.

pour, pore SEE **PORE, POUR**.

power(-) powerboat, powerhouse, powerlifting

power-crazed, power-driven, power-hungry, power-loving, power-mad, power-packed

power brake, power broker, power cut, power elite, power pack, power plant, power play, power politics, power station, power structure

PowerPoint Write *PowerPoint presentation*, not *power-point presentation*.

(the) powers that be No hyphens.

powwow One word.

practical (sensible or useful rather than fashionable or attractive), **practicable** (capable of being done, feasible)

practically Not *practicly*.

practice (noun), **practise** (verb) American English does not make this distinction and uses *practice* for both purposes.

prairie

Praja Rajyam Political party formed by filmstar Chiranjeevi.

Prasar Bharati

praying mantis Not *preying*. The insect is so called because it rests with its first pair of legs raised as if in prayer.

pre(-) Generally, compounds beginning with *pre-* are one word: prearrange, prebiotic, precast, preclinical, preclude, precocious, precognition, precoital, preconceived, preconscious, precook, predecease, predefine, predetermine, predispose, predominant, predominate, prefab, prefabricate, prefix, preflight, prehistoric, prehistory, prehuman,

preindustrial, prejudge, premarital, prematch, premature, prenatal, prenup, prenuptial, preoccupation, preordain, prepacked, prepaid, prepay, prepubescent, prequalify, prerequisite, preschool, preseason, preset, preteen, pretest, pretrial, preview, prewash

If the second element of the compound starts with an *e* or a capital letter, hyphenate: pre-election, pre-eminent, pre-empt, pre-Christian, pre-Columbian, pre-Roman

Some other *pre-* words are hyphenated to avoid ambiguity: pre-boards, pre-med, pre-medical, pre-loved (second-hand), pre-owned (second-hand), pre-sell, pre-tax, pre-war

In many words, *pre-* is redundant: precondition, pre-booked, pre-existing, pre-reserved, pre-ordered, preplanned, prerecorded, prerehearsed. The words would be just fine without the prefix.

precipitate (verb, and adjective meaning *sudden*), **precipitous** (steep)

précis Singular and plural.

predawn If something happened shortly before dawn, *predawn* may be technically correct, but it is a cliché. Avoid it. Never use it to mean merely that something happened during the night.

predilection Not *predeliction*.

predominately There is no such word. Write *predominantly*.

preferable

preferred

pregnant *She is six months* (no apostrophe) *pregnant*. The construction is similar to *She is 25 years old*.

premier (adjective meaning *first in importance or position*)

premier (noun) Keep it for the Chinese prime minister and the prime ministers of Australian and Canadian provinces. Otherwise, use *prime minister*.

premiere The first performance of a musical or theatrical work, or the first showing of a film. Avoid its jargon use as a verb.

premise means *an assumption in an argument*; **premises** (always plural) means *a piece of land together with its buildings*.

premium(s)

prepone Use *advance* instead. *Prepone* will sound wrong to many readers, although some dictionaries have recently listed it as an informal Indian or South Asian word.

PREPOSITION AT THE END OF A SENTENCE

Placing a preposition at the end of a sentence or clause — called preposition stranding by grammarians — is not wrong. Avoid it if you can, but go ahead if it sounds more natural. Sentences like *What are you waiting for?* and *What is he up to?* would be awkward if rephrased to *For what are you waiting?* and *Up to what is he?*

"One of the most persistent myths about prepositions in English is that they properly belong before the word or words they govern and should not be placed at the end of a clause or sentence."
— R W Burchfield in New Fowler's Modern English Usage

"Though for generations ignorant prescrivists have railed against this construction, it is in fact perfectly normal in everybody's English, and there are no sensible grounds for objecting to it."
— R L Trask in "Mind the Gaffe"

PREPOSITION PILE-UP

The use of two or more prepositions together can often make a sentence clumsy. Instead of *I woke up after between 10 and 20 minutes*, write *I woke up after 10 to 20 minutes*. *I bought the house at below market price* will be fine without *at*: *I bought the house below market price*. Similarly, *The accident on Ring Road took place at around 5pm* can be written as *The accident on Ring Road took place around 5pm*.

PREPOSITIONS, MISSING

Avoid constructions like *wait tables*, *baby-sit children* and *graduate college*. Make them *wait on tables*, *baby-sit for children* and *graduate from college*.

prescribe (advise or recommend), **proscribe** (forbid)

presently means *shortly*, *soon*. Do not use it to mean *at present*, *now* or *currently*.

president Use as a title only before the name of a country's president: *President Obama, President Hu Jintao*.

For presidents of companies or organizations, write like this:
M Takedagawa, president of Honda Siel India, spoke to reporters or *Honda Siel India's president, M Takedagawa, spoke to reporters.*

presidium Not *praesidium*.

press Lowercase even if you mean the print media.

press conference Prefer *news conference*. Do not use *presser*.

pressurize If you mean *put pressure on*, write so or write just *press*: *The Left pressed* (not *pressurized*) *the government to abandon the plan for a nuclear deal with the US*. Gases, liquids and foods can be *pressurized*, which means *compacted into containers under pressure*.

prestigious Avoid this pompous and often tautological word. If something is prestigious or famous, then we need hardly say so. If you insist, try *highly regarded*, *admired*, *eminent*, *leading*, *noted*, *outstanding* or *powerful*.

prêt-à-porter Ready-to-wear designer clothing. For short, *prêt*.

pretence, pretext *Pretence* (American spelling *pretense*) means *a false show of something*, as in *She abandoned the pretence that she loved him*. *Pretext* means *a false reason given to conceal something*, as in *She phoned her former lover on the pretext of asking about an official report*.

prevalent Not *prevelant*.

prevaricate means *to speak* or *act evasively*; **procrastinate** means *to delay*.

Prevention of Money Laundering Act

preventive Not *preventative*.

price discovery The act of determining the price of a stock or commodity in a market environment — by the forces of demand and supply.

price-earnings ratio, or P/E ratio, is the price of a stock divided by its earnings per share. It is also called P/E multiple or multiple.

SEE ALSO **EARNINGS PER SHARE**.

pricey, pricier, priciest

prima donna Plural *prima donnas*.

prima facie (at first sight, or on the surface of it) No hyphen.

primary deficit SEE **FISCAL DEFICIT, REVENUE DEFICIT, PRIMARY DEFICIT**.

prime time (noun), **prime-time** (adjective)

principal can be an adjective meaning *chief*; or a noun meaning *chief person*, as in *principal of a school*, or *principal* (main) *corpus of a fund*.

principle Always a noun. It means *theory* or *moral belief*.

prior to Use *before* or *in advance of*.

prisoner(s) of war *PoW(s)* is acceptable in subsequent references.

pristine means *primitive* or *unspoiled*; it does not simply mean *clean*.

private sector Do not hyphenate even when using it as an adjective, as in *private sector executives*.

privilege Note the sequence *i i, e e*; do not write *priviledge*.

prix fixe means *fixed price*. It also means *a complete meal served for a fixed price*.

prizewinner, prizewinning But Nobel prize winner, Booker prize winner, etc.

pro Latin terms are not hyphenated even when used as modifiers before nouns: pro bono (legal work undertaken without charge), pro forma, pro rata, pro tem.

proactive

probation, parole SEE **PAROLE, PROBATION**.

proctor There is no such word as *procter*. But: *Procter & Gamble*.

prodigal means *wasteful* or *extravagant*, not every *returned wanderer*. A *prodigal son* is a person who leaves home and wastes his money and time on a life of pleasure, but is later sorry about this and returns home.

professor Note single *f* and double *s*. If the word is used as a title before a name, cap it: *Professor M S Swaminathan* or *Prof M S Swaminathan*. Use this title sparingly — only before the names of eminent academics if the context demands so.

profit Unless otherwise specified, *profit* is interpreted to mean *net profit*, or *the amount left after taxes have been paid*. While reporting company results, always mention the net profit figures. If these figures are not available, try to get them or say why they have not been given by the company.

profited Note single *t*.

profit-taking Selling shares, bonds, etc, that have increased in value, in order to make a profit.

program (computers) Otherwise, *programme*.

prohibit, forbid SEE **FORBID, PROHIBIT**.

prone (lying face down), **supine** (lying face up)

PRONOUNS AND ANTECEDENTS

A pronoun needs to agree with its antecedent, the earlier noun that the pronoun stands in for. There are two tricky situations that demand attention:

i. Consider this sentence: *The Mayawati order to remove some IAS officers has incensed her adversaries*. Here, *Mayawati* has been used as a modifier, not as a pure noun. It modifies *order*. The pronoun *her* is thus left without an antecedent. The sentence can be mended by using the possessive form: *Mayawati's order to remove some IAS officers has incensed her adversaries*.

ii. Consider this sentence: *The police officer was shot dead by a property dealer in his office*. The pronoun *his* could refer to either *police officer* or *property dealer*. Whose office are we talking about? Recast the sentence or remove the phrase *in his office* from this sentence and mention the place of crime in the next sentence.

PRONOUNS FOR COUNTRIES AND SHIPS

Use *it* or *its*. Do not use *she* or *her*.

pronunciation

(-)proof Compounds are generally one word: blastproof, bulletproof, fireproof, foolproof, waterproof, weatherproof

A coined or unusual term should be hyphenated: recession-proof, theft-proof.

proofreader, proofreading

propaganda is singular. It is an uncountable noun, so do not write *a propaganda*. It is not a synonym for *lies*; it means *information, especially of a biased or misleading nature, used to promote a political point of view*.

propeller Not *propellor*.

prophecy (noun), **prophesy** (verb)

pro rata Two words. As an adjective, it means *proportional* and as an adverb *proportionally*.

pros and cons

proscribe (forbid), **prescribe** (advise or recommend)

prostate gland Not *prostrate*, which means *lying face down*.

prostitute Write *sex worker*.

protagonist The main character in a drama. A *leading protagonist* is tautological. The word is a favourite of journalists who think long words enhance their copy. An *antagonist* is an adversary or opponent. Phrases like *chief figure* or *rival leaders* are better.

protector Not *protecter*.

protégé (male), **protégée** (female)

protest You protest your innocence, but protest *against, at* or *about* something.

Protestant

protester Not *protestor*. But *demonstrator*.

provable

proved, proven Use *proved*. Keep *proven* for certain phrases like *proven oil reserves* and *proven record*. In Scottish law, *not proven* is used for *neither guilty nor not guilty*.

proviso(s)

prurient means *obsessed with sex*; it does not mean *puritanical*.

p's and q's Use apostrophes in plurals of letters. But no apostrophe in plurals of words: *ifs and buts*.

pseudo (adjective) Pretentious or insincere.

pseudo (noun) A pretentious or insincere person. Plural *pseudos*.

pseudo(-) Compounds are generally one word:
pseudoclassic, pseudonym, pseudoscience

Some compounds are hyphenated to avoid ambiguity:
pseudo-intellectual, pseudo-official

psych is slang as a verb. Avoid.

psychedelic has an *e* after *psych*, unlike *psychology*.

publicly Not *publically*.

public sector Do not hyphenate even when using it as an adjective, as in *public sector companies*.

Puducherry Not *Pondicherry*.

pull out (verb), **pullout** (noun)

PUNCTUATION SEE INDIVIDUAL ENTRIES LIKE **COMMA**, **FULL STOP**.

purchase (verb) Prefer *buy*.

purport To claim to be or do something, even if this may not be true: *The document is purported to be 300 years old*. Do not use *purported* as an adjective, as in *the purported document*. The adverb *purportedly* is fine: *a portrait purportedly of Shakespeare*.

purposely (deliberately, on purpose), **purposefully** (resolutely, with a strong purpose)

pursue, pursuit

push(-) pushback (noun meaning *negative response*), pushbike, pushcart, pushchair, pushover (noun)

push-button, push-up (noun)

pussyfoot To act in an excessively cautious way, to move stealthily.

put You *put on* a play, not *put up* a play.

putative means *generally considered* or *reputed to be*; it does not mean *likely* or *possible*.

put-down A remark intended to humiliate someone.

Puthandu The traditional Tamil New Year's Day. It corresponds to April 13 or 14. The Tamil Nadu government's decision to shift the New Year's Day celebrations to Pongal (corresponding to January 14) was challenged in court.

putsch A violent attempt to overthrow a government.

pygmy

PYRAMID CONSTRUCTION

Also known as inverted pyramid construction, this method of writing arranges information in descending order of significance and interest. A story can then be cut from the bottom upwards, always leaving a self-contained version.

pyrrhic victory Too costly a victory.

pzazz (energetic excitement) Not *pizzazz* or *pizazz*.

***

I often quote myself. It adds spice to my conversation.
— **George Bernard Shaw**

Q

Qaid-e-Azam Name given in Pakistan to Mohammad Ali Jinnah, regarded as the founder of that country.

quarantine Isolation to prevent the spread of a disease.

qawwali Not *quwwali*.

quadrillion 1 followed by 15 zeros. Use *million billion*.

quadriplegia, quadriplegic Not *quadra-*.

quadruped Not *quadra-* or *quadri-*.

Quai d'Orsay The riverfront street on the Seine's southern bank (called Rive Gauche or Left Bank) in Paris, and by extension the foreign ministry headquarters there.

quandary Not *quandry*.

quantum jump, quantum leap Avoid these clichés.

quarrel *The man picked* (not *picked up*) *a quarrel with his neighbour*.

quarter(-) quarterback, quarterdeck, quarterfinal, quartermaster

quarter horse, quarter note, quarter tone

quarter-hour

quasi Hyphenate in adjectives: quasi-judicial, quasi-stellar

In nouns, some *quasi* compounds are one word and some are two words: quasicrystal, quasiparticle. But: quasi comfort, quasi contract.

Queen Elizabeth 2 The ocean liner. In subsequent references, *QE2*. The British monarch is Elizabeth II.

queer In the sense of *homosexual*, the word is derogatory, but has been lately used by some academics and homosexual activists as a descriptive term without negative connotations. Homosexuals are happy to call one another *queer* but take offence if someone else uses this label for them. Do not use it if the connotation is offensive.

question hour (in Parliament) Lowercase.

QUESTION MARK

Put a question mark only after a direct question. An indirect question takes a full stop: *I asked her if she was going to Paris.*

Do not use the question mark in a headline where, if it is accidentally dropped, the meaning can change from a possibility to a fact. Avoid the question mark as a headline shorthand for speculation. Readers want information, not questions. However, a question mark can be used effectively in the headline of a story raising an issue of grave public concern: *Who will pay for these deaths?*

A direct question, be it in a story or a headline, should have a question mark at the end:

Why drag the shareholders into the Ambani spat? asked the court.
Not *Why drag the shareholders into the Ambani spat, asked the court.*

Similarly, *Where should I go now? he wondered.*
Not *Where should I go now, he wondered.*

If an inverted sentence is not intended as a question, but as a request, invitation or instruction, a full stop replaces the question mark:

Could I use your phone.
Won't you come in.
Would you switch off the fan.

In such cases, when in doubt, use a question mark. You will not go wrong.

Do not put a comma or a full stop after a question mark.

questionnaire

queuing Not *queueing*.

quick(-) quicklime, quicksand, quicksilver, quickstep

quick fire (noun), quick march, quick response, quick trick

quick-fire (adjective), quick-freeze (verb), quick-tempered, quick-witted

quicker Use only as an adjective. Do not use as an adverb, as in *He walked quicker*. Make it *He walked more quickly*.

quid pro quo(s)

quiet (adjective meaning *calm*), **quite** (adverb meaning *completely*, *truly*, *to a considerable extent*)

quincentenary 500th anniversary.

quintillion 1 followed by 18 zeros. Use *billion billion*.

quip *The official quipped* ... is a phrase almost invariably followed by something that is not funny. Avoid both *quip* and third-rate humour.

quiz Plural *quizzes*; verb forms *quizzes*, *quizzed*, *quizzing*.

quotable

QUOTATION MARKS

In copy, captions and digest items, use double quotation marks for quotes or even while putting a word or a phrase in quotation marks; use single quotation marks only for a quote within a quote.

Comma, full stop or question mark should come before the closing quotation mark if it is a full quote:
"Nothing in these agreements prevents us from further nuclear tests if warranted by our national security concerns," the Prime Minister said.

For a partial quote, or a word or phrase in quotation marks, comma, full stop or question mark should come after the closing quotation mark:
The Prime Minister said that he was a politician "by accident".

If a full quote is broken in two and the reporting verb comes in the middle, the comma after the first part of the quote is placed inside the closing quotation mark:
"Nothing in these agreements," the Prime Minister said, "prevents us from further nuclear tests if warranted by our national security concerns."

Generally, a colon is used to introduce a quotation. A comma can be used to introduce a quotation of one sentence or less.

If a full paragraph of quoted material is followed by a paragraph that continues the quotation, do not put close-quote marks at the end of the first paragraph. But do put open-quote marks at the beginning of the second paragraph, and so on.

Do not use quotation marks to enclose dialogue labelled with *Q* and *A*.

Put a word in quotation marks if it is used in an ironical sense: *The "story" is a bundle of inconsistencies*.

Avoid quotation marks where they are unnecessary, as in *She called him "incompetent"*.

In headlines, shoulder headlines (straplines), digest headlines, subheads, headlines for graphics and caption kickers, use single quotation marks.

QUOTATIONS IN STORIES

Quotations personalize stories and give them immediacy.

Do not alter anything put in quotation marks other than deleting words, and that too only if the deletion does not change the sense of the quote. Delete routine obscenities. Show deletions from a quoted text with an ellipsis.

Try to get a quote into the first three paragraphs of a story.

Selective use of quotes can be unbalanced. The quotes you use should be representative of what the speaker said.

Describe body language (a smile, a wink) that could affect the sense of what is said.

Avoid broken quotes and do not use them in a lead paragraph unless the words have special significance or relevance. Any such partial quote must be backed up with a full quote later in the story.

If an entire sentence is in quotation marks, put the full stop before the closing quote: *He said, "We will win by fair means or foul."* If the quoted passage, however long, does not constitute a full sentence, put the full stop after the closing quote: *He said they would win "by fair means or foul"*.

If you need to explain a quote, do so in a separate paragraph or by putting the information in square brackets within the quoted remarks: *He said, "They [the Maoists] are bound to fail."*

When you are quoting the same source for a lengthy statement, you need not repeat the source paragraph by paragraph so long as there is no doubt who is speaking.

Long quotes (say, 100 words) can be unwieldy. In such cases, keep the more important part of the quote in quotation marks and paraphrase the rest.

Quotes in an Indian language can add colour to a story. If you give such quotes, explain what they mean.

Do not end one paragraph with a close-quote mark and begin the next with an open-quote mark. If the quote is continuous, the close-quote mark is not needed. If the quotes are not consecutive, end the paragraph with three full stops.

Use double quotation marks for quotes. If there is a quote within a quote, put that in single quotation marks: *He said, "I think the words 'by fair means or foul' portend a dirty election campaign."*

A quote that follows a colon always begins with a capital letter, as in *Singh said, "The conference ignored the principle of equality."*

(did not want to be) quoted This sentence is from one of our stories: *Another IIT director who did not want to be quoted said they had a "lengthy discussion on the issue of faculty reservations and the result was rather positive"*. First we say the IIT director did not want to be quoted, and then we quote him. We should have said *Another IIT director who did not want to be identified …*

Quran Not *Koran*.

Qutub Minar Not *Qutb Minar* or *Qutab Minar*.

***

It is your job to make your meaning clear to the reader. The reader should not have to struggle to make sense of what you have written.
— **R L Trask**

R

rabi A crop that is harvested at the end of winter. SEE ALSO **KHARIF**.

race(-) racecourse, racegoer, racehorse, racetrack

In certain names, *race course* is two words; the Prime Minister's residence is on Race Course Road.

RACIAL, RELIGIOUS, REGIONAL AND LINGUISTIC LABELS
Do not assign anyone a class unless such description is pertinent to the story. Do not label a person with caste, ethnic background, religion, regional identity or linguistic identity unless it is genuinely relevant. The same applies to disabilities, physical or mental illness, physical appearance and sexual orientation.

It is all right to describe someone as a dalit poet if the person's work pertains to the conditions of dalits but to call a scientist who has done important work in biotechnology a dalit scientist is offensive if the person's social background is of no relevance to the work.

Some examples of labels to be avoided: *Nepali servants kill landlord* | *Muslim woman raped by father-in-law* | *Manipuri student caught with heroin* | *Oriyas arrested in murder case*.

If race is relevant, *black*, *white* and *of mixed race* are acceptable adjectives. Do not use *ethnic* to mean black or Asian people. Prefer *ethnic groups* or

communities to *tribes*. Avoid words like *African*, *Asian*, *European* or *Latino* unless an individual's nationality is not known. Do not use *Negro* as an indicator of racial origin unless making a special historical point.

SEE ALSO **SEXIST LANGUAGE**.

racialism, racism Use *racism*. Similarly, *racist*, not *racialist*.

rack, wrack Use *wrack* only for seaweed and in the phrase *wrack and ruin*. Otherwise, use *rack*: *racked with pain, racked with guilt, racked by doubts, nerve-racking, rack your brains with* (or *over*) *something*.

racket Use this spelling, not *racquet*, for a tennis or badminton bat.

radiator Not *radiater*.

radio(s) Cap *radio* only in names, as in *All India Radio*, *Radio Moscow*; otherwise lowercase, as in *FM radio*.

radio(-) radioactive, radioactivity, radiobiology, radiocarbon, radiochemistry, radiogenic, radiogram, radiograph, radioimmunology, radioisotope, radiophone, radioscopy, radiotherapy

radio astronomy, radio beam, radio car, radio communication, radio control, radio frequency, radio microphone, radio spectrum, radio station, radio telescope, radio wave

radio-controlled

radius Plural *radii*.

rage First came *road rage* (violent behaviour of a driver arising out of conflict with the driver of another vehicle), then *air rage* (violent behaviour by passengers in an aircraft). Now, there are *phone rage* (annoyance at being disturbed by mobile phones), *spam rage* (vindictive anger provoked by unwanted emails) and many other rages. Make sure that the meaning is clear to the reader.

railway, railways A zonal railway is a *railway*, not *railways*. Hence, do not write *Northern Railways*; make it *Northern Railway*. Lowercase *railways* when referring to the whole of Indian Railways and treat is as singular. There are other names that have plural forms ending in *s* but are treated as singular: *Netherlands*, *United States*.

In headlines, *railways* can be abbreviated to *rlys* and *railway* to *rly*. Thus, *Northern Rly* for Northern Railway.

Write *railway minister*, not *railways minister*. But: *minister of railways*.

SEE ALSO **MINISTERS, MINISTRIES**.

railway station is British; *railroad station* is American.

RAILWAY ZONES

Indian Railways is divided into 16 zones. Cap *Northern Railway*, *Eastern Railway*, etc. In the names of zonal units, write *Railway*, not *Railways*. Note the absence of hyphens in these names:

Railway zone	Abbreviation	Headquarters
Central Railway	CR	Mumbai
Eastern Railway	ER	Kolkata
East Central Railway	ECR	Hajipur, near Patna
East Coast Railway	ECoR	Bhubaneswar
Northern Railway	NR	Delhi
North Central Railway	NCR	Allahabad
North Western Railway	NWR	Jaipur
North Eastern Railway	NER	Gorakhpur
Northeast Frontier Railway	NFR	Maligaon (Guwahati)
Southern Railway	SR	Chennai
South Central Railway	SCR	Secunderabad
South Eastern Railway	SER	Kolkata
South East Central Railway	SECR	Bilaspur (Chhattisgarh)
South Western Railway	SWR	Hubli
Western Railway	WR	Mumbai
West Central Railway	WCR	Jabalpur

rain In the sense of *rainfall*, use *rain*, not *rains*, which means *a season of rainfall* or *the monsoon*.

rain(-) rainbird, rainbow, raincoat, raindrop, rainfall, rainmaker, rainproof, rainstorm, rainwater, rainwear

rain forest, rain gauge

rain-fed, rain-soaked

rain check A *rain check* (not *rain cheque*) is a ticket that can be used later if a game or show is cancelled because of rain. You *take a rain check* when you refuse an offer but say that you might accept it later: *I'll take a rain check on that drink tonight, if that's all right*.

(come) rain or shine Not *rain or sunshine*.

raise, rear Both words mean *bring up* and can apply to humans or animals: *He was born and raised in Boston.* | *He raises cattle.* | *She reared a family of five on her own.* | *Lions rear their cubs. Raise*, but not *rear*, can also be used for plants. *He raises corn* is fine, but *He rears corn* is not.

raise, rise Use *raise* in the sense of pay increase. Do not use the redundant *pay raise.*

raison d'être

Rajya Sabha MP If you spell out *MP*, you will see the awfulness of the phrase: *Rajya Sabha member of Parliament.* Write *Rajya Sabha member*.

Rakshabandhan Sanskrit name for the festival of Rakhi.

Ram, Rama Normally, use *Ram*, as in *the Ram temple agitation*. Use *Rama* only in religious or formal contexts where the Sanskrit origin of the word needs to be emphasized.

Ramayana Not *Ramayan*.

Ramjanmabhoomi

Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital This Delhi hospital was earlier known as Willingdon Hospital.

Ram Navami

rampage Both *on the rampage* and *on a rampage* are fine. The first is more common in Britain and the second in the US.

Ram Sethu

Ramzan The month of fasting when devout Muslims refrain from food, drink or sex during daylight hours and focus on devotion and good work. The start and the end of the month for most Islamic countries depend on the sighting of the new moon by the naked eye. It is the ninth and holiest month of the Islamic, lunar calendar. Although *Ramadan,* the spelling used in Britain and the US, is a better transliteration of the original Arabic word, we use *Ramzan,* the spelling prevalent in India.

rand The South African currency. Plural *rands*.

R&B Rhythm and blues.

rank and file (noun), **rank-and-file** (modifier, before a noun)

RAPE VICTIM
Do not reveal the identity of a rape victim unless the victim has decided to go public with the accusation. In such cases, always consult the editor. When someone's identity is not to be revealed, any details that could provide a clue to the identity must be avoided.

rapid-fire (adjective)

rapper Not *rap singer*.

rapprochement Diplomatic term for warming of relations. A simpler substitute is *reconciliation*.

rarefy, rarefied Not *rarify*, *rarified*.

Rashtrapati Bhavan Note the *v* in *Bhavan*; do not write *Bhawan*. Similarly, Bal Bhavan, Bharat Bhavan, Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Raj Bhavan, Sena Bhavan. If the official spelling of a name has *w*, do not change it: Umaid Bhawan, Karni Bhawan.

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh

(-)rate birth rate, death rate, insurance rate, interest rate, tax rate

cut-rate (adjective), first-rate (adjective)

rateable

raze Write *The building was razed*, not *The building was razed to the ground*. The ground is the only place to which a structure can be razed.

razzmatazz Noisy exciting activity.

re(-) Generally, compounds beginning with *re-* are one word: readjust, readmit, reaffirm, realign, reallocate, reappear, reapply, reappoint, reappraise, rearm, rearrange, reassemble, reassess, reassign, reassure, rebirth, reboot, reborn, rebroadcast, rebuild, recapture, recharge, recombinant, reconfigure, reconfirm, reconnect, reconsider, reconstitute, reconstruct, reconvene, reconvert, redefine, redeploy, redesign, redevelop, redirect, rediscover, redistribute, redouble, redraft, refinance, refit, regroup, reimpose, reimburse, reinforce, reiterate, remake, reopen, reorder, reorient, rerun, resale, rethink, reunion, reunite, reusable, reuse, rework, rewrite

If the second element of the compound starts with an *e* or a capital letter, hyphenate: re-echo, re-educate, re-elect, re-election, re-emerge, re-employ, re-enact, re-engineering, re-enter, re-entry, re-establish, re-evaluate, re-examine.

When two *re-* words with different meanings are spelled identically, hyphenate the less familiar one to avoid ambiguity: recount (tell a story), re-count (count again); recover (find something lost, get well), re-cover (cover

again); reform (improve), re-form (form anew); reserve (set aside for future use), re-serve (serve again); resign (quit), re-sign (sign again).

read down To dilute an existing law, especially through a court ruling or an amendment by a legislative body. It is legal jargon; avoid.

ready can be stilted as a verb; *prepare* or *shape* is often better.

ready(-) ready-made, ready-mix, ready-to-wear (adjective, before a noun), ready-witted

ready money, ready reckoner

real Brazilian currency; plural *reais*.

realistically

realpolitik Not *realpolitic*.

real time (noun), **real-time** (adjective)

realtor A real-estate agent, not a real-estate developer.

rearguard One word as both noun and adjective. *Rearguard* means *the troops who protect the rear of a military formation*; *rearguard action* is an effort to prevent or postpone something that is unavoidable.

reason Do not write *the reason is because*. Instead write *the reason is that* or *this is because*.

Similarly, avoid *the reason why. That's the reason why I signed here* should be shortened to *That's the reason I signed here. The reason why the decision was made* should be rephrased to *The reason for the decision*.

rebut (a neutral word meaning *to argue to the contrary, producing evidence*), **refute** (win such an argument) Neither word should be used as a synonym of *contest*, *reject*, *deny*, *dispute* or *respond to*.

recce Informal word for *reconnaissance* or *reconnoitre*.

recede

receive, receipt

received an injury Avoid. Prefer *suffered an injury* or *was injured*.

recipient Not *recepient*.

recommend

reconcilable Not *reconciliable*

reconnaissance

record Do not write *He set a new world record*. Any record just set is new. However, this is fine: *The new record exceeds the old by 50 runs*.

record(-) record-breaking, record-holder (a person)

record changer, record player

recreation (amusement), **re-creation** (creating again, as in *re-creation of a ruined city* or *re-enactment of a scene*). The verb is always *recreate*. Do not confuse *recreation* with *procreation* (reproduction).

recrudescence means *an outbreak of trouble or a disease after a period of quiet*. Do not confuse it with *resurgence*.

recruit Not *new recruit*; a recruit is by definition new.

recur, recurred, recurrent, recurring

recuse, recusal Judges *recuse* (withdraw) themselves from cases because of possible biases or personal interests. Do not confuse the word with *rescue*.

redbrick university But *a red-brick building*. The original six redbrick universities were Birmingham, Bristol, Leeds, Liverpool, Manchester and Sheffield.

red card (noun), **red-card** (verb)

Red Cross The full name is International Committee of (not *for*) the Red Cross. The equivalent in Islamic countries is Red Crescent.

red-faced

red-handed

red-hot (adjective)

red-light area, red-light disctict

red meat

red tape

red-tapism is rarely used in British English and American English, but is quite common in Indian English.

referendum(s)

REFLEXIVE PRONOUNS SEE **(-)SELF, (-)SELVES**.

reforestation Do not use *reafforestation*, a misspelling resulting from confusion with *afforestation*.

reform Use with care. The word means *improvement*. One person's reform can be another's exploitation. Neutral substitutes are *overhaul* and *revision*.

refute Use this much-abused word only when an argument is disproved; otherwise, use *contest*, *deny* or *dispute*.

SEE ALSO **REBUT, REFUTE**.

(with) regard to Not *with regards to*.

regime As an alternative to *government* the word has a tone of disapproval. Use with caution.

regimen is a medically prescribed course of exercise, way of life or diet. Do not confuse it with *regime*.

REGIONAL IDENTITY SEE **RACIAL, RELIGIOUS, REGIONAL AND LINGUISTIC LABELS | STEREOTYPES**.

regrettable, regretted, regretting

regrettably (unfortunately, as in *Regrettably, a number of jobs will be lost*), **regretfully** (in a sad or disappointed manner, as in *He shook his head regretfully*)

Although some dictionaries accept the use of *regretfully* in the sense of *regrettably* or *unfortunately*, it is worthwhile to maintain a distinction for the sake of clarity.

reign (the period during which a ruler is on the throne), **rein** (a band of leather that is fastened around a horse's head for controlling it, and hence by extension, *give free rein to your imagination*, *keep a tight rein on the company's operations*)

reinforce

rein in Not *reign in*.

reinstate

relationship A pompous word in political or diplomatic contexts. It is often sufficient to say *relation* or *relations* unless you are referring to a romantic relationship.

relative Use this word, not *relation*, if you mean a family member.

release, discharge SEE **DISCHARGE, RELEASE**.

relevant

RELIGION
Do not mention the religion of a person in a story unless it is pertinent and the pertinence will be clear to the reader.

SEE ALSO **RACIAL, RELIGIOUS, REGIONAL AND LINGUISTIC LABELS | STEREOTYPES**.

RELIGIOUS DESIGNATIONS
Cap religious designations: Hindu, Muslim, Sikh, Jain, Christian. Cap caste names: Jat, Lingayat, Brahman, Rajput. Also: Dalit.

relinquish Simpler terms like *give up* and *yield* are often better.

reluctant (unwilling to act), **reticent** (unwilling to talk)

remainder Avoid as a synonym of *the rest*.

remand A person is *remanded in custody*, not *remanded to custody*.

remembrance

reminiscence

remuneration Not *renumeration*.

Renaissance, the The great revival of art, literature and learning in Europe in the 14th, 15th and 16th centuries. Lowercase *renaissance* in the general sense of revival or rebirth.

rendezvous Singular and plural.

rendition The practice, especially in the US, of sending a foreign criminal or terror suspect covertly to be interrogated in a country with less rigorous regulations for humane treatment of prisoners. Also *extraordinary rendition*.

reopen

repechage A trial, in athletics, giving competitors who have already lost a heat another chance to qualify.

repellant (noun), **repellent** (adjective)

repertoire (an individual's range of skills or roles), **repertory** (a selection of works that a theatre or dance company might perform)

repetition

replace, substitute SEE **SUBSTITUTE, REPLACE**.

repo rate, reverse repo rate The RBI lends short-term (overnight) funds to banks at repo rate; it absorbs excess bank funds at reverse repo rate. A reduction in repo rate helps banks to get money at a cheaper rate. This can lead to a fall in interest rates. An increase in repo rate, a measure resorted to by the RBI to contain inflation, tends to push interest rates up.

SEE ALSO **CASH RESERVE RATIO**.

report card

reported, reportedly If you use the word *reported* without stating the source at once, you must give the source in the next sentence or paragraph.

Do not use *reportedly* as a substitute for *allegedly*. Sometimes, reporters use *reportedly* when they are not sure of their facts. This usage is not acceptable. You can say that an event *reportedly happened* only if the event has been reported elsewhere and you mention the source.

Representation of the People Act Not *Representation of People's Act*.

Republic Day In headlines, *Republic Day* can be shortened to *R-Day*, but not to *R-D*.

SEE ALSO **ANNIVERSARY**.

Republican Party

reputation, character SEE **CHARACTER, REPUTATION**.

requirements Prefer *needs*, which is shorter and better.

rerun

rescission (not *recision*) The act of rescinding.

resemblance

reside *Live* is shorter and better.

resilient Not *resiliant*.

resistance Not *resistence*.

resistible Not *resistable*.

respectively (in the order designated or mentioned) Generally, no comma is needed before *respectively*: *These books cost $55 and $30 respectively*.

rest(-) restroom

rest home, rest house, rest period, rest stop

restaurateur (not *restauranteur*) Note the absence of *n*.

result *As a result*, not *as the result*.

result in Avoid. Prefer *cause*, *bring about*, *create*, *evoke* or *lead to*.

résumé CV.

resuscitate

retaliation Write *in retaliation against* or *for*, not *to*.

reticent (unwilling to talk), **reluctant** (unwilling to act)

retired, retd Most retired military officers keep their titles. Avoid this form: *General (Retired) J J Singh was appointed governor of Arunachal Pradesh*. A more elegant alternative: *General J J Singh, who retired as the chief of the Indian Army, was appointed governor of Arunachal Pradesh*.

Reuters Note *s*.

reveal Use with caution. The use of the word implies that the journalist accepts that the statement is true and that the information had previously been kept secret, which may not be the case.

revel(-) *Revelry* in both British English and American English. But *revelled*, *revelling*, *reveller* in British English and *reveled*, *reveling*, *reveler* in American English.

revenge SEE **AVENGE, REVENGE | VENGEANCE, REVENGE**.

revenue deficit SEE **FISCAL DEFICIT, REVENUE DEFICIT, PRIMARY DEFICIT**.

Reverend, Rev Do not omit *the* before *Reverend* or *Rev*, except in headlines.

reverie (daydream) Not *revery*.

reverse-engineer, reverse-engineering

revert Do not write *revert back*; *revert* is sufficient.

rheumatism

Rh factor, Rh negative, Rh positive

rhino(s)

rhinoceros(es)

Rhodes scholarship But Rhode Island (US state).

rhythm, rhythmical

Richter scale Superseded by the moment magnitude scale.

SEE **EARTHQUAKES**.

rickshawpuller

ricochet, ricocheted, ricocheting

riffraff

right, rightist Lowercase in references to political ideology.

right(-) right-hand (adjective), right-handed, right-hander, right-minded, right-thinking, right-wing (adjective)

right hand (noun), right(s) of way, right wing (noun)

rigmarole

rile Annoy or anger.

ring(-) ringleader, ringmaster, ringside, ringtone, ringworm

ring finger, ring road

Rio Grande Not *Rio Grande river*. *Rio* means *river*.

riot Keep the word for violent outbreaks, usually involving deaths, major injuries or heavy damage to property.

rip-off (noun), **rip off** (verb)

rite of passage (not *right of passage*) A ceremony or event that marks an important stage in a person's life.

river Write *the Ganga*, *the Yamuna*; not *the Ganga river*, *the Yamuna river*. Put *river* after the name if the river is less familiar to the readers or shares its name with a place: *the Don river*, *the Mississippi river*.

river bed Two words.

riveted, riveting Avoid its clichéd use.

road Cap it only if it is part of a name: *Mahatma Gandhi Road*. In headlines, the abbreviation *Rd* can be used.

Do not write *at Ring Road*. Make it *on Ring Road*.

road(-) roadblock, roadholding, roadhouse, roadroller, roadshow, roadside (noun and adjective), roadway, roadworks, roadworthy

road hog, road map, road rage, road test

roadkill means an *animal, or animals, killed by a car on the road*. It is demeaning to use it for a person killed on the road or for a crime suspect killed by police on the road.

rob You *rob* a person or a bank, using force or the threat of violence, but you *steal* a car or a bag. Instead of *The gang robbed Rs 10 lakh from the bank*, write *The gang robbed the bank of Rs 10 lakh*.

rock bottom (noun), **rock-bottom** (adjective)

rock'n'roll One word.

rocks People throw stones, not rocks.

role model He is a role model *for* (not *to*) his son.

rollerblade

rollercoaster One word.

rollerskate

rollover (noun), **roll over** (verb)

Rolls-Royce Note hyphen.

roly-poly

ROMAN NUMERALS

I, II, III, IV, V… (or i, ii, iii, iv, v…)

Never write *Ist*, *IInd*, *IIIrd*, etc. The correct forms are *1st*, *2nd*, *3rd,* etc. In copy, spell out *first*, *second*, up to *ninth*.

Rongali Bihu The Assamese New Year's Day, also known as Bohag Bihu. It corresponds to April 13 or 14 of the Gregorian calendar.

room(-) roommate

room service, room temperature

(-)room bedroom, classroom, schoolroom, storeroom, workroom

dining room, family room, living room

rottweiler

rouble is the British spelling; *ruble* is American. There are 100 kopeks in 1 rouble.

roughshod

round, around SEE **AROUND, ROUND**.

round(-) roundabout

round robin (noun), round the clock (adverb), round table (noun), round trip (noun), round up (verb)

round-robin (adjective), round-the-clock (adjective), round-table (adjective), round-trip (adjective), round-up (noun)

ROYALTY, NOBILITY

Do not use titles like King, Queen, Prince, Princess, Lord, Lady and Sir. Instead of *Queen Elizabeth* or *King Abdullah* write *Elizabeth, the British monarch*, or *Abdullah, the hereditary ruler of Saudi Arabia*. In a quote, *Queen Elizabeth* or *King Abdullah* is fine.

Rs for rupees. No full stop. The singular is *Re*.

Write *Rs 500 crore*, not *Rs500 crore*; the space is needed because unlike *$*, which is a symbol, *Rs* is an abbreviation.

SEE ALSO **RUPEES**.

RT Retweet. SEE ALSO **TWEET**.

rubber stamp (noun), **rubber-stamp** (verb and adjective)

rubbish Avoid as a verb.

RUMOURS

Treat all rumours with caution. Try to pinpoint their origin. Report them only if they have or are likely to have a significant impact. Do not give up when confirmation or denial is not immediately available. Get official comment as quickly as possible. Do not write *unconfirmed rumours*; a rumour is by definition unconfirmed. In trying to check unofficial reports of the death or serious illness of a leading political figure, the newspaper should not lay itself open to a charge of spreading rumours.

Rumours, including unconfirmed press reports and trade speculation, can affect markets. Check such impact thoroughly and report it responsibly.

— If one source tells you about a rumour, do not call other sources and mention it to them. Just ask how they account for the price change. If different sources independently volunteer the same rumour, it would be widespread.

— Any "no comment" must be reported, especially when it involves a response to market-moving news. Carry the exact quotation.

— Say how a price is affected by a rumour and explain why the market views it as bullish or bearish. When rumours continue to affect markets, always include whatever official reaction you can get.

— A rumour about a specific company or individual must not be referred to in market reports without checking with the company or individual involved.

run, stand In a country with a presidential system you *run* for office; in one with a parliamentary system, you *stand*.

run(-) runaround (noun), runaway (noun and adjective), rundown (noun meaning *brief review* or *summary*), runway

run-down (adjective meaning *exhausted* or *worn-out*), run-in (noun), run-off (noun), run-of-the-mill, run-through, run-up

runner(s)-up

running mate

rupees With the abbreviation *Rs*, use figures even for numbers below 10: *Rs 5*, *Rs 8.30*, *Rs 1 lakh*, *Rs 2 crore*. But: *one rupee*, *five rupees*.

For one rupee or a decimal fraction below one rupee, use *Re*: *Re 1*, *Re 0.75*. But: *Rs 1.50*. Do not write *Rs 1.50 paise* or *Re 1.50*.

Write *Rs 2 lakh to Rs 5 lakh*, not *Rs 2 to 5 lakh* unless that is what you mean.

Do not use a hyphen in the simple adjective form: *Rs 5 crore deal*. Longer modifiers need hyphens: *a Rs 10-crore-a-year job*. Use apostrophes in expressions like *a crore rupees' worth* but drop the apostrophe in *Rs 1 crore worth*.

SEE ALSO **SINGULAR OR PLURAL?**

rushed to hospital Do not use this cliché. Write *taken to*, *driven to* or *flown to hospital*.

rush hour (noun), **rush-hour** (adjective)

russian roulette Lowercase.

***

If you can't explain it simply, you don't understand it well enough.
— **Albert Einstein**

S

's, s' SEE **POSSESSIVES**.

Saarc (not all caps) is acceptable even in first reference to the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation. But the full name should be given somewhere up front in the story.

sabbath Cap in religious references; lowercase otherwise.

saboteur

saccharin (noun), **saccharine** (adjective)

sacrilegious Not *sacreligious*; the word, derived from *sacrilege*, is not related to *religion*.

safe(-) safebreaker, safecracker, safeguard, safekeeping

safe-conduct (noun), safe-deposit (adjective)

safe house, safe surfing

safe sex *Protected sex* is more precise.

Safta South Asian Free Trade Area. Not all caps.

saga A long story of adventure or heroism, not just any story.

Sagarmatha Nepalese name for Mount Everest.

Sahabhagi Not *Sahbhagi*.

Sahara, the Not *Sahara desert*; *Sahara* means *desert*. Examples: *He travelled across the Sahara.* | *The Sahara is heading north.*

Sahitya Akademi Not *Sahitya Academy*.

said Put *said* after the subject: *The flood was a national calamity, the minister said*. Avoid putting it befor the subject, as in *The flood was a national calamity, said the minister*.

Remember also that the plain *said* is often better than loaded verbs like *claimed*, *commented*, *declared* and *pointed out*.

sail(-) sailboard, sailboarding, sailcloth, sailfish, sailplane

sailer (ship or boat), **sailor** (seaman)

sake Not *saki*. Japanese wine made from fermented rice.

saleable

salesgirl Use *saleswoman* for an adult.

salutary Not *salutory*.

Salvadoran(s) A native or inhabitant of El Salvador. *Not Salvadorean* or *Salvadorian*.

salvo(s)

Salwa Judum State government-backed fight against Naxalites in Chhattisgarh. Literal meaning: *peace march*.

sanatorium(s) Not *sanitarium(s)* or *sanitorium(s)*.

sandal Not *sandle*.

sand dunes

S&M Short for *sadism and masochism*, or *sadomasochism*.

sandstorm

sandwich Not *sandwitch*.

Sangh Parivar Do not italicize.

sanitary Not *sanitory*.

Sankara Nethralaya Not *Shankar Netralaya*.

sans This archaic word is best confined to humorous references and, of course, to sans serif fonts. Use *without*.

Santa Claus

Santiniketan One word; do not write *Shantiniketan* or *Santi Niketan*.

SEE ALSO **VISVA-BHARATI**.

sari Not *saree*.

SARS Acceptable in all references to severe acute respiratory syndrome, but spell it out somewhere up front in the story.

sarsanghachalak The chief of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh.

Satan But lowercase *devil* and *satanic*.

satphone Satellite phone.

Saudi Arabia Do not shorten to *Saudi* in headlines. *Saudi* is an adjective.

sauté, sautéed, sautéing

saw Avoid constructions like *The day saw 10 accidents*. Days, months, years or events cannot see anything.

scalable

scam, scandal A scam is a fraudulent operation for making money: *an insurance scam*. *A* scandal is behaviour or an event that is thought to be morally or legally wrong and causes public feelings of shock or anger: *a sex scandal*.

Scandinavia Denmark, Norway and Sweden. The three Scandinavian countries, together with Finland and Iceland, are known as Nordic countries.

scant Not just small but inadequate or meagre.

scapegoat

scarf Plural *scarves*.

scars do not heal. Wounds heal; scars remain.

scenario means *an outline or synopsis of a play or opera, indicating scenes and characters*. It also means a *predicted sequence of events*, as in *Let's try another scenario involving the demise of democracy*. Do not use it as a substitute for *a chain of events*, *situation*, *scene* or *plan*.

sceptic, sceptical are the British spellings; *skeptic* and *skeptical* are American.

SEE ALSO **CYNICAL, SCEPTICAL**.

schadenfreude Lowercase. This German word means *glee at another's misfortune*.

Schedule (of the Constitution) *First Schedule, Fifth Schedule, 10th Schedule*.

scheduled caste(s), scheduled tribe(s) Lowercase.

schizophrenia, schizophrenic Instead of *X is schizophrenic*, write *X has schizophrenia*. Do no use *schizo*; it is an offensive word.

school(-) schoolbook, schoolboy, schoolchildren, schoolgirl, schoolmaster, schoolmate, schoolroom, schoolteacher, schoolwork

school board, school bus, school day, school night, school year

school-leaving certificate

scissors requires plural verbs and pronouns.

scoreboard, scorecard

scotch (verb) means *disable* or *stop something from happening*: *He issued a statement to scotch the rumours of his death*. It does not mean *destroy*.

Scotch whisky If the context is clear, *scotch* (lowercase) is fine.

scot-free

screen(-) screenplay, screensaver, screenwriter

screen door, screen test

scribe Avoid. Use *journalist* or *reporter*.

scriptwriter

scrutiny means *a close or careful examination*, so do not write *close scrutiny* or *careful scrutiny*.

SC, ST Act The full name is Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

scuba Acronym for self-contained underwater breathing apparatus. Lowercase.

Scud missile

sculptor A person who makes sculptures. The verb is *sculpt* or *sculpture*.

scurrilous

sea(-) seabed, seaboard, seaborne, seacoast, seafarer, seafaring, seafood, seaman, seaplane, seaport, seashore, seasick, seaside, seaweed

sea anemone, sea bird, sea breeze, sea change, sea cucumber, sea dog, sea green, sea horse, sea level, sea otter, sea serpent, sea sickness, sea urchin

seasonal, seasonable *Seasonal* applies to what depends on or is controlled by the season of the year: *a seasonal rise in prices*. *Seasonable* applies to what is appropriate to the season (as in *seasonable clothing*) or timely (as in *seasonable intervention in the dispute*). Rain is seasonal if it occurs at a certain time of the year; it is seasonable at any time if it saves the crops. The opposite of both *seasonal* and *seasonable* is *unseasonable*. However, *unseasonal* can be used in weather descriptions.

SEASONS
Lowercase *winter*, *spring*, *summer*, *autumn*.

seat belt

Sebi (not all caps) is acceptable even in first reference to the Securities and Exchange Board of India, but give the full name somewhere up front in the story.

sec Clipped form of *second(s)*. Use only in headlines. Do not write *secs*.

secede

second Use *2nd* only in headlines and charts. Never write *IInd*, *IIIrd*, etc.

second guess (noun), **second-guess** (verb)

second-hand (adjective)

second-rate

secretary general No hyphen, lowercase.

section Cap when used with a figure, as in *Section 304A of the IPC*.

Securities and Exchange Commission The US market regulator. *SEC* in subsequent references.

securityman One word. An Indian coinage.

see it happen, see it happening Both are correct but their meanings are different. *He saw it happen* means he saw the entire action or event, whereas *He saw it happening* means he saw a part of the action or event in progress, going on. Other verbs of perception, which take similar constructions, include *hear*, *notice* and *watch*.

seesaw

seize Not *sieze*.

self(-) Compounds are hyphenated: self-abuse, self-assured, self-censorship, self-centred, self-confidence, self-control, self-defence, self-destruct, self-esteem, self-fulfilling, self-government, self-help, self-immolation, self-interest, self-loading, self-made, self-medicate,

self-realization, self-rule, self-sacrifice, self-seeking, self-styled, self-sufficient, self-timer

Exceptions: selfhood, selfless, selfsame, selfward

(-)self, (-)selves herself, himself, itself, myself, ourselves, themselves, yourself, yourselves

Called reflexive pronouns, these words add emphasis or turn the action back to the subject: *The minister said so himself.* | *He is not himself today.* | *You should drive the car yourself.*

Never use a reflexive pronoun as the subject of a verb. *He and I are partners* is right, but *He and myself are partners* is wrong.

Never use a reflexive pronoun when it does not refer to the subject of the verb. *I wrote the story myself* is right, but *The story was written by myself* is wrong.

self-goal An Indian coinage for *own goal*. Use *own goal*.

sell(-) selloff (noun), sellout (noun and adjective)

sell off (verb), sell out (verb)

sell-by date

(-)sell hard sell (noun), hard selling (noun), soft sell (noun), soft selling (noun), short sale (noun), short selling (noun)

hard-selling (adjective), soft-selling (adjective), short-selling (adjective), short-seller (noun)

semi(-) Compounds formed with *semi-* are generally one word in American English. In British English, many of them are hyphenated but the trend is to write them as one word. For the moment, we write only the more familiar among them as one word:

semibold, semicircle, semicolon, semiconductor, semifinal, semimetal, semivowel

semi-arid, semi-automatic, semi-conscious, semi-fluid, semi-literate, semi-official, semi-precious, semi-pro, semi-professional, semi-skilled, semi-solid, semi-tropical

Hyphenate if the second element of the compound begins with *i* or a capital letter. Also hyphenate coined compounds to avoid confusion.

semi-annual, semi-yearly Happening every half year, or twice a year; *biannual* means the same. *Biennial* means *happening every two years*. To avoid confusion, use expressions like *every half year*, *every six months* or *every two years*.

SEMICOLON

The semicolon is used to connect two complete sentences when they meet the following conditions: (i) they are too closely connected to be separated by a full stop; (ii) they are not joined by a connecting word that would require a comma, such as *and*, *or*, *but*, *while* or *yet*; and (iii) they do not meet the requirement for a colon. Examples: *Some films were excellent; others were ordinary.* | *The plane hovered over Delhi for an hour; there was no ATC clearance.*

If three or more items form a series and any item includes a comma, use a semicolon between the items; retain the semicolon even before the final *and*. Example: *The victims included Puneet, Ram's younger brother; Pramod, the family's domestic help; and Rani, their maidservant.*

The semicolon cannot be used if what precedes or follows is not a complete sentence. An example of wrong use: *He finished his work on time; as always.* Replace the semicolon with a comma.

Use a semicolon to separate two parts of a headline if a comma has been used in either part.

semi-monthly Twice a month. *Bimonthly* means *once every two months*. To avoid confusion, say *twice a month* or *once every two months*.

semi-weekly Twice a week. *Biweekly* means *once every two weeks*. To avoid confusion, say *twice a week* or *once every two week*s.

Senate Cap in reference to the upper house of the US Congress.

send-off (noun), **send off** (verb)

senior In names, abbreviate to *Sr*, not *Sen* or *Sn*.

senior citizen Use the term with care. SEE **ELDERLY**.

seniormost Use *most senior*. Similarly, *most junior*, not *juniormost*.

(come to one's) senses The expression *he came to his senses* means *he started to think clearly and behave sensibly again*. It does not mean *he regained consciousness*. The expression for regaining consciousness is *come to*: *He had been in a coma. When he came to, he recognized his family members*. The opposite of *come to* is *pass out*.

sensex for Bombay Stock Exchange sensitive index. Write *the sensex* and lowercase. The lowercase *sensex* is in the good company of lowercase names like *sun*, *earth* and *internet*.

sensual, sensuous *Sensual* means *carnal* or *voluptuous*. S*ensuous* means *pertaining to aesthetic appreciation*; it does not imply *lasciviousness*.

SENTENCE LENGTH

Long sentences are less readable; they slow down the reading and the thought. An average sentence length of 20 to 25 words is considered ideal. But varying your sentence length is important; some sentences could be 30 or 40 words and others 3 or 4 (Garner's Modern American Usage).

separate

septuagenarian

sequence of tenses SEE **TENSE**.

sequester (seclude), **sequestrate** (confiscate or make bankrupt) The distinction, however, has disappeared and *sequester* is used in both senses (Garner's Modern American Usage).

sergeant

server A server is a computer that is host to a website.

serviceable

services, the Armed forces.

serving officer Write just *officer*. Unless you write *former officer,* it is clear that you mean a serving officer.

set(-) setback (noun)

set back (verb), set in (verb), set off (verb), set screw, set up (verb)

set-in (adjective), set-off (noun), set-to (noun meaning *fight*), set-top box, set-up (noun)

Sethusamudram project

set to A cliché. Write *will* if the event is certain to happen; otherwise, write *to* or *likely to*.

7-Eleven A chain of convenience stores. Its stores are located in 18 countries, its largest markets being Japan, the US, Taiwan and Thailand. It has been, since March 2007, the largest store chain in any category, beating McDonald's by 1,000 stores.

seven seas Used since antiquity, this term has meant different sets of water bodies to different cultures in different periods. In modern usage, it generally denotes a great expanse of water or all the planet's seas and oceans.

Seven Sisters Seven northeastern states: Assam, Nagaland, Tripura, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram and Arunachal Pradesh.

seven-year itch A tendency towards infidelity, traditionally said to begin after about seven years of marriage.

sever, severe *Sever* means *cut*; its past tense and past past participle is *severed* and its -ing form is *severing*. *Severe* means *harsh*.

sewage, sewer, sewerage *Sewage* is waste matter carried off by *sewers* (pipes or drains). *Sewerage* means *a system of sewers*.

SEXIST LANGUAGE

Do not use language that perpetuates the stereotype of women as the weaker, inferior sex. Such language is offensive, out of date and often inaccurate. Sexist references should be avoided, as should be such linguistic absurdities as *people-slaughter*. It is wrong to assume that police, firefighters or soldiers are always men. *Police* is shorter than *policemen* anyway. Most armies can be said to deploy troops or soldiers rather than men, avoiding any need to worry about whether women are among them. To say police *set up roadblocks* is more active than saying *manned*. Man does not explore space alone any more. People do, and they can *crew* a ship or *staff* an office. Do not identify a woman as such unless her gender is pertinent to the story. Wherever possible, use the same term for men and women; for example, *mayor* or *poet*, not *mayoress* or *poetess*. The government sets up a *five-member committee*, not *five-man* or *five-person committee*. The fact that a president is a woman and a mother is no more relevant to most stories than the fact that another president is a man and a father. Do not describe her dress or hairstyle where you would not describe his. Use *woman*, not *lady*. Any female older than 18 is a woman, not a girl, just as any male older than 18 is a man.

SEE ALSO **FEMALE, MALE** | **LADY, GENTLEMAN** | **(-)PERSON** | **SPOKESPERSON**.

sexual orientation Use this term rather than *sexual preference*, which carries the disputed implication that sexuality is a matter of choice. Mention a person's sexual orientation only if it is pertinent to the story.

SEE ALSO **BISEXUAL** | **GAY** | **LESBIAN** | **LGBT** | **STRAIGHT**.

Shab-e-Barat Not *Shabb-e-Barat*.

shadow-boxing Hyphenate.

shake(-) shakeout, shakeup (nouns)

shake out, shake up (verbs)

shake hands Not *shake hand*.

Shakespearean

shall, will The rule we all learned in school is that while expressing simple futurity, *shall* is used with *I* and *we*, and *will* is used with everything else: *I shall not be here next week.* | *They will arrive tomorrow*. While expressing a command, obligation or determination, the positions are reversed: *It shall be done.* | *I will give up smoking*. However, *shall* has come to be largely neglected in favour of *will*, which has become the common form of the future in all three persons (Collins English Dictionary).

There are two significant exceptions to this trend. First, in India as well as Britain, *shall* is used even with the second person or the third person in formal written English of legal documents and regulations: *A person not adhering to the city's traffic rules shall have to pay a fine of up to Rs 2,000.* In the US too, *shall* is preferred in this context. Second, *shall* rather than *will* is used with the first person in questions like these: *Shall we go?* | *Shall I open the door?*

The contraction for both *shall* and *will* is *'ll*: *I'll go, he'll go*. Contractions, however, should be used only in quotations or informal contexts.

By the outdated textbook rule mentioned at the beginning of this entry, "We shall overcome" is grammatically wrong!

shambles Always *in a shambles*, not *in shambles.*

Shangri-La An imaginary paradise on earth.

shantytown

shape-up (noun), **shape up** (verb)

shareholder One word.

share owner Two words.

shares outstanding (not *outstanding shares*) Stock currently held by investors. It includes restricted shares owned by the company's officers and insiders. Shares that have been repurchased by the company are not included in shares outstanding. Stocks owned by investors and available for trading constitute a company's *floating stock* or *float*. These do not include restricted shares owned by the company's officers and insiders.

sharia Islamic law.

sharpener Not *sharpner*.

sharpshooter A person who shoots with great accuracy.

s/he Never use. SEE **HE OR SHE, HIS OR HER, HIM OR HER**.

she, her Do not use for countries, ships, cars and aircraft. Use for an animal only if it has been given a name. The occasional bright story may be enhanced by the use of a feminine or masculine pronoun to personalize a machine or animal, but these should be rare exceptions.

sheepdog

shelf life Two words.

shell shock (noun), **shell-shocked** (adjective)

shenanigans Trickery or mischief.

shepherd

sheriff Not *sherrif*.

shh Interjection used to tell people to be quiet.

Shia Not *Shiite* or *Shi'ite*. SEE ALSO **SUNNI**.

shiatsu Japanese massage therapy.

shibboleth A phrase or custom distinguishing a particular class or group of people.

shih-tzu A small dog of a breed originally developed in Tibet.

shined, shone *I shone the torch in his eyes.* | *I shined my shoes.*

ship(-) shipbuilder, shipbuilding, shipmate, shipowner, shipwreck, shipyard

ship canal

ship-rigged

shish kebab in Britain and America; *shikh kebab* in India.

shock wave

shoe(-) shoehorn, shoelace, shoemaker, shoeshine, shoestring

shoe leather

shoo-in (not *shoe-in*) A person or team that will win easily.

shootdown (noun) Use *shooting down* instead. In a headline, *downing*.

shooter Use *gunman*; *sharpshooter* is fine.

shooting, shootout A *shooting* is a killing by gunfire. A *shootout* is a gunfight involving two or more sides.

shop(-) shopkeeper, shoplifter, shopowner, shopsoiled (in American English, *shopworn*), shoptalk, shopwalker (in American English, *floorwalker*)

shop assistant, shop floor

(-)shop barbershop, bookshop, pawnshop, sweatshop, toyshop

machine shop, repair shop

short(-) shortbread, shortcake, shortcoming, shortfall, shorthand, shortsighted

short covering, short cut (noun), short leg (cricket), short selling, short shrift, short story, short term (noun)

short-change (verb), short-circuit (verb), short-cut (verb), short-handed (short-staffed or with less than the full complement of players), short-lived, short-tempered, short-term (adjective)

short covering Expecting prices to continue falling, traders often sell securities that they do not own. When the trend reverses, they must *cover their short positions* by buying back, often at a loss, what they sold. Because many traders are buying, prices rise, resulting in a *short-covering* rally.

SEE ALSO **POSITION**.

shortlist (noun and verb) Similarly, *longlist* for a list from which suitable candidates are selected; not *long list*, because a *longlist* is not necessarily long.

short selling Selling or agreeing to sell shares, currencies, etc, that you do not yet own, hoping that the price will fall and you will make a profit by buying them later at a lower price.

short shrift (not *a short shrift*) If you or your idea is *given short shrift*, you are told immediately that you are wrong and are not given any attention or sympathy. If you *make short shrift* of something, you dismiss it quickly and unsympathetically.

short work The phrase is *make short work* (not *a short work*) *of somebody or something*. It means *to defeat* or *deal with quickly*.

shotgun

shot put (noun), **shot-put** (verb), **shot-putter** (noun)

show(-) showcase, showdown, showgirl, showground, showman, showpiece, showroom

show house, show off (verb), show stopper

show-off (noun)

(-)show Compounds are generally one word:

chatshow, gameshow, quizshow, talkshow

show-cause (adjective, as in *a show-cause notice*) Do not use the word as a verb. Instead of *He was show-caused* (or *showcaused*) *by the party*, write *He got a show-cause notice from the party*.

showing (presentation, performance)

shrink The past tense is *shrank* and the past participle *shrunk*. Use *shrunken* only as a modifier before a noun.

shut(-) shutdown, shuteye, shutout (nouns)

shut-in, shut-off (nouns)

shut down, shut in, shut off, shut out (verbs)

Shyam Lal College Not *Shamlal* or *Shyamlal*. The college is in Delhi.

Siamese twins Do not use. Write *conjoined twins* instead.

Sichuan (not *Szechwan*) Province in China and its cuisine.

sick(-) sickbed, sickout (a kind of industrial protest in which all workers report sick), sickroom

sick bay, sick leave, sick list, sick note, sick pay

sick, ill In British English, *sick* is now commonly restricted to the senses of *experiencing nausea* and *mentally disturbed*. Except in expressions like *sick leave* and *sick pay*, the old sense of *out of health*, is conveyed by *ill*. In American English, *sick* retains the old sense and *ill* is considered formal. In both varieties of English, *sick* also means *morbid* (as in *a sick joke*), *disgusted* (usually as *sick and tired*) and *having a great longing for* (as in *sick for the hills*, *homesick*).

side(-) sideburns (also called sideboards, side whiskers), sidecar, sidekick, sidelight, sideline, sidelines, sidelong, sideroad, sideshow, sideslip, sidestep, sidetrack, sidewall, sideways

side chain, side deal, side street

side-effect, side-splitting

siege Not *seige*. The phrase is *lay siege to*, not *lay siege of*.

sieve

sightseeing, sightseer

sign Do not use as a noun meaning *signature*.

signpost

silhouette

silicon (computer chips), **silicone** (breast implants)

silver When *silver* is used as a substitute for *silver medal*, its plural is *silvers*: He *won 5 silvers*, not *He won 5 silver*.

sim card Lowercase; *sim* stands for subscriber identity module. Like *awol* and *laser*, it has become an everyday word; hence, lowercase.

SIMI All caps. Students Islamic Movement of India.

since As a synonym of *because*, *since* can sometimes be ambiguous because of its association with time. Use *because* to avoid ambiguity.

since, for SEE **FOR, SINCE**.

sine die Without a day being set for meeting again: *The Lok Sabha was adjourned sine die* or *The Lok Sabha adjourned sine die*.

sine qua non A thing that is absolutely essential.

singe The -ing form is *singeing*, to distinguish from *singing*.

single-handed, single-handedly

single out By definition, this phrase should be used only for single examples. Do not write, for instance, *He singled out Britain, France and Italy for blame*. Write *He blamed Britain, France and Italy*.

singles bar, singles scene No apostrophe.

SINGULAR OR PLURAL?

i. A verb must always agree with its subject — a singular subject takes a singular verb and a plural subject takes a plural verb. Simple, isn't it? Not always. Consider this sentence: *A closer look at the pay commission's recommendations show that the percentage raise varies even within the same scale*. Here, *show* is wrong; it should be *shows*. The writer mistook *recommendations* for the subject.

Look at another sentence: *He is one of those politicians who opposes reservation for women in the legislature*. Here, *opposes* is wrong; it should be *oppose*. In this case too, the writer misidentified the subject. The subject is not *he*; it is *who*, which refers to the plural *politicians*.

This mistake occurs especially when the verb is far removed from the subject. You must carefully read what you have written.

ii. Some subjects are plural in form but singular in sense. They take singular verbs. Examples include sums of money, quantities of commodities and periods of time:

Five hundred rupees does not buy much these days.
Seven kilos of cocaine was found by police during the raid.
Ten years is a long time.

Use the plural when the focus is on individual items: *One thousand packets of food were distributed.*

iii. A phrase beginning with *a number of* is plural: *A number of remedies exist*. But a phrase beginning with *the number of* is singular: *The number of teen pregnancies is rising*. The same rule applies to phrases like *a total of*, *the total of*, *a series of* and *the series of*.

iv. A tricky situation arises when the subject is the pronoun *what*. Depending on the sense, you should decide whether to construe it as *the thing that* (singular) or *the things that* (plural). Once the decision is made, all verbs must conform: *What was disturbing was the mistakes made by editors.* | *What were most in demand were T-shirts and jeans.*

v. Consider this sentence: *One person was killed and nine injured in the accident.* Nine persons *was* injured? No, the sentence needs *were* after *nine*: *One person was killed and nine were injured in the accident.*

vi. Collective nouns like *audience*, *crew*, *family* and *staff* are generally treated as singular. They are treated as plural when the emphasis is on individual members. In sports contexts, *team* is plural in British English, but singular in American English. *Police* is always plural in British as well as American English.

Treating a word as singular in one sentence and plural in the next is bad style. Once you have decided on singular or plural, stick to the decision.

In American English, treating collective nouns as plural is generally considered wrong, *police* being perhaps the only exception.

vii. The name of a country is treated as singular even if it has a plural form ending in *s*; for example, *the United States*, *the Netherlands*.

SEE ALSO **ALONG WITH** | **AS WELL AS** | **COUPLE** | **FEW WHO** | **EITHER ... OR** | **MORE THAN ONE** | **ONE IN** | **ONE OF THE**.

Sinhalese

sink Past tense *sank*, past participle *sunk*. Modifier before a noun: *sunken*.

Sinn Féin

Sino-Indian Old-fashioned. Use *India-China* or *China-India*.

SEE ALSO **INDOCHINA**.

siphon Not *syphon*.

sissy Not *cissy*.

sit-down (noun), **sit down** (verb)

sit-in (noun and adjective), **sit in** (verb)

sitting MLA, sitting MP Write just *MLA* or *MP*. Unless you write *former MLA* or *former MP,* it is clear that you mean a present MLA or MP.

situated Like *located*, often redundant. Write *Jantar Mantar is in Delhi* rather than *Jantar Mantar is situated in Delhi*.

sizable Not *sizeable*.

size size 2 dress, size 9 shoes

(-)size, (-)sized Generally, *-size* rather than *-sized*.

midsize, outsize

king-size, life-size, medium size

ski, skis, skier, skied, skiing

skilful

skulduggery (dishonest behaviour) Not *skullduggery*; the word is not related to *skull*.

skyrocket Use *rocket* instead.

skyscraper

slam dunk A basketball term meaning *a forceful move* or *something that can be done with certainty*: *The presidential race was not a slam dunk for Barack Obama.* | *The movie is a slam-dunk hit.*

SLASH

Use the slash only in joint datelines like *Lucknow/New Delhi*, fractions like *2/5,* and expressions like *24/7* or *9/11*. It can also be used to denote the ends of lines in quoted poetry. In other instances, it can often be replaced with *and* or *or*. Instead of *his/her*, *SCs/STs*, write *his or her*, *SCs or STs*.

Do not confuse the slash (/) with the backslash (\ ), which is used as a path separator in Windows, as in *C:\Program Files\Microsoft Office*.
Web addresses use the slash, not the backslash:
http://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/.

slate Avoid as a verb. Use *plan* or *schedule*.

slaughterhouse One word.

Slav Not *Slavic*.

slay takes the forms *slaying*, *slew* (not *slayed*) and *slain*. The word is outdated and best avoided except in literary contexts. *Slain*, however, continues to be used as an adjective, as in *slain police officers*.

sledgehammer

sleeper cell In intelligence parlance, a sleeper is an agent long in place but not yet activated. Intelligence agencies use the term *sleeper cell* to refer to a unit of terrorists that lies dormant inside a target population until it receives orders or decides to act.

sleep with means *to have sex with*. Do not use it if a sexual relationship is not implied, as in this line from one of our stories: *She was sleeping with family members, unlike the other victims who were attacked while sleeping in the open*. You should, however, let a mother sleep with her baby.

sleight of hand

slew Informal word meaning *a large number of*, as in *a slew of books on cricket*.

Slovak Not *Slovakian*.

slowdown (noun), **slow down** (verb)

slumlord

small-business man Not *small businessman*. Similarly, *small-business woman*.

smallpox After successful vaccination campaigns, the WHO certified the eradication of smallpox in 1979. Smallpox is the only human infectious disease to have been completely eradicated.

small scale (noun), **small-scale** (adjective)

smart alec Not *smart aleck*. Adjective *smart-alec* or *smart-alecky*.

smartcard One word, as *scratchcard*, *swipecard*.

smartphone

smelled, smelt Use *smelled*.

smiley(s)

Smithsonian Institution Not *Institute*.

smokescreen One word.

smooth Noun and verb.

SMS Plural *SMSs,* not *SMSes*; verbs *SMSing*, *SMSed*. In both British English and American English, *text* is the preferred word.

snarl Not *snarl-up*.

sneaked Never *snuck*, which is considered non-standard in American English as well.

snigger Prefer *snigger* to its American variant, *snicker*.

sniper has a military connotation; if that is not the case, use *gunman*.

snow(-) snowball, snowbird, snowblower, snowboard, snowbound, snowcapped, snowfall, snowman, snowmobile, snowshoe, snowstorm

snow bridge, snow day, snow fence, snow job, snow leopard, snow line

snow-blind, snow-white (but Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs)

so-called (adjective), **so called** (adverb) Quotation marks are redundant in expressions like *so-called "social service"*, *so-called "justice"*.

soccer US name for the game that is called football everywhere else.

soccer mom A typical mother from the middle or upper classes in the US who spends a lot of time taking her children to activities like sports and music lessons. Similarly, *hockey mom*.

social distancing Maintaining physical distance to reduce disease spread.

socialism Lowercase.

socialist Lowercase in references to the ideology; cap in references to a specific party.

socio(-) sociobiology, sociocultural, sociolect, sociolinguistics,

sociopath socio-economic, socio-political

soft conrer Do not say *The boss has a soft corner for her*. Make it *The boss has a soft spot for her*.

soft-spoken

software Not a countable noun. Do not form a plural by adding *s*. If you think *software* will be ambiguous in plural, write *software programs*.

soi-disant is a French term meaning *self-proclaimed* or *self-styled*. It does not mean *so-called*.

solar Lowercase.

soliloquy, soliloquies

solvable

some Write *about 500 people* rather than s*ome 500 people*. As an indication that a figure is an approximation, *some* is more likely to confuse readers.

sometime, some time, sometimes, some times

Some time or *some times* is two words only when it refers to a measurable period of time. Some examples of correct use:

Let's meet sometime next week.
Can you find some time to meet me next week?

My mother sometimes gets angry.
We've had some times together since I met her in March.

Sometimes (one word) is always used as an adverb. *Sometime* (one word) is generally used as an adverb but can also be used as an adjective meaning *former,* as in *M P Modi, sometime chairman of the Telecom Commission, became a member of the RIL board.* It has another meaning, *occasional*, as in *He is a sometime contributor to the newspaper*.

songs Put titles of songs, including national anthems, in quotation marks.

sooner rather than later A cliché. Replace with *soon*.

sort SEE **TYPE, KIND, SORT**.

SOS Distress call.

soul patch A small growth of beard under a man's lower lip.

soundbite A comment from a source, caught on camera or radio. *Byte* is a computer term. Do not write *soundbyte*.

soundtrack

SOURCING

Every story should be clearly and explicitly sourced to enable readers to form their own judgment of its credibility and to protect the reporter and the newspaper from libel action.

General guidelines

— Any contentious statement must be rigorously sourced. But do not blunt the impact of a story, particularly of an intro, by excessive and intrusive sourcing if the sourced information is not in dispute. Ensure that a story is credible, impartial and legally safe.

— Do not use *reports* or *unconfirmed reports* as the basis for a story. You can quote an acceptable source commenting on them. For example, *The minister said he could not confirm reports that 100 people had died.*

— Avoid writing *it was not known*. In many cases, this phrase simply means the reporter does not know. Do not say *It was not known who committed the robbery.* Use a source instead: *Police said they did not know who committed the robbery.*

Confidentiality

The extent to which a source's identity can be revealed while attributing varies from story to story. It is the section editor's call. In the case of a sensitive story, consult the editor.

Sourcing gradation

A reporter eyewitness is the best source. Next best is a named source. It gives more protection if the story is challenged. The weakest sources are unnamed ones. Responsibility for reporting what they say is the newspaper's alone. Unnamed sources rank as follows, in order of strength:

— A source identified by name as well as by position carries more weight: *the company's spokesman, Arjun Mehta, said* rather than *a company spokesman said*. But cite *sources* only for substantial information and contentious statements, not for routine information of a secondary nature. Be as specific as possible: *an official who was at the meeting* rather than *an official source*; *an army officer at the scene* rather than *military sources*.

— An authoritative source exercises real authority on the issue in question. A defence minister is an authoritative source on defence matters, but not necessarily on finance. Do not use the plain *analysts* in first reference; explain the analysts' area of expertise: *political analysts, military analysts, stock analysts*.

— Do not use *on condition of anonymity* indiscriminately. The revelation must be serious or confidential enough to justify the phrase.

Sourcing style

— Cite a source, not sources, in direct quotations. Do not write: *"This will anger the government," the sources said*. Instead write: *"This will anger the government," one of the sources said.*

— Quote *a diplomat,* not *diplomatic sources*; *an official*, not *official sources*.

— Write *police said* rather than *police sources said*, unless the information has been expressly given on an unattributable basis.

— Use the phrase *who declined to be named* when you have to make clear that a source insisted on anonymity. You need not use it as a tag every time you quote a diplomat or a police officer.

— If your information comes from various unnamed sources, you need not source each item. Give a generic sourcing: *Interviews with members of the different guerrilla groups showed a deep split on the issue.*

— Attribution should never amount to a truism. Because *source* merely means a provider of information, *sources said* or *a source* said is equivalent to *somebody said*. The word *source* is empty without a modifier. Hence, do not write *a source, sources or observers.* But a *CBI source* or an *oil ministry* source is acceptable unless, of course, it is possible to tell the reader more. You would not quote a source unless he is reliable or informed. Hence, do not write *reliable sources, informed sources* or *well-informed sources.* Never attribute information or opinion to *quarters* or *circles.*

— If an informant wants to make a vituperative attack on an individual, organization or country he must speak on the record. In expressions of opinion and vituperative attacks, when quoting unnamed sources on one side of a conflict about what is happening on the other side use them only for facts, not opinions.

— Do not use phrases that suggest we are taking sides in a dispute. Do not write *Hopes rose that Opec would set a lower benchmark price for oil.* Clarify whose hopes these are. But you can share unsourced the hopes and fears of common humanity: *Fears were mounting that 132 miners trapped …*

— Do not use passive sourcing: *it was announced, it was believed, it was understood.*

If information comes from people with vested interests, acknowledge that. The readers will appreciate it if you write *The document was provided by a CPM MP who did not want the party to bring down the UPA government.*

Do not write *home ministry officials* while citing a single official. Also, do not write *another official* while citing someone named in a previous paragraph.

south, southern, southeast, southwest, the south
Lowercase except when it is part of a name: *south Delhi*, *southern food*. But: *South Asia.*

South Africa (the country), **southern Africa** (Africa south of the Congo and Zambezi rivers)

South Asia comprises Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. Afghanistan is considered part of central Asia but is a member of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation.

Southeast Asia comprises Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand and Vietnam.

southern hemisphere

south pole

souvenir

sovereign, sovereignty (not *sovereignity*)

soyabean Not *soybean*, but *soy sauce*.

space Avoid its clichéd use in the sense of *area of business*. Do not write *There are too many players in the retail space*. Make it *There are too many retailers* or *The retail market has too may players*.

space(-) spacecraft, spaceflight, spaceman, spaceport, spaceship, spacesuit, spacewalk

space age, space bar, space capsule, space shuttle, space station

spark off *Spark* alone is sufficient. Delete *off* in *The proposal sparked off a storm of protest*.

spartan Lowercase, except in references to ancient Greece.

spastic Never use figuratively or as a term of abuse.

spat (quarrel or dispute) Use it as a noun, not as a verb.

speciality (British), **specialty** (American) In the context of medicine, the spelling is *specialty* in both forms of English.

specially, especially SEE **ESPECIALLY, SPECIALLY**.

species Singular and plural. There is no such thing as a *specie*.

SEE ALSO **GENUS, SPECIES**.

speculation Avoid the plural *speculations*. Most often the singular form is appropriate.

speechwriter

speed dating An organized meeting in which people talk to potential romantic partners for a short time in rotation to assess whether there is mutual interest.

speeded, sped Use *speeded*.

spelled, spelt Use *spelled*.

spell out In the sense of explaining, prefer *detail*, *enumerate*, *explain*, *list* or *specify*. *Spell out in detail* is redundant. In the sense of rendering letter by letter, prefer *spell*.

spicy Not *spicey*.

Spider-Man But *Superman*.

spiky Not *spikey*.

spilled, spilt Use *spilled* as a verb and *spilt* as an adjective: *The crowd spilled out of the theatre.* | *She was crying over spilt milk*. In American English, *spilled* is used in both senses, so an American can *cry over spilled milk*.

spin doctor No hyphen.

spin-off (noun), **spin off** (verb)

spiral (noun and verb) does not necessarily suggest upward movement. Be specific in references to costs, prices or wages.

spit (verb) Past tense is *spat* or *spit*; use *spat*.

spitting image A person who bears a strong physical resemblance to another, especially a relative. The original idiom *spit and image* is no longer the preferred form (Concise Oxford Dictionary, Collins English Dictionary).

split Both *split from* and *split with* are correct: *She split from her boyfriend last month.* | *He split with his wife last year*. *Split up with* too is correct: *He split up with his wife last year*. Prefer *split from*.

SPLIT INFINITIVE

If you write *I asked her to immediately leave*, you are splitting the infinitive *to leave* by putting *immediately* between *to* and *leave*. Such sentences are sometimes awkward and can be easily recast. The above sentence sounds better as *I asked her to leave immediately*.

Such recast is not always easy. Consider this: *He decided to gradually give up smoking*. Here, *gradually* qualifies the action of giving up. The meaning changes if *gradually* is moved to the end of the sentence or after *decided*:
He decided to give up smoking gradually.
He decided gradually to give up smoking.

Avoid splitting an infinitive wherever possible, but split it when that sounds natural and does not cause ambiguity. Most authorities approve of splitting the infinitive; they agree that there is no reason to put the needs of the infinitive above the needs of the adverb.

"Apparently because of a badly confused comparison with the grammar of Latin (which has nothing corresponding to English *to*), a minority of people have for generations allowed themselves to be persuaded that it is unacceptable to place an adverb, or anything else, between *to* and its following verb. I have no sympathy whatever with this view, which I consider ignorant, wrong-headed, foolish and contrary to the facts."
— R L Trask in "Mind the Gaffe"

SEE ALSO **ADVERB PLACEMENT** | **NOT TO, TO NOT**.

SPLITTING A STORY

While splitting a Page 1 story, make sure the part going on an inside page has a newsy intro. Do not repeat the points of the Page 1 story in the story inside. Treat the story inside as a stand-alone story and write the intro and the headline accordingly.

split-up (noun), **split up** (adjective)

spoiled, spoilt Use *spoiled* as a verb and *spoilt* as an adjective.

spokesperson Use *spokesman* or *spokeswoman*, whichever is applicable. Use *official* or *representative* if you do not know the sex of the person. Often a quote can be attributed to an organization rather than a spokesman: *the home ministry said* rather than *a home ministry spokesman said*. When the word is to be used in plural and may include both men and women, use *representatives* or *officials*. Do not use *spokesman*, *spokeswoman* or *spokesperson* as a title before a name.

SEE ALSO **(-)PERSON** | **SEXIST LANGUAGE**.

spoonful Plural *spoonfuls*. Write *two spoonfuls of sugar*, not *two spoons full of sugar* unless you are talking of spoons rather than sugar. Do not write *two spoonsful of sugar*.

Some other similar words are *bagful*, *bucketful*, *cupful*, *handful*, *teaspoonful*; their plurals are *bagfuls*, *bucketfuls*, *cupfuls*, *handfuls*, *teaspoonfuls*.

sport utility vehicle Also *sports utility vehicle*. *SUV* is acceptable in all references.

sports(-) sportscast, sportsman, sportswoman, sportswriter

sports cap, sports car, sports editor, sports jacket, sports medicine, sports shirt

sportswear

spouse When possible, use the more precise *husband* or *wife*. But use *spouse* in sentences like this: *All employees of the company and their spouses have been invited to the party*. *Wives* instead of *spouses* in this sentence would mean that all employees of the company are men.

spring (verb) The past tense is *sprang* and the past participle *sprung*.

spring, springtime

spring-clean (verb), **spring-cleaning** (noun)

spyware Software that is installed on a computer without the user's knowledge and transmits information about the user's computer activities over the internet.

squall A sudden strong wind or short violent storm.

SQUINTING MODIFIER
An ambiguous modifier, usually an adverb, which appears to qualify the words both before and after it. Consider this sentence: *Those who commit mistakes frequently get caught*. To avoid ambiguity place *frequently* either before *commit* or after *caught*. Consider another sentence: *The Prime Minister said on Sunday prices would fall*. Make it *The Prime Minister said on Sunday that prices would fall* or *The Prime Minister said prices would fall on Sunday*, if that is what the Prime Minister meant.

St for *street* is fine in headlines but only when you name the street, as in *Dalal St cold to FM's announcements*. Do not use *St* as a stand-alone abbreviation, as in *St cold to FM's announcements*.

staccato

stadium(s) Do not use *stadia*. Cap *stadium* only when it is part of a proper name: *Wankhede Stadium*.

staff, staffer Like *army*, *crew* and *police*, *staff* is a collective noun. It refers to all the members of a group, not to individuals. Do not say *five staff* or *many staff*. Use *staff members* instead. Keep *staffer(s)* for informal contexts.

stage(-) stagecoach, stagecraft, stagehand

stage door, stage effect, stage fright, stage manager, stage whisper

stage-manage, stage-struck

(-)stage offstage (adjective and adverb), onstage (adjective and adverb)

centre stage

stagflation High inflation plus stagnant growth.

stalactites hang from cave roofs; **stalagmites** (like the Amarnath Shiva lingam) rise from cave floors. Remember: stalactite has a *c* (ceiling) and stalagmite has a *g* (ground).

stalemate Do not use to mean *deadlock*, *impasse* or *stand-off*; a stalemate is the end of the game, and cannot be broken or resolved.

stanch, staunch SEE **STAUNCH, STANCH**.

stand, run See **RUN, STAND**.

stand(-) standby (noun and adjective), standout (noun and adjective), standstill (noun)

stand-alone, stand-in (noun and adjective), stand-off (noun), stand-up (adjective)

stand by, stand in, stand off, stand out, stand up (verbs)

standard-bearer

star-gazer

Star Trek Two words.

startup One word. A company that is just beginning to operate, especially an internet company.

state (verb) Avoid; use *say*.

state Lowercase except when it means *the Union of India* in a legal context.

STATE ABBREVIATIONS

In headlines, the following can be used: Andhra, Arunachal, Guj, Himachal, J&K, MP, Maha, TN, UP and Bengal. *AP* can be ambiguous; it can mean Andhra Pradesh or Arunachal Pradesh. Do not use *C'garh*; it can mean Chhattisgarh or Chandigarh. Keep *WB* for World Bank. J'khand, K'taka, M'rashtra and R'sthan are simply inelegant.

state assembly Lowercase.

state of the union message The US president's written report to Congress. The related speech is the *state of the union address*.

STATES AND UNION TERRITORIES

India has 28 states and 7 Union territories.

States: Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Goa, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Odisha, Punjab, Rajasthan, Sikkim, Tamil Nadu, Tripura, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal

Union territories: Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Chandigarh, Dadra and Nagar Haveli, Daman and Diu, Delhi (official name National Capital Territory of Delhi), Lakshadweep and Puducherry

Delhi remains a Union territory despite getting a legislative assembly after the enactment of the National Capital Territory Act in 1991.

statewide One word.

stationary (not moving), **stationery** (paper, envelopes, pens and other writing materials)

station house

staunch, stanch Use *staunch* for both verb (stop the flow of a liquid) and adjective (loyal or dependable). *Staunch* is an emotive adjective. It should be used with care because it implies approval, as in a *staunch anti-communist*. In American English, *stanch* is the preferred spelling as a verb.

staycation The word is a cross between *stay* and *vacation*. It means *a vacation spent at home or nearby*.

St Bernard The dog.

steam(-) steamboat, steamroll (verb meaning *force*), steamroller (another word for *roadroller*), steamship, steamtight

steam bath, steam boiler, steam engine, steam iron, steam point, steam turbine, steam whistle

sten gun

step(-) stepbrother, stepchild, stepdaughter, stepfather, stepmother, stepsister, stepson

step-family, step-parents

stepbrother, stepsister Your stepbrother is the son from an earlier marriage of your stepmother or stepfather. There is no blood relation between you and your stepbrother. Similarly, *stepsister*.

SEE ALSO **HALF-BROTHER, HALF-SISTER**.

step dance (noun)

Stephanian Not *Stephenian*.

stepladder

stepping stone Two words. In American English: *steppingstone*.

STEREOTYPES

Avoid sweeping characterizations of ethnic, regional, religious, linguistic or caste groups or of the sexes or sexual orientations. Take care to avoid even an indirect stereotype like *cultured Haryanvis*, which implies that Haryanvis are generally uncouth.

SEE ALSO **RACIAL, RELIGIOUS, REGIONAL AND LINGUISTIC LABELS**.

stifling

stiletto(s)

still life (painting or drawing) Plural *still lifes*.

stimulus Plural *stimuli*.

stock(-) stockbroker, stockholder, stockpile, stockroom, stockyard

stock certificate, stock exchange, stock market, stock split

STOI All Caps. Sunday Times of India.

stomp To tread or stamp heavily.

Stone Age

stony Not *stoney*.

stop(-) stopcock, stopgap, stoplight, stopover (noun), stopwatch

stop off (verb), stop order, stop over (verb), stop payment, stop press

store(-) storefront, storehouse, storekeeper, storeroom

(-)store bookstore, drugstore

department store, grocery store

storey is the British spelling; *story* is American. *Multistorey* or *multistoreyed* in British English; *multistory* or *multistoried* in American English.

(-)storm hailstorm, rainstorm, snowstorm, thunderstorm, windstorm

dust storm, ice storm

STORMS

A storm is more severe than a gale. The most severe of all storms is a cyclone, in which winds blow spirally inwards towards a centre of low barometric pressure. The word *cyclone* is used for such storms in the Indian Ocean and Australia. In the China seas and West Pacific, such a storm is called a *typhoon* and in the Caribbean and on the east coast of the US a *hurricane*. A *tornado* or *twister* is a violent whirling windstorm with a very narrow focus; it is common in the US.

storm trooper

story This word for what we print in our columns is newspaper industry jargon. To many readers, it conveys a sense of fiction. Use *article* or *report* while referring to a newspaper story.

storyteller

strafe To machine-gun enemy troops from the air, to punish harshly.

straight As a synonym of *heterosexual*, the word is labelled slang by some dictionaries. But it is all right to use it in sentences drawing a contrast with *gay*. Use *straight* as an adjective, never as a noun: *straight men*, never *straights*.

straightforward

straitened Without enough money.

straitjacket (not *straight-jacket*) means anything that confines or limits.

strait-laced Having old-fashioned ideas about people's moral behaviour.

strangle, strangulate If you mean *choke to death*, use the shorter word *strangle*. Only an external agent, a person or a thing, can *strangle* somebody. The form of *strangulate* that is generally used is *strangulated*. In this form, it is an adjective: *a strangulated whimper*, *a strangulated hernia*.

stranglehold One word.

strapped means *short of cash*; *cash-strapped* is redundant.

stratagem (a trick or plan to deceive an enemy or gain an advantage); unlike in *strategy,* the second *t* is followed by *a*.

strategic The distinction between *strategy* (the conduct of a military campaign) and *tactics* (manoeuvre in the presence of the enemy) is worth preserving. Do not abuse *strategic* by making it simply mean important. A mountain pass, a bridge or even a building is of strategic importance if its possession could affect the conduct of a campaign as a whole. If it is only of local importance its value is tactical.

stratum Plural *strata*. In non-scientific contexts, *layer(s)* is better.

streetcar

street-smart

streetwise

strike Do not use as a verb in the sense of *going on strike*. Wrong: *The employees are striking this week*. Right: *The employees are on strike this week*. Instead of *The employees struck last week*, write *The employees struck work last week*.

strong-arm As in *strong-arm tactics*.

stronghold

strongman (one word) A man who rules a country with strong power. It can also mean *a man who performs feats of strength, as in a circus*.

strongroom

structure (verb) Prefer *arrange*, *build*, *construct* or *organize*. In the sense of setting the terms of a debt, *structure* is fine.

stubbornness

stylebook One word. But *style guide* is two words.

styled on Not *styled after*.

Styrofoam A trademark of Dow Chemical Company for a polystyrene used as a building material and in boat construction. The Dow product can be identified by its distinctive blue colour.

Cups, food containers and packaging material are not made of Styrofoam. The light plastic, typically white, from which they are made, is, in fact, expanded polystyrene beads. Write *plastic foam cup*, not s*tyrofoam cup*.

sub(-) subantarctic, subassembly, subatomic, subclass, subcommittee, subcontinent, subcontract, subculture, subdistrict, subdivide, subdivision, subeditor, subequatorial, subgroup, suheading, subhuman, sublet, submarginal, submarine, subnormal, subordinate, subplot, subprime, subscript, subsection, subsoil, subsonic, subspecies, substandard, subtext, subtitle, subtotal, subtropical, suburban, subway, subzero

sub-clause, sub-inspector, sub-post office, sub-Saharan

Latin phrases, never hyphenated: sub judice (in court, under judicial consideration), sub rosa (in secret)

SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT SEE **SINGULAR OR PLURAL?**

SUBJUNCTIVE

A subjunctive form, or mood, of a verb is used to express a wish, possibility or hypothesis. Broadly, it has four categories:

i. A special kind of present tense that has no *-s* in the third person singular. It is used after words which express that something is important or desirable. The same forms are used in both present and past tenses. It is more frequent in American English than in British English, but there are signs of its revival in British English. Some verbs, nouns or phrases after which the subjunctive is used: advise, ask, demand, desire, direct, insist, order, recommend, request, stipulate, suggest, essential, important, necessary, vital, in order that, on condition that.

I suggested that he take the morning flight.
The committee recommended that the RBI reduce interest rates.
It was important that he write to his son as soon as possible.
Our advice is that the newspaper carry more local stories.

In negative subjunctives, *do* is not used: *The committee recommended that the RBI not reduce interest rates.*

Each of these sentences can also be written with *should* or ordinary present and past tenses:

I suggested that he should take the morning flight.
Or *I suggested that he took the morning flight.*

ii. The *be* subjunctive: The verb *be* keeps its original form rather than becoming *am*, *is*, *are*, *was* or *were*.

The doctor advised that she be in bed for two days.
It is important that Alok be present when his results are announced.

A *not* construction with *be* is like this: *I suggest that this not be done.*

iii. The *were* subjunctive: Used with *wish*, *if, as if* and *as though* in unreal or impossible conditions in the past tense.

I wish it were a holiday.
If he were a good reporter, he would not make such a mistake.
She felt as if she were floating in space.
He looked as if he were drunk.

In such sentences it is always advisable to retain the *were* form for unreal conditions and use the *was* form for real ones.

iv. Fixed phrases: as it were, be that as it may, come what may, if I were you, if need be, God bless you, God save the Queen, Heaven forbid, so be it.

SEE ALSO **IF ... WAS/WERE**.

submachine gun

submersible

subpoena, subpoenaed

subprime An adjective used to describe a risky or less than ideal loan, mortgage or investment.

substitute, replace As a verb, *substitute* is followed by *for,* not *by* or *with*. When *A substitutes for B*, or *A is substituted for B*, A comes in and B goes out. In passive constructions, *substitute* can also be used without *for*: *Ronaldinho was substituted in the second half after an injury*. Here, the meaning is that somebody else played instead of Ronaldinho.

The verb *substitute* can often cause ambiguity, especially in passive constructions. Except in contexts where the meaning is clear, it might be better to use *replace*. When you *replace B with A*, A comes in and B goes out. The same idea is conveyed by *A replaces B* or *B is replaced by A*.

such as, like SEE **LIKE, SUCH AS**.

suchlike

Sudan Not *the Sudan*.

sudoku

suffer Avoid this pitying term in references to people with disabilities or severe illnesses: *He has AIDS*, not *He suffers from AIDS*.

suffice it to say Not *suffice to say*.

sufficient Generally, *enough* may be better.

sugar cane

sui generis means *the only example of its kind* or *unique*: *This man, in fact, was sui generis, a true original*.

A sui generis legal system is a legal system specifically designed to take care of a particular issue. Plant Breeders Rights in UPOV (International Union for the Protection of New Varieties of Plants) and the intellectual property rights protection of integrated circuits as reflected in the Treaty on Intellectual Property in Respect of Integrated Circuits (Washington Treaty, 1989) are often cited as examples of sui generis regimes.

A species that is the sole member of its genus is sui generis if the genus was specifically created by scientists to refer to that single species, with no other known members. If the species is alone merely due to extinction, as in the case of Homo sapiens, it is not sui generis.

suing Not *sueing*.

suit (of clothes or cards, or a lawsuit), **suite** (of rooms, music or furniture)

sulphur Not *sulfur*, which is the American spelling.

summertime

summit Use this term only for a meeting of heads of state or government. Do not use it for a meeting at a lower level. You cannot have a summit of trade union leaders or foreign ministers. Do not write *mini-summit* or *summit meeting*.

summiteer A participant in a summit or a climber who has reached the summit of a mountain.

summon, summons The verb is *summon* or *summons*. The noun is *summons*; plural *summonses*. A person is *summoned* to appear in court; but a person in receipt of a specific summons can be said to have been *summonsed*.

sun Generally lowercase. SEE **EARTH, MOON, SUN**.

sun(-) sunbathe, sunbather, sunbathing, sunburn, sundial, sundown, sunflower, sunglasses, sunlight, sunrise, sunroof, sunset, sunshade, sunshine, sunspot, sunstroke, suntan

sun lamp, sun lounge

sun-care products

Sunday Times of India Note the absence of *The*.

Sunni Muslims are split into two main groups, Sunnis and Shias. Sunnis, the orthodox majority, are estimated at about 80% of all Muslims and include the vast majority of Arabs. They follow the Prophet Muhammad's rule of life (the Sunna) and traditions based on his sayings. Shias, not to be referred to as Shi'ites, give weight mostly to the Quran's interpretations by their theologians.

suo motu Not *suo moto*. Itals.

super Generally, compounds beginning with *super-* are one word:

superannuate, superbike, superbug, supercalendar, supercar, supercharge, supercomputer, superconductivity, supercontinent, supercool, supercritical, superdelegate, superdominant, superelastic, superfine, superfluid, superglue, supergravity, superheat, superheavyweight, superhero, superheroine, superhigh, superhighway, superhuman, superman, supermarket, supermax, supermini, supermodel, supernaturalism, supernormal, supernutrient, superphosphate, superpower, supersaturated, superscript, supersize, superstar, superstate, superstore, superstring, superstructure, supersymmetry, supertax, superwaif (a very young and very thin supermodel), superwoman

super-duper, super-rich, super-slick

Hyphenate if the second element begins with a capital letter: super-Republican.

Super Bowl (American football) The championship game of the US National Football League. Two words and Roman numerals: *Super Bowl XLIV*.

SUPERLATIVES

Avoid superlatives if they constitute value judgments. Such descriptions as first, largest, biggest, highest and oldest are often challenged. Be particularly sceptical about press releases claiming records.

supersede, supersession Not *supercede*, *supercession*.

super-spreader Event/person causing many infections.

supervisor Not *superviser*.

supine (lying face up), **prone** (lying face down)

supportive See if *helpful* conveys what you mean.

suppress

susceptible

suspect, suspected SEE **ALLEGE, ALLEGED, ALLEGEDLY**.

SUV Sport (or sports) utility vehicle.

swansong One word.

swap Not *swop*.

swat (to hit sharply), **swot** (to study hard)

SWAT is acronym for special weapons and tactics.

swath (noun, a strip or belt), **swathe** (verb, to bandage or wrap)

swear in (verb) No hyphen. *K Rosaiah was sworn in as the chief minister of Andhra Pradesh*. Contrary to what many believe, the use of *as* in the previous sentence is not wrong, and it is not optional.

swearing in (noun, as in *the swearing in of Rosaiah*), **swearing-in** (adjective, as in *the swearing-in ceremony*)

swearword One word.

sweatshirt, sweatsuit, sweat pants

SWIMMING

Competitions involve four strokes: breaststroke, backstroke, freestyle and butterfly. A race with all four strokes is called a *medley*.

swine flu

swingeing (severe or causing hardship, as in *swingeing budget cuts*) Not *swinging*.

swish means *fashionable* in British English; in American English, it means *effeminate*. In both forms of English it is a slang word.

Swiss challenge A system under which a private party makes an unsolicited offer to a public authority for a public project. The public authority is required to publish the bid and invite other parties to match or better it. Some Swiss challenges also allow the party that submitted the unsolicited bid to match or better the best bid that comes out of the process. The word *Swiss* here does not mean *of Switzerland* and hence, logically, it should not be capped. But cap it for the sake of clarity, because *Swiss challenge* is not yet a popular term.

swollen

sword of Damocles (not *Democles*) A precarious situation.

SWOT analysis A strategic planning tool used to evaluate the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats involved in a project or business.

syllabus(es) Not *syllabi*.

symptom Do not forget the *p*.

synagogue(s)

sync, synch Short for *synchronization*. Use *sync*, except in *lip-synch*, *lip-synching*.

synonymous

synopsis Plural *synopses*.

synthesis, synthesize, synthesizer

***

Our nation must come together to unite.
— **George W Bush**

T

T Write *fit to a T* (not *to a tee*): *The work suited her to a T*, not *The work suited her to a tee*.

tab, tabs The phrases are *pick up the tab*, *keep tabs on somebody or something*.

Tabasco is the name of a state in southeast Mexico and a hot red sauce made from capsicums.

table (verb) The meanings are opposite in British English and American English. In Britain and at the UN, it means *submit a bill or proposal for discussion*. In the US, it means *suspend discussion of a bill or proposal indefinitely or for some time*.

tableau The plural is *tableaux* in British English and *tableaus in American English*.

tablecloth

table d'hôte

tablespoonful(s) SEE ALSO **SPOONFUL**.

tactics Singular and plural.

(a) tad Heavily overworked as a synonym of *a little* or *a bit*. Avoid.

taikonaut A Chinese astronaut. Use *astronaut* unless the word *taikonaut* is pertinent to the story.

tailback

tailor-made

tailspin

tailwind

take, bring SEE **BRING, TAKE**.

take(-) takeout, takeover (nouns), takeaway (adjective, as in *takeaway meals*)

take-off (noun)

take away, take off, take out, take over (verbs)

take-home pay

take place, occur SEE **OCCUR, TAKE PLACE**.

Taliban Plural. The singular *talib*, meaning *student*, is rarely used.

talking terms Instead of *I am not on talking terms with him*, write *I am not on speaking terms with him*.

talks (noun) means *discussions* or *negotiations*. In all other senses, including conversation, lecture, rumour or gossip, use the singular form *talk*: *There is talk* (not *there are talks*) *of terrorist groups manipulating the stock market*.

talkshow

Talmud The writings that make up the Jewish civil and religious law.

Tamiflu Trade name of the antiviral drug oseltamivir. It is not a vaccine.

tamper with (interfere with something without permission), **temper with** (modify so as to make less extreme)

tap, bug SEE **BUG, TAP**.

tape (verb), **tape-record** (verb), **tape recording** (noun)

target Do not *target* your efforts. Instead, *direct* them.

As a verb, *target* is jargon and is best confined to military contexts. Alternatives: *concentrate on*, *single out*, *take aim at*.

targeted, targeting Not *targetted*, *targetting*.

tariff Note single *r* and double *f*.

tarot cards

taskforce

taskmaster

tattletale A scandalmonger or gossip.

tattoos, tattooed, tattooing

taxi, taxiing (of aircraft)

taxman, taxpayer

TB Tuberculosis.

tea(-) teabag, teacup, teakettle, teahouse, teapot, teaspoon, teatime

tea cloth, tea cosy, tear garden, tea leaf, tea maker, tea party, tea set, tea table

Teachers' Day Celebrated on September 5, the birthday of Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, India's second President.

TEAM, TEAM NAME

In British English, plural in sports contexts: *Real Madrid were beaten by Manchester United*. However, for off-field activities involving the owners or management, a team name is treated as singular: *AC Milan has signed up Ronaldinho*. | *Mumbai Indians is owned by Reliance Industries*.

In American English, the word *team* or a team name is always singular.

team(-) teammate (one word, according to Concise Oxford Dictionary and Webster's New World College Dictionary), teamwork

team play, team spirit

teargas (noun and verb) One word.

tear-jerker

teaspoonful(s)

techie Not *techy*.

Technicolor Cap. It is a trademark.

teenage, teenager No hyphen. As a modifier before a noun, *teenage* (not *teenaged*).

teetotaller

Teflon Cap. It is a trademark. In generic sense, use *non-stick,* as in *non-stick pan*.

telecom Not *telecoms*.

televangelist The word has a disparaging tone. Use a neutral term like *religious broadcaster* if the context is clear.

TELEVISION PROGRAMMES
Put quotation marks around their titles.

telltale

Telugu Not *Telegu* or *Telagu*.

temblor (earthquake) Not *tremblor*.

temper with, tamper with SEE **TAMPER WITH, TEMPER WITH**.

temperature Do not write *hot temperature* or *cold temperature*; temperatures are *high* or *low*.

SEE ALSO **CELSIUS** | **FAHRENHEIT**.

temporary respite Use just *respite*. A respite is by definition temporary.

Ten Commandments Do not abbreviate; do not use figures: *First Commandment*. *Tenth Commandment* (an exception to the rule of using figures above *ninth*).

tendency

tender-hearted

tendinitis Inflammation of a tendon, not *tendonitis*.

tenor In finance, the tenor of a loan is the length of time before it becomes due for payment. If a bank loan initially comes with a 10-year tenor, after three years, it will be said to have a tenor of seven years.

tenpin bowling

TENSE
The choice of tense in a text must be consistent. Once you have decided which tense to use, you must stick to it, unless there are clear reasons for using another.

While narrating an event, a newspaper generally uses the past tense. If the verb that introduces the rest of the sentence (called reporting verb in grammar) is in the past tense, the other verbs in the sentence should also be in the past tense:
He said he had eaten (not *He said he has eaten*).
He said he was happy (not *He said he is happy*).
He said he would go (not *He said he will go*).

The sequence of tenses helps the reader keep track of the sequence of events. *The rioters fled when police arrived* does not mean the same as *The rioters had fled when police arrived*.

When the reporting verb is in the past tense, events in the immediate past should be reported in the past tense: *The CEO said he was happy with the company's first-quarter results*. Events in the distant past should be reported in the past perfect tense: *The CEO said the company had suffered huge losses during the previous decade*.

If the reported clause is a continuing or eternal truth, retain the present tense: *He recognized that all life is sacred*.

A reporting verb is always at the beginning of a sentence. If it is moved, it is no longer a reporting verb: *The Prime Minister's condition is improving, the doctor said*.

Note that *has said* is not past tense; it is present perfect tense. Accordingly, *He has said he will go* (not *He has said he would go*).

SEE ALSO **PAST TENSE VS PRESENT PERFECT TENSE**.

tera A prefix denoting one trillion units of a measure.

teraflops is a measure of computing speed (one trillion floating-point operations per second). The part *flops* stands for floating-point operations per second. Do not write *teraflop*; even the singular form is *teraflops*. Do not write *teraflops per second*.

Teri for The Energy and Resources Institute, which was earlier known as Tata Energy Research Institute.

Territorial Army

terror(-) terror-ridden, terror-stricken, terror-struck

terrorist The word can be used for a person who kills or tries to kill innocent people, generating a pervasive sense of fear in order to influence government policy. All conditions of this definition must be met for an act to be described as a terrorist act. The murder of an independent candidate in elections could be a criminal act in Bihar. In Jammu & Kashmir, it is more likely to be a terrorist act because it is meant to influence India's policy on Kashmir. To avoid repetition, use *gunmen*, *bomb squads*, *suicide bombers* or *fidayeen* as the case may be. Do not use *ultra* as a synonym of *terrorist*.

Test (cricket)

test-fire Hyphenate; use only as a verb.

tête-à-tête

text rather than *SMS* is the term prevalent in Britain and the US. It can be used as a noun, adjective or verb.

textbook

-th Write *12th*, *25th*; not *12th*, *25th*.

than The word can sometimes cause ambiguity, as in *He loves cricket more than me*. Make it *He loves cricket more than he loves me* or *He loves cricket more than I do*.

It is wrongly used in sentences like this: *Nearly five times as many men than women watch cricket on TV*. Make it *Nearly five times as many men as women watch cricket on TV*.

It is wrongly used after *hardly* in sentences like this: *Hardly had he reached home than he got a call from his office*. Make it *No sooner had he reached home than he got a call from his office* or *Hardly had he reached home when he got a call from his office*.

thankful, grateful There is a subtle difference between the two words. When you are pleased and relieved that something has happened or has not happened, you say *I am thankful*. In this case *thankful* is not followed by *to someone*. When you express gratitude to a person for a favour done to you, you say *I am grateful to you*.

Thanksgiving, Thanksgiving Day US holiday, celebrated on the fourth Thursday of November. In Canada, Thanksgiving is celebrated on the second Monday of October.

THAT, OMISSION OF

For flow and conciseness, *that* can often be omitted after verbs like *said*, *disclosed*, *suggested*, *thought* or *wrote*: *Pawar said (that) it was a great day for Indian cricket*. But if the verb is followed by a word which can be mistaken for its direct object, dropping *that* can lead to confusion, at least momentarily. Consider: *The Prime Minister announced the employment programme would need Rs 500 crore*. Here, *that* must be retained after *announced*. For the same reason, *that* should always be retained after verbs like *added*, *advocated*, *asserted*, *contended*, *declared*, *estimated*, *made clear*, *pointed out*, *proposed*, *replied* and *shouted*.

When a time element follows the verb, *that* is always needed for clarity: *The Prime Minister announced on Monday that the employment programme would need Rs 500 crore*. Omitting *that* after *Monday* could suggest that Rs 500 crore would be needed on Monday. If such is indeed the case, write *The Prime Minister announced that the employment programme would need Rs 500 crore on Monday*.

If a sentence with two parallel clauses needs the expression *and that* in the second part, do not omit *that* in the first part: *The chief minister said that the outbreak of cholera in three districts was a matter of grave concern and that a team of 100 doctors was being sent to the districts.*

Do not omit *that* before subordinate clauses beginning with *after*, *although*, *because*, *before*, *in addition to*, *till*, *until* and *while*: *The doctor assured her that after the operation she would be completely cured.*

When *that* introduces a relative clause, it can often be omitted: *This is the style guide (that) I was looking for.* | *This is the story (that) I wrote.* But it must be retained in certain cases: *The story that led to a change in the city's traffic plans appeared in June last year.*

After certain adjectives too, *that* can be omitted: *It's funny (that) I have only five rupees in my purse.* | *I'm glad (that) you are here.*

Two-word conjunctions like *so that*, *such that*, *now that*, *immediately that*, *provided that*, *supposing that*, *considering that*, and *assuming that* are often used without *that* in speech or informal writing: *He was so late (that) he missed the flight.* | *You can borrow the book provided (that) you return it in two days.* | *He hit the ball with such force (that) it landed in the stands.*

Rule to remember: Retain *that* if its omission can cause ambiguity.

that, which A *that* clause should never have commas before and after it. A *which* clause may or may not be enclosed by commas.

Relative clauses beginning with *that* or *which* are of two kinds: essential (restrictive) and non-essential (non-restrictive). Essential clauses, never enclosed by commas, define; non-essential clauses, always enclosed by commas, give extra information. If an essential clause is dropped, the sentence loses its meaning. A non-essential clause can be dropped and the sentence would still make sense. Either *that* or *which* can be used in an essential clause, but *that* should be preferred. Only *which* can be used in a non-essential clause. Examples: *The newspaper that has the best stories is the most popular.* | *The Times of India, which I have been reading for 10 years, has the best stories.*

In the first example, *which* can be used in place of *that* without any enclosing commas. In the second, *that* cannot replace *which*.

Sometimes, *that* in a relative clause needs to be changed to *which* to avoid repetition of *that*. For example, *The quizmaster announced that the team that won would get a free trip to Paris* is clumsy. Replace the second *that* with *which*: *The quizmaster announced that the team which won would get a free trip to Paris.*

that, which, who Use *who* or *whom* to refer to human beings. For an animal, use *who* or *whom* only when its sex is known or it has been personalized with a name.

For inanimate objects, animals not personalized with names, and plants, use *that* or *which*.

Do not use *who* or *whom* to refer to companies, organizations, countries or teams; use *which* or *that* instead. The use of *that* for people is not wrong (*If you succeed, you have more people that love you but also more that envy you*), but it may sound rude to some ears.

the The definite article *the* is like common salt, which makes our food tasty but adversely affects our health if we use too much of it.

When writing about a specific person or thing use *the*. For example, *the first man to go to the moon was Neil Armstrong.* Here, you are referring to a particular person who went to a particular moon (not the moons of Jupiter or Saturn).

However, when talking in general terms, do not use *the*. *Our space programme will succeed when we put man on the moon*. Here, it could be any man who could reach the moon.

With society, use *the* only when you mean a specific body, like a building cooperative: *The flat owner paid his dues to the society*, but *The reformed prisoner has paid his dues to society*. Similarly with industry, use *the* only when referring to a particular industry: *The steel industry wants an increase in import duties,* but *Industry is divided on the issue of import duties.*

Use *the* before names of religious books: *the Gita*, *the Quran*, *the Ramayana*, *the Bible.*

Use *the* before *exchequer*.

Use *the* before *Army*, *Navy*, *Air Force*.

Use *the* before *Lok Sabha* and *Rajya Sabha,* but not before *Parliament*.

Use *the* before names of political parties — written in full or as abbreviations: *the Congress*, *the Bharatiya Janata Party*, *the Samajwadi Party, the Communist Party of India, the CPM, the BSP.* Also: *the Left.*

Do not use *the* before company names — full or abbreviated. Use *the* only when a company's name works as a modifier: *the Wal-Mart CEO*.

Use *the* before names of organizations except companies — written in full or as abbreviations: *the Central Bureau of Investigation*, *the Board of Control for Cricket in India, the CBI*, *the BCCI*, *the IPL*, *the RBI*, *the UN.* Acronyms —

abbreviations that can be pronounced as words — do not generally require *the* before them: *Nato*, *Unicef*.

Do not use *the* before *Congress* when referring to the US legislature. Use *the* when *Congress* is modified by *US* or modifies another word: *the US Congress, the Congress debate*.

For a more detailed treatment, SEE **APPENDIX 2: WHEN TO USE 'THE'?**

SEE ALSO **TITLES**.

theatregoer

The Hague Even in the middle of a sentence, write *The Hague*.

their, theirs, them, they Do not apply these plural pronouns to singular antecedents (like *anyone* or *someone*) even when the aim is to avoid assuming maleness or femaleness; try other solutions.

A company or a team is *it*, not *they*. The only exception is the use of *they* for a sports team, although this British style, followed by us too, is frowned upon in America.

theirs No apostrophe.

(the) then The use of *then* as an adjective produces clumsy phrasing: *The then chief minister, J Jayalalithaa, had Karunanidhi arrested*. Rephrase it to *Jayalalithaa, then the chief minister, had Karunanidhi arrested*.

Instead of *The then Prime Minister V P Singh*, write *V P Singh, who was Prime Minister at that time,* or *V P Singh, then Prime Minister*.

thereabouts Avoid. Do not write *thereabout*.

thereby, thereof Do not use these stilted words. Try *that way* or *in that way* for *thereby* and *of it* for *thereof*.

theretofore Use *until then*.

Thermos Cap; it is a trademark.

The Times of India Cap *the* while using the full name. Lowercase *the* when the newspaper's name acts as a modifier: *the Times of India report*, *the Times of India reporter*. Note the lowercase *o* in *of*. *TOI*, however, is all caps.

Omit *the* in the names of newspapers other than *The Times of India* and *The Economic Times*, even if it is part of the name; for example, *Indian Express*, *New York Times*, *Guardian*. Do not italicize the names of newspapers. Here, itals have been used for a different reason (SEE **WORDS AS WORDS**).

think Avoid the clichéd use of *think* without an *of*, as in *How to get dressed? Think Carla Bruni.* Add an *of* and make it *Think of Carla Bruni*.

thinktank One word.

third-hand

third man (cricket)

third world Lowercase, but *developing countries* is preferable.

thoroughbred, thoroughgoing

though, although SEE **ALTHOUGH, THOUGH**.

thrash (to beat soundly), **thresh** (to beat out; for example, grain or a problem)

3D Not *3-D* or *three-D*.

threefold

3G The third generation of mobile phone standards; the GSM and the CDMA technologies are called 2G. 1G, or first-generation, wireless communications systems used analog technology. From 2G onwards, digital technology was adopted.

3G users can make and receive video calls, watch live TV, access the internet, receive emails and download music, apart from making voice calls and exchanging text messages. GPRS, often referred to as 2.5G, can provide data speeds of up to 170Kbps downstream, but realistically it has a maximum speed of only 50Kbps. 3G technologies provide a downstream speed of 1.5Mbps, but even 20Mbps is considered within reach, at least theoretically. 4G technologies with data speeds of 100Mbps (when the user is moving at a high speed relative to the station) and 1Gbps (when the user and the station are stationary) are already being tested.

three Rs Reading, 'riting and 'rithmetic.

threesome

threshold Not *threshhold*.

thrice Old-fashioned; use *three times*.

(at/on full) throttle Not *press the full throttle*.

throwaway (noun and adjective), **throw away** (verb)

thumb rule

thumbs down, thumbs up Each is two words; no hyphen.

thunder(-) thunderbolt, thunderclap, thundercloud, thundershower, thunderstorm, thunderstruck

thus far Avoid. Use *so far*.

Tiananmen Square An extensive open area in central Beijing. Not *Tienanmen*.

ticket Write *He was elected on Congress ticket*, not *He was elected on a Congress ticket*.

tie, tied, tying

tiebreak, tiebreaker (nouns) No hyphen.

tie-up (noun), **tie up** (verb)

tight(-) tightrope

tight-fisted, tight-lipped

till is largely interchangeable with *until*.

Timbuktu Not *Timbuktou* or *Timbuctoo*. City in Mali.

TIME, DATE, DAY, YEAR

Write 2004, not *the year 2004*. For a span of years, use a hyphen: *2004-05*, not *2004/5*.

From 1939 to 1945, not *from 1939-45*. Similarly, *between 1939 and 1945*, not *between 1939-45*. *The 1939-45 war* is fine.

Cap *New Year's Day*, *New Year's Eve* and *New Year* (the holiday), but lowercase *new year* (the 12-month period).

Use an apostrophe when reducing a year to two digits: *mid-'95*, *the class of '90*. Omit the apostrophe in tables and charts when the meaning is clear. Also, omit the apostrophe before a two-digit designation of a decade: *the 80s*. In first reference, give all four digits of the year: *1970*, *1980s*. The shorter forms can be used in later references or in headlines.

Spell out and lowercase the numbers of centuries from first to ninth: *the second century*, *the ninth century*. Use numerals from 10th on: *the 14th century*, *the 20th century*.

Technically, a century begins with the "01" year — 1901, 2001, etc — because there was no year 0. But in popular consciousness, centuries begin with 1900, 2000, etc. That informal style is suitable for references to celebrations and social or cultural turning points (New York Times stylebook).

No comma if only the month and the year are given: *July 2007*. But use a comma if a day of the month is given with the year: *July 25, 2007*. The comma is essential before and after the year when the year follows a specific date: *the October 15, 2007, order*.

In headlines and graphics, September can be abbreviated to *Sept*, not *Sep*. Avoid abbreviating April, June and July. Do not abbreviate months in copy.

1.45pm, *3.20am* (full stop, not colon, in the numeral; no full stop in *am* or *pm*).

10 o'clock last night but *10pm yesterday*; *half past two* (no hyphen), *a quarter to three*.

Avoid the redundant *8.30pm yesterday evening*; just say *8.30pm yesterday* or *8.30 yesterday evening*.

Midnight refers to the end of the day, not the beginning of the next.

For 24-hour clock, *00.47*, *23.59*.

Avoid clumsy phrases like *this past Saturday* or *this coming Saturday*. If you say *something happened on Saturday*, it is normally clear from the context that you are talking of last Saturday. Similarly, if you say that *something will happen on Saturday*, it is clear from the context that you are talking of next Saturday. If you still think that the day needs to be qualified for clarity, write *last Saturday* or *next Saturday*, rather than *Saturday last* or *Saturday next*.

Write *arrived on Monday*, not *arrived Monday*. In copy, *on Tuesday*, *on* Wednesday, *on Thursday* rather than *yesterday, today, tomorrow*. In headlines, *yesterday, today, tomorrow*. In copy, *today* means the day of writing; in headline, it means the day of publication.

The time element should normally come in the intro of the story except when the action being reported took place a previous day; in that case, the time element can come lower in the story.

The time element should come after the verb — immediately after, if the verb has no direct object: *The chief minister announced on Monday that there would be an airport in every district of the state.* If there is a direct object, the object should immediately follow the verb, and the time element should follow both: *The Supreme Court pulled up the Tamil Nadu government on Monday for failing to comply with its order on a bandh call given by the ruling DMK*.

A clumsy expression like *the Supreme Court on Monday* should be avoided. Largely confined to newspaper writing, it is not natural English. (See Bill Bryson's quote at the beginning of the chapter on J.) *The Supreme Court yesterday* is slightly less clumsy but we do not use *yesterday*, *today* and *tomorrow* in copy unless they are in direct quotes.

If the direct object is long and cumbersome and placing the time element before the verb seems unavoidable (*The government on Friday announced a whopping Rs 60,000 crore package to provide relief to indebted farmers by waiving loans of small and marginal farmers*), make it *the government has announced* and put *on Friday* in the next sentence.

Do not use phrases like *several months ago* or *recently* which suggest either that we do not know exactly when something happened or have been too lazy to find out. Be precise: *last August, on March 2*.

A three-month-old revolt refers to an event that began three months ago and is still going on. A three-month revolt refers to one that is over.

Use apostrophes in phrases like *in two days' time*, *12 years' imprisonment* and *six weeks' holiday*, where the time period (two days) modifies a noun (time), but not in *nine months pregnant* or *three weeks old*, where the time period is adverbial (modifying an adjective like *pregnant* or *old*).

time(-) timecard, timekeeper, timeline, timeout, timepiece, timescale, timeserver, timeshare, timetable, timeworn

time bomb, time capsule, time clock, time deposit, time frame, time limit, time machine, time management, time warp, time zone

time-consuming, time-honoured, time-saving

(-)time daytime, lifetime, longtime (adjective), nighttime, overtime

full time (adverb), long time (noun), part time (adverb), real time (noun)

all-time, full-time, part-time, real-time (adjectives)

time-barred is a legal term meaning *barred by the passage of time*.

TIME ELEMENT IN A STORY SEE **TIME, DATE, DAY, YEAR**.

timepass Used in colloquial Indian English to denote an unproductive, leisure activity. Do not use this word except jocularly or in quotes.

times less, times more Many of us often say *four times more* when we mean *multiplied by 4*. But *four times more* actually means *multiplied by 5* — the original amount plus *four more times*. Write *four times as much*. Do not write *times less* or *times smaller*. Something *three times smaller* or *four times smaller* does not exist because a thing can be decreased only *one time* before it vanishes. Write *one-third as small* or *one-fourth as small*.

timetable Noun. Do not use as a verb.

tip off (verb), **tip-off** (noun)

tiptoe (noun and verb) No hyphen.

tiptop No hyphen.

titbit is British; *tidbit* is American.

titillate

titleholder One word.

TITLES

Write like this: *President Pratibha Patil*, *Prime Minister Manmohan Singh*, *President Barack Obama*, *governor S C Jamir, chief minister Sheila Dikshit*. (SEE ALSO **CAPITALIZATION**.)

If the title is preceded by *the*, set the name off by commas: *The Prime Minister, Manmohan Singh, inaugurated the function*. The absence of commas would mean the country has more than one Prime Minister.

To avoid clumsy constructions, place long titles like *minister of state for internal security* before or after names and set them off with commas.

Do not create titles out of mere descriptions. For example, do not write *PhD student Anil Verma* or *accused Ram Niwas*. Make it *Anil Verma, a PhD student,* or *Ram Niwas, the accused*.

In reference to well-known people, occupational descriptions can be used as titles. The question is: should it be *the writer Arundhati Roy* or *writer Arundhati Roy*? New York Times uses the form *the writer Arundhati Roy* and considers the form without *the* unpolished usage. So do many grammarians. But the form without *the*, used by The Times of India, has wide acceptance. It is used by AP and most of the American newspapers. The advantage of this form is that you do not have to worry whether Arundhati Roy is famous enough to be called *the writer*.

Avoid place names as parts of titles. Write, for example, *The US president, George Bush, ordered the invasion of Iraq* rather than *US President George Bush ordered the invasion of Iraq*. Similarly, *The UP chief minister, Mayawati, accused the CBI of framing her* or *Chief minister Mayawati of UP accused the CBI of framing her* rather than *UP chief minister Mayawati accused the CBI of framing her*.

Remember, the absence of commas can change the meaning. *The Bollywood star Hrithik Roshan* (or *Bollywood star Hrithik Roshan*) *is a good dancer* means there are other Bollywood stars no matter how accomplished they are as dancers. *The Bollywood star, Hrithik Roshan, is a good dancer* means there is only one Bollywood star.

SEE ALSO **OFFICIAL TITLES**.

TNT is fine in all references. The abbreviation stands for trinitrotoluene.

tobacco(s)

to-do (adjective) A *to-do list* is a list of things that need to be done. *To-do* is also a noun meaning *commotion*, *fuss* or *quarrel*.

together with Avoid it where *with* is sufficient. Similarly, *blend*, *meet*, *link* rather than *blend together*, *meet together*, *link together*.

TOI The Times of India. All caps, not *ToI*.

told reporters Use when the source is speaking informally to a group of reporters. If the source is addressing a news conference, say so. Do not use *told newspersons* or *mediapersons* or *presspersons*.

told The Times of India, told TOI Use only when we are being given significant information or an exclusive interview. Otherwise, write *told reporters*, *told a news conference* or simply *said*.

toll *take a toll on* (not *of*)

toll(-) tollbooth, tollgate, tollhouse, tollkeeper

toll bridge, toll call, toll collector, toll road

tomato(es)

tomorrow

tonne Metric unit equal to 1,000kg as distinct from the British ton (long ton) of 2,240lb, or 1,016.96kg, and the American ton (short ton) of 2,000lb, or 907kg. In foreign copy, *ton* should be left unchanged. If you must change it, then convert the figures. In India, [metric] tonne is used. In expressions like *tons of money* and *thanks a ton*, always write *ton*.

top Use sparingly. The word is often redundant, as in *Obama met his top aides*. He would hardly consult junior aides.

top(-) topcoat, topknot, topmast, topmost, topsail, topsoil, topspin

top cat, top dog, top dollar, top drawer, top gear, top hat, top secret (noun), top whack

top-end (adjective), top-flight (adjective), top-heavy, top-hole, top-level, top-notch, top-secret (adjective)

top brass is fine but *brass* is preferable; *top brass* as well as *brass* is always treated as plural.

Top 5, Top 10

topsy-turvy

torchbearer

tormentor

tornado(es)

torpedo The plural is *torpedoes*; the -ing form of the verb is *torpedoing*.

tortuous (winding or twisting), **torturous** (tormenting or anguishing)

Tory (singular), **Tories** (plural) The terms are acceptable in later references and in headlines for Britain's Conservative Party or its members. But: *Tory party*, not *Tory Party*.

totalizator Not *totalisator*. A device that shows the number and amount of bets staked on a race, to facilitate the division of the total among those backing the winner.

totalled, totalling in British English, but *totaled*, *totaling* in American English.

touch(-) touchdown (noun), touchhole, touchline, touchmark, touchstone

touch-me-not, touch-typing, touch-screen (adjective), touch-tone, touch-up (noun)

touch down (verb), touch screen (noun), touch up (verb)

touch and go But as a modifier before a noun, *touch-and-go*.

touchy-feely means *openly expressing love or affection, especially through physical contact*. It is used disparagingly to convey excess, indulgence or superficiality.

townhouse

toxin, toxic A toxin is a poison produced by a plant or an animal. The adjective *toxic* can be used for any poison: *toxic toys*, *toxic spill*.

traceable

track record

tracksuit

trademark A trademark is a brand, symbol or word registered by a manufacturer and protected by law to prevent others from using it. Use a generic equivalent unless the trademark is important to the story. When using a trademark, follow the owner's capitalization; for example, *Halls*, not *halls*; but *aspirin*, not *Aspirin* (*aspirin* is a generic name, not a trademark).

trade-off (noun), **trade off** (verb)

traffic trafficked, trafficker, trafficking

Trai Telecom Regulatory Authority of India.

trailblazer, trailblazing

trailer Not *trailor*.

tranquil In British English, *tranquillize*, *tranquillizer*, *tranquillity*. But in American English, each is spelled with a single *l*.

trans(-) Compounds are generally one word: transcontinental, transgender, transsexual, transship, transoceanic

When the second element of a word beginning with *trans-* starts with a capital letter, hyphenate. For example, *trans-Siberian*. Exceptions: *transatlantic*, *transpacific*.

trans fat (noun), **trans-fat** (adjective) Trans-fatty acids or trans fats are unsaturated fats formed by turning liquid oils into solid fats through a process called hydrogenation. Hydrogenation increases the shelf life and flavour stability of foods. Hence, a trans fat lasts longer than a saturated fat, say butter, without going rancid. Trans fats can be found in fried foods, margarine, salad dressings, crackers, cereals, candies, baked goods, cookies, chips, snack foods and many other processed foods. Trans-fatty acids are found naturally in small quantities in some foods including milk, butter, beef, pork and lamb.

Trans fats cause clogging of arteries by raising the level of bad cholesterol, or LDL, as do saturated fats. But saturated fats also raise the level of good cholesterol, or HDL, whereas trans fats may lower the level of HDL. Hence, many scientists believe trans fats are worse.

transgender, transsexual Do not use *transgender* as a noun; use it only as an adjective. *Transgender people* or *transgender youth* is fine but *He is a transgender* is not. *Transsexual*, however, can be used both as a noun and an adjective.

TRANSITIONAL WORDS AND PHRASES

Transitional words and phrases are often useful, but at times avoidable. The overworked *meanwhile* should not be used mindlessly. Sometimes, it crops up quite early in a story — in the second or third paragraph — and irritates the reader. Stop and think. You will come up with something more appropriate and less trite.

transparency See if *openness* serves your purpose.

transpired Use it in the sense of *came to be known*, not of *happened*.

transportation Use *transport* unless it is part of an official designation, as in *US secretary of transportation*.

trapshooting

trash As a verb meaning *destroy* or *denounce*, *trash* is slang.

trash can

traveller's cheque Not *travellers' cheque*.

travelogue Same spelling in American English too.

treble, triple SEE **TRIPLE, TREBLE**.

trenchcoat

tri(-) triathlon, tricentenary, tricentennial, tricycle, trilateral, trilingual, trimonthly, tripartite, triweekly

trickle-down (adjective), **trickle down** (verb)

tricolour One word, lowercase.

trigger off *Trigger* alone is sufficient. *Peanuts can trigger off a violent allergic reaction* would be better without *off*.

trigger-happy

trillion A trillion is 1 followed by 12 zeros. Mention in copy that one trillion is equal to 1,000 billion, a million million or a lakh crore. Abbreviate *trillion* to *tn* in headlines, tables and charts.

SEE ALSO **BILLION** | **MILLION**.

Trinamool Congress Not *Trinamul Congress*. For short, *Trinamool*. Avoid abbreviations like *AITC* and *TC*.

trio Use it only for a group of three closely connected people or things. Do not use it as a fancy substitute for *three*. Write *three*.

trip hop A style of dance music.

triple, treble Both words are used as nouns, verbs or adjectives. In British English, *treble* has been traditionally preferred as a verb and *triple* as a noun or adjective, but now *triple* is becoming preponderant even as a verb. In American English, *triple* is the prevalent form, even as a verb. Use *triple* except in *treble chance* in football.

Also, keep the following distinction in musical contexts in mind: *triple* refers to three (or a multiple of three) beats to the measure, as in *triple time*; *treble* refers to the highest part in musical harmony, as in *treble clef*, *treble recorder*.

trolley Plural *trolleys*, not *trollies*.

troop(s), troupe In the singular form, *troop* means *a number of people organized as a group or working together*: *cavalry troop*, *troop(s) of sightseers*. For armed forces or a large contingent of soldiers, always use the plural

form. An expression like *10,000 troops*, meaning *10,000 soldiers*, is fine. Avoid the use of *troops* for a few soldiers. Instead of *four troops*, write *four soldiers*.

The adjective is always *troop*: *troop deployment*, *troop movement*.

Troupe means *a group of performers*: *theatre troupe*, *circus troupe*.

trophy wife A pejorative term, usually applied to a physically attractive younger woman married to a man who has obtained a high level of success.

troubleshooter, troubleshooting

trouble spot Two words.

truck Not *lorry*.

truly

try and Use *try to*.

tryout (noun), **try out** (verb)

tsar Use *czar*.

T-shirt Not *tee-shirt*.

tsunami A huge sea wave caused by a great disturbance under an ocean, as a strong earthquake or volcanic eruption. Adjective: *tsunamic*.

tube, the Lowercase. London Underground is the name of the company.

tuberculosis *TB* is acceptable in all references.

tubewell

Tughlaqabad Not *Tughlakabad*, in Delhi.

tug-of-war

turbid (muddy, cloudy, confused), **turgid** (swollen, pompous)

turbojet, turboprop

turn(-) turnabout, turnaround, turncoat, turndown (noun), turnkey, turnover (noun), turnpike (meaning *tollgate*), turntable,

turn down (verb), turn off (verb), turn on (verb), turn over (verb)

turn-off, turn-on (nouns)

turning point Where things start getting better.

Tussauds, Madame (not *Tussaud's*) The group has dropped the apostrophe from its name.

Tutankhamen Not *Tutankhamun*, *Tutankhamon* or any of the variants having an *e* after the second *t*. *King Tut* is fine in headlines and even in copy, but use the full name at least once in copy.

TV Acceptable in all contexts as a substitute for *television*.

tweet (not *twit*) A message on Twitter. As a verb, use *tweet* or *Twitter*. *Twitterati*, like *literati*, *chatterati* and *glitterati*, is plural.

twelfth

Twelve Apostles An exception to the rule of using figures for numbers above nine.

21st century

twenty-four seven Also 24x7. It means *all the time*, *24 hours a day*, *seven days a week*: *The helpline works twenty-four seven.*

20-something Also *twentysomething*. Similarly, *thirtysomething*.

Twenty20 (cricket) Also *T20*.

20/20 (vision)

twofold One word.

tying

type, kind, sort Use the plural *types*, *kinds* or *sorts* after *all*, *both*, *certain*, *different*, *many*, *several*, *some*, *various*, etc: *music that appeals to certain kinds of people*, not *certain kind of people*.

Do not write *What kind of a mother is she?* Make it *What kind of mother is she?*

type(-) typecast, typeface, typescript, typeset, typewriter

type foundry

(-)type antitype, antitypical, stereotype

blood type

typify Not *typefy*.

tyranny

tyro(s)

***

If I see *upcoming* in the paper one more time I will be downcoming and someone will be outgoing.
— **Bernard Kilgore,** Wall Street Journal editor from 1941 to 1967

U

UAE United Arab Emirates. SEE ALSO **UNITED ARAB EMIRATES.**

über German prefix meaning *super*, as in *über-babe*, *über-hip*, *über-style*. Use it only for special effect. Do not use it as an everyday substitute for *super*.

Uefa Cup Not *UEFA Cup*.

UFO(s) Acceptable in all references to *unidentified flying object(s)*.

Ugadi New Year's Day, according to the Hindu calendar, in Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka. It is celebrated on the first day of the month of Chaitra. In Maharashtra, the festival is called Gudi Padwa.

Uighur (noun and adjective) Not *Uyghur*, except in *World Uyghur Congress* and *Uyghur American Association*. The Uighurs are a Turkic people, living mainly in northwest China's Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region and central Asian countries such as Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan. Their language is Uighur. Note that the spelling used by the Chinese government in the official name of the province is *Uygur*.

UK United Kingdom. SEE ALSO **UNITED KINGDOM**.

ukulele (not *ukelele*) A small guitar, usually with four strings, that developed in Hawaii from an earlier Portuguese instrument.

ulema Plural. The singular, *alim*, is rarely used.

ultimatum Plural *ultimatums*, not *ultimata*.

ultra Do not use as a synonym of *militant*, *terrorist* or *extremist*.

ultra(-) Most compounds are one word:

ultraconservative, ultracritical, ultrafast, ultrahigh frequency, ultralarge (as in *ultralarge crude carrier*), ultraliberal, ultramodern, ultramundane, ultranationalism, ultrashort, ultrasound, ultrastructure, ultraviolet

Hyphenate if the second element of the compound starts with an *a* or a capital letter. Some *ultra-* compounds are hyphenated to avoid ambiguity: ultra-German, ultra-distance (as in *ultra-distance runner*)

Words like *ultraconservative* can be pejorative. Exercise caution.

ultra vires Beyond the legal power of a person or company. Literal meaning: *beyond strength*. If a law goes beyond the powers conferred on the government by the Constitution, the Supreme Court or a high court can declare the law *ultra vires of the Constitution*.

umbilical cord

UN Acceptable in all references to the United Nations.

un(-) Nearly all *un-* compounds are one word, even those in which the second element begins with an *n*: unnatural, unnecessary, unnerve, unnoticeable, unnoticed, unnumbered

But: un-American, un-Islamic

unani Lowercase. Other systems of medicine too are lowercase: *allopathy*, *homeopathy*.

unbridgeable

uncharted waters Not *unchartered waters*. *Uncharted* means *not yet mapped, surveyed or investigated*.

unchristian

Uncle Sam

unconscious But *un-self-conscious*.

uncooperative

unctuous Oily or greasy, too suave or oily in speech or manner.

under(-) Compounds are generally one word:

underachieve, underact, underarm, underbelly, underbid, underbred, underbuy, undercarriage, undercharge, underclass (noun), underclothes, undercoat, undercover (adjective), undercurrent, undercut, underdeveloped,

underdog, underdressed, underemployed, underestimate, underexpose, underfeed, underfloor, underflow, undergarment, undergo, undergraduate, underground, undergrowth, underhand, underinsure, underleaf, underlie, underline, undermost, undernourish, underpaid, underpants, underpass, underpay, underpinning(s), underplay, underpopulated, underprice (verb), underprivileged, underrate, underreact, underripe, underscore, undersea, unsersell, undersexed, undershirt, undersigned, undersized, underskirt, undersoil (meaning *subsoil*), understaffed, understatement, understudy (noun and verb), underthings, undertone, undervalue, underwater (adjective), underwear, underweight, underworld, underwrite

under cover (adverb), under the counter (*under-the-counter* when used before a noun), under the table (*under-the-table* when used before a noun)

underage One word. In American English, it can also mean *shortfall*; do not use it in that sense.

underconstruction, under-construction Do not use. Instead of *An underconstruction Metro line collapsed*, write *A Metro line under construction collapsed*.

Under-19, U-19

underprivileged You are either privileged or not privileged; you cannot be underprivileged. Privileges are by definition limited to a few. *Underprivileged* implies that everyone is entitled to a privilege. Do not use this jargon word.

undersecretary One word; but in the US government, two words: *under secretary*.

underway, under way The one-word form now predominates in American English and is gaining ground in British English. The traditional view is that the phrase should be two words, except when used as an adjective before a noun. Guardian, New York Times and AP still follow this rule. Use the two-word form. The phrase means *in progress*.

undocumented A euphemism for people who have entered a country illegally. Prefer *illegal (im)migrants*.

Unesco

unexceptionable (not open to objections), **unexceptional** (ordinary)

unflappable Imperturbable, calm, composed.

unforgivable

unfreeze Not *defreeze*.

unfriend To remove someone as a friend on a social networking site.

UN general assembly

UNHCR United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees.

unheard-of retains the hyphen even when it follows the noun.

unhygienic

Unicef United Nations Children's Fund; no need to spell it out.

uninterested, disinterested SEE **DISINTERESTED, UNINTERESTED**.

unique You cannot qualify uniqueness. Never write *almost unique*, *more unique*, *rather unique* or *very unique*. Do not even think of writing *uniquest*.

Unique Identification Authority of India UIDAI.

un-Islamic

United Arab Emirates The country consists of seven emirates: Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman, Umm al-Qaiwain, Ras al-Khaimah and Fujairah. This is how the names are spelled on the United Arab Emirates government's website.

United Kingdom This formal name, a shortened version of *United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland*, should be used only in quotations or in contexts requiring emphasis on Northern Ireland's status. Otherwise, *Britain* or *the UK*.

United Nations Generally, *UN* even in first reference. If a story has a United Nations dateline, write like this:
United Nations:

United States Generally, *US* will suffice. Possessive: *US's*, not *US'*.

UNITS

When abbreviating units, use the singular form without a full stop; for example, *kg* or *km*, not *kgs* or *kms*. The following need not be spelled out even on first mention: kg, km, lb, cm, mm.

All units named after scientists are lowercase; for example, *ampere*, *volt*, *watt*, *celsius*, *fahrenheit*. The abbreviation is the first letter (capped): *A* (ampere), *V* (volt), *W* (watt), *C* (celsius), *F* (fahrenheit).

Do not leave a space between the figure and the abbreviated form of a unit: *10m*, not *10 m*; *20kg*, not *20 kg*. But: *10 metres*, *20 kilograms*.

The above rule does not apply to contractions like *sec* (seconds), *min* (minutes), *hrs* (hours), *yrs* (years). Hence, write *20 sec*, not *20sec*; *30 yrs*, not *30yrs*.

Note that units, when spelled out, take plural forms, wherever necessary.

universe Cap in astronomical sense. Otherwise lowercase, as in *She is the centre of his universe*.

unless and until Choose one or the other.

unlike The items contrasted by *unlike* must be parallel and therefore comparable. Do not write *Unlike Delhi, the climate in Kolkata is humid*. Make it *Unlike Delhi, Kolkata has a humid climate*.

unlike in There is no problem with this phrase when *unlike* is used as an adjective: *The two men were quite unlike in appearance*. Sticklers, however, object to sentences like this: *Unlike in Bangalore, there are hardly any pubs in Delhi*. They say that *unlike* is not an adverb and hence cannot be used to modify a verb or a clause. The same goes for *like in*. The phrase *like in* can, of course, be replaced with *as in*, but no such remedy exists for *unlike in*. For instance, if the sentence above is to be rid of *unlike in*, you will have to write something like this: *Whereas there are many pubs in Bangalore, there are hardly any in Delhi*. It is perhaps not worth the effort. There is no harm in using *unlike in*. It has wide acceptability: *Unlike in Asia, where some jellyfish are eaten by people, here they have no economic or epicurean value* (New York Times). | *Unlike in Paris and Rome, life goes on in British cities in August, whatever the poor folk trapped in their offices think* (Guardian).

unmistakable Not *unmistakeable*.

unparalleled

unprecedented means *for the first time*. A thing is either unprecedented or precedented. It cannot be *rather unprecedented* or *almost unprecedented*.

unreadable, illegible SEE **ILLEGIBLE, UNREADABLE**.

unreligious, irreligious SEE **IRRELIGIOUS, UNRELIGIOUS**.

unseasonable, unseasonal The opposite of both *seasonal* and *seasonable* is *unseasonable*. However, *unseasonal* can be used in weather descriptions.

SEE ALSO **SEASONAL, SEASONABLE**.

unshakable

UN secretary general

UN security council

unto is archaic except in fixed expressions like *do unto others, faithful unto death* and *fast unto death*.

until Note single *l*.

untrammelled

up Avoid as a verb except in idioms like *up the ante*.

UP for Uttar Pradesh. Generally, no need to spell it out, even on first mention.

up(-) Compounds are generally one word:

upbeat, upcountry, update, upstage, upstart, upstream, upsurge, uptown

up close and personal (not *up, close and personal*), up to date (modifier after a noun), ups and downs

up-and-comer (someone who shows promise in a particular field), up-do (hairstyle), up-to-date (modifier, before a noun)

(-)up Compounds formed with *-up* are generally one word in American English. In British English, many of them are hyphenated but the trend is to write them as one word. For the moment, we write only the more common among them as one word.

backup, lineup, makeup, pickup, pinup, shakeup

blow-up, break-up, build-up, check-up, clean-up, close-up, cover-up, flare-up, follow-up, frame-up, grown-up, hold-up, hook-up, let-up, mix-up, pile-up, push-up, round-up, runner(s)-up, set-up, sit-up, stand-up, tie-up, toss-up, wake-up, walk-up (noun and adjective), wind-up, warm-up, wrap-up

Remember, the compounds are two words when used as verbs.

upcoming (going to happen soon, forthcoming), **up-and-coming** (promising continued and future success, as in *an up-and-coming writer*) Do not use *upcoming* when you mean *up-and-coming*. Avoid *upcoming*; use *coming* or *forthcoming*. (See Bernard Kilgore's quote at the beginning of this chapter.)

SEE ALSO **FORTHCOMING**.

upfront (adjective, as in *upfront payment*), **up front** (adverb, as in *these hotels charge up front*)

upload, download SEE **DOWNLOAD, UPLOAD**.

upmarket

uppity (adjective) Not yielding easily.

upsurge Use *surge*, or better still *rise* or *increase*.

uptill Do not use if you mean *till* or *until*. *Uptill* is an obsolete word meaning *to* or *against*. It can, however, be used as two words, as in *She was up till midnight*. Do not use *uptil* either.

up to Two words.

up until Write just *until*: *The talks will continue until* (not *up until*) *August 20*.

URL (uniform resource locator) is the technical term for an address on the world wide web. Unless the context is technical and needs *URL*, write *web address*.

urs Death anniversary of a Sufi saint. Italicize or put in quotation marks.

US for United States, no need to write *USA*; no need to spell out, even on first mention; *America* is also acceptable. *USA* is sometimes used for special effect. The possessive is *US's*, not *US'*.

usable

usage, use *Usage* means *established practice in fields like grammar, law and diplomacy*. Do not write *usage* where the shorter *use* is sufficient.

USAID US development aid agency.

user-friendly Avoid. Write *easy to use* instead.

user-generated content

usher (noun) Use for both men and women.

UT means *Union territory*; do not use it as an abbreviation for *undertrial*.

UTC Abbreviation of *Coordinated Universal Time,* which has replaced *Greenwich Mean Time*, or *GMT*, as the world standard. It is the equivalent of the old system but corrected by atomic clocks to take the earth's rotation into account. The abbreviation was chosen as a compromise that would favour neither English (*CUT* for Coordinated Universal Time) nor French (*TUC* for Temps Universel Coordonné).

utilize means *make practical or profitable use of something*: *The resources could have been better utilized*. In most contexts, the shorter *use* can be used.

utopia Lowercase except in references to the place in Thomas More's book.

Uttarakhand The hill state created in 2000 was known as Uttaranchal till 2006, when Uttarakhand became the official name. The high court is still called Uttaranchal high court.

U-turn

***

The best way to be boring is to leave nothing out.
— **Voltaire**

V

vaccinate

vacillate

vacuum Note single *c* and double *u*.

vagaries Sudden and inexplicable change, as in *vagaries of fashion*, *vagaries of weather*, *vagaries of life*. The singular, *vagary*, is rarely used.

Valentine's Day (normally omit *St*), **Valentine card**

Valium Cap; it is a trademark.

valley Lowercase, as in *the Kashmir valley* or *the valley*.

Vaseline Cap; it is a trademark for a brand of petroleum jelly.

VAT All caps.

Veda, Vedanta

VE-Day The day (May 8) marking the surrender of the German forces to the Allies in 1945. *V* stands for victory and *E* for Europe.

vegetarian (a person who does not eat meat or fish), **vegan** (a person who does not eat or use any animal products, including dairy items, eggs, honey, fur, silk and wool)

veggie Shortened form of *vegetable* or *vegetarian*.

veld Not *veldt*.

venal (open to bribery), **venial** (easily forgiven) A venal person is corruptible; a venial sin is pardonable.

venereal disease *VD* is acceptable in subsequent references.

venetian blind Lowercase.

vengeance, revenge The two nouns are sometimes said to be differentiated on the basis that *revenge* means *retaliatory action carried out by the injured party*, and *vengeance* is *just retribution* carried out by a third party. But examples abound of *vengeance* used in the sense of revenge — without implying *just retribution*: *Thwarted love inspires ambition or vengeance.* | *Iraq has been seized by cycles of vengeance.*

The most common use of *vengeance* is in the phrase *with a vengeance.* Here, it simply means *with great force*.

SEE ALSO **AVENGE, REVENGE**.

ventricles Not *ventricals*.

venue Prefer *place*.

veranda Not *verandah*.

verbal (words used in any manner — spoken, written or printed), **oral** (pertaining to the mouth, hence *spoken words*) *Verbal* is generally used in the sense of *spoken*, but the distinction is worth preserving.

vermilion Note single *l*.

vernacular press Many people consider *vernacular* a pejorative term. In references to the non-English-language press in India, write *language press*, or better still, *Hindi press*, *Tamil press*, *Urdu press*, etc.

versus Spell out in ordinary contexts. Use the abbreviation *vs* in headlines or in special contexts like names of court cases.

vertex (apex or high point of something, point at which two sides of a figure meet to form an angle), **vortex** (swirling matter, like a whirlpool or tornado; plural *vortices*)

very Usually redundant. Mark Twain said: "Substitute 'damn' every time you're inclined to write 'very'; your editor will delete it and the writing will be just as it should be."

vet, whet *To vet* is *to make a careful check of a person or document for suitability*: *The candidates will be vetted by an interview panel.* | *Sensitive*

stories should be vetted by the editor. *To whet* means *to sharpen*, as in *whet a knife*, or *to stimulate*, as in *whet your appetite*.

veto, vetoes, vetoed, vetoing

viable originally meant *sufficiently developed to survive outside the uterus*, as in *a premature but viable infant*. Some authorities and stylebooks insist that its use should remain confined to the original sense. However, it is widely used in the sense of *practicable* or *feasible*, as in *viable plan*, *viable alternative*, *viable economy*. This usage is accepted by Concise Oxford Dictionary, Collins English Dictionary and Webster's New World College Dictionary, among others.

vial Rather than *phial*.

Viagra Trademark. The generic term is sildenafil citrate.

vice(-) Compounds are hyphenated: vice-chairman, vice-chancellor, vice-president. The abbreviations are not hyphenated: VC, VP.

In American English, *vice* compounds are two words. Hence, *US vice president*.

vice versa Two words, no hyphen.

vicious circle, vicious cycle Both mean the same thing; *vicious circle* is more common.

victim The term often carries a tone of pity. Rather than *He is a victim of multiple sclerosis*, write *He has multiple sclerosis*.

Victoria and Albert Museum *V&A*, for short.

video(-) videocassette, videoconference, videoconferencing, videodisc, videogame, videophone, videotape

video link, video recorder, video recording

vie, vied, vying

vigilant

vigilante A member of a group of people who try to prevent crime or punish criminals in their community, especially because they think police are not doing this.

vilify Not *villify*. The word is related to *vile*.

VIP(s) Acceptable in all references to *very important person(s)*.

viral Apart from its traditional meaning of *related to or caused by a virus*, the word is nowadays also used to describe a marketing technique that uses

social networks — online or offline — to promote a brand through self-replicating processes similar to the spread of pathological or computer viruses: *Many businesses are going for viral advertising on social networking websites*.

As a noun, *viral* means *a video, audio or text file that spreads rapidly via the internet*.

virtuoso(s)

vis-à-vis

visitation Except in religious or supernatural contexts, use *visit*.

Visva-Bharati Note hyphen; do not write *Vishwa Bharati*.

SEE ALSO **SANTINIKETAN**.

vitamin A (or B, C, D, E) Lowercase *v*.

viz Use *namely*.

VJ Not *veejay*.

VJ-Day The day (August 15) in 1945 on which Japan stopped fighting in World War II, or the day (September 2) when Japan formally surrendered.

V-neck (noun and adjective)

vocal cords Not *chords*. SEE ALSO **CHORDS, CORDS**.

voicemail One word.

voiceover

volcano(s)

volley(s)

volte-face

vomit, vomiting, vomited

voodoo

vote bank (noun), **vote-bank** (adjective)

vs Short for *versus*; lowercase, no full stop, no itals. Not *Vs*, except in first-letters-capped headlines.

***

Nobody believes a rumor here in Washington until it's officially denied.
— **Edward Cheyfitz**

W

wacky (not *whacky*) Funny or amusing in a crazy way.

wafer-thin

WAGs Wives and girlfriends, especially of star footballers.

Wahhabi Not *Wahabi*.

wait (verb) When *wait* is followed by a time element, *for* can often be omitted: *I waited half an hour*. | *He has been waiting long*.

waiter, waitress *Waiter* or *server* can be used for a man or a woman. *Waitress* remains in wide use and seems exempt from objection, according to the New York Times stylebook. The AP stylebook too endorses *waitress*.

waiting The phrase *in waiting* is used in two senses: *waiting to occupy a position* and *waiting upon a dignitary*. In both senses, the phrase is hyphenated.

When the Chinese president, Hu Jintao, came to India, Kapil Sibal was the minister-in-waiting. | *Gordon Brown was Britain's prime minister-in-waiting for many years*.

waiting list, waitlist Avoid *waitlist* as a noun; use *waiting list*. Use *waitlist* as a verb.

waiver, waver A *waiver* is an act of giving up a claim; *to waver* is to vacillate.

wake, waken, awake, awaken All four verbs can mean that a person has emerged from sleep or the person has been roused by somebody from it. In both senses, *wake (up)* is the most common of the four verbs: *I usually wake up at six in the morning.* | *Try not to wake the baby up.* The past tense of *wake* is *woke* and the past participle *woken*.

The verb *awake* (past tense *awoke*, past participle *awoken*) is generally used only in writing and in the past tense: *He awoke to a day of brilliant sunshine.* *Waken* (past tense and past participle *wakened*) and *awaken* (past tense and past participle *awakened*) are much more formal: *He was awakened at dawn by a noise.* | *We must awaken people to the threat of global warming.*

Awake is more often used as an adjective: *I was awake all night.*

wake-up call is a cliché except while describing a telephone call that wakes you up.

walk(-) Walkman (a trademark; plural *Walkmans*, not *Walkmen*), walkout, walkover, walkway

walk-in (adjective), walk-on (noun and adjective), walk-through, walk-up (noun and adjective)

walkie-talkie Note hyphen.

wallpaper One word.

Wall Street The historic headquarters of the largest US brokerages and investment banks. Many have since relocated to other areas. But *Wall Street* is still used as the collective name for the financial and investment community, including stock exchanges, large banks, brokerages, and securities and underwriting firms. In subsequent references, *the Street* is acceptable.

(-)walla dabbawalla, Dilliwalla, kebabwalla

Do not use *(-)wallah*, except in *boxwallah*.

wannabe (slang) A person who tries to be like someone else or to fit in with a particular group of people.

waqf Not *wakf*.

war(-) warfare, warhead, warhorse, warlike, warlord, warmonger (not *war-mongerer*), warpath, warplane, warship, wartime

war baby, war bride, war chest, war crime, war cry, war dance, war footing, war game, war zone

war-torn

warranty (an assurance from a manufacturer that a product will be repaired or replaced within a specified period if necessary), **warrantee** (the person who gets a warranty)

wary (cautious), **weary** (sick and tired)

wash You wash your hands *of* something, not *off* it.

wash(-) washboard, washbowl, washcloth, washout (noun), washroom, washtub

wash goods (washable fabrics or garments)

wash-and-wear, washed-out, washed-up

wastebasket is fine for *wastepaper basket*.

Waste Land, The Poem by T S Eliot; not *The Wasteland*.

watch(-) watchdog, watchmaker, watchman, watchtower, watchword

watch list

water(-) waterborne, watercolour, waterfall, waterfront, waterhole (pond or pool), waterline, waterlogged, waterlogging, watermark, watermelon, waterproof, watershed, waterside, watertight, waterway, waterworks

water bed, water buffalo, water cooler, watering hole (pub), water meter, water pipe, water plant, water ski (noun), water supply, water system, water table, water tower

water-cooled (adjective), water-ski (verb)

waterboarding An interrogation technique in which water is forced into a detainee's mouth and nose so as to induce the sensation of drowning.

watt is a unit of power, that is, energy supplied or consumed per unit of time. One watt equals one joule per second. *A conventional TV consumes 130 watts per hour* is wrong. Make it *A conventional TV consumes 130 watts*.

SEE ALSO **ENERGY, POWER**.

(to part) ways Not *way*.

WB World Bank. For *West Bengal* in headlines, use *Bengal*.

weak-kneed

(-)wear childrenswear, eyewear, footwear, headwear, menswear, rainwear, sportswear, swimwear, womenswear

formal wear

weather Write *good*, *poor* or *stormy weather*; not *good*, *poor* or *stormy weather conditions*.

web, webpage, website, world wide web

web 2.0

wed For past tense and past participle, prefer *wedded* to *wed*. Write *wedded bliss* or *wedded to an idea*, but *newlywed couple*.

wedding, marriage SEE **MARRIAGE, WEDDING**.

wedge issue A hot-button issue that splits a political coalition or party.

SEE ALSO **HOT-BUTTON ISSUE**.

wee hours Avoid this outworn phrase; write *early hours*.

week(-) weekday, weekdays, weekend, weeknight

weeklong One word.

weightage Prefer *weight* or *weighting*.

weightlifter, weightlifting No hyphen.

weird Not *wierd*.

well(-) A compound modifier formed with *well* needs a hyphen when it is placed before a noun: *It is a well-established practice.* | *He is a well-read man.* The hyphen is omitted when the modifier is placed after the noun: *The practice is well established.* | *He is well read.*

well-being

well-nigh

well-wisher

welsh, meaning *renege on an obligation*, is slang and an ethnic slur.

west, western, the west, western Europe

West Bengal Do not abbreviate to *WB* in headlines.

West End (of London)

western hemisphere The part of the earth comprising North and South America.

Westminster Abbey

wetware The human brain, considered as a computer program or system: *Computers are hardware, programs are software and brains are wetware.*

WFH (Work from Home) Remote work from home.

wharf Plural *wharves*.

wheelchair Say, if relevant, that *X uses a wheelchair* or *X is in a wheelchair*. If a wheelchair is needed, say why. To say that *X is wheelchair-bound* or *X is confined to a wheelchair* is stigmatizing and offensive as well as inaccurate.

wheeler-dealer (noun), **wheeling-dealing** (noun and adjective)

whence means *from where*. Do not write *from whence*. In any case, this old-fashioned word should be avoided.

whereabouts Dictionaries say it can be treated as singular or plural. But the plural form is more common: *Her whereabouts are not known.*

wherever

whet, vet SEE **VET, WHET**.

whether, if SEE **IF, WHETHER**.

which, that SEE **THAT, WHICH**.

while Use it temporally. Avoid its use in place of *although* or *whereas*.

whilst Use *while*.

whisky Plural *whiskies*. Irish and US *whiskey*.

whistleblower

whistle-stop

white-collar

white paper Lowercase, even in reference to a special report.

whitewash (noun, verb and adjective)

whiz (as in *She's a total whiz at maths*; not *wiz* or *whizz*), **whiz kid**

who, whom In traditional usage, *who* is a subject (it does the same job as *he* or *she*); *whom* is an object (it does the same job as *him* or *her*). In modern English, *whom* has virtually disappeared and, even in formal writing, given way to *who*: *Who are you waiting for?* | *There are several people who he has not invited*. By the rules of old grammar, *whom* would have been required in both these sentences.

However, even modern English does not allow the use of *who* after a preposition. *To who did you give it?* is wrong. It should be *Who did you give it to?* (conversational) or *To whom did you give it?* (formal).

There are certain types of sentences in which *who* cannot be used: *The migrants, most of whom are from north India, are scattered all over the city.*

You may choose to stick to old grammar and use *whom* as an object, but never use *whom* as a subject as has been done in the following sentences:
Rajnish, whom tests showed was on drugs, has been arrested.
We were talking about whom should be given the assignment.
Give the keys to whomever opens the door.

The first two sentences need *who*; the third needs *whoever*. As a test, replace *whom* with its logical equivalent *him* and the error becomes obvious: *him was on drugs*, *him should be given the assignment*, *him opens the door* — all awkward constructions.

"The American newspaper columnist who chided George Bush for his slogan *Who do you trust?* and demanded instead *Whom do you trust?* must have spent several generations living in a cave." — R L Trask in "Mind the Gaffe"

whodunit Not *whodunnit*.

wholehearted

whose It is wrong to believe that *whose* can be used only for people. There is nothing wrong with constructions like these: *the book whose cover is red*, *a car whose brakes had failed*, *an idea whose time has come*.

wicketkeeper No hyphen.

wide Write *wide of the mark*, not *wide off the mark*. But: *off the mark*.

wide(-) widespread

wide-angle, wide-awake, wide-eyed, wide-ranging

(-)wide citywide, countrywide, industrywide, nationwide, statewide, worldwide. But: world wide web.

widow, widower Describe a person as a widow or widower only if such description is relevant to the story and the relevance will be clear to the reader.

Wi-Fi is a trademark. The generic term is *wireless computer network*.

wiggle room (flexibility, room to manoeuvre) Not *wriggle room*.

wiki A website or database developed collaboratively by a community of users who are allowed to add and edit content. The most famous example is Wikipedia. The word *wiki* (meaning *quick*) is of Hawaiian origin.

wildlife

wilful Not *willful*.

will, shall SEE **SHALL, WILL**.

will, would Remember that *would* is the past tense of *will*. If the reporting verb is in the past tense, use *would*: *He said he would go*, not *He said he will go*.

There are other uses of *would*. It expresses a supposition or condition: *She would resign if she knew her boss was planning to transfer her*. In this sense, *would* can also be used without an *if* clause: *The plan would cost Rs 100 crore*. Here, the statement is suppositional: *if the plan were adopted* is implied. If the plan has been adopted or is certain to be adopted, the sentence becomes *The plan will cost Rs 100 crore*.

Would is also used in polite requests or offers: *Would you like a coffee.* | *Would you please open the window.* It can be an alternative to *used to* when discussing past habits: *My mother would wake up at four and listen to devotional music.*

willy-nilly

wind farm

window dressing (noun), **window-dress** (verb)

wind-swept

WINES

Normally, lowercase even if the name comes from a region (bordeaux, burgundy, chablis, champagne) or a grape variety (cabernet sauvignon, chardonnay, merlot). Cap when it would otherwise look awkward: Côtes du Rhône.

wingspan

Winnie-the-Pooh The name of the original character, in A A Milne's books, is hyphenated. In Disney movies, it is not hyphenated.

wipeout (noun), **wipe out** (verb)

wiretap, wiretapping

(-)wise No hyphen when it means *in the direction of* or *with regard to*: clockwise, lengthwise, slantwise. The word *penny-wise* is hyphenated because *wise* here has a different meaning: *smart*.

wish Do not use in the sense of *greet*. Write *She greeted him*, not *She wished him*. Use *wish* in constructions like *She wished him happiness.* | *She wished him good luck.* | *She wished him a Happy New Year*.

wish list

wisteria Not *wistaria*.

witch(-) witchcraft

witch doctor, witch hunt

with a view to must be followed by a noun or a gerund (-ing form of a verb working as a noun). Right: *The committee was set up with a view to reducing pollution.* Wrong: *The committee was set up with a view to reduce pollution.*

withhold Not *withold*.

wits' end Note the position of the apostrophe.

woebegone, woeful

woes Acceptable in headlines, but avoid such journalese as *economic woes* in copy.

woke Originally 'aware of injustice'; now politicised term.

women activists, women voters Not *woman activists*, *woman voters*. Also: *menservants*, *men drivers*. But: *man-haters*, *woman-haters*, *maneaters*.

womenswear In British English, one word, no apostrophe; in American English, *women's wear*.

wonk A person who studies an issue thoroughly or excessively; for example, *a policy wonk*. The word has a derogatory connotation; use with care.

woollen Not *woolen*.

word processor, word processing

WORDS AS WORDS

When a word is used merely as a word, and not to represent the concept generally associated with it, italicize it. Example: *Wicketkeeper* is not hyphenated. In headlines, use single quotation marks for this purpose.

work(-) workaholic, workaround, workbench, workbook, workbox, workflow, workforce, workhorse, workhouse, workload, workman, workout (noun), workplace, worksheet, workshop, worksite, workspace, workstation, workwear, workweek

work camp, work ethic, work experience, work out (verb), work permit, work rate, work study

work-shy

workaday (commonplace, ordinary), **workday** (working day)

World Health Organization *WHO* is fine in subsequent references.

world heritage site

world view

World War I, World War II

worldwide

worrisome, worrying Either is fine; *worrisome* is more common in American English and *worrying* in British English.

worship worshipper, worshipped

worthwhile

would, will SEE **WILL, WOULD**.

would-be (adjective)

wounds, injuries SEE **INJURIES, WOUNDS**.

wow factor The quality of being very impressive or surprising: *If the singer wants to succeed, she needs a wow factor*.

wrack, rack SEE **RACK, WRACK**.

wreaked, not *wrought*, is the past tense of *wreak*. Write *wreaked havoc*, *wreaked vengeance*. But: *wrought iron*.

writ You file a *writ petition*, not a *writ*, in a high court or the Supreme Court. *Writ* is the order issued by the court on your petition. In headlines, do not use *writ* as a short form of *writ petition*; use *petition* or *plea* instead.

Writs are of five types: habeas corpus, mandamus, certiorari, prohibition and quo warranto.

write(-) writedown (noun)

write-in, write-off, write-up (nouns)

write down, write in, write off, write up (verbs)

Writers' Buildings The secretariat of the West Bengal government in Kolkata. *Writers' Buildings* is not preceded by *the* and takes a singular verb. Note *Buildings*; do not write *Writers' Building*.

wrong(-) wrongdoer, wrongdoing

wrong-foot (contrive to place an opponent at a tactical disadvantage), wrong-footed, wrong-headed

wunderkind Not *wunderkid*. A child prodigy.

WWF World Wide Fund for Nature. Formerly *World Wildlife Fund*, which remains its official name in the US and Canada.

***

A word is dead
When it is said,
Some say.
I say it just
Begins to live
That day.
— **Emily Dickinson**

XYZ

xenophobe, xenophobia

xerox Cap while using it as a trademark; lowercase in generic sense. Prefer *photocopy* as a verb or as a noun.

Xmas Do not use *X-mas* or *X'mas*. Use *Xmas* only in headlines. Write *Christmas* in copy.

X-rated

x-ray (noun and verb) Lowercase.

yacht

yagya, yajna The commonly used spelling is *yagya*. Use *yajna* when the Sanskrit origin of the word needs to be emphasized.

Yamuna Not *Jamuna*.

Yangtze River in China.

yard Prefer *metre*. One yard equals 3 feet, or 0.91m.

(-)yard backyard, churchyard, courtyard, graveyard, schoolyard, shipyard, steelyard

front yard

yardstick

YEAR SEE **TIME, DATE, DAY, YEAR**.

yearbook One word.

year-end

yearlong One word.

yen Japanese currency; singular and plural.

yesterday Rather than *yesterday*, write *Monday*, *Tuesday*, etc. If you must use *yesterday*, bear the following in mind:

The correct form is *last night*, not *yesterday night*. Both *last evening* and *yesterday evening* are fine, but write *yesterday morning* and *yesterday afternoon* rather than *last morning* and *last afternoon*.

yesteryear Not *yesteryears*.

yeti

yield

yob (British slang) A rowdy, aggressive young man; a hoodlum; a lout. The word was coined in the 19th century by spelling *boy* backwards. Also: *yobbo*.

SEE ALSO **CHAV**.

yogurt Not *yoghurt*.

yojana (not *yojna*) Jawahar Rozgar Yojana, Yojana Bhavan

yoke (oxen), **yolk** (egg)

young turk A young political rebel, a young person eager for radical change to the established order. The term has become a much-misused cliché. Even young cricketers are being called young turks. Ration its use.

yours No apostrophe.

youth

yo-yo Lowercase; it has become a generic term.

-yse, -yze British English uses *-yse*: *analyse*, *catalyse*, *hydrolyse*, *paralyse*. American English uses *-yze*. In both varieties of English, the noun forms of these verbs are *analysis*, *catalysis*, *hydrolysis* and *paralysis*. The verbs have nothing to do with the root *-ize*.

yuan Chinese currency; singular and plural.

Yule, Yuletide They are trite. Just write *Christmas*.

yuppie

Zakir Husain College Note the single *s* in *Husain*. The college is in Delhi.

zeitgeist Spirit of the times.

zero(s) (noun) Verb forms are *zeroes* and *zeroed*, as in *zeroed in*.

zero-based budgeting A technique for preparing a budget, in which each proposed item is evaluated on its merits without considering any previous budget. Preferred form in American English: *zero-base budgeting*.

zero hour

zigzag One word.

zloty Polish currency; singular and plural.

zodiac, zodiacal Lowercase.

zookeeper One word.

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Appendix I

Lists of names

PEOPLE

Aakash Chopra Cricketer.

Aamir Khan

A B Bardhan

Abhishek Nayar Cricketer.

Abhisit Vejjajiva Thai prime minister.

Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury Congress MP from West Bengal.

Adnan Khashoggi Arms dealer.

Aftab Shivdasani Actor.

Aishwarya Rai Bachchan

Ajay Devgn Actor.

Ajay Maken

Ajmal Kasab

Ajoy Mukherji Chief minister of West Bengal in late 60s and early 70s.

A K Antony Defence minister.

Akshaye Khanna Actor.

Alex von Tunzelmann British historian.

Ameesha Patel

Amitabh Bachchan

Anatoly Karpov

Anbumani Ramadoss Former Union health minister.

Angela Merkel German chancellor.

Anil Kapoor

Anju Bobby George Athlete.

Annu Malek The music director earlier spelled his name as *Anu Malik*.

Anuuj Sawhney Actor.

A P J Abdul Kalam

Apoorva Lakhia Film director.

Arnold Schwarzenegger *Arnold* or *Arnie* in headlines.

Arun Jaitley

Arun Shourie Journalist and former Union minister.

Arvind Jadhav Appointed chairman of Air India in May 2009.

Asha Bhosle

Ashish Nehra Cricketer.

Ashutosh Gowariker Filmmaker.

Ashwani Kumar Appointed CBI director in August 2008.

Ashwini Nachappa Athlete.

Atal Bihari Vajpayee

Aung San Suu Kyi Nobel laureate fighting for democracy in Myanmar.

Aunshuman Gaekwad Cricketer.

Azim Premji

Babu Lal Marandi Former chief minister of Jharkhand.

Bachendri Pal

Baichung Bhutia

Bangaru Laxman

Ban Ki-moon UN secretary general.

Bappi Lahiri

Barack Obama

Basudeb Acharia CPM MP from West Bengal.

Beyoncé Knowles

Bhagwat Subramanya Chandrasekhar Cricketer.

Bhairon Singh Shekhawat Former Vice-President of India.

Bharati Mukherjee Author.

Bhikaiji Cama Freedom fighter. The building named after her in Delhi is, however, known as Bhikaji Cama Place.

Bhumika Chawla Actor.

Bhupinder Singh Hooda Haryana chief minister.

Bidhan Chandra Roy First chief minister of West Bengal.

Bishan Singh Bedi

Boutros Boutros-Ghali Former UN secretary general.

B S Yeddyurappa Karnataka chief minister.

Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee West Bengal chief minister.

Budhia Singh

Camilla Parker Bowles No hyphen.

Cate Blanchett

Catherine Zeta-Jones

Celina Jaitley

Chanda Kochhar Appointed managing director and CEO of ICICI Bank in May 2009.

Chandra Shekhar Former Prime Minister.

Charles de Gaulle World War II figure and French president from 1958 to 1969.

Charles Sobhraj

Che Guevara

Chetan Chauhan

Chiang Kai-shek Kuomintang leader and ruler of Taiwan from 1949 to 1975.

Chiranjeevi Actor and politician.

Chuni Goswami Nickname of Subimal Goswami, footballer, cricketer and football administrator.

Condoleezza Rice

C Rajagopalachari

Danny Denzongpa

Darrell Hair Australian cricket umpire.

David Coleman Headley

Dawood Ibrahim Allegedly the mastermind of the 1993 blasts in Mumbai, India's most wanted man, on the wanted list of Interpol, declared a "global terrorist" by the US.

Deendayal Upadhyaya

Deepak Kapoor Army chief from September 2007 to March 2010.

Deepak Parekh

Deepika Padukone Model and actor.

Deng Xiaoping De facto leader of China from 1978 to 1989.

Dhanraj Pillay Former hockey captain.

Diana Edulji Cricketer.

Dilip Kumar

Dimple Kapadia

Dinesh Karthik Cricketer.

Dmitry Medvedev Russian president. This is how the name is spelled on the Russian president's official website.

Dostoevsky

Duvvuri Subbarao Appointed RBI governor in September 2008. The surname is Subbarao; do not make it *Rao*.

Ekta Kapoor

Ela Bhatt Founder of Self-Employed Women's Association (SEWA).

Elle Macpherson

Emraan Hashmi

Farokh Engineer

Farooq Abdullah Former chief minister of J&K.

Farooq Shaikh Actor.

Federico García Lorca Spanish poet.

Feroze Gandhi

Fidel Castro

François Mitterrand French president from 1981 to 1995.

Gabriel García Márquez

Garry Kasparov

Gautam Gambhir Cricketer.

George Fernandes Former defence minister.

Giridhar Gamang Former chief minister of Odisha.

Gisele Bündchen Brazilian supermodel.

Giselle Monteiro Brazilian-born Bollywood model and actor who starred opposite Saif Ali Khan in "Love Aaj Kal".

Goolam Vahanvati Appointed attorney general of India in June 2009.

Gopal Subramaniam Appointed solicitor general of India in June 2009.

Gundappa Viswanath Cricketer.

Hans Christian Andersen

Hans Raj Bhardwaj Former Union law minister.

Harbhajan Singh

Harold Macmillan

H D Deve Gowda

Himesh Reshammiya

Hitler First name *Adolf*, not *Adolph*; the title *Führer* (leader), not *Fuehrer*.

Ho Chi Minh Communist leader of North Vietnam from 1945 to 1969.

Hrithik Roshan

Hugo Chávez

Iftikar Muhammad Chaudhry Controversial chief justice of Pakistan.

Immanuel Kant Not *Emmanuel*.

Indra Nooyi PepsiCo CEO. Not *Indira*.

Irfan Pathan Cricketer.

Ishant Sharma Cricketer.

Ismat Chughtai Urdu writer.

Jackie Shroff

Jagadish Chandra Bose Physicist and botanist; he did pioneering research on radio waves during 1894-1900. His work predates that of Guglielmo Marconi, who is generally credited with the development of radio.

Jagdish Bhagwati Economist, brother of P N Bhagwati.

Jagmohan Dalmiya

Jai Parkash Aggarwal Delhi Congress leader.

Jawaharlal Nehru

Jaya Jaitly

Jayanthi Natarajan

Jaya Prada

Jayaprakash Narayan Freedom fighter and socialist leader, remembered especially for leading the opposition to Indira Gandhi in the 1970s.

Jay Prakash Narayan Yadav Former Union minister of state.

Jessica Lall Not *Lal*.

Jiah Khan Actor.

J Jayalalithaa

J M Lyngdoh Former chief election commissioner.

Joe Biden (US vice president) Not *Joseph Biden*.

John le Carré

Josef Stalin

José María Aznar Former prime minister of Spain.

Josip Broz Tito Yugoslavia's president from 1953 to 1980.

J R R Tolkien Not *Tolkein*.

Jyotiraditya Scindia Congress MP.

Jyotirmoyee Sikdar Former CPM MP from West Bengal, Asian Games gold medallist.

Kaká Brazilian footballer.

Kamal Haasan Actor.

Kangna Ranaut Actor.

Kanshi Ram

Kapil Dev

Kareena Kapoor

Karisma Kapur

Karnam Malleswari Weightlifter.

Kate Winslet

Keira Knightley

K G Balakrishnan Chief Justice of India.

Kim Clijsters

Kim Dae-jung South Korea's president from 1998 to 2003.

Kim Jong-il North Korean leader.

Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw

K Kanimozhi

K M Beenamol Athlete.

Konkona Sen Sharma

K S Duleepsinhji

K S Ranjitsinhji

Kuldip Nayar

Kumar Mangalam Birla

Kunjarani Devi Weightlifter.

Kushboo Actor.

K Yerran Naidu (Not *Yerrannaidu*) Member of Telugu Desam Party politburo.

Lakshmi Niwas Mittal

Lakshmipathy Balaji Cricketer.

Lal Bahadur Shastri

Lal Krishna Advani

Lalu Prasad Not *Laloo*. He does not use the surname *Yadav*.

Laurence Olivier Not *Lawrence*.

Leander Paes

Le Corbusier Swiss-French architect and city planner (born Charles-Édouard Jeanneret-Gris) who led the planning of Chandigarh.

Lee Kuan Yew

Leonardo da Vinci In subsequent references, *Leonardo*; not *da Vinci*.

Leonardo DiCaprio Hollywood actor.

Liza Minnelli

Lula da Silva President of Brazil.

Madeleine Albright Former US secretary of state.

Madhavrao Scindia

Madhavsinh Solanki

Madhuri Dixit

Mahasweta Devi Bengali writer.

Mahathir Mohamad *Mahathir* in subsequent references.

Mahendra Singh Dhoni

Mahesh Bhupathi

Mahima Chaudhary Actor.

Mahinda Rajapaksa President of Sri Lanka.

Malaika Arora Khan

Mallika Sarabhai

Mallika Sherawat

Mamata Banerjee

Mammootty Muhammed Kutty, actor.

Mani Shankar Aiyar

Manoj Bajpayee The actor earlier spelled his surname as *Bajpai*.

Mao Zedong *Mao* in subsequent references or in headlines.

M D Valsamma Athlete.

Medha Patkar

Meena Kumari

Meira Kumar

M F Husain

Michelangelo

Mikhail Gorbachev

Minissha Lamba Actor.

Mirwaiz Umer Farooq

M K Alagiri In August 2009, he changed the spelling of his name from *Azhagiri* to *Alagiri*.

Mohamed Al Fayed This is how the chairman of Harrods spells his name.

Mohamed ElBaradei

Mohammad Hamid Ansari Vice-President of India.

Mohammad Kaif

Mohammed Azharuddin

Morarji Desai

Mother Teresa

Muammar Gaddafi

Muhammad Ali

Mullah Mohammed Omar

Munaf Patel Cricketer.

Murali Kartik Cricketer.

Murali Vijay Cricketer.

Muttiah Muralitharan Cricketer.

Najma Heptulla

Nana Patekar

Nandan Nilekani

Napoleon Not *Napolean*.

Narain Karthikeyan

Naseeruddin Shah

Nasim Ashraf Former chairman of Pakistan Cricket Board.

Naveen Jindal

Naveen Patnaik

Navin Chawla

N D Tiwari

Neelam Sanjiva Reddy India's President from 1977 to 1982.

Nicolae Ceausescu

Nicolas Sarkozy

Nietzsche

Nikita Khrushchev

Nirad C Chaudhuri

Nita Ambani Wife of Mukesh Ambani.

Nitish Kumar

Noam Chomsky US linguist.

Norah Jones

Nouri al-Maliki

N R Narayana Murthy

Nutan Actor.

O Henry Not *O'Henry*.

O P Nayyar

Osama bin Laden

Ottavio Quattrocchi

Padmini Kolhapure

Palaniappan Chidambaram Just *P Chidambaram* unless writing for special effect.

Parkash Singh Badal

Parthiv Patel Cricketer.

Parveen Babi

Paul McCartney

Paulo Coelho Brazilian author.

P C Mahalanobis

Penélope Cruz

Perizaad Zorabian Actor.

Pervez Musharraf

P N Bhagwati Former Chief Justice of India.

Pragyan Ojha Cricketer.

Prakash Javadekar

Pratapsinh Rane

Praveen Kumar Cricketer.

Preity Zinta

Prithviraj Chauhan Twelfth-century king of Delhi.

Prithviraj Chavan Union minister of state.

Priyanka Vadra Not *Vadera*.

Priya Ranjan Dasmunsi

Raakhee Gulzar

Rafik Hariri

Raja Bhaiya Not *Bhayya* or *Bhaiyya*.

Raj Kapoor

Rajinikanth (not *Rajnikanth* or *Rajnikant*) Superstar of Tamil films. His original name is Shivajirao Gaekwad. He was born to Marathi parents in Karnataka.

Rajiv Gandhi

Rajkumari Amrit Kaur Health minister in Nehru Cabinet.

Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore

Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra

Rakhi Sawant

Ramesh Powar Cricketer.

Ram Gopal Varma Filmmaker.

Ram Vilas Paswan

Randeep Hooda Actor.

Ranganath Misra Former Chief Justice of India.

Rani Mukerji

Raveena Tandon

Ravi Kishan Bhojpuri film star.

Ravindra Jadeja Cricketer.

Reena Roy Actor.

Renée Zellweger

Renuka Chowdhury

Rimmi Actor. She does not use the surname *Sen*.

Rishi Kapoor

Ritiesh Deshmukh Actor.

R K Pachauri

Robert De Niro

Robert Zoellick World Bank president.

Roh Moo-hyun Former South Korean president.

R P Singh Cricketer.

Rudolph (or **Rudy**) **Giuliani**

Russell Crowe

Sacha Baron Cohen The man behind Ali G and Borat.

Sachin Tendulkar

Saddam Hussein

Saif-ud-din Soz

Salman Khurshid

Salman Rushdie

Samak Sundaravej Former Thai prime minister.

Sanath Jayasuriya

Sandeep Dikshit Congress MP and son of Delhi chief minister Sheila Dikshit.

Santhi Soundarajan Stripped of the silver medal won at the 2006 Asian Games after failing a gender verification test.

Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan

Satyendra Nath Bose Physicist, famous for Bose-Einstein statistics.

Seema Biswas Actor.

Selja Union minister.

Seymour Hersh

Shahid Kapur

Shah Rukh Khan

Shammi Kapoor

Shankar Jaikishan

Shankersinh Vaghela

Shashi Kapoor

Sheila Dikshit Chief minister of Delhi.

Shekhar Kapur

Shibu Soren

Shinzo Abe Former prime minister of Japan.

Shivraj Singh Chouhan Chief minister of Madhya Pradesh.

Shivshankar Menon

Shobhana Bhartia

Siddhartha Shankar Ray Former chief minister of West Bengal.

Sikander Bakht

Sis Ram Ola

Sitaram Yechury

Sivaji Ganesan

S Jaipal Reddy

Smriti Iraani

Somdev Devvarman Tennis player.

Somnath Chatterjee

Sonia Sotomayor

Sontosh Mohan Dev Not *Santosh Mohan Deb*.

Sonu Niigaam

Sourav Ganguly Not *Saurav*.

Sridevi

Sriprakash Jaiswal Union minister of state.

Steve Ballmer

Steven Spielberg

Subash Ghisingh

Subhas Chandra Bose

Subhash Chakraborty Former West Bengal transport minister. He died in August 2009.

Subodh Kant Sahay

Subramaniam Badrinath Cricketer.

Sufi Muhammad Not *Sufi Mohammed*. Leader of the Pakistani militant organization Tehreek-e-Nafaz-e-Shariat-e-Mohammadi.

Suniel Shetty Actor.

Suresh Pachouri

Suresh Raina Cricketer.

Sushilkumar Shinde

Sven-Göran Eriksson

Swraj Paul

Syama Prasad Mookerjee

Syed Shahnawaz Hussain BJP MP and former Union minister.

Syed Yousaf Raza Gilani Prime minister of Pakistan.

Tahawwur Rana

Tarun Gogoi

Tejendra Khanna Lieutenant governor of Delhi.

Tiger Woods

Tolstoy

Tom Cruise

T R Baalu

T Subbarami Reddy

Tusshar Kapoor Actor; son of Jeetendra and brother of Ekta Kapoor.

Ujjwala Raut Model.

Uma Bharati

Valéry Giscard d'Estaing Former French president.

Vallabhbhai Patel

Vasundhara Raje

Vayalar Ravi

Veer Savarkar

Velupillai Prabhakaran

Venkatraman Ramakrishnan Indian-born scientist who was awarded the 2009 Nobel prize in chemistry along with Thomas Steitz and Ada Yonath.

Vijayaraje Scindia

Vijayashanti Actor.

Vijay Mallya

Vijender Singh

Vilasrao Deshmukh

Vineet Nayar CEO of HCL Technologies.

Vineet Nayyar Chairman of Mahindra Satyam.

Virat Kohli Cricketer.

Virender Sehwag Nickname *Viru*, not *Veeru*.

Virgil Not *Vergil*.

Viswanathan Anand

Viveik Oberoi

Vladimir Nabokov Author of "Lolita".

V S Achuthanandan

V V S Laxman

Vyjayantimala Bali

Waheeda Rehman

Warren Buffett

Wasim Jaffer Cricketer.

Yashodhara Raje Scindia

Yasser Arafat

Younis Khan Pakistani cricketer.

Y S R Reddy In headlines, *YSR*. The initials stand for Yeduguri Sandinti Rajasekhara. YSR was the chief minister of Andhra Pradesh. He died in a helicopter crash in September 2009.

Yusuf Pathan

Yuvraj Singh

Zaheer Khan Cricketer.

Zakir Husain Third President of India (1967-69) .

Zakir Hussain Tabla player.

***

PLACES

Abuja Capital of Nigeria.

Adilabad In Andhra Pradesh.

Aizawl

Alappuzha Not *Alleppey*, in Kerala.

Almaty Largest city of Kazakhstan. It lost its status as capital to Astana in 1997.

Amravati Not *Amaravati*, in Maharashtra.

Anantapur In Andhra Pradesh.

Ara Not *Arrah*, in Bihar.

Astana Capital of Kazakhstan.

Asunción Capital of Paraguay.

Azerbaijan The people of Azerbaijan are Azerbaijanis. Most Azerbaijanis are Azeris, but there are Azeris in Armenia and northern Iran too. The language is Azeri.

Bagpat In UP.

Balochistan Not *Baluchistan*.

Bangkok

Bangladesh

Baramulla

Bardhaman Not *Burdwan*, in West Bengal.

Bareilly But *Rae Bareli*.

Basel Not *Basle*, city in northern Switzerland.

Bathinda In Punjab.

Belarus Its people are *Belarusians*, not *Belarussians* or *Belorusians*.

Bellary In Karnataka.

Bengalaru Not *Bangalore*

Berne Capital of Switzerland.

Bharuch In Gujarat.

Bhikaji Cama Place In Delhi.

Bhubaneswar

Bijnor Not *Bijnore*, in UP.

Bloemfontein In South Africa.

Borivli Not *Borivili*, in Mumbai.

Bosnia-Herzegovina Officially, Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina or Bosnia and Herzegovina. But *Bosnia-Herzegovina* is acceptable.

Bosphorus

Brasilia Capital of Brazil.

Bucharest Capital of Romania.

Bulandshahr

Buxar In Bihar.

Cachar In Assam.

Cádiz City in southwestern Spain.

Cameroon Not *Cameroons*, *Camerouns* or *Cameroun*.

Cancún

Cape Town Two words.

Chechnya Its inhabitants are Chechens.

Chhapra In Bihar.

Chhattisgarh

Chhindwara

Chickmagalur In Karnataka.

Chittoor In Andhra Pradesh.

Christchurch In New Zealand. The Oxford college is *Christ Church* (not *Christ Church College*).

Cincinnati

Cooch Behar In West Bengal.

Copenhagen

Côte d'Azur French Riviera.

Cuddalore In Tamil Nadu.

Cuttack

Czech Republic

Dang Not *Dangs*, in Gujarat.

Darjeeling

Davangere In Karnataka.

Dehradun Not *Dehra Dun*.

Dharamshala (not *Dharamsala*) In Himachal Pradesh; seat of the Tibetan government in exile.

Ecuador Adjective and noun: *Ecuadorean*.

El Salvador Country in South America. Its people are Salvadorans and capital is San Salvador.

Farrukhabad In UP.

Ferozepur In Punjab.

Fez City in Morocco; not *Fes*.

Firozabad In UP.

Gambia Not *the Gambia*.

Gaza Strip

Gibraltar Its residents are Gibraltarians.

Giridih In Jharkhand.

Gothenburg City in Sweden. Do not use the Swedish spelling *Göteborg*.

Guangdong

Guangzhou Formerly *Canton*.

Guatemala City Capital of Guatemala.

Gujarat Not *Gujrat*.

Haarlem In the Netherlands.

Hanover

Haridwar Not *Hardwar*, in UP.

Harlem In New York City.

Hassan In Karnataka.

Hawaii

Hazaribag Not *Hazaribagh*, in Jharkhand.

Hisar Not *Hissar*, in Haryana.

Ho Chi Minh City Vietnamese capital, known as Saigon till 1975.

Hong Kong

Hooghly

Illinois

Jalandhar

Jeddah

Jhajjar In Haryana.

Johannesburg Not *Johannesberg*.

Junagadh In Gujarat.

Kachchh Not *Kutch*.

Kadapa In Andhra Pradesh; not *Cuddapah*.

Kanchipuram In Tamil Nadu.

Kandhamal In Odisha.

Kannur In Kerala.

Karol Bagh In Delhi.

Kashmere Gate Not *Kashmiri Gate*, in Delhi.

Kathmandu Not *Katmandu*.

Kazakhstan Adjective *Kazakh*.

Kendrapara In Odisha.

Keralam Not *Kerala*

Khammam In Andhra Pradesh.

Kishanganj In Bihar.

Kochi Not *Cochin*.

Koderma In Jharkhand.

Kosovo Adjective *Kosovan*.

Kozhikode Not *Calicut*.

Kuala Lumpur

Kyrgyzstan Adjective *Kyrgyz*.

Lakshadweep

Lhasa Capital of Tibet.

Liechtenstein

Louisiana The people of Louisiana are Louisianians.

Luxembourg

Lyon Not *Lyons*, in France.

Maastricht

Macau Not *Macao*. A special administrative region of China.

Mahabubnagar In Andhra Pradesh.

Mahesana Not *Mehsana*, in Gujarat.

Malappuram In Kerala.

Malegaon In Maharashtra.

Maligaon In Guwahati.

Mangolpuri Not *Mongolpuri*, in Delhi.

Marrakech Not *Marrakesh*. City in Morocco; the capital of Morocco is Rabat.

Marseille In France.

Massachusetts US state. Its capital is Boston.

Milwaukee City in Wisconsin, US.

Minneapolis City in Minnesota, US.

Minnesota US state.

Mississippi

Missouri

Moldova Adjective *Moldovan*.

Monaco The world's smallest country after the Vatican.

Montana US state.

Monte Carlo City in Monaco.

Montenegro Its inhabitants are Montenegrins.

Montreal

Myanmar Not *Burma*; for the people of Myanmar, use *Burmese*.

Nagapattinam In Tamil Nadu.

Nalgonda In Andhra Pradesh.

Naypyidaw New capital of Myanmar.

Nashik Not Nasik.

Nawada In Bihar.

Nawanshahr In Punjab.

New South Wales In Australia.

New York City In most contexts, *New York* will do but cap *City* when using the full name.

North-West Frontier Province Province in Pakistan.

Northwest Territories In Canada.

Nova Scotia Canadian province.

Nuremberg (not *Nuremburg*) German city where the Allied trials of war criminals took place in 1945-46.

Odisha Not *Orissa*. For the language and the people, *Odia*.

Ottawa Capital of Canada.

Palakkad Not *Palaghat*, in Kerala.

Palamu Not *Palamau*, in Jharkhand.

Palika Bazaar In Delhi.

Panaji Not *Panjim*.

Panchmahal Not *Panchmahals*, district in Gujarat.

Paramaribo Capital of Suriname.

Pavagadh In Gujarat.

Pennsylvania

Phnom Penh (not *Pnom Penh*) Capital of Cambodia.

Port-au-Prince Capital of Haiti.

Port of Spain Capital of Trinidad and Tobago.

Prakasam In Andhra Pradesh.

Puducherry Not *Pondicherry*.

Puerto Rico A semi-autonomous territory of the US in the northeastern Caribbean.

Purnia Not *Purnea*, in Bihar.

Queens Area in New York.

Rae Bareli But *Bareilly*.

Raigad In Maharashtra.

Raigarh In Chhattisgarh.

Raipur Capital of Chhattisgarh.

Rajahmundry In Andhra Pradesh.

Rajinder Nagar In Delhi.

Rajouri In J&K.

Rajouri Garden In Delhi.

Ramanathapuram In Tamil Nadu.

Rangareddy In Andhra Pradesh.

Rangoon Use *Yangon*.

Rayagada In Odisha.

Rayalaseema Region in Andhra Pradesh.

Reykjavik Capital of Iceland.

Rhode Island US state.

Rio de Janeiro

Romania Not *Rumania*.

Sanaa Capital of Yemen.

Santa Cruz In Mumbai.

São Paulo Brazilian city, not *São Paolo*.

Sarajevo Capital of Bosnia and Herzegovina.

Seattle City in the US state of Washington. Olympia, not Seattle, is the capital of the state.

Shahdara Area in Delhi.

Sharm el-Sheikh In Egypt.

Shimla Use *Simla* only in historical contexts.

Shravasti In UP.

Sichuan A province in western China. Its capital is Chengdu. *Szechwan* and *Szechuan* are old spellings. Use *Sichuan* in references to the cuisine too.

Sindh

Sivasagar In Assam.

Sonipat Not *Sonepat*, in Haryana.

Srikakulam In Andhra Pradesh.

Sriperumbudur In Tamil Nadu.

St Louis City in the US state of Missouri.

St Petersburg

Suriname Not *Surinam*. Formerly *Dutch Guiana*.

Taipei Capital of Taiwan.

Tajikistan The people of Tajikistan are Tajiks.

Tallinn Capital of Estonia.

Tangier Not *Tangiers*, in Morocco.

Tbilisi Capital of Georgia.

Tehran Not *Teheran*.

Telangana Not *Telengana*.

Tennessee US state.

The Hague Not *the Hague*.

Thimphu (not *Thimpu*) Capital of Bhutan.

Thiruvananthapuram

Thrissur Not *Trichur*, in Kerala.

Tinsukia In Assam.

Tiruchirappalli In Tamil Nadu; commonly known as Trichy.

Turkmenistan Adjective *Turkmen*. A citizen of Turkmenistan is a *Turkmen* (plural *Turkmens*).

Udham Singh Nagar In Uttarakhand.

Udupi Not *Udipi*, in Karnataka.

Ukraine Not *the Ukraine*.

Ulan Bator Capital of Mongolia.

Uluru Formerly *Ayers Rock*, in Australia.

Uzbekistan Adjective *Uzbek*.

Vadodara Not *Baroda*.

Valletta Capital of Malta.

Visakhapatnam

Vizianagaram In Andhra Pradesh.

Washington US capital; use *Washington DC* only to avoid confusion with Washington state or for special effect.

Wayanad In Kerala.

Xi'an City in China where Terracotta Warriors are located.

Xinjiang

Yangon Not *Rangoon*.

***

BRANDS AND COMPANIES

Accenture Formerly *Andersen Consulting*.

AC Nielsen

Adidas Cap. An exception to the rule of spelling a company's name the way it does. In this case, the company's official name is *adidas AG*.

Aeroflot Russian airline.

Airbus Industrie

Air India The airline dropped the hyphen from its name in 2005.

Alcoa Formerly *Aluminum Company of America*.

Alitalia Airlines

Allianz

Alstom Formerly *GEC Alsthom*.

AltaVista

Amazon.com

Andersen The accountancy firm formerly known as Arthur Andersen.

ArcelorMittal One word with *M* capital, no hyphen.

AstraZeneca One word with *Z* capital.

AT&T The company was known as American Telephone & Telegraph Company until 1994. In 2005, AT&T was acquired by its former subsidiary, SBC Communications Inc, which renamed itself AT&T.

AT Kearney Management consulting firm.

Axis Bank Formerly *UTI Bank*.

BAE Systems Formerly *British Aerospace*, or *BAe*.

Bank of China is a commercial bank. People's Bank of China is the central bank of China.

Barclays Bank

Barnes & Noble

Baskin-Robbins

Benetton

Bennett, Coleman & Company Ltd BCCL. The company that publishes The Times of India and The Economic Times. Times Group includes BCCL and the subsidiaries of BCCL.

Berkshire Hathaway

BlackBerry Plural *BlackBerrys*.

Bombay Dyeing

British Airways

Café Coffee Day

Campari

Canal+ French TV channel.

Capgemini Consulting, technology and outsourcing services company.

Carrefour

Cartier Not *Cartier's*.

CB Richard Ellis

Chevron

Chloé

Christie's

Chrysler Full name *Chrysler Group LLC*.

Citibank

Citigroup Citigroup was formed by combining Citicorp and financial conglomerate Travelers Group in 1998.

Coca-Cola, Coke

Crisil A Standard and Poor's company.

DaimlerChrysler The merged entity was in existence from 1998 to 2007. Now Daimler (full name *Daimler AG*, not *Daimler-Benz*) and Chrysler are two separate companies.

Delhi Metro Rail Corporation DMRC.

Dettol

Diners Club No apostrophe.

DuPont Not *duPont*. The full name *EI du Pont de Nemours and Company* is rarely used.

EADS European Aeronautic Defence and Space Company. It makes and sells civil and military aircraft.

easyJet *EasyJet* at the beginning of a sentence or in a first-letters-capped headline.

eBay *EBay* at the beginning of a sentence or in a first-letters-capped headline.

ebookers UK-based online travel company. *Ebookers* at the beginning of a sentence or in a first-letters-capped headline.

EgyptAir

Électricité de France EDF.

Ericsson

Ex-Im Bank Export-Import Bank of the US.

Exxon Mobil Corporation was formed in 1999 by the merger of Exxon and Mobil.

FedEx The US Federal Express delivery service company.

Ford Motor Company In subsequent references, use *Ford*, not *FMC*.

GAIL The company's name is GAIL (India) Limited. Do not write *Gas Authority of India Ltd*.

Game Boy Handheld videogame console from Nintendo.

Gaz de France GDF.

General Electric Company GE.

General Motors GM. The old General Motors Corp filed for bankruptcy in 2009. General Motors Company, a new entity, emerged from the bankruptcy court proceedings. The assets of the old company were transferred to the new company.

Gillette The brand is owned by Procter & Gamble.

GlaxoSmithKline GSK.

GoAir Airline.

Goldman Sachs

Group 4 Security company.

Häagen-Dazs American ice cream brand. It is not a European brand, although the name suggests so. The name is simply two made-up words meant to look Scandinavian. The company was set up by Reuben and Rose Mattus in the Bronx, New York, in 1961.

Harley-Davidson

HarperCollins

Harrods No apostrophe.

HCL Technologies

Hewlett-Packard In headlines, *HP*.

Hindustan Unilever

Iberia Iberia Airlines of Spain.

Icelandair

Icra Indian associate of Moody's Investors Service.

Indian Oil Corporation

IndiGo Airline.

IndusInd Bank

Jack Daniel's

Japan Airlines JAL.

J C Penney

Johnson & Johnson

JPMorgan Chase & Co *JPMorgan* is acceptable in all references.

Kalashnikov

KFC No longer spelled out as *Kentucky Fried Chicken*.

Kissan

KitKat

KLM Royal Dutch Airlines In most references, *KLM* will do.

Kmart

Kwality Wall's

Land Rover No hyphen.

Learjet

Levi's (brand), **Levi Strauss & Co** (company)

LinkedIn

Lloyds Bank International Ltd

Lloyd's of London (insurance)

Lloyd's Register

Lockheed Martin Corporation

Lufthansa The full name is Lufthansa German Airlines.

Macmillan Publishers

Macy's

Marks & Spencer M&S.

Marriott (not *Marriot*) The hotel chain.

MasterCard

McDonald's

McDonnell Douglas US aircraft manufacturer. It merged with Boeing in 1997.

(Le) Méridien Hotel chain.

Merrill Lynch

MGM Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer Studios Inc.

Microsoft

Moody's Investors Service

MySpace

Nestlé

Northwest Airlines

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation ONGC.

PepsiCo *Pepsi* in headlines.

Peugeot

Philip Morris Philip Morris International and Philip Morris USA, which sell the Marlboro brand, are subsidiaries of the Altria Group.

Philips Electronics company.

PlayStation Videogame console from Sony.

Pond's

Porsche

PricewaterhouseCoopers One word; *PwC*, for short.

Procter & Gamble Not *Proctor & Gamble*.

Qantas Airways Usually, just *Qantas*. It was originally an acronym for Queensland and Northern Territory Aerial Services.

QuarkXpress

Range Rover

Ray-Ban

Raymond Not *Raymond's*.

Reliance Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group R-ADAG. Run by Anil Ambani.

Reliance Industries Ltd RIL. Run by Mukesh Ambani.

Rolls-Royce

Royal Dutch Shell plc

Ryanair

Saatchi

Sabena Belgian World Airlines Usually, just *Sabena*.

SAIL Steel Authority of India Ltd.

Sanofi-aventis Hyphenate and lowercase *aventis*.

Satyam Computer Services Ltd is now known as Mahindra Satyam.

Saudi Arabian Oil Co *Saudi Aramco* is acceptable.

Savile Row

7UP

Siemens

Sotheby's

SpiceJet Airline.

Standard and Poor's

Swiss (full name Swiss International Air Lines) is the principal airline of Switzerland and the successor of Swissair. In 2005, it became a subsidiary of Lufthansa.

Tata Elxsi

Tata Motors

TGI Friday's

Times Group SEE **BENNETT, COLEMAN & COMPANY LTD**.

Toys"R"Us

20th Century Fox, Twentieth Century Fox Film Corporation

Unilever

United Airlines

Varig Brazil's flagship airline.

Vodafone Not *Vodaphone* as has appeared in some papers.

Volkswagen AG Ordinarily, *Volkswagen*. In subsequent references or headlines, *VW*.

Wall's Ice cream.

Wal-Mart The company's name remains Wal-Mart Stores Inc, although the name of its stores in the US is now *Walmart*. Write *Wal-Mart*.

Wii Videogame console from Nintendo.

Wockhardt The name suggests that the company has German roots, but that is not the case. It is an Indian MNC.

Xbox Videogame console from Microsoft.

Yahoo An exception to the rule of writing a company's name the way it spells it. In this case, *Yahoo!* is the official name.

YouTube

Yves Saint Laurent Never *St Laurent*.

***

Appendix 2

When to use 'the'?

Grammar requires the use of *the* in the following situations:

While referring to things or people already mentioned, or when the reader knows which particular people or things you mean: *There was a murder in Gurgaon last night; the victim was a property dealer.* | *The job is getting tougher.* | *I'll pick you up at the airport.*

While referring to a person, place or thing that is unique: *the Taj Mahal*, *the Mona Lisa*, *the Prime Minister, the White House*, *the theory of relativity*, *the 2010-11 Union Budget.*

Before names of rivers, seas and oceans: *the Ganga, the Atlantic.*

Before names of points on the globe: *the equator, the north pole.*

Before names of geographical areas: *the Middle East, the south.*

Before names of deserts, forests, gulfs and peninsulas: *the Sahara, the Persian Gulf.*

Before words like *first* and *only* or numbers showing the unique position of a thing or a person: *That was one of the best films I've ever seen.* | *What's the highest mountain in Europe?* | *I'll never forget the first time we met.*

While explaining which person or thing you mean: *The house opposite the post office* | *The people I met there were friendly* | *Friday the thirteenth* | *It was the best day of my life* | *Alexander the Great.*

While referring to a thing in general: *My brother taught himself to play the violin.* | *The dolphin is an intelligent animal.*

Before some adjectives to turn them into nouns which refer to people or things in general: *The French were defeated at Waterloo in 1815.* | *With him, you should always expect the unexpected.* | *We'll just have to wait for the inevitable.* | *The unemployed have no hope under this government.*

Before the plural of a person's last name to refer to a whole family or a married couple: *Don't forget to invite the Sharmas.*

Enough of something for a particular purpose: *I wanted it but I didn't have the money.*

With a unit of measurement to mean *every*: *My car does 12 kilometres to the litre.* | *You get paid by the hour.*

With a unit of time to mean the present: S*he's flavour of the month with him.*

Before each of two comparative adjectives or adverbs when you want to show how one amount gets bigger or smaller in relation to the other: *The faster I get this piece of work finished, the sooner I can go home.*

Before comparative adjectives or adverbs when you want to show that someone or something has become more or less of a particular state: *She doesn't seem to be any the worse for her bad experience.*

To show that the person or thing referred to is famous or important (stressed and pronounced *thee*): *At that time Delhi was the place to be.* | *You don't mean you met the Shah Rukh Khan, do you?*

***The* is not used before:**

Names of countries. Exceptions: *the Maldives*, *the Netherlands, the Philippines, the US, the UK.* Also: *the EU.*

Names of cities. Exception: *The Hague*.

Names of streets.

Names of railway stations and airports: *New Delhi railway station*, *IGI airport*, *Heathrow airport*.

Names of lakes and bays: *Lake Erie*, *Lake Michigan*. Exception: a group of lakes, like *the Great Lakes*.

Names of mountains: *Mount Everest*, *Mount Fuji*. Exceptions: ranges of mountains, like *the Andes*, *the Himalayas, the Rockies.*

Names of continents: *Antarctica*, *Asia*.

Names of islands. Exceptions: island chains, like *the Aleutians*, *the Hebrides*, *the Canary Islands*.

Uncountable nouns referring to something in a general sense: *Honesty is the best policy.* | *Tea is a popular drink.* | *Bengali was his native language.* But *the* is used with uncountable nouns that are made more specific by a limiting modifying phrase or clause: *The honesty of the Prime Minister is undisputed.* | *The tea in my cup is too hot to drink.* | *The Bengali he speaks is often heard in rural Bangladesh.*

Some examples of where *the* should be omitted and where it should be used:

- ~~The~~ industry is up in arms against govt's new investment policy. *The* telecom industry feels cheated.
- *The* Left often makes noises about govt policies.
- Expressing concern over *the* growth of casteism, *the* leader of *the* opposition said it was *the* biggest challenge before ~~the~~ society.
- Yashwant Sinha attracted *the* wrath of *the* supporters of Advani. (To remove one *the,* this can be changed to *Yashwant Sinha attracted the wrath of Advani's supporters*.)
- Manmohan Singh was made ~~the~~ Prime Minister by Sonia Gandhi.
- *The* Prime Minister's residence is on ~~the~~ Race Course Road.
- Mayawati has overwhelming support of ~~the~~ Dalit voters in UP.
- *The* MEA has expended valuable diplomatic capital to bring *the* US around from its initial position.
- The use of fake ST certificates came to light after an employee of *the* National Archives petitioned *the* Delhi high court last year with allegations that *the* use of forged certificates was rampant. On *the* court's directive, *the* CBI undertook a sample scrutiny and found that around 30% of *the* certificates were fake.
- The plan is being funded by *the* Oil Industry Development Board.
- For those who toil in darkness to bring light to homes and offices in <u>the</u> cities, there's no respite.
- *The* CCEA cleared <u>the</u> budgetary support for *the* payment of staff dues of 16 sick PSUs.
- Called <u>the</u> Hand Scan Biometric System, it establishes *the* identity of an individual, and prevents unknown persons from gaining access to sensitive and strategic locations of various establishments.
- Rahul Gandhi, Congress president Sonia Gandhi's son and <u>the</u> Congress MP from Amethi, has taken up the case of <u>the</u> UP farmers.
- ~~*The*~~ Govt has a number of programmes for *the* unemployed.
- Delhi is pleasant in <u>the</u> winter.
- She is taking lessons in how to play *the* piano.
- The assailant hit him in *the* eye.

- Companies are hiring by *the* dozen.
- He has scaled ~~the~~ Mount Everest as well as ~~the~~ Kanchenjunga. *The* Himalayas have many other tall peaks.
- During his visit to *the* Netherlands, he visited *the* queen's palace in *The* Hague.
- ~~The~~ Best of both worlds (headline).

We have really everything in common with America nowadays except, of course, language.
— **Oscar Wilde**

Appendix 3

American spelling and usage

The influence of American English has been growing steadily thanks to the prominence enjoyed by the US in the world economy, higher education, technology, publishing industry and mass media. American popular culture has had a profound impact on language habits everywhere. The internet has accelerated the process. Many spellings and expressions that were once considered Americanisms are now standard in British English. However, significant differences remain between these two forms of English. Such differences have been pointed out throughout this book. Many of those and some more differences are listed below along with some common American spellings.

ABBREVIATIONS

American English generally has periods (full stops) in abbreviations: *Dr.*, *U.S.* British English does not have periods: *Dr*, *US*.

-ae-, -oe American English generally has only *-e-* in place of *-ae-* or *-oe-*:

anemia, anesthesia, cesarean, cesium, diarrhea, edema, encyclopedia, eon, esophagus, estrogen, fecal, feces, fetus, gonorrhea, gynecology, hemoglobin, hemophilia, hemorrhage, hemorrhoid, homeopathy, leukemia, medieval, orthopedic, pedagogy, pediatric, pedophile, pedophilia, paleontology, primeval

But *aesthetics* and *archaeology* prevail over *esthetics* and *archeology*. *Amoeba* (plural *amoebas*, *amoebae*) is by far more common than *ameba*; and *paean* prevails over *pean*. Similarly, *subpoena*, not *subpena*.

Note that even in American English, the following words have *-ae-* or *-oe-*: Aesop, Caesar (but cesarean, as in *cesarean section*), Oedipus, phoenix.

airplane British *aeroplane*. But *aircraft* is the preferred word in both forms of English.

all right, not *alright*, is the standard form, as in British English.

aluminum British *aluminium*.

annex Both noun and verb. In British English, the verb is *annex* and the noun *annexe*.

anymore Generally, one word, as in *I don't want to talk to you anymore*. Americans distinguish *I couldn't love you anymore [so I left you]* from *I couldn't love you any more [than I already do]*. In some dialects of American English, *anymore* can also mean *nowadays*: *Everybody's cool anymore*. But this usage is considered non-standard.

In British English, *any more* is two words.

appeal (challenge a court ruling in a higher court) In American English, you *appeal* a court verdict; in British English, you *appeal against* it.

artifact British *artefact*.

ax (noun and verb) British *axe*.

balk In British English both *balk* and *baulk* are used. TOI style: *balk*.

banister In British English too, *banister* is preferred to *bannister*.

behoove British *behove*.

beltway, loop British *ring road*, *circular road*.

befitted, befitting Double *t*, as in British English.

benefited, benefiting Single *t,* as in British English.

biased, biasing Single *s*, as in British English.

blank In British English, empty spaces in a printed form are called *blanks*. In American English, the form itself is called a *blank*: *You will have to fill out one of these blanks*.

Briticism, rather than *Britishism*, is the preferred spelling in both forms of English.

call, ring In American English, you call or ring people *at* their telephone numbers. In British English, you call or ring people *on* their telephone numbers.

carat, karat C*arat* for weight of diamonds and other precious stones, *karat* for fineness of gold. In British English, *carat* is used in both senses.

carburetor British *carburettor*.

cauldron prevails over *caldron*.

-ce, -se SEE **-SE, -CE**.

check British *cheque*.

check, bill In American English, a bill for food or drinks is called a *check* and a currency note is called a *bill*. In Britain as well as in India, a restaurant or shop bill is a *bill* and a currency note a *note*.

checkered British *chequered*.

chili(es) British *chilli(es)*.

cigarette is the preferred spelling although *cigaret* too is used.

cipher is preferred to *cypher* in both forms of English.

citrus (noun and adjective) In British English, the noun is *citrus*; the adjective can be *citrous* or *citrus*. TOI style for the adjective is *citrous*.

counterclockwise British *anticlockwise*.

cozy British *cosy*.

czar In British English, *tsar, tzar* or *czar*. TOI style: *czar*.

DATES

In British English, you can write *July 25, 2007* or *July 25 2007*. (TOI style is to use a comma.) In American English, a comma is always required: *July 25, 2007*. But no comma is used in either form of English when only the month and the year are mentioned: *July 2007*.

dependent (both noun and adjective) In British English, the noun is *dependant* and the adjective *dependent*.

dicey is the only correct spelling in either form of English; *dicy* is wrong.

dietitian is preferred to *dietician* in both forms of English.

disc, disk As a general rule, *disk* is American and *disc* is British. But in both forms of English, *disc* is used for optical discs. For example, *compact disc* (CD) or *digital versatile disc* (DVD). Similarly, *disk* (short for *diskette*) is used in both forms of English for products using magnetic storage: *floppy disk*, *hard disk*.

dispatch is preferred to *despatch* in both forms of English.

doughnut is the preferred spelling although *donut* too is used.

Down syndrome British *Down's syndrome*.

draft *Draft beer* in American English, but *draught beer* in British English.

draftsman (of document or drawing) In British English, *draftsman* of document but *draughtsman* of drawing.

driver's license In British English, *driving licence*.

drunk driving In British English, *drink-driving*. TOI style: *drunk driving*.

-(e)able, -(e)ing In *-able* compounds, British English prefers *likeable*, *liveable*, *rateable*, *saleable*, *sizeable*, *unshakeable*, whereas American English prefers to drop the *e*. (For TOI style, see the individual entries.) In the following words, *e* is dropped in both forms of English: breathable, curable, datable, lovable, movable, notable, provable, quotable, scalable, solvable, usable.

Both forms of English retain the silent *e* when it is necessary to preserve a soft *c* or *g*, as in *traceable*, *changeable*. Also, both retain *e* in *-dge(able)*: *knowledgeable*, *unbridgeable*.

American English prefers *aging*; British English *ageing*. (TOI style: *aging*) Both systems retain the silent *e* in *dyeing*, *singeing* and *swingeing* to distinguish them from *dying*, *singing* and *swinging*.

elder, eldest; older, oldest American English prefers *older, oldest*.

elevator British *lift*.

epaulet British *epaulette*.

-er, -re American English generally uses *-er*; British English uses *-re*:

accouterment, caliber, center, centered, fiber, goiter, liter, luster, meter, niter, reconnoiter, saber, saltpeter, somber, specter, theater

The ending *-cre*, as in *acre*, *lucre*, *massacre* and *mediocre*, is preserved in American English too, to indicate that the *c* is pronounced *k* rather than *s*.

In American English, *ogre* and *euchre* are standard but *manoeuvre* is *maneuver* (*maneuvered*, *maneuvering*, *maneuverability*, *maneuverable*, *maneuverer*) and *sepulchre* is *sepulcher*. *Louvre* — or a framed opening in a wall, door or window — is *louver* in American English but the famed museum in Paris remains *the Louvre*.

Relatively recent French loanwords retain an *-re* spelling in American English, especially when a French-style pronunciation is used — double entendre, genre, oeuvre (plural *oeuvres*). Similarly: cadre, macabre, maître d', Notre Dame and timbre.

fall British *autumn*.

fagot (bundle of sticks), **faggot** (a term of contempt for a homosexual person) In British English, *faggot* in both senses.

favorite British *favourite*.

fetus In British English, both *fetus* and *foetus* are used, but *fetus* is now preferred. TOI style: *fetus*.

fill out In American English, a form is usually *filled out*; in British English, it is *filled in*.

first floor, ground floor In American English, *first floor, second floor* rather than *ground floor, first floor*. Hence, what is *ground floor* to a Briton or an Indian is *first floor* to an American.

flashlight is the American word for what is known as a *torch* in British English.

flier British *flyer*.

flotation In British English, both *flotation* and *floatation* are used but *flotation* is preferred.

flutist British *flautist*.

focused, focusing are the standard forms in both American English and British English, although British English accepts *focussed* and *focussing* also. TOI style: *focused*, *focusing*.

font (type face), **fount** (a source, as in *fount of knowledge*) The distinction is the same as in British English. American English uses *font* also for *fount* but *fount* is the preferred form.

formatting, formatted Same as in British English.

furor British *furore*.

forums The plural of *forum* is *forums* in both forms of English; *fora* is archaic.

gas, short for *gasoline*, is an informal American word for what is called petrol in Britain and India.

gauge prevails over *gage* in American English. In British English, it is always *gauge*.

gizmo, rather than *gismo*, is the preferred spelling in both forms of English. Of course, *-ism* in words like *socialism*, *parochialism* and *racism* remains unchanged.

glamour, not *glamor*, is the spelling in American English as well British English.

glycerin British *glycerine*.

gobbledygook British English also uses *gobbledegook*.

gram In British English too, it is *gram*; *gramme* is outdated.

gray British *grey*. But *greyhound* in both forms of English.

guerrilla, rather than *guerilla*, is the preferred spelling in both forms of English.

hauler (transporter) British *haulier*.

hodgepodge British *hotchpotch*.

hood (of a car) British *bonnet*.

-ise, -ize British English accepts both. American English uses *-ize*. (TOI style: *-ize*)

aggrandize, apologize, appetizer, baptize, capitalize, categorize, characterize, colonize, computerize, criticize, dramatize, economize, empathize, emphasize, equalize, finalize, glamorize, harmonize, hospitalize, initialize, liberalize, memorize, mesmerize, mobilize, monopolize, moralize, motorize, naturalize, normalize, organize, oxidize, pasteurize, patronize, polarize, popularize, pulverize, recognize, realize, satirize, scandalize, sensitize, stabilize, standardize, symbolize, sympathize, tantalize, terrorize, trivialize, utilize, vaporize

Similarly: civilization, colonization, nationalization, organization, realization

Some words take only the *-ise* form in both forms of English: advertise, advise (verb), apprise, arise, chastise, circumcise, comprise, compromise, demise, despise, devise, disguise, exercise, excise, franchise, improvise, incise, merchandise, revise, supervise, surmise, surprise, televise.

A few words always take the *-z-* form in both forms of English: capsize, prize, seize, size.

In British English, *prise* is what you do when you *force something open*, but in American English *prize* is more common in this sense. In American English, *pry*, a back formation of *prise* or *prize*, is also used.

karat, carat SEE **CARAT, KARAT**.

kidnapped, kidnapping, kidnapper Same as in British English.

-l-,-ll-

British: barrelled, cancelled, cruellest, counsellor, modelling, panelled, panellist, quarrelled, tranquillizer, traveller

American: barreled, bedeviled, canceled, councilor, counseled, counseling, counselor, cruelest, dialed, disheveled, equaled, equaling, fueled, fueling, groveled, groveling, grueling, hosteler, initialed, labeled, labeling, leveled, leveler, leveling, libelous, marveled, marveling, marvelous, medalist, metaled, metaling, modeling, paneled, paneling, panelist, pedaling, pupilage, quarreled, quarreler, quarreling, reveled, reveler, reveling, rivaled, signaled, signaling, tranquilizer, traveled, traveler, traveling

However, even in American English, *-ll-* is used if the stress is on the last syllable. For example, dispelled, excelled, gelled, propelled, rebelled, rebellion.

In American English, caliper, calisthenics, jeweler, jewelry and woolen.
In British English, calliper, callisthenics, jeweller, jewellery and woollen.

The following are spelled with a single *l* in British English and a double *l* in American English: appal(l), distil(l), enrol(l), enrol(l)ment, enthral(l), fulfil(l), fulfil(l)ment, instil(l), skil(l)ful, thral(l)dom, wil(l)ful.

lasagna British *lasagne*.

linchpin is preferred to *lynchpin* in both American English and British English.

line British *queue*.

make a decision In American English, *decisions are made*; in British English, *decisions are taken*.

math British *maths*.

mollusk British *mollusc*.

mold British *mould*.

mom(my) British *mum(my)*. TOI style: *mom(my)*.

mustache British *moustache*.

named for American: *road named for Gandhi*; British: *road named after Gandhi*.

-oe-, -ae SEE **-AE-, -OE**.

-og(ue) In American English, *catalog* (*cataloged*, *cataloging*) is more common than *catalogue*.

In computer and technology terminology, *analog* (as in *analog clock*) and *dialog* (as in *dialog box*) are used in both forms of English. Otherwise, the dominant forms are *analogue* and *dialogue* in both forms of English.

The following can also be spelled with *-og* in American English: demagogue, epilogue, homologue, monologue, pedagogue, prologue and travelogue. But the *-ogue* spellings are preferred. American English, like British English, accepts only the form *synagogue*, not *synagog*.

Rogue and *vogue* are thus spelled in both forms of English.

omelet British *omelette*.

on Friday, on Saturday The British say *The CEO resigned on Friday*; the Americans often say *The CEO resigned Friday*. Both forms are common in American usage.

-or, -our In British English, *-our*; in American English, *-or*.

ardor, armor, armory, behavior, candor, clamor, color, demeanor, enamor, endeavor (but space shuttle Endeavour), favor, fervor, flavor, harbor, honor, humor, labor, neighbor, odor, parlor, rancor, rigor, rumor, savor, savory, splendor, succor, tumor, valor, vapor, vigor

American English retains the *u* in *glamour*, which has a Scottish — not Latin or French — origin. Both s*avior* and *saviour* are used in American English but *savior* is preferred. Verb and adjective forms of *glamour* are *glamorize* and *glamorous*; these are spelled with *-or* even in British English.

out of Americans throw things *out the window*; the British throw things *out of the window*.

pajamas British *pyjamas*.

pedaler (cyclist) British *pedaller*.

peddler (hawker) British *pedlar*.

peddler (drug dealer) Same in British English.

percent is one word in American English, two words in British English.

plow British *plough*.

polyethylene British *polythene*.

practice (noun and verb) In British English, the noun is *practice* and the verb *practise*.

presently In American English, *presently* can mean *at present*. In British English, it means *soon*.

program, programming, programmed, programmer In reference to computer programs, the British spellings are the same.

public school In the US, a public school is a school that is maintained by public taxes and supervised by local authorities. In Britain, as in India, a public school is a private school.

quarter Fifteen minutes before two, an American says *it is a quarter of two*; a Briton says *it is a quarter to two*.

quiz As in British English, the plural of *quiz* is *quizzes*; the verb forms are *quizzes*, *quizzed* and *quizzing*.

QUOTATION MARKS AND COMMAS OR PERIODS

In American English, the comma or period goes inside the quotation marks, whether the quote is partial or full. In British English, the comma or period goes inside the quotation marks only when the quote is full.

American: Rebellion means "opposition to authority."
British: Rebellion means "opposition to authority".

Both styles: "I am alive," he said.

The British style is more logical and is gaining currency in the US too.

railroad British *railway*.

rain off, rain out A match is *rained off* in the UK; it is *rained out* in the US.

raise (pay increase) British *rise*. TOI style: *raise*.

-re, -er SEE **-ER, -RE**.

rambunctious British *rumbustious*.

reservation British *booking*.

ruble British *rouble*.

sanitarium(s) is the preferred American spelling. British: *sanatorium(s)*.

savior British *saviour*.

school In Britain, and in India, a school is an educational institution below university level. In America, even universities or their departments are called schools.

-se, -ce In both American English and British English, *advice* and *device* are nouns, with *advise* and *devise* as the respective verb forms. In American English, *practice* and *license* are used in both noun and verb forms. But in British English, the nouns are *practice* and *licence*, and the verbs *practise* and *license*. Also, American English has kept the Anglo-French spelling for *defense* and *offense*, which are usually *defence* and *offence* in British English. Similarly, there are the American *pretense* and British *pretence*; but derivatives like *defensive*, *offensive* and *pretension* are always thus spelled in both forms of English.

sidewalk British *pavement*.

signaled, signaling British *signalled*, *signalling*.

skeptic, skeptical British *sceptic*, *sceptical*.

smolder British *smoulder*.

-st In British English you can write *amid* or *amidst*, *among* or *amongst* and *while* or *whilst*. In American English only *among*, *amid* and *while* are acceptable. *Midst*, of course, remains *midst* in both forms of English. TOI style: *amid*, *among*, *while*.

story (plural *stories*) British *storey*; plural *storeys*.

stanch (verb) British *staunch*.

street American: *on the street*; British: *in the street*.

subpoena is thus spelled in both forms of English. The variant *subpena*, often seen in American English, is considered substandard.

sulfur, sulfate, sulfide, sulfuric, sulfurous British *sulphur*, *sulphate*, *sulphide*, *sulphuric*, *sulphurous*.

Note that American English retains the *-ph-* form in these names: Sulphur Springs (Texas) and Sulphur (Louisiana).

suspenders British *braces*.

tidbit British *titbit*.

tire British *tyre*.

to, through In British English, *Monday to Friday*; in American English, *Monday through Friday*.

truck British *lorry*. In India, *truck*.

trunk (of a car) British *boot*. In India, *boot* or *dicky*.

try and, try to In American English, *try to* is the preferred form and the use of *try and* in formal writing is frowned upon. Americans call *try and* a British colloquialism. In Britain too, *try to* is the preferred form in writing.

vacation British *holiday*.

VERB FORMS

While using the past tense or past participle of a verb, if there is a choice between *-ed* and *-t* endings, the *-ed* form is preferred in American English. In British English, either form is acceptable. TOI style: *-ed*.

Both British and American: beseeched, burned, dreamed, dwelled, leaned, leaped, learned, smelled, spelled, spilled, spoiled, wreaked

Generally British: besought, burnt, dreamt, dwelt, leant, leapt, learnt, smelt, spelt, spilt, spoilt, wrought

In both forms of English, *knelt* is preferred to *kneeled*.

In both forms of English, the preferred past tense and past participle of *bet* is *bet*, although American English also allows *betted*.

Although *dwelled* is more common than *dwelt* in American English, *dwelt* is preferred with the preposition *on* or *upon*.

In both forms of English, the preferred past tense and past participle of *fit* is *fitted*, although American English also allows *fit*. In both forms of English, the adjective is *fitted*: *fitted kitchen*, *fitted bedroom*, *fitted* (made to size) *clothes, etc*.

The past tense and past participle of *knit* can be either *knitted* or *knit*. In both forms of English, *knitted* is preferred. But only *knit* can be used in expressions like *close-knit family*.

The past tense and past participle of *light* can be either *lit* or *lighted*. British English prefers *lit*, American English *lighted*. But in both forms of English, *moonlit night*, *well-lit room*, etc.

The past tense and past participle of *wed* can be either *wedded* or *wed*. In both forms of English, *wedded* is preferred. Also, in both forms of English, *wedded bliss* or *wedded to an idea*, but *newlywed couple*.

In American English, the past participle of *get* is generally *gotten*: *I have gotten up early today.* | *You've gotten us into a lot of trouble*. But in certain cases, *got* is required: *He has got two kids*. | *They've got three cars*. | *I've got to go to the bathroom*. In British English, it is always *got*.

In American English, *kidnapped* because the stress is on the second syllable, but *worshiped* because the stress is on the first syllable. Similarly: *kidnapper*, *worshiper*. In British English, *kidnapped*, *kidnapper*; *worshipped*, *worshipper*.

vise (two-jaw tool) British *vice*.

vs as the short form of *versus*; British *v*. American English uses *v* in court cases: *Roe v Wade*. TOI style: *vs*.

-ward In American English, *forward*, *toward*, *rightward*, *upward*. In British English, *forwards*, *towards*, *rightwards*, *upwards*.

week today, week tomorrow British expressions like *a week today* or *a week tomorrow* are not found in American English, which uses *a week from today* or *a week from tomorrow*.

whiskey In British English, *whisky*. The Scottish drink remains *whisky* even in American English.

windshield British *windscreen*.

worshiped, worshiping, worshiper In British English, *worshipped*, *worshipping*, *worshipper*.

-yse, -yze American English uses *-yze*: *analyze*, *catalyze*, *hydrolyze*, *paralyze*. British English uses *-yse*.

zipper (noun) British *zip*.

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Appendix 4

Politics and the English Language

George Orwell

MOST people who bother with the matter at all would admit that the English language is in a bad way, but it is generally assumed that we cannot by conscious action do anything about it. Our civilization is decadent and our language — so the argument runs — must inevitably share in the general collapse. It follows that any struggle against the abuse of language is a sentimental archaism, like preferring candles to electric light or hansom cabs to aeroplanes. Underneath this lies the half-conscious belief that language is a natural growth and not an instrument which we shape for our own purposes.

Now, it is clear that the decline of a language must ultimately have political and economic causes: it is not due simply to the bad influence of this or that individual writer. But an effect can become a cause, reinforcing the original cause and producing the same effect in an intensified form, and so on indefinitely. A man may take to drink because he feels himself to be a failure, and then fail all the more completely because he drinks. It is rather the same thing that is happening to the English language. It becomes ugly and inaccurate because our thoughts are foolish, but the slovenliness of our language makes it easier for us to have foolish thoughts. The point is that the process is reversible. Modern English, especially written English, is full of bad habits which spread by imitation and which can be avoided if one is willing to take the necessary trouble. If one gets rid of these habits one can think more clearly, and to think clearly is a necessary first step toward political regeneration: so that the fight against bad English is not frivolous and is not the exclusive concern of professional writers. I will come back to this presently, and I hope that by that time the meaning of what I have said here will have become clearer. Meanwhile, here are five specimens of the English language as it is now habitually written.

These five passages have not been picked out because they are especially bad — I could have quoted far worse if I had chosen — but because they illustrate

various of the mental vices from which we now suffer. They are a little below the average, but are fairly representative examples. I number them so that I can refer back to them when necessary:

> 1. I am not, indeed, sure whether it is not true to say that the Milton who once seemed not unlike a seventeenth-century Shelley had not become, out of an experience ever more bitter in each year, more alien *[sic]* to the founder of that Jesuit sect which nothing could induce him to tolerate.
>
> Professor Harold Laski (Essay in *Freedom of Expression*)

> 2. Above all, we cannot play ducks and drakes with a native battery of idioms which prescribes egregious collocations of vocables as the Basic *put up with* for *tolerate*, or *put at a loss* for *bewilder*.
>
> Professor Lancelot Hogben (*Interglossia*)

> 3. On the one side we have the free personality: by definition it is not neurotic, for it has neither conflict nor dream. Its desires, such as they are, are transparent, for they are just what institutional approval keeps in the forefront of consciousness; another institutional pattern would alter their number and intensity; there is little in them that is natural, irreducible, or culturally dangerous. But *on the other side*, the social bond itself is nothing but the mutual reflection of these self-secure integrities. Recall the definition of love. Is not this the very picture of a small academic? Where is there a place in this hall of mirrors for either personality or fraternity?
>
> Essay on psychology in *Politics* (New York)

> 4. All the 'best people' from the gentlemen's clubs, and all the frantic fascist captains, united in common hatred of Socialism and bestial horror at the rising tide of the mass revolutionary movement, have turned to acts of provocation, to foul incendiarism, to medieval legends of poisoned wells, to legalize their own destruction of proletarian organizations, and rouse the agitated petty-bourgeoise to chauvinistic fervor on behalf of the fight against the revolutionary way out of the crisis.
>
> Communist pamphlet

5. If a new spirit is to be infused into this old country, there is one thorny and contentious reform which must be tackled, and that is the humanization and galvanization of the B.B.C. Timidity here will bespeak canker and atrophy of the soul. The heart of Britain may be sound and of strong beat, for instance, but the British lion's roar at present is like that of Bottom in Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream* — as gentle as any sucking dove. A virile new Britain cannot continue indefinitely to be traduced in the eyes or rather ears, of the world by the effete languors of Langham Place, brazenly masquerading as 'standard English'. When the Voice of Britain is heard at nine o'clock, better far and infinitely less ludicrous to hear aitches honestly dropped than the present priggish, inflated, inhibited, school-ma'amish arch braying of blameless bashful mewing maidens!

Letter in *Tribune*

Each of these passages has faults of its own, but, quite apart from avoidable ugliness, two qualities are common to all of them. The first is staleness of imagery; the other is lack of precision. The writer either has a meaning and cannot express it, or he inadvertently says something else, or he is almost indifferent as to whether his words mean anything or not. This mixture of vagueness and sheer incompetence is the most marked characteristic of modern English prose, and especially of any kind of political writing. As soon as certain topics are raised, the concrete melts into the abstract and no one seems able to think of turns of speech that are not hackneyed: prose consists less and less of *words* chosen for the sake of their meaning, and more and more of *phrases* tacked together like the sections of a prefabricated hen-house. I list below, with notes and examples, various of the tricks by means of which the work of prose-construction is habitually dodged.

DYING METAPHORS. A newly invented metaphor assists thought by evoking a visual image, while on the other hand a metaphor which is technically 'dead' (e. g. iron resolution) has in effect reverted to being an ordinary word and can generally be used without loss of vividness. But in between these two classes there is a huge dump of worn-out metaphors which have lost all evocative power and are merely used because they save people the trouble of inventing phrases for themselves. Examples are: *Ring the changes on, take up the cudgel for, toe the line, ride roughshod over, stand shoulder to shoulder with, play into the hands of, no axe to grind, grist to the mill, fishing in troubled waters, on the order of the day, Achilles' heel, swan song, hotbed.*

Many of these are used without knowledge of their meaning (what is a 'rift', for instance?), and incompatible metaphors are frequently mixed, a sure sign that the writer is not interested in what he is saying. Some metaphors now current have been twisted out of their original meaning without those who use them even being aware of the fact. For example, *toe the line* is sometimes written as *tow the line*. Another example is *the hammer and the anvil*, now always used with the implication that the anvil gets the worst of it. In real life it is always the anvil that breaks the hammer, never the other way about: a writer who stopped to think what he was saying would avoid perverting the original phrase.

OPERATORS OR VERBAL FALSE LIMBS. These save the trouble of picking out appropriate verbs and nouns, and at the same time pad each sentence with extra syllables which give it an appearance of symmetry. Characteristic phrases are *render inoperative, militate against, make contact with, be subjected to, give rise to, give grounds for, have the effect of, play a leading part (role) in, make itself felt, take effect, exhibit a tendency to, serve the purpose of,* etc., etc. The keynote is the elimination of simple verbs. Instead of being a single word, such as *break, stop, spoil, mend, kill,* a verb becomes a *phrase*, made up of a noun or adjective tacked on to some general-purpose verb such as *prove, serve, form, play, render*. In addition, the passive voice is wherever possible used in preference to the active, and noun constructions are used instead of gerunds (*by examination of* instead of *by examining*). The range of verbs is further cut down by means of the
-ize and *de-* formations, and the banal statements are given an appearance of profundity by means of the *not un-* formation. Simple conjunctions and prepositions are replaced by such phrases as *with respect to, having regard to, the fact that, by dint of, in view of, in the interests of, on the hypothesis that*; and the ends of sentences are saved by anticlimax by such resounding commonplaces as *greatly to be desired, cannot be left out of account, a development to be expected in the near future, deserving of serious consideration, brought to a satisfactory conclusion,* and so on and so forth.

PRETENTIOUS DICTION. Words like *phenomenon, element, individual (as noun), objective, categorical, effective, virtual, basic, primary, promote, constitute, exhibit, exploit, utilize, eliminate, liquidate,* are used to dress up a simple statement and give an air of scientific impartiality to biased judgements. Adjectives like *epoch-making, epic, historic, unforgettable, triumphant, age-old, inevitable, inexorable, veritable,* are used to dignify the sordid process of international politics, while writing that aims at glorifying war usually takes on an archaic colour, its characteristic words being: *realm, throne, chariot, mailed fist, trident, sword, shield, buckler, banner, jackboot, clarion*. Foreign words and expressions such as *cul de sac, ancien regime, deus*

ex machina, mutatis mutandis, status quo, gleichschaltung, weltanschauung, are used to give an air of culture and elegance. Except for the useful abbreviations *i. e., e. g. and etc.,* there is no real need for any of the hundreds of foreign phrases now current in the English language. Bad writers, and especially scientific, political, and sociological writers, are nearly always haunted by the notion that Latin or Greek words are grander than Saxon ones, and unnecessary words like *expedite, ameliorate, predict, extraneous, deracinated, clandestine, subaqueous,* and hundreds of others constantly gain ground from their Anglo-Saxon numbers*. The jargon peculiar to Marxist writing (*hyena, hangman, cannibal, petty bourgeois, these gentry, lackey, flunkey, mad dog, White Guard,* etc.) consists largely of words translated from Russian, German, or French; but the normal way of coining a new word is to use Latin or Greek root with the appropriate affix and, where necessary, the size formation. It is often easier to make up words of this kind (*deregionalize, impermissible, extramarital, non-fragmentary* and so forth) than to think up the English words that will cover one's meaning. The result, in general, is an increase in slovenliness and vagueness.

MEANINGLESS WORDS. In certain kinds of writing, particularly in art criticism and literary criticism, it is normal to come across long passages which are almost completely lacking in meaning**. Words like *romantic, plastic, values, human, dead, sentimental, natural, vitality,* as used in art criticism, are strictly meaningless, in the sense that they not only do not point to any discoverable object, but are hardly ever expected to do so by the reader. When one critic writes, 'The outstanding feature of Mr. X's work is its living quality', while another writes, 'The immediately striking thing about Mr. X's work is its peculiar deadness', the reader accepts this as a simple difference opinion. If words like *black* and *white* were involved, instead of the jargon words *dead* and *living*, he would see at once that language was being used in an improper way. Many political words are similarly abused. The word *Fascism* has now no meaning except in so far as it signifies 'something not desirable'. The words *democracy, socialism, freedom, patriotic, realistic, justice* have each of them several different meanings which cannot be reconciled with one another. In the case of a word like *democracy*, not only is there no agreed definition, but the attempt to make one is resisted from all sides. It is almost universally felt that when we call a country democratic we are praising it: consequently the defenders of every kind of regime claim that it is a democracy, and fear that they might have to stop using that word if it were tied down to any one meaning. Words of this kind are often used in a consciously dishonest way. That is, the person who uses them has his own private definition, but allows his hearer to think he means something quite different. Statements like *Marshal Petain was a true patriot, The Soviet press*

is the freest in the world, The Catholic Church is opposed to persecution, are almost always made with intent to deceive. Other words used in variable meanings, in most cases more or less dishonestly, are: *class, totalitarian, science, progressive, reactionary, bourgeois, equality.*

Now that I have made this catalogue of swindles and perversions, let me give another example of the kind of writing that they lead to. This time it must of its nature be an imaginary one. I am going to translate a passage of good English into modern English of the worst sort. Here is a well-known verse from *Ecclesiastes*:

> I returned and saw under the sun, that the race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong, neither yet bread to the wise, nor yet riches to men of understanding, nor yet favour to men of skill; but time and chance happeneth to them all.

Here it is in modern English:

> Objective considerations of contemporary phenomena compel the conclusion that success or failure in competitive activities exhibits no tendency to be commensurate with innate capacity, but that a considerable element of the unpredictable must invariably be taken into account.

This is a parody, but not a very gross one. Exhibit (3) above, for instance, contains several patches of the same kind of English. It will be seen that I have not made a full translation. The beginning and ending of the sentence follow the original meaning fairly closely, but in the middle the concrete illustrations — race, battle, bread — dissolve into the vague phrases 'success or failure in competitive activities'. This had to be so, because no modern writer of the kind I am discussing — no one capable of using phrases like 'objective considerations of contemporary phenomena' — would ever tabulate his thoughts in that precise and detailed way. The whole tendency of modern prose is away from concreteness. Now analyze these two sentences a little more closely. The first contains forty-nine words but only sixty syllables, and all its words are those of everyday life. The second contains thirty-eight words of ninety syllables: eighteen of those words are from Latin roots, and one from Greek. The first sentence contains six vivid images, and only one phrase ('time and chance') that could be called vague. The second contains not a single fresh, arresting phrase, and in spite of its ninety syllables it gives only a shortened version of the meaning contained in the first. Yet without a doubt it is the second kind of sentence that is gaining ground in modern English. I do not want to exaggerate. This kind of writing

is not yet universal, and outcrops of simplicity will occur here and there in the worst-written page. Still, if you or I were told to write a few lines on the uncertainty of human fortunes, we should probably come much nearer to my imaginary sentence than to the one from *Ecclesiastes*.

As I have tried to show, modern writing at its worst does not consist in picking out words for the sake of their meaning and inventing images in order to make the meaning clearer. It consists in gumming together long strips of words which have already been set in order by someone else, and making the results presentable by sheer humbug. The attraction of this way of writing is that it is easy. It is easier — even quicker, once you have the habit — to say *In my opinion it is not an unjustifiable assumption that* than to say *I think*. If you use ready-made phrases, you not only don't have to hunt about for the words; you also don't have to bother with the rhythms of your sentences since these phrases are generally so arranged as to be more or less euphonious. When you are composing in a hurry — when you are dictating to a stenographer, for instance, or making a public speech — it is natural to fall into a pretentious, Latinized style. Tags like *a consideration which we should do well to bear in mind* or *a conclusion to which all of us would readily assent* will save many a sentence from coming down with a bump. By using stale metaphors, similes, and idioms, you save much mental effort, at the cost of leaving your meaning vague, not only for your reader but for yourself. This is the significance of mixed metaphors. The sole aim of a metaphor is to call up a visual image. When these images clash — as in *The Fascist octopus has sung its swan song, the jackboot is thrown into the melting pot* — it can be taken as certain that the writer is not seeing a mental image of the objects he is naming; in other words he is not really thinking. Look again at the examples I gave at the beginning of this essay. Professor Laski (1) uses five negatives in fifty three words. One of these is superfluous, making nonsense of the whole passage, and in addition there is the slip — *alien* for akin — making further nonsense, and several avoidable pieces of clumsiness which increase the general vagueness. Professor Hogben (2) plays ducks and drakes with a battery which is able to write prescriptions, and, while disapproving of the everyday phrase *put up with*, is unwilling to look *egregious* up in the dictionary and see what it means; (3), if one takes an uncharitable attitude towards it, is simply meaningless: probably one could work out its intended meaning by reading the whole of the article in which it occurs. In (4), the writer knows more or less what he wants to say, but an accumulation of stale phrases chokes him like tea leaves blocking a sink. In (5), words and meaning have almost parted company. People who write in this manner usually have a general emotional meaning — they dislike one thing and want to express solidarity with another — but they are not interested in the detail of what

they are saying. A scrupulous writer, in every sentence that he writes, will ask himself at least four questions, thus: What am I trying to say? What words will express it? What image or idiom will make it clearer? Is this image fresh enough to have an effect? And he will probably ask himself two more: Could I put it more shortly? Have I said anything that is avoidably ugly? But you are not obliged to go to all this trouble. You can shirk it by simply throwing your mind open and letting the ready-made phrases come crowding in. The will construct your sentences for you — even think your thoughts for you, to a certain extent — and at need they will perform the important service of partially concealing your meaning even from yourself. It is at this point that the special connection between politics and the debasement of language becomes clear.

In our time it is broadly true that political writing is bad writing. Where it is not true, it will generally be found that the writer is some kind of rebel, expressing his private opinions and not a 'party line'. Orthodoxy, of whatever colour, seems to demand a lifeless, imitative style. The political dialects to be found in pamphlets, leading articles, manifestos, White papers and the speeches of undersecretaries do, of course, vary from party to party, but they are all alike in that one almost never finds in them a fresh, vivid, homemade turn of speech. When one watches some tired hack on the platform mechanically repeating the familiar phrases — *bestial, atrocities, iron heel, bloodstained tyranny, free peoples of the world, stand shoulder to shoulder* — one often has a curious feeling that one is not watching a live human being but some kind of dummy: a feeling which suddenly becomes stronger at moments when the light catches the speaker's spectacles and turns them into blank discs which seem to have no eyes behind them. And this is not altogether fanciful. A speaker who uses that kind of phraseology has gone some distance toward turning himself into a machine. The appropriate noises are coming out of his larynx, but his brain is not involved, as it would be if he were choosing his words for himself. If the speech he is making is one that he is accustomed to make over and over again, he may be almost unconscious of what he is saying, as one is when one utters the responses in church. And this reduced state of consciousness, if not indispensable, is at any rate favourable to political conformity.

In our time, political speech and writing are largely the defence of the indefensible. Things like the continuance of British rule in India, the Russian purges and deportations, the dropping of the atom bombs on Japan, can indeed be defended, but only by arguments which are too brutal for most people to face, and which do not square with the professed aims of the political parties. Thus political language has to consist largely of euphemism, question-begging and sheer cloudy vagueness. Defenceless

villages are bombarded from the air, the inhabitants driven out into the countryside, the cattle machine-gunned, the huts set on fire with incendiary bullets: this is called *pacification*. Millions of peasants are robbed of their farms and sent trudging along the roads with no more than they can carry: this is called *transfer of population* or *rectification of frontiers*. People are imprisoned for years without trial, or shot in the back of the neck or sent to die of scurvy in Arctic lumber camps: this is called *elimination of unreliable elements*. Such phraseology is needed if one wants to name things without calling up mental pictures of them. Consider for instance some comfortable English professor defending Russian totalitarianism. He cannot say outright, 'I believe in killing off your opponents when you can get good results by doing so'. Probably, therefore, he will say something like this:

> 'While freely conceding that the Soviet regime exhibits certain features which the humanitarian may be inclined to deplore, we must, I think, agree that a certain curtailment of the right to political opposition is an unavoidable concomitant of transitional periods, and that the rigors which the Russian people have been called upon to undergo have been amply justified in the sphere of concrete achievement.'

The inflated style itself is a kind of euphemism. A mass of Latin words falls upon the facts like soft snow, blurring the outline and covering up all the details. The great enemy of clear language is insincerity. When there is a gap between one's real and one's declared aims, one turns as it were instinctively to long words and exhausted idioms, like a cuttlefish spurting out ink. In our age there is no such thing as 'keeping out of politics'. All issues are political issues, and politics itself is a mass of lies, evasions, folly, hatred, and schizophrenia. When the general atmosphere is bad, language must suffer. I should expect to find — this is a guess which I have not sufficient knowledge to verify — that the German, Russian and Italian languages have all deteriorated in the last ten or fifteen years, as a result of dictatorship.

But if thought corrupts language, language can also corrupt thought. A bad usage can spread by tradition and imitation even among people who should and do know better. The debased language that I have been discussing is in some ways very convenient. Phrases like *a not unjustifiable assumption, leaves much to be desired, would serve no good purpose, a consideration which we should do well to bear in mind,* are a continuous temptation, a packet of aspirins always at one's elbow. Look back through this essay, and for certain you will find that I have again and again committed the very faults I am protesting against. By this morning's post I have received a pamphlet dealing with conditions in Germany. The author tells me that he 'felt impelled' to

write it. I open it at random, and here is almost the first sentence I see: '[The Allies] have an opportunity not only of achieving a radical transformation of Germany's social and political structure in such a way as to avoid a nationalistic reaction in Germany itself, but at the same time of laying the foundations of a co-operative and unified Europe.' You see, he 'feels impelled' to write — feels, presumably, that he has something new to say — and yet his words, like cavalry horses answering the bugle, group themselves automatically into the familiar dreary pattern. This invasion of one's mind by ready-made phrases (*lay the foundations, achieve a radical transformation*) can only be prevented if one is constantly on guard against them, and every such phrase anaesthetizes a portion of one's brain.

I said earlier that the decadence of our language is probably curable. Those who deny this would argue, if they produced an argument at all, that language merely reflects existing social conditions, and that we cannot influence its development by any direct tinkering with words and constructions. So far as the general tone or spirit of a language goes, this may be true, but it is not true in detail. Silly words and expressions have often disappeared, not through any evolutionary process but owing to the conscious action of a minority. Two recent examples were *explore every avenue* and *leave no stone unturned*, which were killed by the jeers of a few journalists. There is a long list of flyblown metaphors which could similarly be got rid of if enough people would interest themselves in the job; and it should also be possible to laugh the *not un-* formation out of existence***, to reduce the amount of Latin and Greek in the average sentence, to drive out foreign phrases and strayed scientific words, and, in general, to make pretentiousness unfashionable. But all these are minor points. The defence of the English language implies more than this, and perhaps it is best to start by saying what it *does not* imply.

To begin with it has nothing to do with archaism, with the salvaging of obsolete words and turns of speech, or with the setting up of a 'standard English' which must never be departed from. On the contrary, it is especially concerned with the scrapping of every word or idiom which has outworn its usefulness. It has nothing to do with correct grammar and syntax, which are of no importance so long as one makes one's meaning clear, or with the avoidance of Americanisms, or with having what is called a 'good prose style'. On the other hand, it is not concerned with fake simplicity and the attempt to make written English colloquial. Nor does it even imply in every case preferring the Saxon word to the Latin one, though it does imply using the fewest and shortest words that will cover one's meaning. What is above all needed is to let the meaning choose the word, and not the other way around. In prose, the worst thing one can do with words is surrender to them.

When you think of a concrete object, you think wordlessly, and then, if you want to describe the thing you have been visualising you probably hunt about until you find the exact words that seem to fit it. When you think of something abstract you are more inclined to use words from the start, and unless you make a conscious effort to prevent it, the existing dialect will come rushing in and do the job for you, at the expense of blurring or even changing your meaning. Probably it is better to put off using words as long as possible and get one's meaning as clear as one can through pictures and sensations. Afterward one can choose — not simply *accept* — the phrases that will best cover the meaning, and then switch round and decide what impressions one's words are likely to make on another person. This last effort of the mind cuts out all stale or mixed images, all prefabricated phrases, needless repetitions, and humbug and vagueness generally. But one can often be in doubt about the effect of a word or a phrase, and one needs rules that one can rely on when instinct fails. I think the following rules will cover most cases:

— Never use a metaphor, simile, or other figure of speech which you are used to seeing in print.

— Never use a long word where a short one will do.

— If it is possible to cut a word out, always cut it out.

— Never use the passive where you can use the active.

— Never use a foreign phrase, a scientific word, or a jargon word if you can think of an everyday English equivalent.

— Break any of these rules sooner than say anything outright barbarous.

These rules sound elementary, and so they are, but they demand a deep change of attitude in anyone who has grown used to writing in the style now fashionable. One could keep all of them and still write bad English, but one could not write the kind of stuff that I quoted in those five specimens at the beginning of this article.

I have not here been considering the literary use of language, but merely language as an instrument for expressing and not for concealing or preventing thought. Stuart Chase and others have come near to claiming that all abstract words are meaningless, and have used this as a pretext for advocating a kind of political quietism. Since you don't know what Fascism is, how can you struggle against Fascism? One need not swallow such absurdities as this, but one ought to recognize that the present political chaos is connected with the decay of language, and that one can probably bring

about some improvement by starting at the verbal end. If you simplify your English, you are freed from the worst follies of orthodoxy. You cannot speak any of the necessary dialects, and when you make a stupid remark its stupidity will be obvious, even to yourself. Political language — and with variations this is true of all political parties, from Conservatives to Anarchists — is designed to make lies sound truthful and murder respectable, and to give an appearance of solidity to pure wind. One cannot change this all in a moment, but one can at least change one's own habits, and from time to time one can even, if one jeers loudly enough, send some worn-out and useless phrase — some *jackboot, Achilles' heel, hotbed, melting pot, acid test, veritable inferno,* or other lump of verbal refuse — into the dustbin where it belongs.

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* An interesting illustration of this is the way in which the English flower names which were in use till very recently are being ousted by Greek ones, *snapdragon* becoming *antirrhinum*, *forget-me-not* becoming *myosotis*, etc. It is hard to see any practical reason for this change of fashion: it is probably due to an instinctive turning-awayfrom the more homely word and a vague feeling that the Greek word is scientific.

** Example: 'Comfort's catholicity of perception and image, strangely Whitmanesque in range, almost the exact opposite in aesthetic compulsion, continues to evoke that trembling atmospheric accumulative ginting at a cruel, an inexorably selene timelessness... Wrey Gardiner scores by aiming at simple bull's-eyes with precision. Only they are not so simple, and through this contented sadness runs more than the surface bitter-sweet of resignation'. (*Poetry Quarterly.*)

*** One can cure oneself of the *not un-* formation by memorizing this sentence: *A not unblack dog was chasing a not unsmall rabbit across a not ungreen field.*

Appendix 5

New words to be used with discretion and caution